Henchmen

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Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Category:
Gen

Fandoms:
He-Man and the Masters of the Universe, She-Ra: Princess Of Power (1985), She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Masters Of The Universe Characters, Evil-Lyn & Teela (He-Man), Trap Jaw & Tri-Klops (He-Man)

Characters:
Mer-Man (He-Man), Beastman (He-Man), Mer-Man & Beast Man (He-Man), Skeletor (mentioned), Evil-Lyn (mentioned), Randor (mentioned), Two-Bad (mentioned), Skeletor (He-Man), Evil-Lyn (He-Man), Tri-Klops (mentioned), Original Masters Of The Universe Characters, Castle Grayskull - Character, Teela (He-Man), Man-At-Arms (mentioned), Keldor (He-Man), O.C. (He-Man), Tri-Klops (He-Man), Trap Jaw (He-Man), Man-At-Arms (He-Man), Randor (He-Man), Mekaneck (He-Man), He-Man | Adam, Marlena (He-Man), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Webstor (He-Man), Spikor

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Henchmen

by WL Swarts

Summary

A fleshing out of the characters of *He-Man And The Masters Of The Universe* with a more sensible and adult take. Chapter by chapter, the characters explore why they are affiliated with either Skeletor or Randor in a vastly more realistic and thought-out way than the animated children's series did. If you loved *Masters Of The Universe* growing up and would like to see an adult version of your favorite characters played out every two weeks, check this out! New chapters every other Thursday (next update May 25!).

Notes

I grew up on *He-Man And The Masters Of The Universe* and the *Masters Of The Universe* toy line. A few years ago, I rediscovered *He-Man And The Masters Of The Universe* and it rekindled my love for that universe. Then I encountered the Filmation *She-Ra: Princess Of Power* and I was blown away. I'm a big fan of the works of J. Michael Straczynski and I was super-impressed by how many adult themes he worked into the animated show.

So, I found myself contemplating *Masters Of The Universe* and I thought a lot about how so many movies and shows today try to simply remake past works. One of the things I truly love about *Rogue One* is that it is an adult story, intended for an adult audience who grew up on the *Star Wars* Saga, but written for their adult sensibilities. My mind kept gravitating toward *Masters Of The Universe* with that in mind. There was so much potential for something more than just a children's story (or vehicle for selling action figures and accessories).

So, I spent some time writing out a whole *Masters Of The Universe* movie series. It's something I do. I'll sit and write out scripts for the films I want to see. Lately, I've been thinking a lot about that project and as I am playing in other people's sandboxes with my works here, I thought it might be fun to revisit that. The purposes of *Henchmen* are simple: to make the characters of *Masters Of The Universe* actually make sense to an adult sensibility and to flesh-out the monolithic characters that inhabit that universe. Will I get to the point of actually telling any a-plot style stories? I'm not sure yet.

This anthology is intended to run the gambit of *Masters Of The Universe* characters in a way that thrills fans and makes it impossible for newbies to watch whatever crap the studio eventually puts out (fans know they aren't going to do justice to the source material). They are, essentially, character studies both of individuals and relationships, centered around the support characters in *Masters Of The Universe*. While most are serious psychological dives into shallowly-written characters, we have some plans for some to be funny, one utterly horrifying (Mekaneck), but all enlightening and intended to be accessible to anyone who has never seen an episode of *He-Man And The Masters Of The Universe* or any subsequent material in the franchise. Because almost all of the characters are built around a simple, single gimmick, it's easy to create much richer backstories and ideas for them without betraying too much of what was established in the children's works.

Our hope is that fans will enjoy my interpretation and new readers might actually look up some of the franchise based on what we have created. Our planned schedule is one chapter a week for the foreseeable future.

Thanks for reading!

-W.L. Swarts

The Lesser Evil Of Compromise

"You're late," Beast Man growled as his compatriot rose from the water.

Mer-Man flexed his webbed feet to confirm his grip on the rocks, but did not rise from his crouching stance. He shrugged in the moonlit darkness as he reached for the thick kelp rope just under the surface of the water he had just climbed out of. The sea water dripped off Mer-Man's skin, though the amphibious humanoid continued to glisten in the moonslight; he had about ten minutes before his mucus-covered body began to dry.

"It's not like we have a wealth of clocks in the Sea Of Rakash," Mer-Man noted, bubbles of fluid pouring out the corners of his mouth. "Besides, I increased your haul with the extra few minutes."

Mer-Man pulled the end of the rope fully out of the water and offered it to the furry humanoid who remained seated on the boulder before him. Beast Man rubbed the ridges on his leathery brow with his powerful hand. Even at a distance, Mer-Man could see his black fingernails were rough, cracked and filthy. The shaggy orange fur of Beast Man's beard and shoulders appeared more matted than usual, even to Mer-Man who did his best not to spend too much time in the giant mammal's company. Beast Man's eyes looked wetter than usual and the bloodshot whites contrasted with his dark blue irises.

"How are you doing?" Mer-Man asked, not advancing on Beast Man.

"What?" Beast Man replied. His question came more from surprise than failure to hear his fellow minion of Skeletor. While he asked this question instinctively, he took a moment to process the words Mer-Man had actually spoken. It did not take him long to realize it had been a long time since anyone had shown concern for his well-being. He blinked, confusion replacing the discomfort on his

face, unsure if anyone had ever asked him that specific question before. As he shook his head, Beast Man concluded that the closest anyone had come in his memory to asking him how he was doing before now was to check-in on the battlefield; to ask him how he was immediately before ordering him into another dangerous situation.

"Your head hurts?" Mer-Man surmised. Beast Man grunted confirmation of his cold-blooded companion's supposition. "You're telepathic, too, yes?"

While they had witnessed each other leading their respective forces in battle multiple times, this was the first time either had shown any interest in how the other commanded. Beast Man quietly noted, "Yes. Sometimes it's bad when I spend so much time so close to so many... who are suffering."

"Sorry for that," Mer-Man said with a shrug. He looked around the small clearing, past Beast Man.

"Your caravan is just over there," Beast Man said, chucking his right thumb in the direction of the rockface behind him and a break in it. A soft breeze blew in from the road beyond and Mer-Man could smell the captured animals through his pores. The wealth of aromas carried throughout the world of air above his home often overwhelmed Mer-Man, though he would never confess that to Beast Man. If Mer-Man gave any hint at being overwhelmed by the smells, Beast Man gave no sign as he concluded, "It's the usual amount. Nothing more."

"That's fine," Mer-Man said. "It is more than enough to sustain the creatures of the deep.

"Would it be better or make it worse to linger for a moment here?" he redirected.

"You know we're being watched," Beast Man grunted, not answering the question. "If not by Skeletor, then by Lyn."

"I doubt Skeletor has us surveilled," Mer-Man postulated. "I don't think he considers us that much when he doesn't have immediate need of us. As for Lyn, if she is watching us, she is smart enough to realize..."

"Realize what?" Beast Man asked, when Mer-Man did not seem inclined to finish his thought.

"That we are smarter than Skeletor thinks," Mer-Man concluded quietly.

"Maybe you," Beast Man contradicted. "Not me."

"You use more than telepathy, yes?" Mer-Man asked. Beast Man looked confused. The master of sea creatures sighed, a sound that reminded Beast Man of the last of the bathwater gurgling down a drain. "When you communicate with the animals of the field and jungle, you do so with more than just the power of your will, yes?"

"I speak with most," Beast Man agreed.

"How many languages do you speak? How many languages do you know? I doubt you get confused when you go from speaking to a sheep to conversing with a dog." Mer-Man observed.

"They are two very different languages," Beast Man said.

"And you keep them straight," Mer-Man reinforced. "You know innumerable languages; as many as there are for the animals of the land. I've seen you riding flying mammals, too... come to think of it, how are the Avionians not under your control? I wouldn't think bird brains would be harder to manipulate than bats and giant cats."

Beast Man shrugged, "It's not that. If I work hard enough, I can stop a man." He tapped his head to indicate he was referring to his telepathy.

"It is a lot of focus and willpower, though. I've only done it a couple of times and it left me with even more of a headache than I have now," Beast Man recalled. "Of course, that could be because I was getting in Ram Man's head..."

"It makes sense to start at the bottom and work your way up," Mer-Man noted. "But birds... Are you unable to control birds?"

"I haven't tried," Beast Man admitted, shame creeping into his voice. "I'm not a fan of flying."

"I suppose it is lucky for you that Skeletor has so many vehicles that are land vehicles," Mer-Man postulated.

"I get sick when the Roton gets some lift," Beast Man said. He grunted. "Knowing languages doesn't make me smart."

"It separates us from...," Mer-Man began before cutting himself off. "It makes us smarter than Skeletor knows. If Lyn is spying on us, she's intelligent enough to recognize that."

"That doesn't worry you?" Beast Man asked. His left hand involuntarily dropped to his waist, to gently finger the wound bullwhip coiled there.

"Should it?" Mer-Man asked. He shrugged and shook his head. He observed, "It doesn't. Lyn is loyal to Skeletor. You and I give Skeletor the power to rule over the land and the sea. Lyn brings magic to the table; I suppose she could kill us and use her sorcery to do what we do, but that would certainly divide her power. She is loyal to Skeletor; if she does anything to weaken his power base, that would reflect upon her.

"Besides, she's pretty cunning. Lyn might just not expose how smart we are to Skeletor because she has her own plans for us in the future."

"You've put a lot of thought into this for someone who is also loyal to Skeletor," Beast Man growled.

"One doesn't stay master of the oceans without thinking... all the time," Mer-Man philosophized. "It's rare that one my size commands everything under the sea. Maintaining that control means thinking a lot."

"And here I thought you were a coward," Beast Man mused. "You're always the first off the battlefield. I think only Two-Bad runs faster from the field than you."

"Two-Bad **is** a coward," Mer-Man quipped. A light breeze blew off the sea behind him and it made him feel drier, though he knew he had plenty more time before he needed to return to the water. He continued, "And an idiot. There's not enough wisdom in Grayskull to raise his intellect to the point of having common sense. No, I leave when we fail because I must return to the water. Skeletor rarely plans his endeavors around my environmental needs."

"'When we fail,'" Beast Man repeated with a snort. "And you're always back at the start of the next scheme of Skeletor's. And you carry that sword."

Beast Man nodded at the sword hanging from Mer-Man's belt. The sword was thick and yellowed, with sharp teeth adorning the blade's edge. Beast Man had seen the sword in action many times; the mismatched teeth changed a simple slice wound into one that was virtually impossible to recover from. Beast Man had had the opportunity to inspect such a wound early in their association. Skeletor did not assemble his team overnight and he had failed to communicate with his subordinates; shortly after making alliances with both Beast Man and Mer-Man, Beast Man had sent his tribesman to conquer a subaquatic village near the Vine Jungle. The body that had been returned to the jungle looked like it had been through a meat grinder.

"I carry the sword when I'm on business for Skeletor as a symbol of our alliance," Mer-Man confirmed. "He fashioned it from the bones of my last real enemy, whom he helped me overthrow. Beneath the surface, more often than not, I use my trident for battle. It might lack the fear-inducing power of the sword, but it

gets the job done. It also has symbolic value to my people. I suppose I have a symbol for below and above.

"You keep that whip," Mer-Man observed, nodding in the direction of Beast Man's hand and the coil he was still absently running his calloused fingers over.

"Same thing," Beast Man lied. "When Skeletor liberated me, he gave me the weapon The Enslaver was using on me. If you don't believe in Skeletor's vision, why do you go along with his plans?"

"Who says I don't believe in Skeletor's vision?" Mer-Man asked. His tone did not appear simply rhetorical. Beast Man grunted to stop his thought. The furry humanoid was surprised when Mer-Man continued with an earnest tone. "Skeletor is the only one fighting against the oppressors of the oceans. It's a natural alliance, actually.

"The past twenty years have seen unprecedented 'growth' in the land-dwellers. As Randor's kingdom has grown, he has formed alliances and built a vast industry; all of that at the expense of the watery domains. His forges drip metal and ash into our rivers, his barges clog our seas. The humans of Eternia sail our oceans, taking all the fish they want, for no other reason than they can." He snorted. "Their sewage runs off into my world and poisons all who live there. Randor and his allies fill the gills of my people with their waste. Their growth was unparalleled and showed no signs of stopping or slowing.

"Skeletor saw what they were doing and he offered me help in crushing Randor's navy," Mer-Man revealed. "Within a month of joining forces, Randor's merchant fleet and naval ships were all but wiped out on the Ocean Of Gnarl and the Sea Of Rakash. Randor was forced to create an alliance with the Avionans that is exceptionally costly... just to move his goods over the waters of Eternia. Skeletor knew what he was doing; there have long been tensions between the Avionans and the Andreenids. Randor creating such a strong economic alliance with one, certainly upset the other.

"I was able to liberate the oceans and while there are occasional pirates that slip by, for the most part the waterways are getting clearer. I knew what I was getting into with an alliance with Skeletor; I freed my people and protected my environment. The cost is occasionally to help the one who helped me. What do I care if Skeletor overthrows the other land-dwellers?

"He's already shown me he wouldn't be as bad as Randor," Mer-Man concluded.

"You're not worried that when he's done with Randor, he'll come for the seas?" Beast Man asked.

"To what end?" Mer-Man asked. "If Skeletor wins, he'll be preoccupied with the task of maintaining control. I keep my people happy, content; most are satisfied to let me rule over them. Land-dwellers seem to me to be a particularly miserable bunch, the humans especially. Skeletor can win up here, but keeping his victory would be a full-time job. His robotic army is vulnerable to sea water..."

"No kidding," Beast Man in a tone of mild epiphany. He picked up Mer-Man's train of thought. "And our lungs won't let us breathe underwater, so it would be hard for the rest of his forces to wage war on your turf."

"Made even harder by the fact that I've aided Skeletor with armoring his forces," Mer-Man continued. "The bones of my dead make for armor that inspires fear and reinforces many of his soldiers and spies who need light armor. It is not, admittedly, the strongest armor and it is particularly vulnerable to the weapons made by my armies for exactly the purpose of cutting through denizens of the seas.

"It would be unbearably costly for Skeletor to try to conquer my territories. It would be unwise for him to betray me and despoil the waterways and oceans as well. His only solution would be to destroy the oceans altogether and that would kill almost every

living thing on the surface world. Skeletor is neither so stupid, nor so short-sighted.

"But yes," Mer-Man concluded. "I believe in Skeletor's vision for Eternia."

"He insults you all the time," Beast Man grumbled.

"He insults everyone," Mer-Man acknowledged with a shrug. "He's like a child that way. He's frustrated and he doesn't deal with it well. Dealing with him is a small sacrifice to make for my people. Listening to a temper tantrum once every few weeks is a small price to pay for keeping my people's gills free of the filth Randor's people drop into my world."

Beast Man contemplated Mer-Man's words for a moment, then dared to vocalize, "It sounds like he needs us more than we need him."

"He does," Mer-Man agreed. "But he also brought us all together for common purpose. Say what you will about Skeletor's ambitions, he knows how to bring people together. Look at us; to keep peace between us, we work together. We are stronger for this alliance, even when we work outside his purview."

"Like tonight," Beast Man realized. For the first time since Mer-Man had arrived, Beast Man's eyes fixed on the kelp rope the green humanoid held loosely in his webbed hand.

"Not only are we feeding our people," Mer-Man articulated, "it has made us both more organized and stronger. Your carnivores take my weakest and infirm; your aged feed my leviathans. Whether Skeletor wins or loses his attempts for Eternia, our subjects are stronger for our alliance."

"Hmm," Beast Man grunted. After a moment, he observed, "My headache went away."

"It's refreshing to be around someone who isn't in here," Mer-Man said, tapping his own head with his free hand.

"Refreshing," Beast Man scoffed, though his lips pulled back in a sneer that showed off his filthy, yellowing teeth. Mer-Man had been around the muscular mammal long enough to recognize the expression as the closest he could get to smiling. "You wouldn't last a day in the jungle.

"I have a long night ahead of me," Beast Man said, rising to his feet. "I've got many mouths to feed before I get back."

"Of course," Mer-Man replied, matching Beast Man's movement and once again offering the end of the rope to his ally. "I'll give you a few minutes, then come back for the caravan. See you next month."

"I'm sure we'll see each other before then," Beast Man theorized, taking the wet kelp rope in his hand. "Skeletor always has something going on."

Mer-Man nodded, then turned silently to dive off the rocks into the water beyond. He swam down, ignoring the confused thoughts of the schools of netted fish he swam past as Beast Man tugged the rope and pulled the nets from the water. The cold water surrounding him felt good and within moments of breathing underwater, Mer-Man felt reinvigorated. So energized, Mer-Man swam through the cold, dark water much further than he originally intended.

When he returned for the caravan, Beast Man and the fish were gone and the night air was filled with the bleating of Beast Man's sheep and swamp hoppers and their accompanying smell which would soon disappear with them in the salty depths.

Scars Of The Whip

The wind from the canyon carried the smell of fish through the caravan to the pilot's capsule as Beast Man guided the vehicle through the mountains toward the jungle. Mer-Man's words echoed in his mind and Beast Man felt bad. As he manipulated the controls, there was not much else to do but think. Beast Man was not very introspective, but with nothing else to pay attention to, his mind wandered. He felt bad.

The source of his agitation took little time to become clear. As the moonslight lit the path ahead and the smell of fish filled his nostrils, Beast Man's mind kept returning to the sword Mer-Man carried on his belt. Whenever he noticed the sword, Beast Man thought of Thur. As he left their rendezvous, Beast Man found himself troubled thinking of the sword and Thur. More than anything, Beast Man became fixated on Thur, the name, the face it conjured, the sound of the name being growled out in Beast Man's own voice.

Beast Man felt frustrated. He had clear memories of Thur, up to and including inspecting the wounds that ghastly sword had done to his lieutenant and friend, but under the moonslight as he drove the caravan, he realized all those memories were corrupted. In every memory he could conjure of Thur, there was Thur and Beast Man. Beast Man's brow furrowed with that.

Why was he Beast Man in those memories? He had a name back then. He knew he did. The Enslaver had called him Beast. As he manipulated the controls before him with his left hand, Beast Man's right hand reached up to scratch his right shoulder. Beneath his claws, he could feel the scars on his shoulder and back left by the Enslaver's whip. The scars from the Enslaver's whip never fully healed; Skeletor always found a reason to reopen them with his magic. It hurt whenever he did that. Beast Man did not like to feel that pain.

Skeletor had called him Beast Man when he liberated him from the Enslaver, but Thur knew him by a different name. It felt bad to strain to try to recall what that name was. It felt bad to not remember and to be frustrated by the attempt.

Beast Man blinked and focused his gaze on the road ahead. When he focused on driving, he didn't feel as bad.

Only one moon had risen above the canopy of the jungle when Beast Man and Thur raced through the trees. The night air was hot and humid and it felt good on Beast Man's face compared to the cool air of the cavern in which they had awoken. Most of the tribe was at the stream, pulling fish out for first meal, but Beast Man and Thur had awoken energized and they wanted to run. They rushed through the trees, sometimes on hind legs, sometimes on all fours, with such speed that the rabbits, swamp hoppers and squirrels that fled before them barely registered in the vision of either of the young fur-covered men.

As Beast Man began to pull ahead, Thur exerted himself to make a powerful lunge at his friend. His arms closed around Beast Man's legs and the pair crashed to the leaf and moss-covered ground. The move would have been painful had Beast Man not pulled his legs toward his chest and Thur not mimicked the motion. The result was that even as Beast Man's legs were torn out from under him, the pair united as a hairy entangled ball that rolled out of the run comparatively safely. The landing was hardly flawless and the pair bounced messily off a tree before rolling together to a stop. The jungle floor bore evidence of their collision with a series of streaks where the foliage had been scraped from the ground. Neither man was hurt.

Beast Man playfully shoved mud and wet leaves into his friend's face as he pushed off Thur into a crouching position. Thur made no move to rise. Instead, he looked up at Beast Man and smiled.

"Want to go run around the next valley?" Thur asked. He licked his yellowed fangs and his eyes were filled with innuendo that Beast Man found obvious. Trat lived in the adjacent valley and she had recently come of age. Beast Man and Thur had joked that the real race had begun, but neither had made a move on her yet. Perhaps Thur would mate with her first, maybe Beast Man would find her in heat; maybe they both would. The idea of Thur and Beastman having pups from the same litter had a strange appeal to Beast Man. The idea of tracking down Trat had appeal as well.

"Hmm," Beast Man mused, trying to decide what to do. They could run, they could visit Trat, they could eat; options abounded. While Beast Man contemplated, overhead, swamp bats hunted insects and small birds.

"She won't wait forever," Thur noted, tossing leaves and mud at Beast Man to break him from his reverie.

"I'm hungry," Beast Man decided. His eyes began scouring the nearby trees for something to eat. "It won't do to get there only to be too tired to mate!"

"Ha! You'll eat your fill of moles and wolf pups and be too tired to mate then!" Thur joked, still making no move to get off his back.

"I could go for a nice peacock," Beast Man stated. There had been several nesting in the trees not far from where they were, so Beast Man began to lumber off in that direction. He hoped his tribe had not found and consumed them all, though most of his tribe did not stray as far from the cavern and stream as did Beast Man and Thur.

"Mmm, peafowl!" Thur said by way of agreement, following on Beast Man's heels after a moment. "Do you think Trat likes feathers? We could bring her some..."

Beast Man grunted to indicate his ignorance. He had not given much thought to what Trat liked; he had never seen her with feathers, but he had only recently started to notice her.

It took the pair an hour to find a peacock. They took it down fast, though neither Beast Man nor Thur was certain whose telepathy stopped the bird's heart. They could have leapt at it, decapitated it with a swift swipe of their clawed fingers, but several weeks ago, both had agreed that the adrenalin from the bird's fear and pain tainted the flavor of the meat. They had agreed then that it was better to use their energy for running, play, mating, rather than hunting. It made more sense to use their gift and enjoy the meat, then the benefits of the meat. Thur had laughed when Beast Man had joked, "We put more into getting the meat than we get from the meat!" So that night, they made easy work of the peacock.

"You decided to save some," Beast Man noted as they ate. Thur was carefully plucking feathers from the peacock's carcass and setting them aside.

"Yeah," Thur noted. He flinched slightly as Beast Man reached toward his pile of feathers. "Many were broken when it fell, but these seem nice."

"You should dip them," Beast Man asserted, picking one up surprisingly carefully. He rotated it in his fingers so the hollow end pointed down. He brought the feather to the carcass and slowly dipped the calamus into a puddle of blood. Thur watched as Beast Man coated the end of the feather. His friend slowly passed the feather back to him when the calamus shaft was coated.

Beast Man pointed at the entrails and advised, "Liver. Gall bladder. Dipping shows... they weren't just some leftovers you picked up."

"Smart," Thur said. He handed Beast Man a feather before taking one himself and jabbing it into the bird's pancreas. Beast

Man smiled.

When they were done, Thur gathered up the feathers and the pair began to meander on their legs alone toward the nearby valley. Beast Man chewed on the peacock's beak as they wandered. When they entered Trat's valley, the young men could smell her on the jungle wind and they quickened their pace unconsciously. The second moon was directly overhead when they found the cave her tribe slept in. None were about.

Beast Man and Thur remained together, scouring the jungle for Trat. They did not find her, though they smelled her and members of her tribe frequently as they moved through the valley. After a time, they became frustrated and wordlessly decided to turn back for their own valley.

"We should leave the feathers," Beast Man said. He led the way back toward the cavern Trat's tribe would return to at the end of the night.

"We should put our scent on them," Thur said. "So she knows they are from us."

"You first!" Beast Man challenged. Thur stopped walking and carefully began to rub the feathers in his armpit and along his groin. Beast Man laughed.

"You too!" Thur insisted. Beast Man grunted, but took some of the feathers and mimicked his tribemate's motions. Thur inhaled deeply, an exaggeration given how little they needed to breathe in to catch a scent, and declared, "Powerful musk!"

Beast Man laughed and the pair deposited the feathers in the young woman's cavern before heading back to their own cave.

The next morning, Beast Man, Thur and their entire tribe was awoken by the ground shaking. As the tribe untangled from their sleeping ball, its members sleepily rose and wandered toward the entrance of the cavern. The ground shook more and more regularly as Beast Man smacked Thur's shoulder to get him to

wake. By the time Beast Man and Thur reached the mouth of their sleeping cave, most of the tribe was spreading out in the jungle just beyond. As the ground shook, the air carried upon it the unmistakable sound of trees splitting.

Occasionally, there was a storm that would uproot a tree. Somewhat more frequently was a lightning strike that would shatter a tree. Beast Man had heard both sounds rarely in his life, but never forgotten the distinctive thunder and crash. He had never heard the sound so regularly, frequently, nor close to the cave. He glanced at Thur. Thur's eyes were wide with fear and Beast Man was certain his expression mirrored his friend's.

"What?" Thur asked.

Beast Man merely shook his head to indicate his ignorance in response. While the rest of the tribe began to slowly advance on the sound of crashing trees, Beast Man stood frozen near the cavern entrance with Thur.

Despite the cacophony, Beast Man could hear voices in the distance. The voices were higher-pitched than those of his tribe and he did not recognize all the words they said. But hearing the voices so close to where the trees were coming down filled Beast Man with an even greater fear than he felt from the sound of the demise of the trees.

"Damn," the voice in the distance called out. "There are more of them over here! Get the clear team!"

Beast Man turned on his heel to face Thur. Thur still looked in shock in the direction of the voice, their tribemates, the crashing trees. Beast Man reached out and smacked Thur's bare chest twice with his calloused hand, to break his friend from his reverie. Thur blinked.

Wordlessly, the young men bolted in the opposite direction of the sounds. The last noise Beast Man heard over the sound of his

and Thur's run through the jungle was that of one of his younger sisters wailing in shock and pain somewhere far behind.

Without planning to, Beast Man and Thur ran to the mountains that separated the jungle from the sea. They ran in panicked silence for hours without slowing. As the terrain began to become more rocky and the trees changed, the pair slowed. They found themselves in a small clearing. While Beast Man looked around, Thur stepped behind a tree, reached into a small hole he found there, and pulled out a groundhog for the pair to consume.

"What was that?" Thur asked, fear and shock evident in his voice.

Beast Man growled, removing another pebble that had been lodged in the skin of his hand. He had not felt it; it might have been in his palm for hours the way he had been running. As he tossed the rock aside, he looked out on the jungle. They had stopped at an elevated point, which allowed them to surveil much of the jungle beyond from a higher position. In the distance, plumes of smoke rose into the sky. They had traveled so far beyond where either had run before, neither Beast Man nor Thur had any idea of the scope or scale of the jungle they had come from.

Beast Man shook his head and admitted, "I have no idea."

The rocks of the mountain pass opened up to the jungle and as Beast Man drove the vehicle at the head of the caravan through the last of the boulders, his stomach tightened. The road that cut through the Vine Jungle now seemed so well-worn, but Beast Man never forgot that day, nor the terror he felt as he ran from Randor's men. He and Thur had returned to their valley home, but never found another member of their tribe after that day. Even Trat's tribe appeared to have disappeared completely. As Beast Man drove the caravan through his old home, he wondered if we would even recognize the part of the road that occupied his

tribe's lands. It had been so long since Randor had established the road and butchered a swath of the jungle.

The modified jet crawler hummed along as Beast Man relaxed his grip on the vehicle's controls. Tri-Klops had modified this crawler for power over speed, which allowed the vehicle to pull the train cars filled with fish behind it. It had taken a few trades with Mer-Man, building up the convoy vehicles, before Beast Man became fully comfortable with leaving an empty caravan behind for Mer-Man to fill. His aquatic counterpart had not yet betrayed Beast Man, but Beast Man felt like he would at some point.

Everyone betrayed everyone else, that was what Eternia had become. Randor and his forces betrayed the natural world, everyone Skeletor recruited had their own agenda; there were no tribes left. Tribes looked out for one another, they worked together, a realization that made Beast Man feel longing. Maybe he just felt hungry; both feelings originated in the pit of his stomach. The smell of fish permeated his nostrils so pungently that he did not think he could become hungry so suddenly. He missed his tribe, he concluded.

Maybe this is what Thur felt when they were separated, Beast Man realized.

Thur and Beast Man had moved to a den three valleys north of the road. It had become too dangerous for the pair to continue to try to stop Randor's men. When they had returned to the valley of their home, they found no one left, not even their scent. The jungle's lush foliage had been torn out, replaced with the smell of oil and smoke and a wind that carried the scent of metal from somewhere far away. The night of their return, Beast Man and Thur raged. The vehicles Randor's men used to clear their disgusting path, still covered in their carnage of vegetation fragments, lay quiet at the day's stopping point. Beast Man and Thur had torn through the metal with their bare hands and teeth.

They found the worker's camp not far away, close to the cave where Beast Man and Thur's tribe had slept only days prior. Even with claws that were jagged from clumsily tearing at metal, Beast Man and Thur rended canvas and flesh in their anger. They did not keep count, but each had killed at least four sleeping men or women before the camp awoke in panic and began to organize a defense. One worker managed to shoot Thur in the leg, a blast that singed his fur and cauterized a hole in his calf muscle, but the pair still managed to evade Randor's work crews to escape. Beast Man found a nice hollow tree to leave Thur in so his friend could recover. He brought him berries and rabbits to aid in his healing.

And Beast Man hunted at night. He was shocked when the camp did not simply collapse the day after they had destroyed their equipment. Instead, the survivors went to work and discovered the ruined vehicles. They worked together to restore power to one and it lasted long enough for them to call for help and replacement parts. When Beast Man realized what they were doing, in disgust, he threw a log, which crushed the skull of the worker who was operating the radio.

The camp did not go away. Randor's workers waited by day, going in groups of ten or more to the wrecked vehicles and carving into the jungle with machetes and blasters and shovels. Their pace was pathetic compared to the devastation their vehicles had wrought, but Beast Man quickly realized that the men were not stopping. Each night, after hunting or gathering food for Thur and bringing him water, Beast Man hunted at the camp.

At first, it was easy; he snuck in and smelled for tents with lone occupants. They were easy enough to kill, snapping their necks and pulling their limp corpses out to the treeline. For the first two nights, he was able to get four and three kills. He left the bodies eviscerated and hanging from the trees, making it clear that these were no natural deaths and these men and women were in a place they did not belong. On the third night, the workers posted more guards and they slept in communal tents of at least five people. Beast Man was only able to dispatch two that night,

guards both, and without any flair. The next day, reinforcements arrived, a legion of royal guards, workers and vehicles that cut, dug, chopped and burned.

"I'm sorry," Beast Man whispered to Thur after running reconnaissance. He had no need to whisper; the noise of the jungle nearby being stripped and torn was deafening.

"I am proud you tried," Thur said. He sounded confused as he added, "I don't know why they are doing this."

"It doesn't matter," Beast Man replied. "They are doing it. It looks like they will complete it. I cannot stop them and you're in no position to help.

"There's no shame in that," Beast Man reassured, seeing Thur's frown. "You fought as long as you could. Regain your strength and we will fight again! But this fight seems over. We have to leave. Are you able to move?"

"I am," Thur stated with determination. He had not spent much time trying his legs since he was shot. In fact, he had been crawling out of the stump and back when he needed to evacuate, but he spoke with determination that Beast Man trusted. Thur carefully rose to his feet; the days of rest had had the desired effect.

"We should put some distance between us and them," Beast Man said, "in case they brought hunters with them. We can rest in the afternoon and tonight search for a new home."

"Okay," Thur agreed and they quietly left the hollow tree. After an hour of carefully walking, the pair entered the thick jungle, which still reverberated with the sounds of the roadmakers tearing apart the trees behind them. In the thicker trees, the pair climbed into the canopy and began swinging their way away from the metal juggernauts that were destroying all they ever knew.

They settled in the far end of a valley three valleys from the road. Both felt the buffer was enough and Beast Man found an

abandoned den that was sufficient for sleeping. Thur's sharp nose had found a warren near a grove of catcher plants, very close to the den. The catcher plants were starving; the rabbits of the warren apparently the clever survivors of the community. Recognizing that the grove was one the clearer paths between their new home and the distant road, Thur and Beast Man spent weeks carefully culling the rabbits and nursing the catcher plants back to full health.

In that time, Thur recovered nicely. The hole in his leg stopped hurting and he walked with a limp only someone as attuned to him as Beast Man would detect. Without saying it, both knew that Thur would never be as fast as Beast Man again.

Shortly after they had established their new home and built a natural defense with the catcher plants, everything changed once again.

Dusk had fallen and Beast Man and Thur decided to hunt something larger. They knew there were bears and tigers nearby; the entire ecosystem was still in turmoil from the road's creation. Displaced animals were traveling in such quantities that often predators and prey would pass through the same area within minutes, not bothering to hunt or flee from one another. Beast Man had a hankering for bear and both he and Thur knew whatever they couldn't eat would feed the catcher plants for days.

Not far from their new home, Beast Man caught the scent of a bear and he smiled at Thur.

"This way," he indicated, leading his friend away from the grove of catcher plants.

"You know my sense of smell is superior," Thur bragged.

"Since when?" Beast Man growled back playfully.

"Always," he replied. To illustrate, he stopped walking, stood up taller and inhaled deeply. "What's that?"

There was something subtle in his tone, a shift that was clear to Beast Man that his tribemate was no longer joking, that made Beast Man look in his direction. Alarm glistened in Thur's now wide eyes.

Thur's voice was filled with a tone of confusion as he identified, "Roses? Pears?"

Beast Man dropped to a crouch and inhaled. His nose filled with the aroma from the nearby honeysuckle vines and he could smell the bear and dirt on the wind as well. Then he caught the scent Thur indicated.

"Roses don't grow in the Vine Jungle," Thur said, voice still embodying confusion. "Neither do pears."

Beast Man inhaled again, stomach sinking as his supposition was confirmed. He smelled the barest hint of lye.

"Men," he grumbled.

"How many?" Thur asked, dropping down and sidling over to Beast Man.

"I don't know," Beast Man said, confused. Wherever they were, they were keeping quiet and it seemed they had all used the same soap.

"Let's find out," Thur decided, sliding past Beast Man. He kept low to the ground, his knuckles occasionally dragging along the moss and leaf-strewn floor of the jungle.

"Wait!" Beast Man whispered, fear in his voice. Thur ignored him and kept moving. Beast Man lurched into motion. Something did not feel right.

In the dim light from the moons that broke through the canopy of the next clearing, they saw the hunters instantly. They stood at the far end of the clearing, rifles drawn. Thur was focused on

the trio ahead when Beast Man heard the snap of a twig to his left.

Beast Man leapt with all the power his legs had ever mustered and his body rocketed forward into the clearing. As he soared through the air, he straightened and twisted, rotating so his back was to Thur. Beast Man's shoulders hit Thur squarely on his left side, midsection. The force knocked Thur to the right and he went down on one knee, eyes still locked on the trio of hunters before him at the other end of the clearing. Beast Man's gaze was fixated to Thur's left, to where the twig had snapped. He was unsurprised to see the hunter there.

The fourth hunter wore a bear pelt and his skin was covered in dirt from the jungle floor. He carried a fancy rifle which discharged as Beast Man's body flew and rotated. The motion was enough to protect Thur.

The volley of darts from the clever hunter's rifle hit Beast Man directly in his sternum. As his vision blurred, he saw the darts in his chest; a perfect circle of feathers embedded in his skin. His rotational motion carried him as far as it could and Beast Man came crashing to the ground of the clearing. There was an explosion of gunpowder behind him.

Beast Man did not look for the second shot. Instead, his eyes locked on Thur as the muscles of his legs collapsed. Why wasn't his body working? He reached out his hand toward Thur, but in his vision, his arm was at an angle that did not match his intent.

"Run," he may have ordered his tribemate and friend as the thick net shot at him wrapped around him. The weights on the sides pulled him forward and the ground or darkness met him.

"Get him, fools!" the hunter's voice rang out before Beast Man's world turned to darkness.

Beast Man pulled back on the controls as he drove into the clearing, slowing the jet crawler and the caravan behind. When the vehicles had stopped, he put the brake on - Tri-Klops still mocked him for failing to do that on his first run - and turned the crawler off. Beast Man exited the vehicle and approached the first boxcar of the caravan train.

He was grateful he no longer had a headache as he opened the container and sent out the telepathic call to the animals of the jungle. Many of the large animals were surprisingly close; they had become accustomed to the feedings and less scared of Beast Man's monthly caravan. Any other large carnivores that liked fish that were within range of Beast Man's telepathy would soon be there, feeling docile. It had taken Beast Man a few attempts to refine his telepathic call to bring the right animals to him and for them to only want to feed on the fish, instead of attacking each other.

As he extended the invitation from his mind to the animals and mindlessly flung fish from the container, Beast Man's mind once again wandered.

"What is it?" the fancy voice said, a moment before another bucket of cold water splashed onto Beast Man. The bucket had recently held fish and he suspected the water had been ice not too long ago. He regained consciousness with the realization that this was at least the second bucket of water to be tossed on him.

Beast Man roared in pain from the cold. He tried to sit up but in his shock he failed to orient himself. He had been passed out, face-down. The result of his attempt to sit was to bang his head on the metal floor of the cart cage in which he found himself trapped. He opened his eyes to filthy iron, water and his own fur. He moved to brush his hair out of his eye, but instead his other hand punched him in the jaw. Confused, Beast Man closed his eyes, then leaned back, rolling into a sitting position. He was

supported by his toes and knees, his hindquarters coming to rest on his heels. So stable, he flipped his head back once again.

This time, his movement had the desired effect, his wet fur and hair flung back out of his face and eyes. He opened his eyes carefully and above him in bright lights was a sign that read "Robert's Amazing Circus!" He looked down to see that his wrists were bound in iron shackles that were connected by a very short, thick chain.

"Whatever it is, Rober," a voice behind Beast Man began, "it's smart. The other one took out the rest of the team."

The voice sounded familiar to Beast Man and he realized before glancing over his shoulder that it was the hunter who had taken him down who was speaking.

"It got away, though?" the man the hunter had addressed as Rober asked in a voice that embodied class. His voice also contained an element of disregard, as if he wanted the information, but did not so much care about the answer. He looked at Beast Man with curiosity and interest.

"I'm saying this thing's friend killed three of my men," the hunter said. "It's dangerous."

"Of course it is," the man said, coming closer to the cage. He was a clean-looking man with a thin mustache that ended in waxed curls. He wore a black tophat, black jacket and clean black slacks that looked like they were pressed moments before based on the crispness of the pleats. The white button-down shirt he wore was spotless and bright. Rober wore boots studded in crystals and he looked Beast Man over with a keen interest and intelligent eyes that never stopped moving.

"That makes i... him perfect for the circus," the man continued. "People want to see something incredibly dangerous without suffering the consequences. It's a shame you couldn't

capture the other one; they could have done some tricks in tandem, perhaps."

"That's your department," the hunter declared. "I just want to get paid."

"Dolores will take care of you," the man said. "Bring him around back and I'll get the authorization."

He walked off toward the sign and the hunter stepped closer to the cage.

"I'm going to go back for your friend," the hunter whispered to Beast Man. He shoved a prod through the bars in the cage and there was a blinding pain that encompassed the captive before darkness once again took him.

The unintended consequence of the feeding broke Beast Man's reverie. Beast Man's telepathy had drawn a multitude of large animals to the clearing where they had consumed the fish he brought; his empathy allowed him to feel their contentment and joy at being fed. As the warm jungle breeze wafted over him, Beast Man closed his eyes and opened his mind to the raw emotions of the animals.

Beast Man was surrounded with joy and it felt amazing.

Beast Man awoke in lamplight, overcome with misery. He was surrounded by pain and sadness and it made Beast Man feel like something inside was being torn in half. Over and over again, Beast Man was overcome with the waves of emotions of the animals he could not see, but whose feelings he felt in his heart, in his mind, in whatever was deeper within him. The emotions did not ebb, though and he vomited from the sustained terror of those around him.

"What is wrong with you?" the man the hunter had referred to as Rober asked as he approached the cage. "Did you eat something that disagreed with you? Or maybe it's an effect of the tranquilizers?"

"I don't know," Beast Man growled, resisting the urge to throw up again. He leaned back into a sitting position. As he very slowly and carefully raised his bound hands to wipe the corner of his mouth, the shocked man in the fancy clothes addressed him.

"You can speak?! That's amazing!" Beast Man could see that in one hand he held an otter pelt, in the other a whip.

"Of course I can speak," Beast Man grunted.

"How do you know our language?" the man asked. Resisting the urge to vomit again, Beast Man carefully lifted his hands to his head and he tapped his right index finger on the edge of his head, the best way he could think to explain his telepathy. The man smiled, though Beast Man felt no real joy emanate from him as he did so, and cried out, "Magnificent!

"Put this on," Rober demanded, tossing the otter pelt into the cage. Beast Man made no move to retrieve the garment when it landed near the puddle of bile on the floor of the cage. "Cover up; you'll scare the children. Women, too. Then it becomes a different kind of circus."

Beast Man made no move to retrieve the otter pelt and the Enslaver repeated his demand that Beast Man dress, this time pantomiming the act. Beast Man glared at the Enslaver and shook his head. The man nodded and raised the whip.

"Do it," Rober insisted. Beast Man rose from his crouch to a standing position. The ground upon which the man walked was hard-packed dirt; wherever they were it was a well-traveled space. As the man moved to a position behind Beast Man, Beast Man looked around. To his left, beyond the rolling cage, was a white brick wall. To his right and in front there was a massive

canvas wall that suggested a tent a size unlike anything Beast Man had ever seen before. The captive realized he was in an alley of sorts and somewhere before him and to the left were the other captured animals the Enslaver was keeping.

The whip was a thick tendril of metal, a chain perhaps, that was coated in a weave of flexible leather. At the end of the whip were five strands of leather that unwound from the weave and ended in an ornament. As the ornaments dragged along the dirt, they clattered and Beast Man glanced at them. He recognized a raptor's talon, a shark's tooth, a small barbed metal spike and what appeared to be a small piece of glass. Beast Man realized that the net effect of this particular whip was that it would do some actual damage, like a flail, when the tips hit.

"Last chance," the Enslaver said, in a matter-of-fact tone. Beast Man stood taller.

By this point, the Enslaver was behind his captive and Beast Man was unsurprised to hear the sound of the man's arm moving and the whip's tips leaving the ground.

Even the pain did not surprise Beast Man as the tips cut into the flesh of his shoulder and drew bloody paths down his back. What shocked Beast Man was the accuracy with which the strike came. Rober struck with a quick motion, sending the whip in between the bars of the cage with such speed and efficiency that none of the barbs came anywhere close to the bars. Instead, the motion of the man's wrist and arm moved the whip so the tips came together, passed through the space between to bars, connected with the flesh and muscles of Beast Man's back, tore down and off his skin, then came back together and went back out the cage the way they came. Beast Man fell to his knees, his left knee splashing his sick out of the cage.

"Put on the brief," Rober ordered again.

"It would be easier if my hands weren't bound," Beast Man growled, reaching for the otter pelt the Enslaver had tossed in.

"I'm sure it would," the man noted, laughter in his voice. "It's not going to happen, though. So, you're the Amazing Vomiting Beast. What tricks can you do?"

"I could tear your arms off without blinking," Beast Man said, carefully stepping into the brief. He tucked himself back into the pelt as the man watched him, eyes full of mirth.

"That is a trick you shall never have the opportunity to perform," the Enslaver insisted. To reiterate the point, he wound up to crack the whip again and before Beast Man could react, the five tips were lacerating his upper thigh. As the whip retracted, Beast Man made a feeble attempt to grab at the flexible leather, despite the pain he felt. The motion put his hand in the path of the fragment of glass and the smooth surface slid into the flesh of his forearm. The glass sliced a clean cut from his wrist along his right thumb, before the force of the whip pulled it back with the other ends out of the cage.

Beast Man roared in pain and grabbed his wrist with his left hand.

"Try not to bleed to death before our veterinarian can see you," the Enslaver demanded, not making a move to leave the cage. As he spoke, he wound the whip up, wiping it off with a cloth he produced in his other hand. When he was done, he clipped the whip onto his belt. "I'd rather not have to keep doing that. If you're a slow learner, we're going to have to dress you up; people aren't going to want to see all that. But you're going to have to listen and you're going to have to perform. That is your life now. We're going to come up with a routine for you and you're going to do it. Learn it fast, learn that this if all there is for you fast and these will be the only lashes you ever get from this whip."

Without another word, the Enslaver walked away, while Beast Man held the flesh of his right wrist together and felt the blood flowing from the lacerations on his back, shoulder and thigh.

When the fish from the first of the caravan's containers were gone, the animals departed, content. As they dispersed, Beast Man relinquished his control and they fled off before any of their peers decided to fight. Beast Man resealed the container and returned to the cockpit of the jet crawler. When he activated the engines, he waited a moment, giving time for all of the smaller animals along the length of the caravan to scurry away. Then, he deactivated the brake and pushed the controls forward, sending the caravan back on its way.

Beast Man activated the headlights on the jet crawler, despite the fact he did not need them. The moonslight was enough for him to see by, even in the areas of the jungle where the canopy had regrown high above the road. He kept the headlights on for the animals that traveled the road. For some reason, the noise of the caravan alerted most of them, but they were not afraid enough to get out of the way when the lead vehicle was darkened. Somehow, having the lights on informed the lesser animals that the noise was a sufficient danger to flee from. Beast Man had never quite figured it out, but he knew it worked and then he didn't have to deal with the confusion of animals who came for the free meal and saw roadkill on the tires of the train cars.

It occurred to Beast Man that he should feel inherently unsafe on the road, but he had traveled with a caravan like this so many times now that the road no longer bothered him. He felt in control. So as the road through the jungle wound, his mind once again drifted.

Beast Man's back was a map of scars on the day Robert's Amazing Circus rolled into Eternos. Beast Man had no fresh welts and, in fact, had earned a fresh otter pelt brief for his good behavior at the circus's last stop.

The truth was, Beast Man was broken. The Enslaver referred to him solely as The Beast and for many months, Beast Man had

complied with the man because it was easier than enduring the pain left long after the whip rended his flesh and because he was sad. The pain had led Beast Man to work with the Enslaver to create an obstacle course in the center ring that allowed The Beast to best his more traditional animal counterparts at feats of strength, dexterity and endurance. After wrestling a bear, flipping between various trapezes and racing a seal along a winding track filled with objects to avoid, Beast Man would leap into the air to a height that always shocked the people in attendance. It was the only time in any of his days since his capture that he was happy. For one brief instant every performance, he would approach the top of the massive tent, hear the crowd roar with delight, feel their astonishment, then experience that moment of weightlessness at the apex of the jump. That was happiness. That was freedom.

That feeling was fleeting.

Most of his life was misery. The space limitations of the traveling circus were such that the animals were kept in very close quarters. For the bulk of their travels, the rabbits and swamp hoppers that were part of the sideshow were kept in cages right next to the elephant's pen and the tiger cages. The result was that the small animals were consistently terrified, the predators frustrated and occasionally hurt when they would lunge into the bars of their cage. These powerful emotions radiated from every animal in the circus at all times they were contained and Beast Man was caged among them. So surrounded, Beast Man was psychically bombarded constantly and his own emotional spectrum was limited to despondency.

In Eternos, Rober had decided to change up the usual routine Beast Man performed. Word had already reached the capital city of the impressive Beast and the feat of strength he performed that astounded audiences. For the capital city, the Enslaver wanted to up the game. As such, Beast Man would be lifting not just one elephant, but two. The practice attempts had not gone well as the process of lifting two elephants involved using a truss that balanced two elephants upon it. So far, none of the

constructed trusses had held when Beast Man tried to lift them with the elephants. Fortunately for Beast Man, the Enslaver had taken his ire for every iteration of shattered truss out on the engineer who built them and not the performer.

The engineer came back with the final truss only minutes before the matinee performance in Eternos, but the Enslaver had insisted Beast Man would make the attempt during the matinee.

The attempt would never be made.

One of the attendants, a boy Beast Man did not know well, but knew never provided him with anything but the bare minimum of fish when he fed him, released Beast Man from his cage five minutes before his part in the performance was to begin. Beast Man stretched and enjoyed the ability to pace for a moment before he was led to the corridor and the opening in the tent that led into the center ring of the circus. The two elephants Beast Man was expected to lift were ambling toward the same entrance when all hell broke loose.

Beast Man could smell smoke and he felt the fear of the horses that were in the big top. As he and the elephants approached the entrance to the massive tent, Beast Man could hear blaster shots and he flinched instinctively. Out in the tent, the crowd began to shout and the panicked sound of so many bodies attempting to move at once out of fear flooded Beast Man's ears.

Two cloaked individuals appeared in the corridor before Beast Man.

"Here it is," the man said, excitedly. The man gestured to his companion with a blue-skinned hand and he waved at one of the elephants before him. "How soon until you can make another portal?"

"I need just a moment more," the cloaked woman beside him said. Her voice was the embodiment of exhaustion and as Beast Man approached, that feeling became palpable, like a thickness in

the air around her. The man unsheathed a sword and took up a defensive position near the woman. In one hand he held the broadsword, in his other, he held a staff with a ram's head.

"Who are you?" Beast Man asked as he approached.

"We are of no concern to you!" the man declared, swinging toward Beast Man. He stopped the lunge he was making with the sword as he saw who had spoken to him. Beast Man's eyes widened in surprise; he had never seen anyone like this man before. While the cloak covered most of his skin, what was visible was light blue, like the edges of a frozen wound,. What surprised Beast Man most was the man's face or lack thereof. The man's face was missing; there was no flesh upon it. From the shadows of the cloak's hood, Beast Man could see just a yellowed skull. The man did not even have eyes, rather he possessed two glowing red orbs set back in the sockets where eyes should have been. The skull, however, seemed connected to a very blue neck that trembled as the man inhaled.

"Ahh, you're the one they call the Beast," the invader said, apparently seeing Beast Man. "But you're not, are you?"

"I don't know," Beast Man grumbled.

"No, you're not," the skull-faced man declared, wonder filling his voice. In the same high pitched, scratchy tone, he continued, "You are something else, aren't you? You're the best of both, I think. You're some sort of beast and man. You can use this opportunity to escape this wretched circus, Beast Man!"

"Where would I go?" Beast Man croaked out. He had no idea where he was in relation to the Vine Jungle and in that moment, it occurred to him that it had been so long since he had thought of Thur or the Vine Jungle. That returning to his friend was a thought that did not come naturally, instantly, upset him.

"I'm almost ready, Skeletor," the woman cut in before the man could reply. As the woman spoke, she retrieved a wand from her

cloak. The wand featured an animal's claw that Beast Man did not recognize, a claw that held a crystal ball. Beast Man's gaze did not linger on the wand, though; his eyes were drawn to the skin of her fingers that were a dark, sickly yellow, contrasted by bright blue nail polish. "I'll need to do this fast so it doesn't get panicked."

"What are you doing?" the Enslaver asked, coming into the corridor from the big top. "Who are you?!"

Skeletor swiveled to face Rober, his sword at the ready. His stance was confrontational and had the added benefit of protecting the woman he was with, who moved closer to the elephant nearest her.

"We just need one of your elephants," Skeletor said, as if that would disarm the Enslaver.

"You're not going anywhere with that!" Rober bellowed, reaching for the whip on his belt. In response, Skeletor rotated his stance, putting his arm with the staff before him. A fireball blasted out of the staff toward Rober. Panicked Eternians who had been following the performer out of the big top turned on their heels to flee as the fire rushed toward them. Rober, however, did not move. He stood defiantly before the elephants, Skeletor, the cloaked woman and Beast Man and showed no signs of retreating.

The elephants, however, reacted instantly to the fireball. The elephant in front had a fear reaction and tried to move back, falling onto its hindquarters. The elephant behind turned away from Skeletor and all that stopped the woman from being gored on his tusks was that she leapt and rolled out of his way. The woman landed near Beast Man and he reached down to help her up.

She thanked him as he helped her to her feet and Beast Man released her hand to step between her and the elephants. The panicked elephant before him had found its footing and was

tensing to charge back toward the staging area and animal pens behind Beast Man. Before the flexing elephant could break into a run, Beast Man concentrated and raised his hands to his temples. He sent out a telepathic message for the elephant to sleep and his ability worked. The elephant closest to him toppled to the ground, unconscious. As Skeletor advanced on the Enslaver, Beast Man rushed forward and pressed his hand to the seated elephant's back. He focused, trying to telepathically project a feeling of calm into the giant mammal. The elephant appeared to comply as it did not react, even when Skeletor shot off another fireball upon the advancing Enslaver.

The woman stepped up to Beast Man as he remained in contact with the elephant. She looked at him, an impressed expression emanating from her violet eyes.

"What do you need with an elephant?" Beast Man asked.

"You're not taking my elephants!" the Enslaver screamed. At the same time, the woman answered, "We need an elephant to carry something very big up some terrain that is otherwise impassable."

"Hmm," Beast Man grunted. "If you have a way to suspend it between them, you should take them both. It's less pressure on one and they're both more likely to survive than one is."

"Silence, Beast!" the Enslaver demanded.

The woman raised the wand in her hand and uttered a word Beast Man did not understand. The Enslaver dropped his whip. As soon as the whip was out of his grip, the well-dressed man's fingers contorted. Beast Man watched as Rober's fingers twisted at unnatural angles around each other, like vines being woven together, then closed into a fist from which the metacarpals and phalanges protruded through the skin. Rober screamed and dropped to his knees.

The woman looked at Beast Man and offered, "You could come with us, if you like. We only need an elephant for this one task. If you could help us with it, they - and you - would be free when the task was done."

"Lyn!" Skeletor called in a tone that made her name sound like a command.

Beast Man nodded his consent to Lyn and she smiled.

"Wait, Skeletor," Lyn responded. To Beast Man's shock, the cloaked man relented, taking a step back. Beside him Rober's screams faded into a pathetic whimper. "We have a new friend."

"Do we?" Skeletor asked, sheathing his sword.

"You'll never get away with this!" Rober shouted, shoving his bleeding stump of what had been a hand into the opposite armpit to control the bleeding. He began to rise to his feet as his eyes locked onto Beast Man. "You will never be free."

Skeletor laughed and reached down to pick up the Enslaver's whip. It uncoiled as he offered the handle to Beast Man. Beast Man walked slowly over to Skeletor and carefully took the whip from him.

As Beast Man's fingers closed around the whip's handle, Rober sneered, "What are you going to do?! You've never used that before! You have no idea how to..."

Beast Man closed his eyes as the Enslaver mocked him and he reached out with his mind. He knew the Enslaver was looking at him, looking at the whip in his hand. Beast Man focused on that, focused on the feeling it evoked and concentrated on the man's unconscious: muscle memory. Beast Man opened his eyes and latched his gaze directly on the Enslaver's neck and let the muscle memory flow through his own body.

The whip's end wrapped around the Enslaver's neck cutting off his last word. Before he could exhale in shock or make any sort

of sound or motion, Beast Man instinctively pulled back on the whip with all the strength that followed on the speed of his initial motion. Almost as the sound of the whip's crack rendered in the ears of everyone in the corridor, the Enslaver's head fell off the man's body.

Lyn looked at Beast Man, clearly impressed. As she watched, Beast Man reached for the end of the whip and with a quick motion tore the leather at the ends. The five flail ends and their ornaments fell to the ground. Lyn smiled at Beast Man; he felt liberated. Lyn turned to the elephants and raised her wand, beginning the incantation that would open a portal that would teleport them away.

Unphased by the carnage, Skeletor stepped close to Beast Man and lay a hand on his forearm. Nodding at the whip, he said, "You should keep it, so you never forget where you have come from."

There was something intangible in the way Skeletor made the request that made Beast Man feel like he was being given an order and without knowing exactly why, Beast Man followed it without question.

The road twisted toward the Evergreen Forest as Beast Man drove through the night. He was approaching Eternia's largest community of bears and it was his favorite stop on his journey. When making the arrangement with Mer-Man, the bears had been a key negotiating point. While both acknowledged that no system was flawless, the deforestation that went into creating Randor's road had resulted in a massive bear community that had overfished the salmon in the nearby streams and rivers. Mer-Man wanted those populations to thrive again and when it appeared their arrangement might fall apart, Beast Man had come up with an elegant solution.

For the past year, Beast Man had been feeding the bears and then leaving them with a psychic suggestion of sleep. The result was that after gorging on the fish Beast Man brought, almost all of the bears would retire to their caves for an unnatural hibernation. This had had a cumulative effect that benefitted both the local salmon population and innumerable other animals in the area. The smaller animals displaced by the creation of Randor's road were still struggling to find homes and rebuild their populations - as the workers who deforested throughout the Evergreen Forest had been gluttonous and wasteful in their hunting during the destruction project. The hibernating bears allowed vast numbers of prey animals to move fearlessly for most of the month. Bears were not predators to most of the creatures rebuilding their communities or looking for homes, but that did not mean the smaller animals were not terrified of the lumbering furballs.

So the section of the Evergreen Forest that Beast Man was entering was actually a place filled with joy and contentment that Beast Man was almost uniquely able to enjoy. As he drove along, Beast Man wished that Thur had been able to experience that with him, even once.

Beast Man's homecoming after the disastrous elephant fiasco was less than joyful.

Skeletor's plan had been an ambitious one, but it had failed. When Lyn teleported the trio and two elephants away from the circus, they had rematerialized in the Evergreen Forest, near a cliff and path that led to Castle Grayskull. Skeletor's encampment was small and after calming the elephants, Beast Man organized some of the footsoldiers to create a harness for a massive cannon one of Skeletor's lieutenants had created. Beast Man worked with the lieutenant, Tri-Klops, to make a harness that would allow the elephants to carry the cannon with it slung between them, for when the elephants were walking side by side or when they would be single-file, as Tri-Klops predicted they would have to be. The

sling worked incredibly well through the most treacherous parts of the mountain pass, but on their way down, one of the elephants made a bad step and tore its front left leg at the knee. The remaining elephant had carried the cannon the rest of the way to the castle.

The cannon was a clever device; it remained inactive until a spell activated it. As such, the elephant walked the device through the magical barriers that protected Castle Grayskull and, as directed, it stopped in the last barrier before the device was activated. The intent was that the cannon would blast through the closed drawbridge of Castle Grayskull, while Skeletor and his forces passed through the magic barrier that would be so strained from the discharge. Skeletor, Lyn and Tri-Klops had reasoned that the elephant would act as a weak spot in the barrier and they could essentially climb around it to enter the exposed castle when its doors were destroyed.

What happened, though, was that Beast Man coaxed the armed elephant across the rickety bridge separating Castle Grayskull and its abyss-encircled pedestal from the high plains that hid the castle. At the point where the last of the magical barriers were, the air began to spark and undulate with energy. Beast Man had used all his willpower to keep the elephant calm and he was successful. Lyn and Tri-Klops activated the cannon. Instead of demolishing the closed drawbridge of Castle Grayskull, the bolt of raw power the cannon discharged immediately connected with the magical shield around the castle. It was as if the force field reconstituted in front of the cannon. The power of the blast hitting the magical shield, so close to the cannon, propelled the elephant up and back, rocketing the massive mammal off the narrow bridge. Before Beast Man could react, the elephant was plummeting to his death in the abyss that encircled the castle. There was no weak spot in the magic shield through which Skeletor, Lyn or their soldiers could pass and when Beast Man approached the castle while Skeletor's forces retreated, he touched the shield. It felt as solid and smooth as a crystal bubble.

After fleeing a discrete distance away, which Tri-Klops grumbled was necessary as there were other layers of magical shielding that prevented the successful use of magics close to the castle, Lyn teleported the survivors of the doomed mission away.

They had rematerialized in a fortress Lyn called Snake Mountain. She muttered something about having to go attend to the child and disappeared almost instantly. Tri-Klops seemed dejected and said he needed to return to his workshop. The footsoldiers dispersed to the barracks the fortress presumably possessed. Rather soon after materializing in Snake Mountain, Beast Man found himself alone with Skeletor in the throne room of Snake Mountain.

Skeletor paced and cursed. Beast Man listened for a few minutes as he railed on Grayskull, the Sorceress, and King Randor. When it did not appear Skeletor would stop any time soon, or acknowledge his presence in any way, Beast Man spoke up.

"How do I get out of here?" Beast Man asked.

Skeletor flailed his left hand in the direction behind Beast Man, then slumped heavily down onto his throne of bones. As Beast Man turned to leave, Skeletor noted, "You handled yourself well today Beast Man. You were a real asset."

"Was I?" Beast Man asked. He felt sad that the elephants had died.

"You were," Skeletor affirmed. "Join me. Take Eternia back from Randor." He said the king's name with such a tone of disgust that Beast Man felt an instant kinship with him. Beast Man recognized that what Skeletor felt for Randor was akin to how Beast Man felt toward the Enslaver.

"Look," Skeletor ordered, rising from his throne. Near the throne was a bone-framed table. As Skeletor approached, he waved his hand above the table and the surface of the table

rippled and lit up. An image appeared on the table's surface. Beast Man looked at it and then stared at Skeletor blankly.

"This is Eternia," Skeletor explained. In response to Beast Man's continued expression that indicated a lack of understanding, he elaborated, "This is a map of Eternia, the planet we live on. This is where we are now, at Snake Mountain." He pointed on the map and Beast Man looked where he pointed. "I suspect this is where you came from, the Vine Jungle. You can see Randor's influence here. See how his road cuts through the land?"

As Skeletor pointed, the map changed, focusing in on the area near the Vine Jungle and the capital city of Eternos. Thick, glowing blue lines radiated out of Eternos, cutting through the Vine Jungle and other places on the map.

"Randor is already destroying your homeland," Skeletor claimed. "You've seen this, haven't you?"

In his mind's eye, Beast Man saw Randor's construction workers, disemboweled, hanging from the trees. His heart sank as the image in his mind dissipated and he saw the map; the road still existed. A lighter blue glow radiated out from the darker blue of the road, covering much of the visible map.

"Yes," Beast Man grunted.

"You can marshal the animals of the land, Beast Man," Skeletor dictated. "You can help me take these lands back from Randor!"

"No more circuses," Beast Man declared.

It was impossible for Beast Man to know if Skeletor smiled, but he felt that type of joy radiate from the skull-faced man.

"No more circuses," Skeletor agreed.

"No more whips," Beast Man asserted.

The glowing red orbs that served as Skeletor's eyes dimmed in luminescence. Beast Man suspected this was Skeletor's version of narrowing his eyes.

"I've no need for whips," Skeletor declared. He waved his hand in Beast Man's direction and a familiar feeling washed over the furry biped. Several of the scars on Beast Man's back split open, as if reopened by the whip that had initially created them. The pain brought Beast Man to his knees and his vision blurred. Skeletor knelt down next to Beast Man and lowered his voice to conclude, "I will never whip you, Beast Man, but I will punish you if you betray me in any way. Join me and do not fail me."

"Yes," Beast Man agreed as the pain ebbed. Skeletor waved his hand and the wounds on his back closed once more. "I will not fail."

"Good," Skeletor said, standing back up.

Beast Man mirrored his movement and glanced back at the scrying table. So much of what was visible on the map was covered in a blue glow. Beast Man motioned toward the surface.

"All this is under Randor's control?" Beast Man asked.

"Yes," Skeletor said, distractedly walking back toward his throne. He did not look at the map or where Beast Man was indicating.

"I will return to the Vine Jungle," Beast Man declared, pointing on the map. "I will find my people and we will retake this village from Randor!"

"Excellent," Skeletor said. "While you do that, I shall plan our next move."

It took Beast Man a little time to find his way out of Snake Mountain and several days to find his way back to the Vine Jungle from the Dark Hemisphere. Whenever he found himself lost, Beast Man found the road and it carried him in the direction he

wanted to go. When he rested, he would leave the road and whenever he continued his journey, he committed to using his wits and senses. Invariably, he returned to the road. When he reached the Vine Jungle, he remained on the road until he found himself in the valley of his people. From there, he cut out through the jungle to where he had left Thur.

The catcher plants were bigger, stronger, and more prevalent in the clearing near the den Thur still resided in. Beast Man arrived at the den as the moons were setting and he waited for Thur to arrive.

"I thought you were dead," Thur declared upon seeing Beast Man. They embraced and Beast Man felt good for the first time in a long time. They stepped back from one another and Thur tugged on the otter pelt brief. "What's this?"

Beast Man had forgotten he had been wearing it; he had become so used to the Enslaver's garment. Rather than explain, Beast Man tore it off. He still had a thin leather belt, from which the coiled whip hung. Thur looked the same as he had. So, Beast Man stood before him, content to enjoy the moment.

"Let me look at you," Thur insisted. He began walking around Beast Man, running his fingers over the scars on his back, arms, and legs. "What has happened to you? What did this to you? What happened after you were captured? Where did you go?"

"I'm back," Beast Man said simply. "The men who destroyed our home, the ones who built the road... they must be stopped. We need to fight back."

"Why?" Thur asked. "Why don't we just leave? Or why don't we just stay here? I've been safe here; you could be, too."

As if he did not hear him, Beast Man insisted, "They are coming and they have done terrible things. They are taking the land and the water and they will not stop. We must push them back. There's a village near here, in the Sea Of Rakash. It is as far as

they have gotten. We can start there and start to push them back!"

"With what?" Thur asked, confused.

"They are men," Beast Man reasoned. "They cannot easily hold a subaquatic village."

"How are they holding it now?"

Beast Man ignored his question and postulated, "We can use our influence, raise a monkey army! We can outfit them with weapons and bladders that will hold air, lead them into the Sea to stop Randor's advance!

"Please, Thur!" Beast Man said, grabbing his friend and tribemate by the shoulders. "I need your help with this! I've seen their evil. They must be stopped!"

Thur reached out to deny his long lost friend's request, but when he placed his hands on Beast Man's shoulders, he felt the raised scars and his heart sank.

"Okay," Thur consented, his sad voice a stark contrast to Beast Man's manic request.

Thinking back as he stopped the caravan, Beast Man heard the sadness in the memory of Thur's voice; he wished he had heard it back then.

If only, Beast Man thought. If only he had heard Thur's tone, if only he had not been so focused on using his telepathy to bring the monkeys under his thrall, if only he had any clue where his tribemates or anyone else like him and Thur were following the incursion of Randor's people, if only the bladders had failed, if only Skeletor had updated his damned map when he made an alliance with Mer-Man. The week between his return to Thur and

Thur's death was a tense one, filled with barked orders, telepathy headaches and making tools for the doomed offensive.

Sensing his increasing frustration was causing them tension, Thur volunteered to lead the mammal army to liberate the subaquatic village and Beast Man had felt validated by that. The next morning saw the mind-controlled monkeys and Thur descend into the sea. Beast Man knew the liberation had failed well before Thur was returned to him; a short time after they disappeared below the water's surface, a cloud of monkey blood tainted the water red. Soon after, Mer-Man rose from the sea with Thur's body to introduce himself and have a conversation with Beast Man.

It felt bad to think of Thur, how long he had been without him, so Beast Man blinked back the memories and exited the jet crawler. Within moments, he was summoning the bears and he did not feel so bad.

Magic Of The Streets

Chapter Summary

> The night Evil-Lyn and Teela spent in the desert in the "He-Man And The Masters Of The Universe" episode "The Witch And The Warrior" is very truncated. This story fleshes out that night by starting our exploration of Lyn's backstory. This is the first of several chapters (which will appear at various points in this work) set on that fateful night, this time with Lyn giving Teela the answer to the first of her many questions.

Lyn's words echoed in Teela's ear as the sorceress rolled to face away from her.

"In a strange way, we do," she whispered, fully believing Lyn did not hear her. She looked at the fire Lyn had built and smiled faintly. Her smile disappeared as her eyes lifted to the horizon and the night's sky. Almost immediately, Teela's stomach twisted and she was forced to close her eyes to prevent the wave of nausea from manifesting more violently.

Even with her eyes closed, Teela could picture the night sky undulating. The stars were shifting violently, Eternia's two moons appeared and reappeared wildly even in the periphery of her vision; keeping her eyes closed was the only way to prevent herself from vomiting.

"What is happening?" she croaked out, eyes still closed.

Lyn opened her eyes and looked around. The sky pulsed with nighttime colors and various celestial configurations. Lyn felt immediately sad; she recognized what was happening intellectually, but separated from her powers, she did not feel connected to the magic on display in the theater of the sky. She glanced over her shoulder at Teela. The younger woman was

curled slightly on the ground, her hands on her stomach. Even by the firelight, Lyn could see she was an unhealthy shade.

"The desert is not well-marked," Lyn explained. "We have come into the Sands Of Time. Perhaps you are unfamiliar with how they got their name, but time does not work... consistently within the confines of this desert. During the daytime, sunlight protects us from witnessing the full brunt of the temporal anomalies here, but at night..."

"How do you know this?" Teela asked, voice laced with suspicion. "Without your magic..."

"I know many things," Lyn cut her off. She continued in a softer tone, "Magic is a tool, but without knowledge or wisdom, magic is useless. I know many things; it is how I have survived in this world for so long. You people seem to forget that we are smart, creative individuals. You see me just as a powerful magic-user, but to do that, I have to be fundamentally intelligent. You're so focused on the brawn, you forget the brains.

"I don't need my magic to know about the geography of Eternia. I know all about this planet and the regions on it. I suspected Kothos would have additional defenses for his fortress, but I did not anticipate that he would be reckless enough to use the Sands Of Time as his home."

"Why is that reckless? It seems like a smart tactical move, especially with the ill-defined borders between the desert proper and the Sands Of Time."

Lyn closed her eyes again and curled back into her more comfortable sleeping position, facing away from Teela.

"The laws of the natural world do not entirely apply here," Lyn explained, beginning to drift off as she did so. "The temporal anomalies inherent in the Sands Of Time wreak havoc on non-living materials. Kothos's fortress is likely to be under massive stresses if it is within the Sands Of Time. I'm unsure what effect it

will have on the Fountain Of Life, but I think it is imperative that we rest so we can get to his fortress and recover the Fountain as soon as we can tomorrow."

Lyn awoke a short time later to the erratic sound of Teela's breathing. After a moment of calculating the odds of successfully recovering the Fountain Of Life on her own and surviving an attack from a vengeful Duncan, Lyn decided her life would be easier in the near-term for Teela to survive the night. If only she had her magic, she silently mused, she could cast a simple spell that would allow her to feel the benefits of eight full hours of sleep. Lacking that, Lyn forced her eyes open and rolled toward Teela and the fire between them. Her best estimate was that she had been asleep for just over an hour.

Teela was facing away from Lynn, holding herself and shivering. Lyn immediately diagnosed the problem as the fire. The fire between the two women flickered in a rhythm that mirrored the near-constant changes in the night sky. Wherever they were in the Sands Of Time, it appeared to be one of the more extreme areas; the temporal anomalies kept changing how consumed the wood in the fire was. Lyn confirmed her suspicion by crawling closer to the fire and reaching toward it. Even as she watched and the light changed and the wood in the fire morphed in size along a spectrum, she felt almost no heat from the flames. She smiled a moment as she observed more logs appearing and disappearing from the fire.

Lyn raised herself to her knees and found a pocket on the inside of her cloak. She allowed herself to close her eyes and feel a moment of hope before she slipped her fingers inside the pocket she sought. The tips of her fingers pulsed with a familiar energy as they wrapped around the wood inside the pocket. She carefully removed the log, then another. As she reached inside to grasp one more piece of wood, she began to feel dizzy and she stopped herself. Wordlessly, she buttoned the pocket up and turned her attention to the fire.

As she placed the two pieces of wood into the fire, she idly wondered if Teela would have understood the physics of what had just happened or if she would have just called it "fate." As the fire consumed the wood and the time variations restored it, the light from the fire grew and changed.

Lyn crawled around the fire to where Teela lay. Her heart sank as she approached and she could see the young woman shaking. The feeling was only exacerbated by Lyn laying her hand on Teela's exposed bicep. Teela's skin was freezing and her body vibrated under Lyn's fingers. Lyn withdrew her hand and looked at the young woman on the ground before her. After a moment, she began to dig in the sand behind Teela.

"I'm going to warm you up," Lyn explained.

"Your fire isn't keeping," Teela chattered out combatively. Lyn was fairly certain she was still mostly asleep.

"No, it isn't," Lyn agreed. "But it's no fault of the fire; it's just where we are. At least we have the light."

"Need heat," Teela grunted, slowly coming around.

"You do, yes. But the light from the fire will keep the Sand Devils and other predators from attacking. We might not gain warmth from the flame, but it will serve its purpose.

"For heat, you'll have to rely upon me," Lyn concluded, finishing her troth behind Teela’s left hip. She began to lay down behind Teela. "And my cloak."

As Lyn lay down, she grabbed the hem of her cloak with her right hand and carefully pulled the cloak around herself and Teela. She was gratified when the cloak responded by growing subtly to accommodate both women, expanding to cover both of their booted feet. As she moved into position behind Teela, she maneuvered her left arm into the trough she had made so her left elbow came to rest inside the indent. The sand that she had extracted from behind Teela's waist had been collected behind the

younger woman's head and as Lyn came to rest behind her, her head was positioned directly behind Teela's right ear. With her left hand on Teela's stomach, Lyn gently pulled Teela close, their bodies aligned perfectly so that they were both beneath the cloak.

"Not the cloak," Teela mumbled sleepily. "Only villains have cloaks."

"Only young fools go without them," Lyn whispered into Teela's ear.

Teela awoke a short time later with a start, instantly confused. She felt warm and with each breath she took, she felt resistance on her stomach. Her instincts told her she was being restrained, but when she flinched awake, it was clear only her stomach was being held. She felt warmth along her back and a fabric like a blanket covering her. A moment after she flinched, she felt a soft hand return to her right thigh. She did not recoil with the hand's return; as she became conscious, she recognized that the hand had been there before and she did not feel threatened by it.

She was about to open her eyes when she recalled the undulating sky and thought better of it.

"What?" she asked simply, keeping her eyes closed.

"You were freezing to death," Lyn's voice came out of the darkness, softly into her right ear. "It's okay, I'm keeping you warm."

"How long have I been asleep?"

"Not long," Lyn confirmed. "Maybe forever. Who knows out here?

"Seriously, you haven't been asleep long and the time you have spent asleep hardly seems restful. The night here has barely begun. You're safe."

A flash of fear overcame Teela and without thinking, she asked, "Am I?"

"You are," Lyn said calmly, after a moment. She gently squeezed Teela closer with her left arm. The younger woman did not flinch away. Without malice or menace, Lyn concluded, "I've got you. Nothing is going to harm you tonight. Except, perhaps, my cloak."

"How is your cloak going to harm me?" Teela asked, suspicion overcoming her initial sense of disbelief.

"It's magic," Lyn explained. "That fool Kothos stripped me of my powers; he didn't seem to think I might have magical objects on me. But it was a joke, Teela. The cloak isn't sentient and it's not enchanted to harm you. We're lucky I have the cloak, though; it was enough to keep you alive tonight. And after you disparaged it!"

Teela winced and Lyn recognized the flinch even though she could not see Teela's face. She smirked behind the warrior woman.

"I'm lucky you were wearing it," Teela admitted. "Thank you."

"I can't believe you don't have one," Lyn noted. "They are incredibly useful, though you do seem to be biased as to who wears them."

"What?" Teela asked.

"Just something you said while you were asleep. You seem to think that your adversaries are defined by their choice of wardrobe. Tell me..."

Carefully, Lyn lifted her right hand and slid it from Teela's exposed thigh to her hip. Her nails effortlessly slipped under the fabric there and she released the elastic so it made a quiet snapping sound against Teela's skin.

"...why do you wear this?" Lyn asked. "Certainly it cannot be the most practical thing for a woman in your position to wear. And

you're smooth..." Lyn gently squeezed Teela's muscular thigh as her hand returned to its previous position.

"Those are two very different questions," Teela said, swallowing heavily.

"Do you have any reason not to answer them?"

"No," Teela admitted. "Growing up, Man-At-Arms..."

"Oh, Grayskull! Do you actually refer to your father that way?!"

"Adopted..."

"He's your dad," Lyn declared in a tone much more firm than Teela would have suspected her volume could convey. Teela felt a flash of shame and confusion as to why it mattered to her companion. "Show him some respect; he's shown up for you your entire life. Instead of some witless quest to replace him, you should be grateful you have a father who loves you so much."

Lacking a response, Teela swallowed and mentally regrouped to continue, "My dad trained me to be a warrior and a scholar. It became clear from a pretty young age that I would be equal to the task of joining, and perhaps leading, the King's Guard. The more I looked into the position as I came closer to age, the more I recognized that I would be alone in the Guard.

"Women were not forbidden or restricted from entering the King's Guard, there just haven't been any for quite some time. In all of the research I did, I could not find a reason why women weren't part of the palace guard units, but I could see the effects. Through death, retirement and lack of recruitment, women had just disappeared from the King's Guard from attrition and never replaced. The last women to serve in the guard died very early in the reign of King Miro. I guess the women of Eternia just found other professions they were more interested in pursuing.

"So as I came of age, I wanted to be certain that my place was clear. I felt the need to prove myself and show any who would

question it, that I earned my place in Randor's guard. So, I fashioned this outfit. It's based upon armor worn by the King's Guard in the time before Miro. I had this made, so all who tried to challenge me in combat would see that I had never been touched, never wounded, never cut."

"At least you were sensible enough to add the leather to protect the back of your neck and chest," Lyn noted.

"I was ambitious, not stupid," Teela noted, a smile appearing on her lips. It felt good to talk to someone about her choice and have it validated with recognition of the tactics behind her presentation. She flailed her right hand behind her, clumsily missing any part of Lyn's outfit, instead brushing her fingers on Lyn's thigh before she flopped her arm back before her. "What about you?"

"Leather armor is practical as it does not inhibit my range of motion for my magic. The bone accents protect my vital organs, provide support and inspire fear. As for the rest... well, I come from a time and place where men are idiots and I fit into a certain ideal they had for women. I use that to my advantage. If some warrior is disarmed for a moment while his libido trips him up upon seeing me, that's a moment I have to work my magic.

"I'm... smooth because of my condition," Lyn admitted. She did not need to look at her skin in the firelight to know it still had a sickly yellow shade to it. "I'm lucky to have hair on my head at this point."

"I'm sorry," Teela said. Her voice had a hint of confusion to it that Lyn recognized. She wanted to ask, but held herself back. Lyn smiled and let the silence remain. Apparently sensing that Lyn was not about to be forthcoming, Teela offered, "For my part, it's just practical. There are times when training Prince Adam or... in the field that I actually have to wear more substantial armor. I got tired of my hair getting ripped out every time I got into or out of armor. It was just a pragmatic solution, shaving."

"Why don't you just wear leggings? And something with sleeves?" Lyn pulled her left arm back from Teela's stomach, just enough to gain a little mobility beneath the cloak. She turned her left wrist and extended her index finger to carefully run it over the top of Teela's forearm. Teela's arms had warmed up, a fact that Lyn noted with a sense of pride as she confirmed that Teela had removed all of her arm hair. She smiled to herself as Teela responded and Lyn returned her hand to Teela's belly.

"You know how hot it gets sometimes in Eternos. Long sleeves are not entirely practical, especially for some of the armor. I discovered quickly with sleeves that, in addition to tearing out my hair, the armor often shifted when on fabric. There's a similar problem with leggings and it changes my sense of balance. I actually get a lot of information from my skin, even when I'm in combat.

"Besides, it keeps my skills honed. And, truth be told, it's the only real time I take to focus on myself. When I'm bathing and shaving, I'm at peace, but I'm also aware of my body and..."

"And what?" Lyn asked after a moment when it seemed like Teela would not continue.

"I get to pay attention to myself," Teela confessed. "Those moments, they aren't about the cause or the work. That quiet time, it's just about me in a very pure way. I don't feel vulnerable, because, you know... sharp objects, but I don't feel defensive. I suppose there is irony there; I'm preparing myself for armor, but I just get to be myself, in the quiet, alone. My only responsibility then is to me and I don't have to live in anyone else's expectations for me. So I use that sliver of my own time to bathe and shave.

"I'm actually proud; I am exactly the type of warrior I want to be and I do it on my terms. I don't need anyone's validation, but if anyone ever calls me out on it, I can show them that I am unscarred and the equal to any of the armored men under my command."

"Excellent," Lyn reacted. "It's nice that you carry on a higher calling than being a farmer or farmer's wife. It seems in recent years, as the population has declined, that is where most Eternian women have gone. And shopkeeping."

“I didn't know you kept such close watch on things," Teela admitted.

"When you make up roughly eighteen percent of the population, it helps to know who you are. Besides, if you want to rule, it helps to know about the people you want to rule." Lyn felt Teela tense up in front of her. She quickly adopted a more casual tone and concluded, "Regardless of all you have accomplished and how you have accomplished it, I would not mention tonight to your subordinates."

"What?" Teela asked, tone the epitome of naivete. "Why?"

Instinctively, Lyn reached up to Teela's face and her fingers brushed the young woman's cheek. She returned her hand more deliberately to Teela's thigh as she said, "Because your subordinates are men and idiots at that. Men like to talk about situations like this and their imaginations go wild, but they all go to the same place."

"I'm not sure what you mean," Teela said. "Prince Adam and I used to go camping. There were times we were close like this. We stopped a few years ago... I kept waking up and he'd be... poking at me. Sometimes, we'd just be laying close... I don't know if it was intentional, but I didn't like it, so we don't camp out like that any longer."

"Exactly," Lyn asserted.

"But what would they say about us?!" Teela asked, confused. "We're not close, like Adam and I are. We're..."

"Enemies?" Lyn opened her eye to see Teela nod. "That doesn't stop men from talking. If you put two strong women together in a situation, they assume that it will turn sexual. You like to think all

the residents of Eternos are enlightened, but they salaciously refer to it as 'lezzing out,' so it's not like they don't all think alike in that regard.

"It's always so ridiculous and... male. If you mention to any of your friends anything about tonight, they will assume so much and concoct the most ridiculous stories. You could tell them how we tromped through the desert and they will still imagine me using my wand on you tonight, as if it didn't get filthy and covered in sand. You could tell them how my magic was taken from me, but they would still imagine some toy conjured from my cloak..."

"Can your cloak do that?" Teela asked, nervously.

"Feel it. Seriously. Carefully, move your hand around. What do you feel?"

After a moment of complying, Teela noted, "Buttons. Pockets, most of them small."

"That's because my cloak holds critical spellcasting materials. There are three pockets that lead to netherrealms where larger objects are stored; they do not lead to a nightstand or a brothel! But men don't think that way; they think of the carnal, that which gets them hard. They ignore that this is the first time we have been alone together and that we are otherwise affiliated with diametrically opposed camps. To them it is nothing that you are twenty and I am eighteen years your senior. In their fantasies, they don't care who we are, just what we might look like doing what they imagine."

"I don't know what I am," Teela quietly admitted, her voice cutting through the fury Lyn's voice had grown to. "I know I didn't like the feeling of Adam poking me, but I don't know much beyond that. I haven't prioritized relationships, just work."

"That's fine," Lyn said, voice calmer. "You don't have to have it all figured out at twenty. But I know who I am and there are plenty on Eternia who know me as well. And if you were to tell any of

your subordinates about tonight, those who know I am a lesbian would jump..."

"You're...?"

"Certainly, you kn..."

"It's not something we put in the dossier on you," Teela affirmed. She was suddenly very aware of Lyn's hand on her abdomen and a much more detached part of her noted that she didn't seem as aware or caring of the hand on her thigh. She asked, "Are you okay?"

"Yes, Captain," Lyn said, voice dripping with sarcasm. "Your unbelievable naivete is not as alluring as anyone might think. We are allies on this mission, but it does not undo all that came before and simply being alone with you does not make me feel anything different for you. I'm not so desperate that I'll throw myself at the first woman I have to keep alive with my body heat."

Teela snorted in reaction to a joke only she heard.

"What?" Lyn asked after a moment, curiosity getting the better of her.

"Are you sure?" Teela asked, tone one of surprising levity. "I've seen Skeletor's minions and it seems like it would be pretty lonely for a lesbian at the top of his organization."

Lyn could see the humor from Teela's perspective, but she instantly thought of Gwen and frowned.

When Lyn did not respond, after a short time, Teela insecurely asked, "I'm sorry, did I offend you?"

"No," Lyn replied. "I'm used to loneliness, Teela. It doesn't motivate me to do things I would not otherwise do."

"That's good," Teela said. She carefully reached her left hand up to her abdomen and lay it atop Lyn's. She gently pushed the hand into her stomach and wiggled slightly to move her body the tiniest space closer to Lyn.

"You don't seem so evil, Lyn," Teela remarked, her voice content and sleepy. "How did you even get that name?"

Lyn rolled her eyes and Teela could feel her grumble, vibrating through her back.

Very quietly, Lyn whispered in Teela's ear, "For that, you need look no further than your father..."

In all the stories you might have been told about the past, I bet they forget that there were two of us. If Duncan never told you, then I suspect it is out of shame. But I grew up in Eternos, Teela, and for most of my time, I was not alone. Like you, I was orphaned at a young age. I only have the faintest memories of my father, who was a great sorcerer. Or perhaps he was not a great sorcerer; he died in a magical accident, so it is hard to know where to fall on that. I have no memory of my mother, but when I was six years old, my father disappeared or died and I was on my own.

I wandered the streets of Eternos for days. The capital city is unbelievably large to a child and while I was quite smart, I also lacked basic orientation skills. I wandered from my father's house in a stupor and I got lost. I roamed and may have even passed through my old neighborhood, but youth, darkness, odd angles... closed doors without ornamentation all look the same. So I became hopelessly lost on the streets of Eternos.

We like to think we are one thing, but when we look objectively at it, we often discover something very different. The people of Eternos would call themselves friendly and compassionate, but for days, maybe weeks, I wandered unnoticed even on the market

streets. In the early morning, I could urinate in the street gutter within sight of the palace, wander for the day and fall asleep in a doorway at dusk, invisible the entire time to merchants, passersby, everyone. I don't think you could possibly appreciate what it is like to be small, utterly alone and functionally unseen in this world. My father was just gone, my home disappeared and I saw the world through a haze, believing that everyone who glanced in my direction had their vision obscured by the same fog.

And then there was Gwen.

Gwen passed by me in the marketplace one day and as she passed, we made eye contact and she waved. That changed my entire life. Gwen was my age and she walked holding the hand of a tall woman I would later learn was her mother. I don't recall what came in my life before meeting Gwen that would have left me ignorant, but I did not understand how someone with such a dirty face could be accompanied by an adult. My six year-old mind processed all those freckles I saw on Gwen's face as dirt! But I knew this filthy little girl saw me because she waved at me and smiled. So, I followed them.

Gwen was wearing a very clean dark blue dress and had the most shockingly red hair I had ever seen. Her hair was straight and smooth and looked like gemstones with the light hitting it as she walked down the market street. It made her very easy to follow, even as we moved through the massive crowds that clogged the streets of Eternos. I don't know why they were so crowded that day, but they were. I followed her to what turned out to be the Royal Library of Eternos and I wasn't sure why I followed her except that I knew that she had seen me.

Inside the library, we became separated and I wandered among the stacks of books for hours, until the natural light faded and the artificial lights came on. I had ended up in the section of the library where the books about magic and the books of Eternian history were kept and it was an area that had reading nooks flooded with natural light. When I wasn't wandering looking for the girl I had seen, I sat in the nooks watching the dust in the

sunlight and just marveling at the quiet. I had spent days or weeks on the streets and become accustomed to constant sounds. But in the library, it was quiet.

I heard her coming well before I saw her, but somehow I knew it was her. I had been seated in a chair intended for an adult, just looking at spines of books for… I don't know how long, when Gwen approached. As she came into view, I slid off the chair and she smiled at me again and it was one of the happiest moments of my entire life. Whatever tiredness or self-doubt I had experienced throughout that day, her smile once again cut through it all and I felt the simple elation of knowing that I existed.

She walked up to me and stopped right in front of me. Some part of me must have been convinced she was not real because I reached out to her. I touched her cheek, with my left hand, and the moment I confirmed by touch that she was real I was ecstatic and confused. Before we said anything to one another, I was using my thumb to try to wipe her freckles off her cheek, confused that what I thought was dirt was not coming off. I'll never understand why she did not just flee in terror at the crazy little street girl who was rubbing her face, but I was unspeakably grateful that she reacted by just letting me touch her.

Then she spoke and her voice had a lilt and confidence that seemed both unreal and so far beyond my imagination at the time that it convinced me of her existence outside my own head.

"I'm Gwen," she said. When she asked me her question, she did so with such a sense of challenge that it's only after years of retrospect and remembrance that I came to suspect that maybe she was desperate to interact with someone, not to prove her abilities. "Do you know how to read?"

"I do," I declared.

"Oh yeah? Prove it!"

So I reached out for the nearby shelf and pulled the first book off it that was within reach. I will never forget it. The book was *The Nature Of Eternia's Rivers* by Andros N'val. The book seemed so heavy at the time; I must have been weaker than I realized or just exhausted from my time on the streets. But I pulled the book off the shelf and we turned back to the chair I had been sitting on. I placed the book on the seat of the chair and opened it and started reading to Gwen.

I read a paragraph about the River Of Rain, my little index finger tracing each line. As soon as I reached the end of the paragraph, Gwen began reading the next. Something about her made me feel like she was challenging me and that one paragraph, two, a page, another, was not enough to prove to her that I could read, so we kept up the reading. At some point, we climbed into the seat and it was big enough for both of our small bodies. We sat side by side, the book open across both our laps, reading to one another for hours, our legs dangling off the edge of the chair occasionally swinging in unison. We did not understand all of what we read, of course, but we sure acted like we were pronouncing every word correctly and we just defiantly read to one another as if the act was irrefutable proof of our literacy.

"There you are, Gwen," a woman's voice said after we had learned quite a bit about the River Of Rain as an important water source for Eternia. We both looked up from the book.

"Hi, Mom! This is my friend, Lyn," Gwen introduced. I have no memory of when I told her my name.

"Hello, Lyn," the librarian introduced. "I am Meldara, Gwen's mother, the Royal Librarian. I am here to shut down the library for the night and take Gwen home."

I slid off the chair, extended my hand to Meldara - and years later I learned this is when I won over Gwen's mother - and very confidently said, "I am Lyn and I do not have a home to go back to!"

Meldara shook my hand and smiled compassionately at me, but her eyes were filled with sadness that even I could see at my young age.

"Tonight, you can come home with us," Meldara declared. "Then we'll try to figure out what to do with you tomorrow."

Gwen took my left hand and the three of us left the library together. Meldara and Gwen had an apartment of sorts in the library tower, part of the Royal Librarian's compensation. Gwen, more than her mother, led me up the winding staircases to their apartment, as if she was proud to show off her home. While Meldara cooked dinner, Gwen showed me her room, her book case, every knickknack and toy she possessed. She opened every drawer in her dresser and showed me her closet. She had a meager wardrobe, but to someone who had been living on the streets - even for only a few days - it seemed like riches. And she kept telling me we could share, the entire time she showed me everything that was hers.

Meldara made a stew with rabbit and duck that I can still recall so vividly, but have never tasted again. After dinner, we washed up and I was finally, definitively, convinced that Gwen's freckles were not dirt when Meldara washed her face and the freckles did not come off. By contrast, the cloth her mother used on my face took several rinses to come out clean. I must have been a little dirt ball, but Meldara cleaned me right up. Gwen loaned me a nightgown, insisting in front of her mother that this was now mine, and Meldara tucked Gwen into her bed and gave me a bedroll on the floor beside her.

At some point in the night, Gwen joined me on the floor. She pulled the blanket over the edge of the bed and rolled under the bed. From under the bed, she tugged my arm and had me join her with the bedroll. We camped out, two little six year-olds, feeling like we were on an adventure.

I woke up only one other time that night, when Gwen hugged me and said, "You're my best friend, Lyn!"

There were few times in my life that I felt as safe as I did that night.

What followed was a period that was tumultuous and confusing to me at six years old, but evened itself out surprisingly quickly. As I tell you about this time, I think it very important that you understand that the people we become are seldom the people we start as. I can think of no one in my life at that time who more embodies that idea than Duncan. Duncan may have grown to be knowledgeable and wise, but at one point, he was just an eight year-old jackass who was friends with the child prince. And he had a crush on Gwen. But at one point, Duncan was just an idiot boy and that is where our stories overlapped.

There are two stories here, the tale of two girls becoming instant friends and the tragically pragmatic attempts of a mother to do the right things the right way, only to find those efforts thwarted repeatedly. Meldara attempted to find my family, my father, and all I recall of that are memories of her looking sad and people around her looking fearful. At one point, she yelled at the captain of the Royal Guard and I remember being very scared. When the guard went away, she reassured me that things would be all right. Days later, she took me to the Eternos Orphanage. I ran away. I suppose, in retrospect, it did not help me much that I fled the orphanage to the library. Meldara would return me to the orphanage at least a dozen times, each time feeding me before taking me back, before Gwen one day proposed, "Why don't you just adopt her, mom?!"

I don't know what became of that, but I learned that Meldara was unable to adopt me. After she failed to successfully, legally, make me her daughter, she simply did not return me to the orphanage the next time I ran away from it. Because one hand seldom interacted with the other in the Eternos bureaucracy, Meldara quietly enrolled me in school. I was there a month before I was exposed as not Meldara's child and I was sent back to the orphanage. When I escaped that time, two very important things

happened: I began my life fully as a fugitive and I learned my first spell. Meldara was unable to adopt me for some reason, I could not attend school, and if I had any interaction with anyone from the orphanage they would try to take me back there, which I was determined would not happen.

It was just before my seventh birthday that I cast my first spell. I did an enchantment on a simple stone and shortly thereafter, I used it to create a portal. My magical career began with simple teleport spells. I was determined to never, ever, be without an escape plan again.

Throughout this time, Gwen and I became virtually inseparable. While she tried to take me in, Meldara was still incredibly protective of her daughter. She wanted to set a good example and that did not include lying to the authorities, who were visiting her library apartment with increasing frequency. Meldara continued to feel compelled to return me to the orphanage when I ran away, though Gwen's reaction to us being split up rapidly began to tear at the librarian. There were times Gwen broke her mother's heart with her sadness at me being returned to the orphanage. That just made me feel more loved and appreciated and it bonded Gwen and I even more.

For the brief time I was in school with Gwen, we were absolutely connected. It was there that I met Duncan, albeit peripherally. He was in the class above ours and he had a crush on Gwen. So when she became entirely disinterested in him or his attention, he correctly divined that I was to blame. Whenever we were near, he would talk loudly to his friends about "Gwen and her evil twin, Lyn!" Would you believe that thirty-two years later, I live with the shit that that eight year-old flung at me still?! It seems inconceivable, but that is the truth.

Duncan could not stand our friendship and even then he was resourceful. Somehow, that intrepid eight year-old found out about the legal proceedings that fell apart where Meldara attempted to adopt me and he outed her to the school as not my legal guardian. I think he might have had help from Prince

Randor, but regardless, it seemed pretty obvious that Duncan was convinced that if I was no longer in the picture, Gwen would suddenly turn her attention to him.

My first real victory over Duncan was in proving him wrong in this way. Duncan succeeded in exposing Meldara's deception to the school and I was expelled. But what Duncan did not realize was that Gwen and I had already become true best friends, closer than sisters. We did not want to be apart. We wanted to read, walk, eat, sleep, move through the world together with an intensity that only a child can truly feel and know. So Gwen spent her days in school learning and the moment her classes were over, she would run to find me at the library to tell me every single thing she learned. And I gave her my undivided attention and consumed every morsel of information she would give me. Then I would tell her everything I learned in my day.

And Duncan lost all attention or affection he ever could have received from Gwen.

Not long after Duncan got me expelled from the school, I learned my first spell and I beat that child. The orphanage became bored with their attempts to recover me when they would come to the library on a hot tip only to not find me there. The Royal Guard became tired of searching Meldara's meager apartment for a child who was never there when they searched it, presumably on the tip of Duncan or the ignorant child prince. Gwen, Meldara and I were harassed for about a year before Duncan gave up. In that time, I became proficient with the teleportation spells and portal creation and when Duncan finally surrendered, we tormented him mercilessly by appearing places knowing he was powerless to do anything even when he saw us together out in public. He was a little weasel and when he was around his friends or, in later years, when he would interact directly with us, he would refer to us as "Gwen and her evil twin Lyn."

Having mastered basic teleport spells, I moved freely about Eternos. I spent my days in the library, reading whatever caught my interest in a day. As soon as Gwen's school day ended, we

would meet and spend our time together. Most of the time, we had dinner with Meldara and slept in Gwen's room. Sometimes, we would teleport to the streets of Eternos to walk around, getting food from the street vendors and camping out on the roof of whatever building we wanted to. Our weekends were grand adventures in learning or exploring the city, always managing to evade guard patrols or orphanage staff. For years we went everywhere in the capital city and only twice did concerned adults even interrupt us to ask about what two girls were doing alone in the city. In the winters, we would camp out within the Royal Library after it closed, reading to one another long into the nights.

We were ten when Meldara died. One day in the library, she had a heart attack and died suddenly. Gwen was despondent and I took care of her. I provided by stealing whatever we needed when she had needs. A month after Meldara died, a new Royal Librarian was appointed and Gwen was evicted from the library apartment. I found an abandoned room for us on the outskirts of the city in a warehouse for a shipping company. We teleported everything she owned into the room and put a lock on the door and we had a safe space to sleep every night.

Gwen stayed in school until we were twelve, when it somehow became clear to the school officials that she had no legal guardian. We felt confident because at that point, she was already smarter and more well-read than students twice her age. Our days were spent reading in the Royal Library, teleporting to steal just enough to eat, grab clothes when we outgrew what we had, and sleeping in the warehouse room protected only by a lock that the personnel there were too lazy to challenge.

We raised each other and lived free, growing up for years together as best friends. When we explored, our radius slowly increased until we were outside Eternos's walls and slowly expanded to far away places we had only read about previously. And we would inevitably return together to our safe room in the warehouse to sleep and the library to learn.

I don't know if you have ever had a friendship, much less a pale shadow of the bond Gwen and I had. We spent years together, day after day, never tiring of one another's company. We shared information, experiences, food, hopes and dreams, clothes, sorrows, opinions, never once having a fight. I never understood how Duncan could dub me an "evil twin" for Gwen outside his childish, weak, rhyme scheme, because Gwen and I were not opposites or different. We were just together and what we had was just love.

I told Gwen "I love you" plenty and she said it back to me and I certainly felt it, both in myself and radiating from her. But it would be impossible to discuss that love and quantify it in a way anyone who had not experienced it could understand. It was not romantic love, though in the years since I last saw Gwen, there have been moments I realize I missed the opportunity to tell Gwen I felt that way for her. I'm not sure I knew it at the time. I'm not certain I understood there were different kinds of love. We never had sisters, so it's only in the abstract that we can believe we loved one another like family. Our love grew and changed with us. But it was love.

We were just under fourteen years-old when Gwen told me that she wanted to learn magic, too. The truth was, I craved to learn more than what I knew, so her admission to me was perfect. We had read countless books on magic, but had avoided most spellbooks. But by fourteen, we were studying magic together and it was another aspect of our bond that only brought us closer.

Gwen and I were sixteen when we became so proficient in the mystic arts that we eclipsed the sorcerers of Eternos. We had exhausted the Royal Library's collection of spellbooks, as well as the collections of the witches, warlocks, magicians, sorcerers and sorceresses from the magic schools in Eternos and the outlying villages. We became so well-known among the magic users of Eternia that when we would find a new, untapped resource for magical information, our reputation often preceded us.

Unfortunately, by this time, King Miro had disappeared and Randor had been installed as King of Eternia. He turned to his friend and confidant, Duncan, who was generally more responsible by this time. But, Duncan was still far from adult and his moniker for us stuck. As he gained influence and recognized our growing power, he continued to refer to us as "Gwen and her evil twin, Lyn." So, just as our reputation preceded us among our community, so too did Duncan's nickname in the world at large.

We were sixteen and two of the most powerful people on the planet, simply because we had dedicated so much time to learning, when we hit a wall. After almost two years of raiding every magical library on Eternia, we became frustrated because there were gaps in what the magical community actually knew. Several books alluded to books we could not find. More books referenced magical dimensions and other planets, without any real information on how to travel to them. Some of the books casually mentioned artifacts that no one seemed to know anything about. It seemed to us that the Elders of Eternia, who were supposedly still somewhere on Eternia but no one seemed to know where, had been making a concerted effort to remove a vast amount of knowledge from the world. But for all they had hidden, allusions existed and hints were occasionally dropped in obscure tomes we found.

Our frustration ended one day when we found ourselves out on an island in the Crystal Sea. I had been studying ways to improve my perception of magic in a vain attempt to locate the Elders of Eternia. Gwen had been experimenting with spells that could affect the entire planet. That day, both of our attempts bore fruit. I sensed a great power, rather suddenly, and Gwen effectively cast a spell that detected a portal incursion from another dimension. Both her location spell and my heightened magical sensitivity led us to the Crystal Sea.

We teleported to an island that was little more than a slab of flat, clear crystal surrounded by water, so it was exceptionally easy to confirm we had been led to the correct place. Laying on the crystal was a creature unlike anything either of us had ever seen

before. It is hard to describe what it was we saw that day because the body of the being before us was so badly mutilated. We could tell that it was supposed to have four legs, but three of them had been shattered beyond recognition as limbs and as the creature lay on its back, staring up at our sky, it was very clearly immobile. It had one eye, though there was a socket where another eye had been. The grotesque remnant of a creature's remaining eye was on a limp, broken stalk hanging out of its socket. On the other side of its head was the creature's remaining ear, as big as an elephant's ear. The skin of its arms and legs was predominantly blue, but its head was red. On its chest was a symbol we did not recognize, a red winged creature made harder to discern by the fact that the armor was shattered and twisted in unnatural ways.

I used my magic to stabilize the creature as soon as we appeared on the island and the thing screamed.

"What are you?" Gwen asked.

The creature gurgled in pain and as I inspected it closer, I saw that its skull was crushed. I pointed to what I saw and Gwen realized that my magic was keeping the unfortunate individual alive. I raised my left hand to release the spell and put the thing out of its misery.

Before I could, though, it said, "I am Glitix'Glik Tar."

Perhaps the best way I can convey how connected Gwen and I were is in the simple fact that we looked at one another and without words we both realized we had never heard a name like that before and this creature was clearly not from Eternia. I felt instantaneous excitement as this was the first real proof we had seen of a creature from another world on Eternia. Gwen, of course, felt it as well.

"Why are you here?" Gwen asked.

Her question seemed to come a second too late as Glitix'Glik Tar screamed one last time and died, but while she asked her

question, I cast one desperate spell. I conjured a mirror and cast the creature's soul into it. With a healthy individual, the spell would capture the entire soul and allow us to communicate with the dead. In this case, I managed to snatch but a fragment of the soul and it was fixated on Gwen's question.

"I was sent to find the Knowledge Gem on the Lonely Island," the disembodied Glitix'Glik Tar informed us from the mirror. "I failed and have been punished." And then the mirror screamed, a wrenching, unending scream. Gwen shook her head and covered her ears, falling to her knees. I pulled the soul back, listening carefully, making sure I heard his words correctly, before dropping the mirror. The mirror hit the crystal ground and shattered, silencing the screams of pain, though they echoed throughout the Crystal Sea for several seconds afterward.

"Did you hear that?" I asked Gwen as I knelt down beside her.

"The Knowledge Gem has been mentioned in several books, but none have even hinted at its location," Gwen said. "I have never heard of the Lonely Island."

"Neither have I," I confirmed. "But if *that* is here, it stands to reason that the Lonely Island is here on Eternia, probably in the Crystal Sea."

"But he either did not find the Lonely Island or he found it, but could not find the Knowledge Gem on it."

"Exactly. I could cast a spell to find everywhere on Eternia this... thing was before now."

"If it's only a few places, we can search them, but if he was all over, we should consider an alternate tactic."

"Because someone else sent it and they are likely to send someone else to continue the mission," I realized. I reached out and helped Gwen to her feet. While I cast a spell to show me everywhere Glitix'Glik Tar had been, Gwen cast another spell to sense incursions from other planets or dimensions. Gwen's spell

helped me to feel less anxious with what we both knew was a fast-ticking clock. My spell worked as I could almost immediately see a more intact version of the being standing on a nearby crystal island.

"We were correct," I shared with Gwen. As I spoke, I looked around. "Its search seems to be centered around the Crystal Sea. I see the afterimage of it on at least three... no, four islands nearby."

"I wonder why you didn't sense him when he was searching for the Knowledge Gem," Gwen mused as she cast a levitation spell and moved us in the direction of the first crystal island I indicated.

"I do not believe it was magical or possessed magical ability," I reasoned. "I suspect that whatever it was that was punishing it was using magic that lingered, so it would continue being damaged on Eternia after it was teleported here."

"That's horrible," Gwen said. "I wouldn't want anything that would do that to get ahold of something called the Knowledge Gem."

"It certainly sounds sadistic," I agreed. "We need to find it first."

The day stretched on with us anxiously surveying each of the islands Glitix'Glik Tar had visited. At each location, I cast a spell to reveal any magical item and Gwen renewed her spell to warn us of any form of incursion. As night fell on the Crystal Sea, our fear reached a peak and we came to rest on the last crystal island with a magical imprint from Glitix'Glik Tar. The Knowledge Gem was not there.

Without articulating a plan, we resolved to stop the search for the night and regroup. I conjured wood to make a small fire on the tiny island where we found ourselves. Gwen pulled fish from the water nearby with a simple levitation spell and suspended them over my fire until they were well-cooked.

As we ate the fish, Gwen asked, "Are you sure this is everywhere?"

I nodded and confirmed, "Unless it was somewhere much farther away than just the Crystal Sea, yes."

"This place is vast," Gwen noted, waving with her fish. We both looked around.

"Whatever sent that thing, it was impatient."

"With such minimal information, to expect it to be found so quickly is... ridiculous."

"...unrealistic," I agreed in unison with her wording. "If there's a name for the place, presumably it appears on a map, right?"

"Unless whomever hid the Knowledge Gem also had the ability to remove the location from maps."

"Is there a way to conjure a map from the past?"

"Not that I know of," Gwen said after a moment. "The problem is compounded by the fact that most of the Crystal Sea is uncharted. So even if we could pull a map out of the past, it would have to be one of the Crystal Sea that just happened to make mention of the Lonely Island. Considering neither of us has ever seen that name in any of the books we have read, the map would have to be positively ancient.

"And what if it was never on a map? That would explain why that visitor couldn't even begin to find it."

"Maybe part of an oral tradition?" I guessed. "Something that never made it into books… We've read plenty on the geography of Eternia, including what's known about the Crystal Sea."

"Maybe we should find a local sailor to ask."

"Maybe." I took a bite of fish. Neither of us had bothered to season it and it was not particularly flavorful. I realized, "If I was part of the same group and I knew that had happened to the last guy sent to find the Knowledge Gem, that would be the first thing

I would do. But even if a sailor somewhere around the Crystal Sea has even a clue as to where the Lonely Island is, they'd still have to bring me to it. Who knows what kind of tools these guys have? I'm betting they aren't calibrated to Eternia."

"So it would be a race to find the island first, assuming we were all playing with the same skill set. And assuming my spell detects the next interdimensional incursion."

"I'm sure it will."

"If the last visitor wasn't magical, he was searching the Crystal Sea for the Lonely Island with a limited amount of information and his own perceptions. The thing was clearly alien..."

"So if it knows it is looking for a gem in the Crystal Sea on a place called the Lonely Island... it would be doing so based on its perception of what 'Lonely Island' meant..."

"It was searching small islands, all of which seemed to be within sight of one another. What are the other permutations?" she asked.

"It doesn't matter the size, if it's far away from everything else," I postulated. "It doesn't matter how many others are nearby if you're different..."

"I think it's the first," Gwen concluded. I looked at her as I took the last bite of my fish. "Because sailors would be constantly surrounded by other sailors. If I was stuck on a boat, I think the only way I'd be lonely is if I was separated from everyone else. If I was naming islands out here, I think it would have to be one that was away from everything else."

"Okay, in the morning, let's levitate to see what's far and away on the Crystal Sea, away from everything else."

"That sounds like a plan," Gwen said, finishing her own fish. When she did, she mused, "I wonder what his criteria for 'lonely' was."

"Maybe it didn't really know what an island was," I joked as I produced a bedroll and we curled up to sleep for the night.

We awoke with the dawn; the fire remained burning throughout the night and Gwen was up before me, harvesting fish from the sea. I woke to the smell of the fish cooking and she smiled at me in greeting. I stretched and we wordlessly had breakfast. When we were done, Gwen extinguished my fire with the wave of her hand and I, having slightly more enduring and stable levitation spells at the time, cast the spell that lifted us into the air. Gwen provided a magical bubble to surround us with warmth, which proved useful as we had to go just below the clouds to see enough of the Crystal Sea to be useful.

We saw the island at the same time, a surprisingly large crystal structure on the water that seemed far away from everything else. As we wordlessly descended toward it, we easily confirmed that it was far out of sight of every nearby island. The island was large enough that it contained a crater and as we lowered ourselves toward the island, Gwen practiced her spell searching for magic items. We were unsurprised when she felt powerfully drawn toward the island and I carefully accelerated our descent. Gwen's feeling from the locator spell drew us toward the crater in the island and without waiting for her confirmation, I guided our path toward the inside of the crystal crater.

My guess proved fruitful. As we passed over the lip of the crater we could see water in it. At the center was a tiny crystal structure. While we approached, Gwen and I smirked at one another. In the center of the crater was a crystal too small for either of us to even stand upon. So, we landed in the water beside it. The water near the crystal was shallow, barely covering my boots and Gwen's sandaled feet. We knelt down and looked closer at what amounted to a crystal table in the crater. Gwen saw the imperfection before I did and she reached to a point, off-center on the disc. With a flick of her fingernail, she pulled up a simple gemstone that was otherwise indistinguishable from any of the other million rocks in the Crystal Sea.

Gwen handed the Knowledge Gem to me.

"It will take us some time to figure out how to use it," I said.

"Let's not do it here," she said, voice nervous. She glanced around and she tried to conceal how unsettled she felt. I nodded and slipped the gem into my cloak before reaching for her. Touching her forearm had the intended effect; she visibly calmed.

"Which do you think was named the Lonely Island?" I asked to distract her. I nodded at the disc before us before waving more broadly around us. "This? Or this?"

Gwen smiled and shrugged and I began an incantation to open a simple portal back to our warehouse room.

Gwen crumpled to the ground and I barely had the opportunity to catch her before she fell. Her weight seemed exaggerated as she fell into me and I saw her eyes roll back in her head. As she fell forward into me, the cause of her sudden unconsciousness became clear.

Immediately behind Gwen's falling form was a portal, through which a tall man appeared onto Eternia. He barely seemed to step through the portal before it disappeared behind him. The magnitude and proximity of the incursion had clearly knocked Gwen out.

The tall man was well-muscled, made exceptionally clear by the fact that he wore very little clothing. He wore low boots made of an animal skin that had been properly tanned and tailored to his feet and calves. He wore a leather belt, adorned with a metal and leather loincloth that barely covered his fur briefs. He wore no shirt, but rather had a harness that supported a minimal breastplate over his heart and a heavy cloak that draped over his shoulders. His skin, glistening with sweat, was light blue and he had the most piercing gray eyes. His eyes matched a tuft of hair at the front of his scalp that contrasted with the rest of his shoulder-length, jet-black mane. He had a thin mustache and

goatee and as he looked down upon me, holding up Gwen, he smiled a malicious smile that conveyed raw intelligence and power.

The invader took a step forward and with his left hand, he lifted Gwen by the back of her shoulders, as if he was scruffing a kitten. It was only then that I noticed that in his right hand he held an unsheathed sword. His muscles barely flexed as he held Gwen up off the ground.

"I am here for the Knowledge Gem," the man declared in a smooth voice that was low and carried an undertone of subtle menace. "Have you found it?"

My mind raced and I resisted the urge to look at his sword again. My cloak, specifically the pocket into which I had deposited the Knowledge Gem, had the ability to cloak magical objects from detection. The image of the prior visitor flashed through my mind. This man was either asking because he did not know the answer or because he was testing me; either way, he had the bearing of a killer and without any additional enchantments, I could feel magic power radiating from him.

"No."

My first word to Keldor was a lie.

As Lyn concluded her story, she blinked and refocused on the present. Teela had fallen asleep sometime in her recitation and as Lyn became aware of that, she focused on their bodies. At some point, Teela had pulled her left hand to her right breast in her sleep, effectively placing Lyn's hand there. Lyn recognized it as a comforting position and she sighed patiently. She carefully extracted her hand and returned it to Teela's stomach. After a moment of listening to Teela's quiet, steady breathing, Lyn allowed herself to simply feel the warmth of the cloak behind her

and the young woman's body before her and she joined her temporary companion in sleep.

Rival

Perhaps the greatest insult of Tristan L'Suyt's life was that he was never regarded by his adversaries. As a matter of fact, L'Suyt lived the vast majority of his life within the very systems and society that he would one day rebel against, but he did so without his peers ever noticing him standing in their ranks. The unfortunate irony of Tristan L'Suyt's life was that the man whose accomplishments he chased, whose heels he doggedly clawed at his entire life, and the witless king he served, would only notice him when he ultimately chose to hide his face behind his greatest accomplishment. Thus did Tristan L'Suyt remain forever ignored by Duncan, King Randor's Man-At-Arms.

Like many born in the reign of good King Miro, Tristan L'Suyt's mother died giving birth to the boy. Despite a station in King Miro's most trusted advisors, Grandark L'Suyt was unable to avail himself of the royal medical staff and obstetricians to save the life of his wife. As it so happened, Tristan L'Suyt was born on the very same day, within ten minutes and three levels in the Royal Palace from Randor, King Miro's firstborn son. While the birth of an heir was being celebrated only a few floors above him - attended to by trained medical professionals who ultimately observed the event but whose talents went unused -, Grandark L'Suyt watched in desperate frustration as his wife bled out after giving one final, heroic push, which brought Tristan into the world.

Grandark L'Suyt had established himself in Eternos as the greatest living swordsman and his reputation had quickly grown and spread to all of Eternia. King Miro had personally recruited Grandark as his chief counsel in military matters and relied upon Grandark to stand for him in duels of honor and patrol the borders to Subternia in the time preceding the great Fire People Invasion. In truth, King Miro relied upon Grandark's sword and word so heavily that when rumors circulated in the Royal Palace of an affair between Grandark and Queen Amelia, Miro disbelieved his

own wife until the military general testified as to her fidelity. Grandark's loyalty to Miro was so strong that he eagerly remained at his post, serving King Miro, even after his own wife's death amid their revels.

Tristan L'Suyt appeared to have been born into privilege, though his father taught him to remain humble. His father was a very quiet man, which Tristan presumed in his childhood was because Grandark missed his wife; Tristan knew he longed for his mother. As he grew older, he correctly postulated that his father harbored a deep resentment for Tristan - that he should live at the cost of his wife's life built in him a rage that he refused to express, save through his withholding. Grandark's generosity of spirit was spent on Miro, it seemed.

Regardless of his father's quiet interactions with him, Tristan grew up in the Royal Palace with his father. When Grandark was called out into the field, Tristan accompanied him. On one such mission, when Tristan was but six years-old, Grandark's squire, a thirteen year-old who had shown a lot of promise and had worked hard for the honor to learn from the greatest swordsman on Eternia, was torn in half by Goblins. That night as fires raged through the campsite and King Miro's scouts were torn limb from limb, Tristan rose to the challenge. He snuck out of his father's tent and recovered his weaponry; two swords and a shield. Grandark awoke to the screams of his subordinates and the weapons to avenge them.

Throughout that night, Tristan moved efficiently behind his father, obeying every barked order flawlessly. Grandark would plant his longsword in the ground and Tristan would lay the grip of the hilt of his short sword right in his palm. Tristan cleaned off the blades when he recovered them, provided his father's shield, buckled a gauntlet on the swordsman's forearm when he recovered one, warned of Goblin positions and mopped his brow between moments of conflict. As the pair advanced through the camp, they worked as a single unit, slaying every Goblin that sought to kill them first. Tristan followed his father through fresh mud made

with the dirt of the ground and every imaginable bodily fluid spilled onto it; human and Goblin alike. He never once slipped.

Grandark would be credited as single-handedly pushing back the First Goblin Incursion, but the truth was, the invaders would have won the night had Tristan not been able to flawlessly mimic every action he had witnessed from his older predecessor. That night remained Tristan's favorite memory, and his only truly favorable memory of his father.

When Tristan began preschool, he followed his father's lead, often going to a place in the classroom to read, observe his peers or play as if he was sharpening weapons for battle. He went largely unnoticed by his classmates and probably would never have been spoken to, had it not been for the King requesting a portrait of the Prince's class to present to the Queen to immortalize their son's journey. When the day came for the portrait to be made, Tristan wore his very best outfit and arrived early to class.

As the students were being arranged in height order, the child prince Randor tugged on Tristan's sleeve.

"Hey," he said. "Could you slouch a little, please? I want to be next to my friend in this."

In shock and dismay, Tristan sank his shoulders. Duncan passed by him, standing unnaturally tall for the boy and they were soon arranged in the way Randor had hoped. The Royal Artist-In-Residence created the first of what would ultimately be eleven annual portraits, all of which featured Tristan, Duncan, then Randor.

Tristan developed a fascination for all things scientific. While Queen Amelia continued to preach a worship of the Elders and the magics they claimed governed Eternia, Tristan found the grounding of scientific order to be vastly more sensible and satisfying. After all, magic had not saved his mother's life; medical science could have. Tristan was intrigued by physics, biology, and

engineering and he often found himself contemplating the intersection of his three interests.

When he was ten years old, Tristan entered the Royal Science Fair. His project was a wrist cuff that would act as a functional relay between a human and a mechanical hand he had built. Tristan's bionic cuff and hand were attached to a soldier in Miro's army who had been given a hero's retirement after losing his hand in a battle against Goblins. His amazing cuff worked perfectly and Tristan restored the soldier's ability to hold a sword and return to the King's army. Unfortunately for Tristan, days before the Royal Science Fair was to be judged, King Miro went missing. The Queen, grief stricken, locked herself in one of the towers of the Royal Palace, and refused to take up the business of governing. Randor was crowned King and his first official act was to judge the Royal Science Fair. He awarded Duncan first prize; Duncan had built a battery-operated mace that could discharge three laser bolts. Tristan's cuff earned second prize, but he went largely ignored as the members of the royal court sought to win the new King's favor by fawning over the accomplishment of the King's best friend.

Observing that his own father ignored his technical aptitude, Tristan once again began devoting his free time to trying to garner his father's attention and affection. An early bloomer, Tristan had a growth spurt that allowed him to actually hold a full size broadsword. As rumors in the royal court had never subsided about his previous squire's demise, Grandark had found himself without an official squire for some time. He accepted Tristan's offer to be put to work and he begrudgingly began to train his son in the combat arts.

Tristan was a natural at swordplay, a fact which quickly became recognized by his peers. In his early teens, Tristan alternated his time between the school laboratory and the fencing arena. While his father never attended his sporting events, Tristan quickly rose to become the undefeated youth champion in fencing. While Tristan had believed this might expand his social circle with his peers, it had largely the opposite effect. After school, Duncan

would work to impress his royal friend Randor with new devices of limited ability; the pair preferred boxing and wrestling to fencing. The rest of his peers soon became afraid of Tristan's prowess. As he aged, Tristan's fencing career took a sharp decline when there remained no youths who would actually compete against him.

So, more often than not, Tristan would accompany his father into battle, under the pretense of him being his father's squire. By age thirteen, however, Tristan could often be seen fighting beside his father during the Goblin Invasions and the subsequent Fire People War. Tristan had studied his father's combat style and learned to mimic what worked for him - which was everything his father knew - and improve upon it. The improvements Tristan made were simple; he was ambidextrous, so he taught himself to fight with both a broadsword and two shorter swords. As he got older, the short swords became longer until he was able to fight with two broadswords with amazing efficiency and lethality. Often fighting back-to-back with his father, Tristan and Grandark repelled the honorless Goblins who were appearing on Eternia with increasing frequency time and time again.

When Tristan was sixteen, Count Marzo committed to taking the Dark Hemisphere from Randor. Grandark was sent to prevent an invasion, though Tristan's father had interpreted the King's mandate to be broader than was explicitly stated. At the boundaries between the Light and Dark Hemispheres, Randor's soldiers prepared to make camp. Grandark ordered a small force into the dark to scout for positions. Tristan, still technically his father's squire, accompanied them.

Having heard rumors of the Shadow Beasts that Marzo was employing in the Dark Hemisphere from frightened survivors of their attacks who fled to Eternos, Tristan had come to the Dark Hemisphere prepared. In addition to having numerous telescopic devices to probe ahead, he had developed a visor that allowed him to see perfectly in the dark. He made two, in fact. At the boundary to the Dark Hemisphere, he offered his father one as he placed his on his head.

"That looks ridiculous," Grandark insisted, refusing to try the device.

Two days into the Dark Hemisphere, Tristan's nightvision and telescopic equipment came in handy; he spied the first pack of Shadow Beasts on a mountain several kilometers away. The terrain between the valley Randor's scouting team was in and the mountain was rocky; a virtual labyrinth of boulders and gullies. Tristan's warning of the enemy position made many of the soldiers anxious; it appeared the Shadow Beasts had the high ground. Grandark, however, was confident that they could overcome that advantage from a closer position. He had his team press on.

That was the penultimate mistake Grandark would make. Pushing through the rocky terrain, Randor's forces were ambushed by Shadow Beasts.

As men under his command were snatched and rendered by the giant ape-like beasts, Grandark snarled at his son, "How did you miss this?!"

Stabbing a Shadow Beast directly in the heart as he took a position near his father, Tristan defended, "I can't see through solid rock!"

"Maybe you should have built a device that could," Grandark grunted.

And that one line cut through all of Tristan's armor and he was just stunned. How could his own father not see him? How could he never once acknowledge what he did right, as opposed to constantly criticizing Tristan? Grandark had never built anything in his life; he never seemed particularly imaginative to Tristan. And why had he never asked Tristan to build something he might need on the battlefield? Grandark had been married for only a few years; was that not enough time for him to stop holding his wife's death against the teenager?!

Standing behind Grandark, shocked and mute, Tristan failed to register the Shadow Beast that leapt in his peripheral vision. Grandark did not see it at all.

Tristan's reverie was broken by the sound of his father's scream as his right leg was sliced off by a swipe of the Shadow Beast's razor claws. The sound of his father in pain was unlike anything he had ever heard before and Tristan unconsciously registered that he had never heard his father wounded, much less contacted, before. Instinctively, Tristan thrust his sword into the back of the Shadow Beast's neck. As it toppled to the ground, he recovered his father.

Grandark's right leg was severed at the middle of the thigh. Blood was spurting out of it and Tristan looked around for anything that he could use as a tourniquet. The Shadow Beasts wore no armor, used no weapons. The armor Grandark and Tristan wore had no easily-accessible straps.

Thinking fast about the mechanics of the visor he wore to see in the dark, Tristan had an inspired idea. He closed the aperture, turned the gain up on the visual sensors and he counted. At ten seconds, he felt the power supply near his left temple getting hot. At fifteen, that heat began to singe his hair. He reached his right hand up, hoping against all hope that his father had not moved at all, and touched the control to reopen the aperture.

The overcharged visor released a blast of searing heat that had the desired effect. Aimed as it was at Grandark's leg stump, the heat blast cooked the open wound, cauterizing it with a single shot. Tristan reached down and scooped up his wounded father, calling the retreat for the remaining soldiers. Five of Randor's men, including Grandark, made it back to the Light Hemisphere.

Upon awakening, Grandark saw his missing leg and cried. Tristan, entering the medical tent when he was alerted that his father had regained consciousness, was shocked when Grandark ordered him to leave.

"You did this to me!" his father shouted as he left.

Upon returning to the Royal Palace, Tristan worked tirelessly to adapt his childhood science project. After building a bionic leg that would be a perfect fit for Grandark, Tristan studied and refined his interface cuff so it would accept neural commands from Grandark to the bionic leg. When the project was completed, he presented it to Grandark.

Grandark initially refused, claiming he did not want to be made into a monster. But after the Royal Physician inspected Tristan's device and found it "most promising," Grandark relented. A day after the cuff and bionic leg were attached and installed, Grandark was able to run again. Within two days, Tristan was allowed to recalibrate the cuff to respond to finer motor requests and he began practicing his footwork. As he practiced that day with Tristan, it was the young man who had to restrain himself.

Grandark immediately requested Randor send him back out into the field and the king obliged. Randor had found himself in the unenviable position of having multiple fronts open in the military theater. The Shadow Beasts were becoming more aggressive at night on the borders to the Dark Hemisphere and the Fire People were making advances in the Region Of Flame. Grandark requested to deal with the Shadow Beasts and was granted command of the forces there.

En route to the front, Grandark and Tristan continued to practice together. One night, only a day's journey from where the squadron expected to see combat, Grandark and Tristan squared off to practice. While the camp slept, they fenced and Tristan realized that he was restraining himself far more than out of respect for his father's wound. Grandark appeared to realize it as well.

"You're toying with me, boy," Grandark sneered. "Stop it or I will show you what comes of those who underestimate me!"

It was probably the most Grandark had ever said to Tristan.

"If I didn't restrain myself," Tristan began, locking blades with his father, "you would see that **you** have underestimated **me**."

"Ha!"

"Father, **I** am the greatest swordsman on Eternia."

"You will never be the greatest," Grandark snarled, pushing back against Tristan's blade, "so long as I live!"

With a single fluid motion, Tristan pulled back on his right wrist, releasing the tension on the sword. Grandark, still pushing on his blade, was caught off-balance. It did not matter. Before Grandark could even register that he was falling forward even a few centimeters, Tristan had expertly twirled his wrist, extended his arm and rotated his body just enough to the side to have the desired effect. The sword's blade sliced through Grandark's spine and neck with such speed that it barely registered in Tristan's vision.

Grandark, so decapitated, was dead before he could even hear Tristan reply, "Exactly."

As it frequently occurred so close to the Dark Hemisphere, it began to rain. Not one to miss an opportunity, Tristan carried his father's body away from the camp, letting the rain wash away the blood in the process. In the morning, the camp awoke and found their leader missing. Tristan recommended they press on and the soldiers obediently agreed. An hour into their journey to the border, the squadron found Grandark's body where Tristan had left it. As Tristan had hoped, one of Grandark's lieutenants immediately surmised that Grandark had gone scouting in the night and been killed by a Shadow Beast who was doing scouting of its own. That rumor spread through the squadron so rapidly it was immediately assumed to be the truth and no one questioned its veracity.

Grandark's second-in-command led the squadron into the Dark Hemisphere and, guided by Tristan and his night vision visor,

crushed the advancing Shadow Beasts. Over the course of three days in the Dark Hemisphere, Randor's forces pushed the Shadow Beasts back until they were in full retreat. They lost only five men in the entire campaign.

Returning to Eternos, Randor promoted the lieutenant and requested that he take "the best swordsman he had" to go deal with the Fire People. The newly-minted Field General asked Tristan to join him and Tristan agreed, secretly thrilled that the military commander recognized his prowess, despite his youth.

Arriving at the Region of Flame, Tristan and Randor's forces soon learned that the Fire People abhorred the chaos of open conflict, despite their ability to shape-change that often gave them an advantage. The Field General met with his counterpart among the Fire People and the two agreed to representative combat. Tristan was tapped as the representative for Randor's forces and he easily and continually bested each of the Fire People he was pitted against, each time forcing a concession from the Fire People. Over the course of two weeks, Randor's forces pushed the Fire People back to a tiny area of the Region Of Flame and garnered agreements that effectively led to a surrender and a promise of peace for the next decade.

Following the thwarting of the Fire People, Tristan gladly returned to the Royal Palace to complete his schooling. While he found himself mostly bored in the history, etiquette and language classes, he derived great joy from the science and engineering courses. For his entry that year into the Royal Science Fair, he built an intuitive sword with an adaptive blade. When in the hand of its authorized user, the blade would extend and retract based on sensors that detected the enemy. Perhaps equally impressive, the blade on the sword was enhanced by a liquid metal that could rapidly adapt inside a wound and extend the blade into any cut already made. The result was a terrifying weapon that could target vital organs mid-swing and tear out pieces of a combatant as it moved. The final stroke of genius to the weapon was that to stabilize the liquid metal and make it conform, the sword had to use heat and electric fields, which Tristan had worked tirelessly to

manipulate. On most direct hits and virtually all grazes with the sword, the wound would be cauterized closed by the heat. Tristan called it the Organ Stealer and all who saw it at the science fair marveled at its cleverness and viciousness.

The day before the Royal Science Fair was to be judged, all of Eternos was thrown into chaos when a portal opened in the Royal Palace. As alarms sounded throughout the palace, Tristan rushed to the throne room, though several of the royal guards were already doing the same.

He arrived in the large chamber to see Randor on the throne, looking both concerned and afraid. Before him stood three people, their backs to Tristan as he entered. The two cloaked individuals flanked the man who stood before them, facing Randor. The man, which was very clear from his build, minimal clothes and booming voice, had bright blue skin and carried a staff with a ram's head on it. The interloper's tone was moving from angry to frustrated as Tristan entered the throne room.

"...will not care about your goals or your ambitions or even your paltry world! Do you not understand?! You do not have the ability to resist. The era of the sword is over, Eternia's only hope is to join me to develop a defense that protects the whole planet! That requires..."

Randor nodded to his left and Duncan sprang into action. Duncan, employing a moderately refined version of his blasting mace, unloaded four charges that exploded in the direction of the trio who faced the king. With a wave of her hand, as one of the cloaked figures turned out to be a young woman, the figure closest to Duncan deflected the powerful bolts. Tristan recognized the effects of magic and he was surprised when three of the bolts from Duncan's mace were deflected to hit the walls, blow out a window and blast one of the royal guards nearby in the chest.

The fourth blast was redirected toward Duncan. As Tristan watched, still advancing into the throne room, he realized he recognized the young women who were with the blue-skinned

man. One of the cloaked women had been in his class; he had heard rumors of how she had gone missing years ago. Her red hair tumbled out of her cloak as she turned and performed her magic. The other cloaked woman seemed only vaguely familiar, like someone he had seen many years ago in passing on the street. But Tristan paid little mind to either of the women or even the blue-skinned man whose speech had been cut off.

Tristan watched the fourth bolt of energy rocket back at Duncan. The blast connected directly with the mace from which it had been discharged and Tristan realized with horror that Duncan had merely refined his old device over the years. The mace still used a battery and Tristan realized before Duncan exactly what the impact from the energy blast could do to the mace.

Tristan called out a warning as the blast melted much of the mace and shattered the casings on batteries inside. Duncan heard the warning and realized what was happening. Duncan shoved his arm out, releasing the exploding mace as he did so. Tristan's eyes followed the trajectory of the mace and he gasped.

The stranger who stood before the king stood at the apex of the ruined mace's arc. More specifically, his face and head were directly in the path of the shattered weapon. Superheated metal, battery acid and electrical arcs connected with the invader's face, burning and washing over him. Tristan barely registered the man's goatee as it erupted into flames. The man cried out in pain and shock, which alerted the woman behind him - from Tristan's vantage - to what she could not see from where she stood. As the stranger's hair caught on fire, the woman behind him waved her hand to extinguish the flame. The man's screams did not fade, though, as the metal tore through his flesh and into his skull. As the woman behind him waved her hand again, this time to open a portal, Tristan caught sight of the stranger's right eye as he turned. The eyeball was bubbling from acid burns, leaking onto his cheek which was already melting off. His screams ended with the disappearance of the trio through a magical portal that closed instantaneously behind them. The royal court stood in shock for a moment looking where the three people had been, the echoes of

the man's scream and his left ear hitting the floor being the only evidence of his presence a second prior.

When the science fair was judged the next day, Duncan's entry received first prize. It was a Diamond Ray Of Disappearance Detector. Tristan doubted the veracity of the device's claims, but his appeal to the king’s representative fell on deaf ears.

For the next ten years, Tristan toiled in his laboratory and at his forge. His father's pension had been enough for him to invest in a small space to set up shop. He made more than enough money to survive repairing Wind Raiders and other vehicles and it afforded him enough time to develop his projects to try to win favorable contracts and positions with King Randor. When he submitted his enhanced Gammavision visor to allow soldiers to more effectively scout by giving them the ability to see through solid objects, he lost the contract. Randor decided to fund Duncan's Road Ripper project. A year later, Tristan built a safety battery designed using crystals and no corrosive chemicals; Randor devoted the royal treasury's funding to Duncan's witless Bashasaurus. After ten years of toiling such, Tristan developed an energy shield that could protect all of Eternos and, he believed, all of Eternia. With proper funding, he pitched, the shield might even make Eternia invisible to all off-world threats, which had been rumored to be advancing upon the planet. Randor awarded funding instead to Duncan... for a wrist laser.

The final indignity was that King Randor promoted Duncan to Man-At-Arms, "in recognition of a solid decade of unparalleled military and scientific advances." Tristan was certain that it had everything to do with the king's friendship, just as he suspected that Randor needed to find a way to legitimize paying Duncan more to help his friend bear the financial burden of the daughter he was now raising.

Regardless of the reasoning, Tristan returned to his laboratory furious and deeply ashamed. He was surrounded by his technological marvels and incredible devices and he had nothing to show for it. His laboratory and forge were on the outskirts of

Eternos. He would never achieve success and he knew that while he could easily best Man-At-Arms in combat, there was no point; it would not make Randor see his value for the role.

Swirling in his head were his father's words of disdain, his twisted expressions of loathing, his absence, the dire warning of the mysterious blue man - whom Tristan learned later had warned Randor of an impending invasion from beyond the stars. The Goblin Invasions had been but the first interlopers. Rumors at the royal court had circulated that a strange creature with limbs that could operate independently of the main body had been spotted one night crawling around the ceilings; a scout robot had been recovered in the Evergreen Forest, which Tristan had actually seen. It appeared Randor only cared about the safety of Eternia when he had no choice but to confront it. Randor's friendship with Duncan continually made Eternia weaker as he favored Duncan's tinkering to a solid defense strategy. Tristan resolved that he would make Randor see that truth.

As he looked around his workspace, Tristan focused on his many optical devices. He had spent so much time studying how light worked in order to develop his shield technology that Tristan was easily Eternia's expert on light and energy. He recalled his father's disdain for his Nightvision visor, his own pride at developing the Gammavision in response to how they had been ambushed, and even the advances he made in telescoping technologies. He had even developed a visor that combined all three of his major optic components some years prior, but the king had declared it "confusing and annoying" to rotate between the three different lenses. At the time, Tristan had seen it merely as the king's befuddled reaction to the amazing technology.

But as he sat in his laboratory that night, loathing the idiot king and his lack of vision, Tristan thought about all his actual accomplishments. He did not need the king's validation, but he needed his attention. He would make the king see... because he saw. Tristan saw it all clearly and in that moment of clarity, he conceded King Randor's point. Sometimes, it was confusing to see it all; there had to be a better way. All of Tristan's visors relied

upon the interaction with the user's eyes. The eyes filtered so much data out; they did not see clearly, just like Randor was not seeing clearly the threats to Eternia. If Tristan was to show Randor his merit, he reasoned, he had to see everything clearly first.

He worked long into the night, redesigning the interface on his visor to interact directly with a port. Tristan found his cuff technology; the device that restored Miro's soldier's hand and later allowed Grandark to walk again. With a few modifications, he realized, it could interact with the optic nerve the same way. He worked feverishly for the next day and a half until he had built another device. Despite his fatigue, his enthusiasm took over. He checked his math in his head, seeing the interactions of biology and circuits and he was certain he was right. With an unparalleled willpower, he opened his eyes wide and pressed the new interface to his face.

Blinded, Tristan heard Grandark's scream in his ear, filling his entire laboratory. After a moment, he realized that the scream was his own; he had never been wounded in combat to know what he would sound like in pain. He stopped screaming, despite the pain and he reached out for his visor. Blindly, he grasped the heavy metal disc and raised it above his head, even as he felt the interface device clamping deep in his eye sockets to new neural connections. He pulled the device down upon his head and as the base touched the bridge of his nose, he heard the satisfying click as it attached to the interface in his skull.

Tristan's world was filled with light. He saw the wall of his laboratory in microscopic detail, illuminated and textured in a way he had never before perceived. He thought of looking outdoors and the gyroscope in the base of the visor activated and he was almost immediately seeing the abandoned warehouse nearby. He could read the labels on the shipping crates that remained and he knew to do so he was looking through at least seven walls. He switched back to his Distavision and pulled back the focus until he was using no magnification; this, he recognized, would be his default. The inventor walked outside and was gratified to discover

it was night. He thought about his Nightvision and the interface immediately switched to that optic sensor.

He resolved that he would visit the king the next morning, so he went back inside, cleaned the blood off his face, neck and chest and went to sleep.

The next day, he took his sword, sheathed it on his back, and approached the Royal Palace. The citizens of Eternos paid him little mind as he walked the streets toward the palace. When he arrived, the royal guards stopped him and he requested an audience with the king. He was infuriated that his interrogator, a soldier he had served with on at least two campaigns, asked, "Whom should we say is requesting an audience?"

In a booming voice, fueled by anger at the man's ignorance and the decades of indifference paid to him, he said, "I am the Fantastic Tri-Optics and I seek audience with King Randor!"

"Yeah, okay," the guard said. "I'll announce you."

The Fantastic Tri-Optics was led through the familiar corridors of the palace to the familiar throne room. All along his journey, he heard people he knew gasp and whisper about the stranger who was being escorted to see the king. In his mind, he noted that he no longer had tear ducts with which to weep for their stupidity. When they reached the Throne Room, the king and his queen were on their respective thrones.

"The Fantastical Tri-Opts!" the guard bellowed as introduction.

The Fantastic Tri-Optics corrected him. As he approached the throne, Randor peered at him with enthusiasm and asked him what tricks he was there to perform. When his facial expression did not change at all, the Fantastic Tri-Optics realized that, despite creating optic sensors with a marginally human appearance, his eyes no longer emoted to others.

"I am not magician," the Fantastic Tri-Optics declared.

King Randor frowned and lamented, "Then why are you here? What is that thing on your face? May I see it, please?"

The Fantastic Tri-Optics shook his head and explained that he would be blind without it and that it was a device that allowed him to see many things clearly. Randor cut him off to ask if it could be outfitted with weapons and the Fantastic Tri-Optics noted that he had built it with overloading blast capabilities, but that it drew energy directly from him when he did so, so it was not a capability with extensive military use. King Randor asked him to illustrate it anyway and seemed amused with the idea that the Fantastic Tri-Optics could blast out a wall just by looking at it. Queen Marlena lay her hand on the king's forearm and suggested to him that it might not be the best idea to have such a demonstration there.

The king frowned and the Fantastic Tri-Optics suggested that they visit him at his laboratory where he would provide a demonstration. They agreed and he turned to leave.

As he departed the throne room, Man-At-Arms entered. The Fantastic Tri-Optics used his Gammavision to watch behind him as he left. Duncan's face showed no recognition as he asked the king, "Who was that?"

Randor shrugged and said, "Some guy... Tri-Opts."

He shook his head and departed.

King Randor did not come the next day. No one did. The Fantastic Tri-Optics went out into Eternos after two days of waiting. He heard the people around him whispering about how "that must be Tri-Opts!" and "Look! Tri-Opts is real!" But no one approached him or interacted with him. No one from Randor's court came to his laboratory, not even Duncan.

He spent six months waiting, tinkering in his laboratory, waiting for anyone from the Royal Court to appear to follow up on his visit. No one came. No one from Randor's court came.

After six months of waiting, there came a knock on his door. He approached it and asked, "Who is there?"

"Just an old lady seeking your aid," the voice on the other side of the door claimed. It was the most forced interpretation of an old lady's voice that he had ever heard. He adjusted his Gammavision to look through the door and he was surprised by what he saw. In front of him, light was bending in strange ways that he had never seen before. He opened the door to his laboratory.

"Why are you trying to create the illusion that you are an old woman?"

"How can you see through my illusion?" she asked, her voice more natural, though it had a smoky, raspy quality to it as she made the transition. He tapped his visor. "Of course."

The light around the woman swirled and changed again, coalescing into a normal woman wearing a simple brown cloak that covered everything but her face and her hands. In her left hand, she held a wand with a crystal ball. The wand was made of an animal's claw, but he did not recognize the animal from which it had come. He did, however, recognize the woman. She was the woman who had teleported the interloper into the throne room away years ago. The years had been kind to the young woman, though her eyes contained a sadness to them that he could clearly see.

"Are you Tri-Opts?" the woman asked.

"Close enough," he conceded.

"My master requests an audience with you," she said.

"Who is your master?" Tri-Opts asked. "Do you serve King Randor?"

The woman laughed and Tri-Opts guessed that it had been a very long time since she had done so.

"No," she replied. "I serve... Skeletor."

"Are you sure? You don't sound so sure..."

"'Serve' may not be the right word," she stated. "But I work with... for... Skeletor."

Tri-Opts shrugged. "Never heard of him."

"He is as far from Randor as you are from me," the woman stated. "Metaphorically."

Tri-Opts nodded and smiled. The woman smiled back. It was a genuine smile.

"It's been a while since you were around someone who knew what 'metaphorically' meant," Tri-Opts surmised. "Who are you?"

"I am Lyn," she said after a moment. Tri-Opts realized it had been some time since anyone had asked her that as well.

"And who is this Skeletor?"

"Come with me and find out," Lyn offered. "If you don't like what he has to say, I can bring you back just as easily."

"All right," Tri-Opts agreed.

There was a flash of light and a millisecond of black, which Tri-Opts interpreted as some form of negative light/space phenomenon, then another flash along his optic nerve. He found himself in a cavernous room that, appropriately enough, appeared to be a massive cave. There was a clear path in the stone that led toward an elevated space over a chasm. At the peak of that path was a throne made of bones. The room was illuminated from below from the glow of magma in the chasm. Tri-Opts was unsurprised that the cave was hot; he was surprised that Lyn was not beside him. Tri-Opts could see there was a cloaked individual on the throne, a man judging by the muscular blue leg that rested

outside the cloak. The man was hunched over, mostly in shadow, but he immediately acknowledged Tri-Opt's presence.

"You have me at a disadvantage," Skeletor said, his voice high and strained. "I can only ask that you not use any of your special visions to look at me until I am ready."

"Why?"

"My experiences with members of King Randor's court have been... resoundingly negative," Skeletor explained. "They seem to act upon prejudice and fear. I would hate for our conversation to be cut short for such an unfortunate reason."

"I am not like them," Tri-Opts said, advancing upon the throne. He thought about his lifelong quest to be seen by others and how their fundamental lack of respect made him feel. "But I will comply."

"Thank you," Skeletor said.

"Lyn told me she worked for Skeletor," Tri-Opts said. "I had no idea who you were... what was it, eleven years ago?"

"I'm not the same man I was then."

"Why am I here?" Tri-Opts asked.

"Because, you are not the same man you were back then either," Skeletor said. "And I have need of you."

Tri-Opts looked around.

"Are you looking for an interior decorator?" he asked in a sarcastic tone. "Or did you need something repaired?"

"Heh, neither. I need a Man-At-Arms." Tri-Opts flinched.

"Not Duncan," Skeletor continued, voice dripping with disdain, "but one to fill that position. I need a builder and a military

general. And someone who hates Duncan would be, how do you say it? Icing on the cake."

"How do you not know that phrase?!" Tri-Opts asked, focusing on that aspect of what Skeletor was saying.

"Where I came from, we didn't have 'cake.'"

"What makes you think I hate Duncan?"

"Where I came from, we might not have had cake, but we had getting screwed. It is easy to see how Duncan has advanced under Randor's reign while you have been forced to tinker away searching desperately for validation. I'd say you've gotten screwed plenty. Why not join me... and have some cake?"

Tri-Opts smiled at the phrasing. He asked, "Why are you trying to raise an army?"

"I want to save Eternia..."

"That's a vague answer and military conflicts seldom leave a planet 'saved.'"

"I understand your skepticism, so allow me to explain. There is a massive empire sweeping through this universe. Already, four entire galaxies have succumbed to complete control of the Horde. They have subjugated four galaxies, destroyed entirely three more. Their fleet has entered this galaxy and is headed toward Eternia. I do not enjoy the prospect of being conquered; I enjoy the Horde's version of it even less.

"My people were on the outer edges of this galaxy, on a small planet that it took them three days to conquer. I... ingratiated myself to the Fleet Commander of that armada so I could learn about my enemies. Within a year, I had earned a trusted position with them and through an encounter with a powerful magic-user within their upper echelons, I learned of Eternia and what they see as its potentials for the Horde.

"There is power on this planet," Skeletor concluded. "Raw power unlike anything in any of the galaxies the Horde has so far encountered and conquered. They believe the magic that is housed on this planet is the key to unlocking their ability to bring the entire rest of the universe under the Horde's control."

"That's hundreds, thousands of galaxies," Tri-Opts recalled.

"And you don't believe in magic," Skeletor noted.

"I don't," Tri-Opts confirmed. "In my experience, 'magic' is a term used by zealots and fanatics who utilize objects they do not understand."

"As someone who has... some magical abilities," Skeletor said with a wry tone, "I think it best that we agree to disagree on this. What is germane to you is that I believe it is essential we have more than one tool in our arsenal. Eternia, in its present state, cannot survive an onslaught from the Horde. When its fleet arrives, Eternia will fall..."

"...unless we are prepared."

"Exactly."

"You want me to use my technological aptitude to hide your magic planet," Tri-Opts surmised.

"As one potential tactic," Skeletor confirmed. "But beyond that, I want to unify Eternia so we can resist and push back the Horde when it arrives. I want to make the planet unconquerable. And when the Horde gets pushed back and Eternia is safe, I want to liberate whatever remains of my planet. For all of those things, I need some of the power that Eternia possesses, the very power the Horde is coming to take."

"But why do you need an army for that?"

"Because Randor is building an army of his own," Skeletor noted. "Every day, he conquers more of this planet, slowly pillaging and

bringing communities under his banner. He is a fool! He is short-sighted and he disbelieves the threat that is coming for Eternia. Under his 'leadership,' Eternia will fall to the Horde and the universe will be subjugated completely. When that happens, my homeworld is forever lost. I want to unify Eternia under a common goal and a common defense."

"You want to conquer Eternia yourself," Tri-Opts noted.

"It's easier this way," Skeletor confirmed. "As a tactician, certainly you would agree that it is easier to unify us all in advance of the common enemy than it would be to organize a resistance after the invasion. The first thing the Horde will do when it arrives is wipe out the best and brightest within the population. While it might be gratifying to see if they consider Duncan within that category, you would not be around to enjoy their judgment."

"Are you threatening me?"

"Not at all. I'm telling you exactly what the Horde would see when they arrive at Eternia. They might overlook me as a refugee from a conquered world, they would undoubtedly capture Lyn to try to comprehend how she uses magic, but they would just as certainly execute the individual who built even a prototype of a planetary shield."

Tri-Opts swallowed. Skeletor raised his bony blue hand, his sharp blue fingernails glistening in the magmalight.

"You and I have the same goal," Skeletor said, placatingly. "We want to save Eternia. I can empower you to execute your vision of what it means to save the world. But we cannot simply hide forever. And my price for saving your world is a fraction of the power it possesses. I think you would agree, that is a fair trade."

"It is," Tri-Opts conceded. "But so far, this is all speculation."

"If it could be proven to you...?"

"I would join you."

"Then I shall prove it to you," Skeletor stated. He rose from his throne and moved closer to Tri-Opts, pulling his staff from the side of the throne as he stood. As he moved closer to Tri-Opts, the ram's head on the top of Skeletor's staff began to glow and Tri-Opts immediately understood the purpose of the illumination. Skeletor was granting him permission to look, so he did.

The light cast over Skeletor revealed a muscular blue body beneath the cloak that spread open as he walked forward. He wore very little else, which made sense given the heat of the cave. He wore a simple breastplate that protected his heart and a loincloth. The hooded cloak appeared to be connected at the shoulders to the harness that held the breastplate in position. The light focused on Skeletor's face, which Tri-Opts was unsurprised to see was a skull. While Skeletor's glowing red eyes appeared to be gems, Tri-Opts's eyes were drawn to the base of Skeletor's skull and the jagged flesh at the top of his neck. There was a visual distortion there that Tri-Opts assumed was how his sensors interpreted a magical field that connected Skeletor's head to his neck.

"Skeletor," Tri-Opts grunted. "A bit on-the-nose."

"How easily cruelty comes to your people," Skeletor lamented in a tone of deep irony, "that you would mock one who lost his nose!"

"I meant no..."

"You people are such a humorless bunch. What has Randor done to you that you have less levity than the man whose planet was destroyed?! The face..." he waved at his own visage.

"The acid from Duncan's battery, yeah. If I had been here, we might have been able to neutralize it. I'm... shocked your people were able to save you."

"They had creativity... and magic on their side."

"Do you have to renew the magic regularly just to keep your head attached?" Tri-Opts asked, trying to calculate whether Skeletor

could survive long enough to see his vision through.

Skeltor shook his head. He noted, in a tone surprisingly sad, "That magic is self-sustaining. It is quite possible that it shall survive even my death."

"Okay," Tri-Opts replied. Skeletor dimmed his staff and reached into his cloak. "You said you had proof for me to analyze."

"I do." He withdrew from his cloak a piece of metal which he offered to Tri-Opts. The metal was red, shaped like a bat with an enlarged face in the center and had carbon scoring around the edges.

"What is this?" Tri-Opts asked as he took the metal piece. It was surprisingly heavy. As he touched it, he realized he had a vague memory of something virtually identical; he had seen it on the chest of a robot in the royal laboratories years before. It was collected as evidence of an alien incursion. Back then, he had not had the opportunity to touch the artifact.

"This is your proof," Skeletor stated plainly. "If you analyze it, you will find it is an alloy that contains several metals not found on Eternia..."

"They could have come from a meteor," Tri-Opts contradicted. "And just because our scientists have not discovered it, does not mean it does not exist here."

"I think we both know that, while that is possible, there are very few people on this planet who could refine materials that are previously unknown into something like this. Analyze it, you will see I speak the truth."

"And if you do, I will join you." Skeletor tapped his staff on the floor of the cavern and Tri-Opts found himself immediately back in his lab, holding the metal piece.

It took Tri-Opts less than a day in his laboratory to conclude that the metal alloy contained several elements that he could not

identify. When it appeared he had reached that conclusion, he found himself again within Skeletor's throne room. Skeletor confirmed that he had been watching Tri-Opts and while that made his new Man-At-Arms deeply uncomfortable, he had to concede to its efficiency.

Skeletor asked Tri-Opts what he would need and he had the entire contents of his laboratory on the outskirts of Eternos brought to the bowels of Snake Mountain. There, Tri-Opts began to work to further develop his planetary shield.

A month into his tenure as Skeletor's Man-At-Arms, Tri-Opts was summoned to the throne room. There, he and Lyn met with Skeletor, who had just learned of Randor's treaty with the Avionians. Tri-Opts looked over the data, most of which seemed to be supplied by Lyn, and he recognized that the best chance Skeletor had to keep the skies from entirely falling under Randor's dominion was to enlist the Andreenids. The Bee People seemed to have little interest in humans, but they had a deep distrust of the Avionians. Tactically, it made the most sense to Tri-Opts to keep that distrust alive for as long as possible.

Skeletor was hesitant to attack the Avionians, as it might alert Randor to the fact that he was still alive on Eternia, but he liked the idea of sowing greater distrust between the Avionians and the Andreenids. Lyn provided books on the Andreenids's primary hive and Tri-Opts developed a plan that would throw the entire hive into chaos. He built an amberizing bomb, a weapon that - when detonated - would fill the Bee People's catacombs with sticky rock crystals. It was big enough to be inconvenient, but not so large as to wipe out the entire hive. And the genius of it was that Tri-Opts included some elements in the amberizing substance that were very prevalent in Avion.

With the bomb built, Tri-Opts and Lyn teleported into the hive to detonate it. The mission was a success, but Tri-Opts had been forced to kill several Andreenids to maintain their secrecy. Escaping the detonation, Tri-Opts concluded that it was best that he and Lyn avoid Andreenids in case the Bee People shared some

form of hive mind. If Skeletor was ever in a position to negotiate with them, it seemed like it would undo any progress if he was exposed as having authorized the bomb.

Within days of the bombing, word reached Skeletor as to its success. The Andreenids were up in arms at the Avionians and it looked like there might be an open conflict between the two races. The fact that the attack was successful frustrated Tri-Opts in that he believed they had succeeded based on luck more than anything else. He returned to his laboratory to try to ensure Skeletor was not forced to risk his two chief officers on every mission.

Within a week, Tri-Opts had built the prototype of the Hover Robot. While Skeletor was initially suspicious - apparently having had bad experiences with robots during the Horde subjugation of his planet - he approved the idea and Tri-Opts set to work building a production facility deep under Snake Mountain. A year into his hard work, the first wave of Hover Robots went into production. While Tri-Opts oversaw their manufacture, he worked on refining the robots for a better, more efficient droid.

He was in his laboratory working on that project when Skeletor, Lyn and another teleported in. Skeletor never teleported directly into his laboratory. In fact, Tri-Opts had been pleasantly surprised with the autonomy Skeletor had granted him, so much so that he summoned his Man-At-Arms rather than teleported him when he wished to speak. So when the trio teleported in, Tri-Opts was shocked, but he recognized the importance of the intrusion.

"Save him, please," Lynn requested. Her lip was bleeding and she was dirty; there was a cut in her leather armor across her stomach. She referred to the man propped up between her and Skeletor.

Tri-Opts leapt into action, only then consciously realizing that Skeletor did not have a medic on his staff and the other two seemed to rely upon magic for dealing with their wounds. Tri-Opts

cleared his desk with a broad sweep of his arm and nodded to the other two. They brought the body over.

Tri-Opts was confronted with a horrific vision as Lyn and Skeletor lay the body on his desk. The man laid down before him was badly beaten, absolutely mangled. His right arm had been severed at the shoulder, his left thigh was bleeding and it appeared he had been hamstrung on his right side. The man's skin was a sickly dark blue-green that Tri-Opts had never seen before. As he looked at the poor man's head, he saw that much of the back of his skull had been crushed; his brains were visible through multiple cracks. His jaw hung askew, still attached to his skull on the left side, but hanging so the right side rested upon his left shoulder. It was then that Tri-Opts realized that while there was blood splattered all over the man's chest, he was not bleeding.

He was about to ask about that when he noticed the pathetic creature's eyes. They were open; Tri-Opts realized he was conscious in some form.

"What happened?" Tri-Opts asked. Lyn teleported away.

"He served me well," Skeletor explained. He sounded exhausted. Tri-Opts glanced him over and saw that he, too, was wounded. He was nowhere near as harmed as the body on his desk. "The magic that is keeping him alive has a very... finite timespan. Whatever you intend to do to save his life, you must do it quickly."

"I don't know... Wouldn't it be more humane to let him die?"

The man's left hand shot up and grabbed Tri-Opt's right forearm. The Man-At-Arms looked down and saw in his eyes desperation, but not despair. There was anger in the man's eyes. Tri-Opts realized that this man wanted to live to get revenge, but he wanted to live.

"Okay," Tri-Opts agreed. "But this is going to hurt..."

The mechanical genius prioritized the man's brain, quickly finding a helmet that could contain what was left inside the man's skull.

The helmet was one Tri-Opts had designed with a neural interface, intended to be able to provide other people with an interface to a visor like his own, without plucking out their eyes. While he had abandoned the project, the underlying technology seemed like it would work. As gingerly as he could, he scooped the man's head into the helmet. At the left side, he encountered the remnant of the man's jaw and after apologizing, he tore his jawbone off. He quickly overcharged his eye to release a heat blast, cauterizing the wound. In the process, he noticed the edge of the helmet melting. He apologized again, then focused on the seam between helmet and flesh, fusing the metal of the helmet to his flesh, and more often to exposed portions of his skull. In doing so, he had to roll the wounded man over and it was then that he noticed that Skeletor had disappeared as well.

On his way to his cupboard of devices, Tri-Opts took a blood sample for analysis. Recovering the interface cuff he had built and periodically refined, Tri-Opts returned to the center of his laboratory and the body there. His analysis device read out a startling series of facts as Tri-Opts worked. The computer informed him that the entity from which the sample had come was supersaturated with a copper and barium compound that seemed deeply unstable and entirely toxic, but had been bonded to all of the tissue in the creature's body. That, Tri-Opts concluded, explained his pigmentation.

As Tri-Opts worked, he became increasingly frustrated; his cuff had been designed to fit around a limb and the cut at the wounded man's shoulder had left him nothing to work with. There was no portion of arm or shoulder, no bone to connect to. Noticing a faint trickle of blood from the man's leg, Tri-Opts panicked. If the magics that were keeping him alive were wearing off, it would be mere seconds before the patient bled to death. Thinking fast, Tri-Opts looked around his laboratory and his eyes gravitated on a massive iron panel. The curved panel had been part of a thick cauldron; a remnant from a series of tests Tri-Opts had used when determining the capacities of his powerful optic blasts. The twisted piece of metal was heavy but it seemed to be just the right size and had a hole where he needed it. Tri-Opts

grabbed the iron remnant, slid his patient into it so it rested snugly on his right shoulder and surrounded his ribcage. Positioned thus, Tri-Opts apologized again, then superheated the metal, bonding it to the man's body. No sooner was he done than the remaining wounds began to bleed. Tri-Opts attached the cuff to the metal, rooting it in place, stopping the blood from flowing at the shoulder. He assured his patient he would come back to the arm, but he needed to prioritize stopping him from bleeding. The man was unconscious, so Tri-Opts was unsure why he continued to talk to the man.

But he did. He told him what he was doing when he reconnected his hamstring muscle, covering the area with a metal plate that he hoped would prevent such a vulnerable place from being breached again. He sewed up the wounds on the man's left thigh. Tri-Opts was getting tired, but he felt bad leaving the wounded man in such a condition. He refocused on the man's mouth; the wounds on his cheek and upper jaw had been cauterized, but it was only then, looking at the hole at the top of the man's neck that Tri-Opts realized that the young man had no tongue. Realizing that, he felt terrible that he had not noticed that before and that in his haste to save the man's brain, he had neglected the man's ears. In his current state, the man was both deaf and mute. Fortunately, the neural helmet Tri-Opts had outfitted him with gave him some options.

As he worked, Tri-Opts began to make modifications to his equipment and the man's helmet. In the process, his left forearm grazed the man's upper jaw. Tri-Opts was shocked to see his arm bleeding from a rather deep cut. After stopping his own bleeding, he more closely inspected the man's teeth. Whatever had been done to his biochemistry, the teeth on his upper jaw seemed incredibly hard and insanely sharp. Tri-Opts explained that he was going to make sure this man had every chance, but he did not believe he could fashion anything functional like a tongue that the man would not simply bite through.

He smiled realizing what he would do. At the base of the helmet was a relay, which Tri-Opts had lined up with the placement of

what would have been the jaw muscles, had the man still had any. He attached hinged servos to that relay, in the one on the right he installed auditory sensors. On the left side, Tri-Opts installed a relay within the servos that would connect to both the man's brain and vocal cords. That device would mimic the actions of a tongue when the man tried to speak, so when he awoke he would be able to hear and he would not feel his own lack of a tongue. With the joint in place, Tri-Opts found a piece of metal the right size. With minimal manipulation, he would be able to fashion it into a lower jaw that would fit the man's face and compliment his brutal teeth.

He had no conception of time as he worked, but when he attached the makeshift jaw to the man's face, he was exhausted.

As he collapsed into the chair near his desk, he promised, "I'll get to your arm when I wake up."

He put his head down, but then felt a hand on his shoulder. The man's left hand had reached out to touch his right shoulder. The sound of the jaw servos activating compelled Tri-Opts to open his eyes and lift his head just enough. The man was testing out the movements of his jaw. Tri-Opts rose so his patient could see him. The man's eyes were wide with fear until they connected with Tri-Opts's gaze.

"It's okay," Tri-Opts assured. The man looked scared.

"Why...?"

His breath was terrible and metallic, but the scratchy voice was the most wonderful thing the scientist had heard in such a long time.

"I tried my best," Tri-Opts assured. "I used whatever I had around to save your life and put you back together. Most of it is metal. Your jaw..."

"Explains it..."

Tri-Opts nodded.

"Tired."

"Me, too," Tri-Opts agreed. "Why don't we both get some sleep?"

The man nodded slightly and Tri-Opts began to retract to his chair. His jaw began moving again.

"Thank you, Tri-Klops."

"Tri-Opts," he corrected.

The man worked the jaw several times, a growing sense of fear starting to emanate from his eyes.

"Tri-Klops," he said again. His eyes widened in fear.

Compassion flooded his heart. Either the auditory sensor was not fully connected, the clicking and whirring in the jaw interfered or the auditory subroutines were not fully calibrated, but it was clear that the man was trying his very best. Without knowing what he had been through, how he had come to such a horrible state - body poisoned, broken, and reconstructed by someone without the proper training, empathy was all he felt in that moment.

"Yes, very good," he said in a reassuring tone. "I am Tri-Klops."

Apprentice

Chapter Summary

> Kronis, the young man who will become Trap Jaw, is recruited by Lyn to infiltrate Duncan's workshop.

The stated purpose of an apprentice was for interested parties to gain experience in highly-skilled crafts. As Duncan rose to become the foremost weapon's crafter on Eternia, the rumor in the Royal Palace was that the purpose of an apprentice was to have a disposable assistant upon whom Duncan could experiment. The Royal Guards and servants alike quietly referred to Duncan's rotating collection of apprentices simply as "target practice." Somehow, for eight years, they managed to never snicker the phrase within earshot of Randor, Marlena, Duncan or his daughter, who had a tendency to loudly repeat everything she heard to him.

Such rumors had not reached Drisdos City. There were, however, two individuals in Drisdos City who knew of Duncan's revolving door of apprentices and they saw the opportunity there. Eight years after the accident that had transformed Keldor into Skeletor, the wounded warrior and his remaining confidant found themselves successfully laying low in a basement below one of the larger housing complexes in Drisdos City. Lyn had discovered easy ways in and out of the building and its basement that allowed her and Skeletor to move freely through the city when they needed to.

It was late one night when Skeletor dragged his fingernail down Lyn's door, a habit he had gotten into a few years prior and never broken. It always woke Lyn up, so he continued to do that rather than knocking. In truth, Lyn preferred the single scratch; while it woke her, it never woke the child. Lyn lifted herself off her mat, confirmed that the child remained asleep, then slipped out of the room. She pulled her cloak around herself, unsure if it was truly cold or if it was just her.

Skeletor had already returned to the uneven wooden table in the center of their basement room. He was seated on a wooden chair, the lamp on the table illuminating his skull and red gem eyes. Lyn was used to running cold now, but she still felt unsettled when she felt a chill in the air.

"Do you mind if I turn on the light?" Lyn asked.

"I'd rather you didn't," Skeletor replied.

Lyn shrugged. "What's the point of siphoning off energy from the rest of the building if we're not free to use it?"

Skeletor shrugged. "You asked if I minded, I told you. Do what you want, Lyn."

"Is this going to be a long conversation?"

"I don't know."

"All right," Lyn declared. She walked over to the stove and turned it on, checking the kettle to make sure it had water. Without warning the man in the room, she activated the lights and smirked as he shielded his eyes. She found her mug and a satchel of tea. Knowing the water would take a few minutes to boil, she sat down at the table opposite Skeletor.

"Randor is starting to make a concerted effort to consolidate his power outside Eternos," Skeletor noted. "But he seems to be doing so without any regard for actually protecting Eternia from the Horde. I... I find myself at a loss. By the time rumors reach us here, usually Randor's plans are well underway. It puts me at a disadvantage."

"Eternos is big," Lyn noted with a shrug. "There are plenty of places we could occupy within the capital to more quickly gain information about what Randor is up to."

"The risk is too great," Skeletor declared. "Right now, our greatest advantage over Randor is that he has no idea I am still alive. His

ignorance allows us to move more freely. If we are too close to him, we risk being exposed before we are ready to move. As much as it pains me to admit it, the two of us are not enough to overthrow Randor."

"Three of us couldn't even warn him," Lyn grumbled. The water began to boil and the kettle began to hiss. She rose to deal with it before the sound coming from it became a shriek that would wake the occupant of the room nearby.

"Despite that, there is so much discontent on Eternia that we should be able to take what we need to stop the Horde. But we need more information on Randor's plans. We need better information."

Lyn turned off the stovetop. She postulated, "We need someone in the Royal Palace working for us."

"Yes," Skeletor confirmed as Lyn poured the boiling water over the satchel of tea leaves in her mug. "It is a long-term assignment."

"It's not going to be me," Lyn declared. "I'm not leaving him. Not for that long."

Skeletor put his hand on his chin, a gesture Lyn had come to recognize as the closest the skull-faced man could come to frowning.

"Besides," Lyn continued, "I would have to be using my magic constantly in order to maintain an illusion as a disguise. Otherwise, Duncan would recognize me."

"Hmmm," Skeletor hummed, scratching his left shoulder. That gesture usually indicated he was having a musing.

"What are you thinking?" Lyn asked as she returned to her seat.

"Duncan is close to Randor," Skeletor noted. "His productivity has been... erratic since he brought his daughter back to the palace. Perhaps Duncan is the weak link in Eternos."

"Perhaps," Lyn agreed. "But how would you use that? He might be vulnerable, but since he brought his child to the Royal Palace, my magic has been... less effective."

"Yes," Skeletor agreed. "If you could still scry into the Palace, we would not be in this situation. No matter! I have an idea that does not require magic. We shall place an agent of our own in Randor's court."

"Such a delightfully simple idea," Lyn replied with a smirk, sipping her tea. "It's a wonder you haven't thought of it before."

"If Randor had heeded my advice, I would have been one of his advisors! No, we will have to be more subtle. But I believe that Duncan is the key. If we could get an agent into the royal guard..."

"That would take a long time," Lyn contradicted. "It would be easier to replace Duncan's apprentice than it would be to groom and position an agent of ours in the royal guard."

"An excellent idea, Lyn," Skeletor agreed. "Replacing Duncan's apprentice... we could arrange an accident to befall his current student..."

"We need to have an agent ready to go, first."

"Of course. Certainly there are some young tradespeople in this filthhole who could be turned to our mission..."

"In the city, for sure. In this building, I'm not so convinced."

"What would you need to get this done?" Skeletor asked.

Lyn took another sip of her tea and shrugged. After a moment's consideration, she suggested, "Enough time to find a young apprentice working here in Drisdos City. One who is talented enough to want to study under Duncan, but who shares our politics. That might be tough; it's more than a single day's work.

"And in case it hasn't dawned on you, the difficulty of engaging in spycraft with someone new is the age-old curse of the spy."

"What's that?" Skeletor asked and if she had not known better, she would have sworn he squinted at her.

"If they are willing to work for us so easily, what's to stop them from working for the next person who offers them something better?"

As it stood, Lyn's luck could not have been better. She started at the outskirts of the city, where a farmer politely informed her that he had all the fieldhands he needed, "especially with so many of the farms in the area shutting down!" He had not been much of a talker, but on the subject of family farms shuttering, he was surprisingly articulate. He informed her that most of his neighbors had sent their kids into Drisdos City proper to learn a trade that would "earn them some coin in the future!" Lyn surmised that with an influx of potential labor, the slums of Drisdos City might have some disenchanted youths who would do anything to move up in the world. Despite the sickly yellow tinge that had overtaken her skin, Lyn suspected where she was going, even hers was considered a pretty face for which youth would do almost anything.

In one of the poorest areas of the city, there was a row of tradesmen - a cooper, a leather tanner, a clothier, and a blacksmith - who preferred to work near the outskirts or were compelled to by local ordinances. The prospects were slim; Lyn's ideal candidate was more in the tinkering field, but there were no poor watchmakers on the outskirts, much less one who had an apprentice. Lyn opted for the blacksmith's shop.

The moment she walked in, she suspected she had found the perfect candidate.

Kronis, as the young man would rapidly introduce himself to her, was potentially everything she sought. He was over two meters tall and seemed like a meter wide in his muscular chest. He had cross-cropped brown hair, bright brown eyes and a babyface tanned by the forge's heat. He wore a filthy brown leather apron that barely covered his broad chest and his arms were bare. His biceps were easily as big as Lyn's entire head. She smiled as she entered the shop.

"My master is out at the moment, ma'am," he said. His voice was gravelly and hoarse, as if he had spent quite a bit of time yelling. ”I'm Kronis. Is there something I can help you with?"

"I hope so," she admitted. "I've never actually taken a tour of a blacksmith's forge before. Do you think you can show me around?"

"Yeah, sure," he agreed. "But are you looking to order something?"

"It depends upon the quality of the forge and the work you and your master do here."

"I'm still pretty new around here, so I don't have much in the way of completed pieces I can show off yet, but I'm happy to show you what we're working with." He waved for her to follow him around the counter and into the forge proper.

As soon as they went through the doorway separating the two rooms, Lyn regretted the fact that she was wearing the cloak. The forge was appropriately hot and even with her condition, she quickly became uncomfortable in the room's heat. The blacksmith's forge was not particularly large; it had the furnace occupying the far corner, next to it the massive anvil, a table nearby covered in ingots and tools, a bath - in truth, little more than a giant bucket next to the forge - on the opposite side and another table and wall covered in completed pieces. Lyn was not overly surprised by the blacksmith's inventory; his work was not particularly good and she suspected that his clients were all stuck

in the same basic income bracket, making it hard for the blacksmith to create anything more intricate or profitable.

"What, if anything here, is yours?" Lyn asked as Kronis completed the tour of the small workshop. He picked up a set of four horseshoes and Lyn was surprised that the powerful-looking young man actually had the capacity to look sheepish. "They're good."

Lyn was not entirely lying or pumping up his confidence. The four shoes were virtually identical in size and shape, had flat surfaces and appeared durable. The hole placement looked right for what Lyn knew of horses and horseshoes; they appeared to be a decent quality.

"Thanks," he grunted.

Something in his tone made Lyn suspect the opening she had been looking for had arrived. She gently asked, "Is something wrong?"

"No," Kronis lied obviously. He continued, wonderfully contradicting his initial assertion. "My master took me on, hoping that he could profit from my labor. I get that view; he's teaching me. But he's not the only blacksmith in the world and I think he needs more help than he let on. So, I made these for my dad's horse, only the master won't let me just take them.

"I mean, I don't blame him... much. He's got expenses and the metal cost money. I get that. But my father's horse needs shoeing. She's not a foal anymore; she needs to work."

"Does your father raise horses?"

"Not so much anymore," Kronis admitted. "He did for a while after my mom died, but not so much since. His last mare died about a year ago. He says his stallion ran off."

"'Says?'"

Kronis shrugged. "I didn't see it around after the last time the king's men came through. I think they took him. My dad... won't speak ill of the king. That jester and his alien bride want to take most of our land and he still won't speak ill of him."

"What's this now?" Lyn asked, trying to sound curious. She suspected she already knew the answer.

"King Randor has some big plan to build roads," Kronis explained. Lyn restrained her smile. "His men came through months ago with their teams and their architects and plans. The king wants to cut his road right across my dad's land. They said we can still have the property on the other side, but the back half, that's harder to manage with a road cut through it.

"But between the king's decree that takes so much of his land and a bad crop, it's not like my dad's real flush with cash right now. So he can't just come in and buy these."

"How much are they?" Lyn asked.

"Five each," Kronis replied, dropping the horseshoes back on the table.

"Twenty seems fair for the craftsmanship," Lyn noted. "And a hard sell for one who is impoverished. Tell me, would your master charge you for the nails?"

"My dad has plenty. He stocked up years ago."

"What do you want, young man?" Lyn asked.

"Ma'am?"

"Out of life," she elaborated. "What would you like to do with your life?"

"Honestly? I get the importance of learning the trade, but I think my master's only interested in having me around because I can haul and pound things. I could do that on the farm, you know? I

always thought I'd inherit my father's farm; grow food. Maybe marry some neighbor's daughter, send her into town to sell what we farm... keep the tradition alive."

"That's a lot harder to do without your father's land," Lyn noted.

"So I'm here learning to beat metal."

"How would you like to learn from a better master?" she asked.

"Who? You? I don't think so, lady."

Lyn smirked. "No," she agreed. "Not me. My... skill set is a bit different. What if you could train in Eternos? What if you had an apprenticeship at the Royal Palace?"

Kronis grunted. "It'd be hard not to spit on the king if I saw him."

"How would you like to learn more than one skill at a time?" Lyn asked, producing a small money pouch from inside her cloak.

"What's that for?" he asked. The pouch made a clear clinking sound and it unmistakably contained coins.

"For your horseshoes," she offered, handing him the small pouch. "Take them to your father, get his horse shoed. I'd also like to place an order."

"Yeah?" he responded, suspicion evident in his voice. "For what?"

"Swords," she said, just a little quieter. "Daggers, a chain mace or two, some war hammers. I'm looking for one hundred pieces in all."

"That's a big order," Kronis noted. "You work for the king?"

"I can afford it," Lyn replied. She lowered her voice a little bit more and concluded, "And absolutely not."

Kronis took a moment to put it together, then smiled.

Lyn's plan was brilliant in its simplicity, though it never came to fruition. Lyn placed an order for Skeletor's desired munitions; they would need weapons for their eventual soldiers and if they had some, it might be easier for her to recruit in the future. The order was intended for far more than simply preparing for soldiers who did not yet exist. The size of the order would, no doubt, require Kronis's master to work the forge for quite some time. Lyn suspected that would keep Kronis engaged long enough for her to set-up Duncan's current apprentice for an unfortunate demise. As well, with such a large order, the blacksmith was likely to actually teach Kronis something and he might actually produce a weapon they could use to audition the youth for an apprenticeship with Duncan. It was a good plan.

Lyn brought the plan back to Skeletor and he was surprisingly pleased with her.

Unfortunately, the plan was never fully realized. Two days after Lyn brought payment to the blacksmith, news reached Drisdos City that the Royal Palace was taking on more staff, including craftsmen and apprentices. A discrete inquiry among some associates still living in the capital confirmed that Duncan, specifically, was in need of multiple apprentices. Apparently, his latest vehicle project - which had recently been funded by King Duncan - had some logistical issues and Duncan was in need of an apprentice who was young, strong, and not looking to second-guess the inventor's concept.

Lyn approached Kronis the day she learned of the opening in Duncan's workshop.

She entered the forge when the master blacksmith was going out to lunch. He always went out to lunch at the same time. It was the same time as the horse trainer at the nearby farm took his team out for their afternoon ride every day. Lyn suspected the horses were not the only ones getting a ride, as the horse trainer's wife never went with him and the blacksmith always

returned to the forge after his break to eat a meal. Kronis never appeared to notice that.

"The order's not ready yet," Kronis said as soon as he caught sight of Lyn entering the blacksmith shop.

"Of course not," Lyn replied. "But are you?"

"Ma'am?"

"An opening has come up in Duncan's workshop. I was hoping we could audition one of your pieces and get you an apprenticeship there now."

"I made this dagger," he said, rushing to retrieve it. Rather than call after him, Lynn waited for him to return. The dagger was simple and inornate. While the tip was sharp, it had not yet been sharpened on a stone.

"It's perfect," Lyn noted. It was enough to show he had some ability and training, but primitive enough to illustrate that he needed more education in the art. "I would like to take you to Eternos tomorrow to apply to be one of Duncan's apprentices."

"What about my master?" Kronis asked.

Lyn shrugged. "Do you care?"

Kronis returned the shrug in acknowledgement that he did not particularly care what befell of the blacksmith. He asked, "What of my father?"

"We will take care of him," Lyn assured. "For as long as you work for us, he will be tended to. We cannot pay you directly; being an apprentice comes with perks within the Royal Palace, like housing and meals, but it is seen as part of your education. Apprentices are not paid, except in experience. But because you will be there working for us, we would pay you by taking care of your father."

"How would this work?" he asked, sitting down and pulling some jerky out of a pouch he had stashed under the counter. He began to chew on a strip, without offering Lyn any.

"For as long as you work for us, your father will find himself gainfully employed. Whatever his farm produces shall be bought, in full, for quite a bit over the market price. We will arrange it so periodically when he goes into town, everywhere he plans to shop is prepaid. At least once a year, a money bag that he drops accidentally shall be returned to him."

"My dad doesn't just drop bags of money," Kronis noted.

"But is he foolish enough to fight when someone chases him down, insisting he must have dropped a bag?" Lyn asked.

"I suppose not. What is it, exactly, you want me to do?"

"Three things. The first is that, in your position working for Duncan, you are bound to encounter all sorts of information. Duncan is the king's best friend. Randor is likely to be around quite a bit or Duncan might talk with you about him. When you learn information about any of Randor's plans, simply write me le..."

"I'm going to stop you right there," Kronis cut in. "That plan's not going to work."

Lyn stared at him for a moment. She postulated, "You can't read or write."

"Yup," he confirmed.

"That's fine. We have a workaround in place, though it will require a tiny bit of work on your part." Lyn reached into her cloak and removed a small red gemstone. She set it on the table before Kronis. After a moment, the blacksmith's apprentice set his jerky down and picked up the gem. As he rearranged himself, Lyn removed her wand, with the crystal ball atop it, from her cloak.

"With all your fancy gadgets and money, why do you need me?" Kronis asked.

Lyn smiled and said, "It's because Randor and Duncan have different toys that I need you. And the money... riches can be created or lost with more simplicity than most people know. Wealth flows through me as a means to get what I truly want. Right now, what I want is to help save Eternia from King Randor's ignorance and shortsightedness. So, money is less important to me than you are."

"Hmm," Kronis grunted. "Thank you. How does it work?"

"Place it in your right hand," Lyn instructed. Kronis slowly complied. "Put it as close to the center of your palm as you can. Now, use your thumb to stroke along that curved edge of the crystal. Three times. No more, no less. Three times and say 'listen.'"

"That's it?" Kronis asked, starting to rub the crystal with his thumb.

"I'll show you," Lyn confirmed.

"Listen," he said when he got to the requisite number.

Lyn's crystal ball lit up.

"What?" Kronis asked. His eyes widened as he heard his voice come from Lyn's crystal ball.

"All you have to do is say what you want me to know and I will hear it. When you are done, rub the crystal with your thumb the opposite way."

"Interesting," Kronis said, flinching at the sound of his own voice coming from the crystal ball. He rubbed the crystal as Lyn had directed and he was gratified to see Lyn's wand dim. "That's all?"

"For the most part," Lyn confirmed. "But I cannot stress this enough. You must not use it within the Royal Palace itself. Duncan and Randor appear to have some form of magical protection on the grounds of the palace itself. If you use it there, you will be found out and this will all be over."

"You said there were three things you need me to do," Kronis noted. "That's one."

Lyn smiled and stated, "You'll like this one. As you learn from Duncan, we need you to subtly sabotage his endeavors. He seems to currently be obsessed with vehicles. If you would be so kind as to periodically drop a pebble in a fuel tank, loosen a wire, undermine a pipe, make a tiny hole in a tube, it would slow Duncan and Randor's progress. It will give me time to assemble a more overt force. You might have to occasionally make a mistake that can be tracked back to you, but we're hoping that most of your undermining of Duncan's work will be subtle enough to keep suspicion from you."

"Ruin Duncan's machines? I'd do that for free," Kronis declared. "The more of his crap that fails, the longer it takes for him to start on the damned road through my father's property."

"Exactly."

"What's the third thing?" he asked.

"Endure," she replied. "I don't imagine it will be easy for you, living so close to Randor and working with Duncan. But we need you in place, feeding us information, for as long as possible. That means, no matter what Duncan throws at you - and that might be metaphorical or it might be physical - we need you to stick it out. Do not quit, do not let on what you are doing for us, do not return in person to interact with us. Be Duncan's apprentice."

"I can do that."

The next morning, Lyn appeared on the outskirts of Kronis's farm and made sure he was prepared. She confirmed he had the dagger he had made and the gem she had given him. When he was ready, she opened a portal, transformed her appearance before him and when he nodded, the two passed through the portal.

They arrived in Eternos, in a dark alley a short distance away from the Royal Palace and Duncan's workshop. Lyn directed Kronis one last time, having him place the gem back in his palm.

"When you first meet Duncan, keep your hand in your pocket and be prepared to rub the gem backward once. Right now, though, rub it three times, left to right, with your thumb. That's good. Now, as soon as you finish the third, say 'choose me.'"

"Choose me," he said.

"Now rub it once the opposite way. Good, now stop. One last rub when you first meet Duncan will activate it."

"I thought you said magic wasn't going to work," he noted, eyes narrowing.

"It might not, but this is a much more subtle spell and simple. My hope is whatever magical protections are in place, this might be overlooked, especially because the main enchantment is already done out here."

"You're using my audition to test their defenses," he realized.

"Yes," Lyn replied honestly. "Regardless of whether you get the apprenticeship or not, we need the intel."

"Okay," he said. Without another word, he trudged off toward the Royal Palace. After a moment, Lyn teleported away and was happy when she returned to her current lodging that she was able to revert to her true form.

The calls began that night. Kronis's first message was simple, "I got the job. I start tomorrow."

The second day was surprisingly succinct, as Kronis relayed, "I spent the day working in Duncan's workshop. So far, it's a lot of cleaning. That place is a mess."

The third day Kronis sounded exhausted as he revealed, "I'm not the only apprentice Duncan has, apparently. I mean, I might be now; this morning, one was crushed with a boulder. Grim stuff. I was there to roll the giant rock off the last guy helping Duncan. I'm not sure what the point of cleaning a boulder was, but it's how I spent most of my day. It's for some ridiculous project he's calling, I kid you not, Bashasaurus. The thing has so many moving parts, it'll be easy to keep that from getting mass-produced."

"I took the opportunity today to sabotage Duncan's racing vehicle," Kronis reported on the fourth day. "It's called Road Ripper and while it seems to be done, they haven't started producing a lot of them yet. The damn thing is so loud. I weakened the front axle, when it snaps it should look like a metal flaw. I also cracked a firing diode for the primary weapon's system. That might show up when he powers the thing up next, but I figured it was worth a try."

"Exhausted today," he said through Lyn's crystal ball. "I've been working at the forge all day. Randor has a large order in for swords and armor and Duncan is having me help him produce it. Today it was just working the forge. Duncan asked me about boxing. His daughter wandered into the forge today and started talking about the child prince. Nothing useful there."

Each day, there was something and it became clear rather quickly that Kronis was holding up his end of the deal. Occasionally, Kronis would mention hearing something from his father, about a stroke of luck he had at the store or with a bet he didn't remember placing on a sporting event he had never heard of. Kronis, it turned out, was exceptionally good at sabotage and had a penchant for diverting attention from new projects that he

jeopardized by undermining works that well preceded his tenure in Duncan's company in a timely fashion. Kronis quickly learned to read Duncan's moods and stay silent during his tirades, listen when he discussed the plans for the devices they were building and avoid addressing any personal aspect of Duncan's life. For three days, Duncan had a young apprentice who had a real aptitude for the mechanical, but the boy noted that Teela seemed confident, smart and beautiful and suddenly he wasn't around anymore.

It was through Kronis that Skeletor and Lyn learned that Randor was almost constantly at war with tiny tribes around Eternia. They learned about Count Marzo, another sorcerer who seemed bent on overthrowing Randor, who was raising an army of Shadow Beasts. Through Kronis's intel, Lyn and Skeletor found opportunities to subtly back Randor's adversaries with minimal effort and no exposure. When they relocated to Snake Mountain, Kronis's reports became even more vital. It was Kronis who overheard Duncan talking about Castle Grayskull as if it were real and not some child's myth. Kronis informed them, after more than a year undercover, that Duncan had been promoted to Man-At-Arms and they were moving to a much larger facility within the Royal Palace. Kronis detailed everything they could ever hope to know about the royal family - from Randor's eating habits to Prince Adam's pranks to Marlena's bathing times.

And he endured. Kronis became Duncan's sole apprentice and his position for Lyn and Skeletor quickly became reinforced when Kronis realized that he was not growing in his craft. Even Kronis was able to recognize that Duncan kept him busy, but there was never a conversation of him moving beyond his apprenticeship to journeyman. Duncan used him for all manner of building, hauling, cleaning, crafting, and even literal target practice, but managed to keep his professional secrets to himself in such a way that Kronis was not growing noticeably better at building, designing or even manufacturing more ornate pieces. As such, Kronis was soon able to recognize that the spycraft he was engaged in was far more fulfilling and useful than the gruntwork with which Duncan kept

him occupied. He was also, then, able to recognize potential in others and pass that information on to Lyn.

"There was a guy who came into the palace today," Kronis relayed, "who they sent away. He was introduced as Tri-Opts, but that might not be his actual name. He's built some sort of device for his eyes that can be used for spying and seems to have some form of weapon's technology integrated into it. Randor didn't seem impressed, but Duncan keeps mentioning 'the smoothness of design' for his visor. I think he wants to acquire the man's technology, but doesn't want to work with him or anything. There's some confusion around the guy's name, but I can use my break to try to track him down. I'm pretty sure he's here in Eternos. Duncan has a little streak of gluttony when the cooks make fried chicken, so I might have enough time to slip out the next time that happens."

"I've been noticing," Kronis observed shortly after he and Man-At-Arms moved into the royal workshop, "there doesn't seem to be any real inventory control here. I think I can send a few pieces or parts out to you..." And he did. Kronis worked simply; he informed Lyn when he would be shipping something to his father and Lyn always managed to intercept them as planned. For a young man who showed no interest in learning to read or write, Kronis had an aptitude for timing smuggling items at irregular intervals so he never drew suspicion. It seemed he learned to lean into the stereotypes by leaping upon opportunities to reinforce his ignorance publicly. Kronis told Lyn of a boxing match he won and how the next day, Duncan brought Teela and Prince Adam into the workshop to meet him. They were gushing over a newspaper about the match and tried to get Kronis to read about himself. Kronis told Lyn of how he actually picked up the paper and tried a few sentences before the kids, shocked and baffled, stopped him and read the passage aloud to him.

It was Kronis who passed along a warning that Duncan's latest projects seemed to be focused on energy weapons and that there was a marked build-up in production. Kronis informed Lyn that Randor had made a treaty with the Avionians and he said Duncan

kept using the term "mutual defense" in regard to the Andreenids. Duncan, it seemed, was very interested in acquiring some of the Bee People's ambrosia and was frustrated that they did not have the means. That frustration skyrocketed days later when a bomb was detonated in the Andreenid's central hive. Duncan, Kronis reported, had been swearing all day about how foolish the Avionians had been to stage such an attack. He seemed particularly frustrated that the bombing hadn't killed the Queen because now the Andreenids were arming up for war and Duncan was struggling to find adequate countermeasures to the energy weapon component to their axes. Kronis even managed to smuggle the prototype for the personal energy shield Man-At-Arms invented out of Eternos for Lyn.

For years, Kronis endured Duncan's mood swings and crankiness. He found himself more frequently exhausted by Man-At-Arms using his physical strength as he created more and more elaborate devices for Randor. He bore the daily humiliations of Duncan demanding a part from a place that "was clearly marked" and Kronis endured it because he was able to recognize that in all of the insults, Duncan never once offered to help Kronis change his station. Instead, he merely kept Kronis in his place and used his family to help remind him of what that place was.

For all of Duncan's insults against Kronis, Kronis endured for years. Randor, Man-At-Arms, the revolving door of junior apprentices (those who survived); no one suspected the massive, quiet blacksmith apprentice of being anything other than what he appeared.

Two days before the moment that changed everything for him, Kronis sent Lyn a message. He was out of breath as he reported, "Man-At-Arms is working on something new and it looks like it might actually be successful. It's a fluid, some sort of copper and barium solution that is designed to significantly enhance the strength of metals that are soaked in it. Duncan is working on figuring out the health risks of it, but it seems while the solution is

highly toxic, the results of the bath are incredible. Duncan thinks armor made with this will change Randor's army forever."

The day before, he was equally-concerned, stating, "Man-At-Arms has begun to experiment with some of the crystals in the solution. He seems convinced that they will make more potent firing diodes. I'll try to get some out to you, but things are moving very fast here. We're taking some of this refined metal to the forge today to see how we might work it. I should know tomorrow what the results of that are, but Duncan won't shut up about how this will revolutionize Randor's army. That can't be good for us."

The next day, Kronis was leaving the shipping service he used on the edge of the city when he activated the gem Lyn had given him so many years before.

"I've shipped out the first two pieces. One is a scrap from a piece of boot armor that Man-At-Arms cast aside. The other, you'll appreciate this; it's my dagger. Duncan tossed it into the solution he made two days ago and yesterday, we reworked it at the forge. I swear, he didn't even remember... it was... mine. What's this?"

As he had concluded his report, Kronis became engulfed in a rapidly moving crowd. Citizens were flocking to the streets and that, in turn, was encouraging shopkeepers to leave their stores and try to discover what the commotion was about. The crowd, then, was made up of people fleeing from the Royal Palace coming into contact with surprised citizens leaving buildings. Kronis found himself at one interaction between the two fronts and, as he tried to glean exactly what was going on, he forgot to deactivate the gem as he slid it into his pocket.

"There's been an invasion!"

"Someone is at the Palace!"

"The prince came back with an alien!"

"The king is harboring an alien!"

"There's an alien at the Royal Palace and it's taking over the kingdom!"

"Run!"

Kronis heard all of the various screams and rumors and he rushed into action. Whatever the reality of the situation was, Kronis was able to recognize an opportunity for what it was. If there was chaos in the street, Man-At-Arms would be advising King Randor. There was a chance that Duncan would not return from lunch to the workshop. If the crystals in the solution in the workshop were truly as important as Duncan had said, then it was important to get one and get it to Lyn. Kronis had played it cautious with his exports already; but if there was so much chaos in the Royal Palace, this was his chance to sneak at least one of the crystals away. If Duncan noticed, Kronis decided he would suggest that maybe the solution dissolved a crystal. Anything that made Duncan doubt his work helped throw off Randor's timetable.

His travel through the Royal Palace was predictably chaotic. Servants were running in every direction, royal guards were blocking paths, getting trampled, herding citizens out of corridors, alarms rang. Kronis smiled as he entered the palace, seeing the chaos. It was the last time he would ever be able to smile.

Kronis arrived back at the workshop to find it empty and he approached the massive tub filled with the blue-green liquid. He looked around for the safety gloves and found one, then a straining tool Duncan had used whenever interacting with the fluid. He began to agitate the liquid when he heard voices in the hallway outside. One was Duncan's, another the captain of the guard.

"Whatever it is, it's in here!" Duncan shouted to be heard over the alarms. "In my workshop!"

"Something magical?" the captain asked loudly. "That doesn't make sense."

“Unless we truly are under attack,” Duncan replied loudly.

Kronis realized his mistake, just as the door opened. He had not deactivated the gem; he had entered the Royal Palace and Duncan's workshop with it active. He did not have time to reach into his pocket to stop the inadvertent transmission. He swore under his breath, inhaled deeply, dropped the tools and leapt into the vat before him.

"The Sorceress has never steered me wrong before," Man-At-Arms yelled as he rushed into the workshop.

As Kronis did his best to get to the bottom of the vat and remain still, he heard Man-At-Arms's voice become slightly more faint. He was turning around, Kronis realized as he listened.

"You! Stay out of my workshop!"

A high-pitched voice insisted, "I might be able to help!"

"No!" Man-At-Arms roared. "I don't want you anywhere near my equipment. You, keep him out while we find the source of this..."

"Yes, sir" another voice replied.

At the bottom of the vat, Kronis felt several of the crystals. If this was his last chance, he figured, he might as well take it. He scooped up what he could; the crystals were very small and he counted ten. Duncan had put twelve into the solution the day before, but Kronis could not risk trying to find the other two.

He opened his mouth and the solution rushed in. Until he opened his mouth, he had not focused on how the liquid around him felt. As he opened his mouth, he recognized how every nerve on his skin was feeling. The solution was cold and the effect was numbing, but there was something insidious about the cold temperature. The cold kept penetrating his skin, a feeling he became consciously aware of as the fluid filled his mouth. The sensation kept getting deeper and it was when he became aware that he could not feel his cheeks at all that he consciously

understood that the cold he felt penetrating him was a freezing feeling deep below his skin, in his muscles. Thinking fast, he set the crystals in his mouth - he could not feel them on his tongue - and he did his best to swallow. The sharp edges of the crystals went unnoticed by Kronis as the fluid numbed the nerves of his esophagus.

Kronis knew he was going to have to surface soon, but he had no plan and he had kept his eyes firmly closed in the vat; he had lost track of direction. He heard voices outside the vat; they were getting closer. He reached into his pocket for the gemstone as he felt he reached the limits of his endurance. He found the bottom of the vat with his feet, thumbed the gem to deactivate it, and pushed what he hoped was upward to the surface.

Kronis leapt out of the vat, opening his eyes as the caustic solution splashed out around him. The captain of the guard gasped. Kronis opened his eyes as his feet slipped on the wet floor. He saw the expression on Man-At-Arms's face as Duncan turned toward him.

Duncan's face transformed in a way Kronis had never before witnessed. As Kronis fell, he watched as the blue-green fluid splashed onto Duncan. Duncan’s expression started with revulsion, then flashed a moment of recognition as he saw Kronis landing clumsily. The recognition lasted only a millisecond before Duncan's eyes widened and Kronis realized that in the years they had been working in proximity, he had never seen Duncan look shocked before. Even the epiphany of shock did not last, as Kronis slid across the floor to a bench packed with completed weapons. Anger took its place.

"Kronis! What is the meaning of this?" Man-At-Arms roared, fury in his voice, as he approached, mace in hand.

Kronis rolled to a crouch next to the bench and Man-At-Arms lifted his mace. Kronis wished in that moment that he had not sent his dagger to Lyn; he could really use it now. With his left hand, he reached out for a sword hilt on the table. He was aware of the

gem in his right, but he did not have time to place it back in his pocket. He tossed it up and caught it in his mouth as he passed the sword from his left to right hand.

"What is that? Tell me, Kronis!"

Kronis shook his head, less in defiance of his master and more to determine where, exactly, the captain of the guard was. The other soldier was advancing on him from the right, behind him. Duncan did not take the tactical move for what it was, interpreting it instead as his apprentice defying him.

"What magic are you using? By Subternia, you will tell me!"

Kronis turned his attention back toward Duncan and raised the sword. His attention was a fraction of a second too late, though, and Man-At-Arms's mace caught the right side of his face. It was fortunate that Kronis could not feel the impact of the blow; Duncan was not restraining himself. Kronis's vision changed as the force of the mace knocked his head. He felt something wet slide across his chest to his left shoulder and his eyes widened as the gem that had been in his mouth sailed into his line of sight. Kronis attempted to close his mouth, but the numbness permeated his whole body.

Seeing the gem flying through the air, Kronis felt alarm. He was not consciously aware of the fluid that followed the magic stone, though it was his saliva and blood spraying out of his numb body. Kronis thought of his father, his farm, the horses. The gem had been his link to Lyn and provided a better life for his father. Years of protecting the gem had created an instinct for keeping it safe that overrode all other impulses. Kronis dropped the sword and leapt after the gem.

"I've got him!" the captain of the guard declared. Kronis did not feel his longsword pin him down through his right leg. He did not feel the tendons slice and tear as the momentum of his jump cut his body away from the rooted sword.

Kronis did not even feel the gemstone in his hand as he watched his right hand close around it.

"What is that?!" Man-At-Arms yelled again.

Kronis heard a snapping sound, but did not feel the impact of his body landing. His vision was at an awkward angle and he realized that he was lopsided; his right side was noticeably lower than his left. The Captain of the guard was rushing him, pulling his sword out of the floor nearby as Kronis spun and got his bearings.

"Get that!" Man-At-Arms ordered.

As Kronis found his footing with his left foot, the Captain complied, slicing downward through Kronis's right shoulder. Even as he watched his own arm falling to the ground, Kronis felt no pain. He was shocked, though, to see a bright light appear behind the captain of the guard. There was a bright yellow glow, then the captain exploded, as if his internal organs had instantaneously expanded and burst his body. Even as the innards and armor from his adversary splattered onto his unfeeling skin, Kronis reached with his left hand for the gem his right hand, on the floor, still held.

"No!" Man-At-Arms shouted, surprisingly close as Kronis's remaining hand grasped the precious gem. The last thing Kronis felt was the impact of Duncan's mace in the back of his skull. He saw Lyn approaching from the glow, her wand discharging more magical energy. As he lost consciousness, he heard Duncan shouting, "I trusted you! How could you?!"

What followed for Kronis was a hellish fog that took an indeterminate amount of time to clear. Kronis could barely hear; what little he could was only on his left side and everything sounded like it was being said from a great distance and underwater. His vision was filled with the floor, then light; the numbness wore off to pain and Kronis was shocked when he did

not lose consciousness from the overwhelming sensation. The light was obscured by the face of a man, vaguely familiar, with a giant eye looking down upon him. He heard something about "let him die" and he knew the man was speaking about him. He reached out to him.

He was able to feel his hand connect with the man's skin and he clung to him for a moment. Outside a gloved handshake, he had never purposely touched or been touched by Duncan. The man with the strange eye nodded his understanding and Kronis felt gratified. Kronis wanted to live. He wanted to see his father again. He wanted to see Duncan get his comeuppance.

He struggled to remember what he had heard moments before his world was turned upside down. It seemed like there was something important in there he needed to tell Lyn.

"I'll get to your arm when I wake up," the man said, head very close to Kronis's face. Kronis realized to his surprise that he could hear the man perfectly. There was such clarity to the sounds he heard and he heard exhaustion in the man's voice. He reached out to the other man, who was putting his head down on the desk.

He realized he was reaching out with his left hand. He could not feel anything on his right side, save a profound weight. He felt as if his chest was being pinned down by a boulder and like his back was anchored to the table. He opened his mouth to speak, but felt nothing in his jaw and heard only a whirring sound, like Duncan's motors, in his ears.

"It's okay," the man reassured. Kronis felt fear despite the man's words.

"Why?" was all he could think to ask. His voice sounded mechanical, foreign and distant.

"I tried my best. I used whatever I had around to save your life and put you back together. Most of it is metal. Your jaw..."

He worked it and heard multiple hinges where muscles had been. He was overcome with fatigue.

"Explains it," he breathed out. The man who had kept him alive nodded. Kronis admitted, "Tired."

"Me, too. Why don't we both get some sleep?"

Kronis did not want to move; he was unsure that he could move. The man began to recline in his chair and Kronis realized exactly who he was. The fog ebbed away enough. He had seen the man, years before, when he had come to the Royal Palace and Randor had disregarded him. He struggled for the man's name.

"Thank you, Tri-Klops," he said. The name sounded off in his ear, the sound of his own voice still did not seem quite right.

"Tri-Opts," the man corrected.

Kronis worked his jaw, testing the servos. He tried to run his tongue over the metal jaw that he could not feel, tried to pass it over his teeth, tried to push it to the roof of his mouth. He felt the cold of the metal, as if from a great distance, like it was far outside his body. His tongue gave him the sensation of the rigidity of his front teeth, but he could not feel how sharp they were. While he could press into the roof of his mouth, he realized that he could not taste anything, not even the metal that he knew rationally he ought to. Fear overcame him as he understood in some corner of his mind that he no longer had a tongue.

"Tri-Klops," he called out, wanting to articulate that fear. How was he able to say even that without a tongue in his mouth?!

"Yes, very good," the man reassured. "I am Tri-Klops."

Kronis felt comforted by the sound of the man's voice and he allowed himself to feel safe for a moment and he closed his eyes to lose consciousness.

Kronis awoke to the feeling of a hand on his jaw. He instinctively reached out with his right hand, but the phantom limb immediately dissipated. He slowly reached up with his left hand as he opened his eyes.

Tri-Klops was using tools on the left side of his jaw and he touched the other man's forearm with his hand.

"You're awake," Tri-Klops noted. "Please lay still for a moment. I am making some adjustments. I know this might be uncomfortable for you for a moment, but I need you to not try to speak while I do this. Please.

"You are stable. You are safe. I will do my best not to hurt you, but I am honestly not certain I can promise none of this will hurt. I'll get a mirror in here as soon as I can, but I'm not sure you're ready for how you look. It might take you a little while to get used to. Then again, I'm not entirely sure how much you'll remember. The magic Lyn used kept you together, but I'm not exactly a brain surgeon. In this case, it was more like a brain collector. I'm pretty sure I got everything you had back into your head, but I'll be honest, I wasn't exactly careful.

"I focused on saving your life and reconstructing you, but there's a lot I did on the fly. As a result, some of your systems might work better than others and some of it is going to take a bit of fine-tuning. Right now, I'm adjusting your jaw and some of your vocal controls. I'm not sure how much you remember from last night... or this morning, I'm not sure what time it was when we fell asleep... but your voice probably sounded very different to you. We can try to adjust that. But right now, I'm trying to fix a little impulse control issue.

Tri-Klops moved his head back so the reclined man could see him better. The apparent cyclops smiled and explained, "You talk in your sleep. The adjustment I am making now is to create a partition that will recognize only your conscious attempts at communication. I woke up to you jabbering about Duncan, the

Sorceress, something about a trap, your jaw. I'd like to reassure you that you are safe here. It's going to be okay."

He moved back to his close position to finish the adjustments. He noted, "It was pretty noisy as you kept working your jaw. If you want, later on we could fix it so you can use the voicebox technology independent of your jaw. But this morning, as you were dreaming, the system was working well and your body was relaying all of the impulses properly. The result is that you were talking in your sleep and your jaw got a bit of mileage. We're going to have to keep that well-oiled. It was pretty bad this morning. It was like: 'Duncan... SQUEAK... Sorceress... SQUEAK... Trap!... SQUEAK... JAW!... SQUEAK...' well, you get it. It was very loud. It was like you wanted to be sure I heard you.

"Okay, that should do it. Do you remember your name, Kronis?" he asked gently, leaning back in his chair.

The patient squinted slightly and he felt himself frown.

"No," he admitted. His voice still sounded strange to him. "Maybe I told you."

"Unless your name is Duncan Sorceress Trap Jaw, you didn't tell me anything," Tri-Klops reassured.

"Trap Jaw works," he decided. Tri-Klops frowned.

"Are you sure, Kronis?" he asked.

"Yes," Trap Jaw assured. "From what you said, it's going to be one of my more recognizable features."

"It's better than Armless," Tri-Klops confirmed. "We should be able to do something about that today, too. Can I help you sit up?"

"Please," Trap Jaw consented. He still felt a massive weight on his right side and he was not sure how exactly he would push himself up with his left hand without rolling off the right side of the table. Tri-Klops came around to his side and hugged him, using the

motion to lift him up off the table. After he was perpendicular to his legs, a moment of lightheadedness came over him in which time Tri-Klops moved around behind him and began to adjust his body, Trap Jaw struggled to become balanced. His legs were bare and blue-green in a way that seemed familiar, but that Trap Jaw could not immediately identify. Tri-Klops carefully adjusted Trap Jaw's left arm to use it to support the man.

"If we can rotate you, so your legs are hanging off the table, you might be able to balance on your own," Tri-Klops advised.

Trap Jaw thought for a moment. He heard the tone of sadness in his own voice as he declared, "I don't know how."

"That's understandable," Tri-Klops reassured. "Are you really sure you want to go by the name Trap Jaw, Kronis?"

"Yes," he replied as Tri-Klops gently took his legs. "Why wouldn't I?"

"No reason," Tri-Klops said with a frown. "Careful now."

Tri-Klops worked in silence for a moment, arranging Trap Jaw so his legs hung over the edge of the table and he would not have to strain his left arm as much to remain upright. There was a chiming behind Tri-Klops.

"That's the door," Tri-Klops noted. "I'd like to get it. Can you hold yourself up?"

"I think so," Trap Jaw affirmed.

"Good. I'll be right back."

Tri-Klops went to the door of his workshop and activated the controls. Predictably, Skeletor and Lyn stood in the mostly-dark hallway beyond.

"How is your patient, Tri-Opts?" Lyn asked.

"It's Tri-Klops now," he corrected. "It's not the first name I've had and it seemed to reassure him. Come on in. There seem to be some gaps in his memory; I would go on the assumption that the memory loss is permanent. This seems to include some basic information."

"Like what?" Skeletor asked, tone suspicious.

"He doesn't show any recognition of his name. He likes the name Trap Jaw," Tri-Klops said as the trio rounded the corner to see the man on the table.

"What a fitting name for such a powerful individual," Skeletor declared.

"Do we know each other?" Trap Jaw asked, looking confused from Tri-Klops to Skeletor to Lyn.

"You recognize me, right?" Tri-Klops asked.

"Of course, Tri-Klops," he reassured. He turned his attention toward the other two. As Skeletor spoke, Lyn approached and a look of tenderness and sadness crossed her face. She reached out to touch Trap Jaw's right cheek.

"We've never met," Skeletor confirmed. "But you have been invaluable to me."

"We knew each other," Lyn said sadly. "We've been working together for quite some time."

"Oh," Trap Jaw said. "I'm sorry, I don't remember that."

"It's all right," Lyn assured. "We'll take care of you and your father."

"Father?" he asked. His eyes connoted a complete lack of recognition, as if the term were completely alien to him.

"We can take you out to see him when you're all back together," Lyn said. "How long is that likely to be Tri... Tri-Klops?"

"That depends on our buddy Trap Jaw here," he said. "It depends how picky he is about his new arm."

"What do you mean?" Skeletor inquired.

Tri-Klops smiled, looking from Skeletor back to Trap Jaw as their eyes met. He said, "I have a lot of options for you. The cuff I have installed will relay all sorts of neurological impulses to where your arm was, Trap Jaw. What receives that can be... up to you. I can give you a very basic prosthetic or we can make something that you really like, something that makes you feel really good about yourself.

"But I don't want to put the cart before the horse. Your body has just undergone a massive trauma; I think we should be patient. You're going to have to take some time to get your balance back. We haven't even tried walking yet! We have some time, though; I'd like to get this right and help you be happy."

"You will have a place here with us for as long as you want," Lyn reassured.

"I would be happy to have you by my side as we save Eternia," Skeletor confirmed.

"See? You have options," Tri-Klops said with a smile. "What would you like, Trap Jaw?"

"Apprentice," he replied.

Tri-Klops nodded. Lyn frowned. Tri-Klops said, "I suppose we could get you an apprentice..."

"No," Trap Jaw said, the fog in his head lifting further. "Yours. You seem to know things. I'd like to learn. Teach me, please. Duncan didn't teach."

Tri-Klops smiled.

"Yeah, I'll teach you," Tri-Klops assured, his tone starting to embody joy. "Gladly. I will teach you everything I can. We'll get you walking, we'll figure out your arm... together. Then, we'll start with the basics. We'll have you reading and writing before you know it."

"Is that necessary?" Trap Jaw asked.

"Most assuredly," Lyn replied.

"Yes," Tri-Klops agreed. "If you're going to learn from me, you'll need to be able to read blueprints and write some notes. So, yeah, it'll be important. Then, we'll start building together. I will teach you everything you want to know."

"Thank you," Trap Jaw said. He turned his gaze toward Skeletor. "Then I will be useful."

"Yes," Skeletor confirmed. "You will."

"Duncan," Trap Jaw said. Tri-Klops and Lyn bristled at hearing the name and they focused completely on Trap Jaw. "Duncan was bad. I want an arm. I want to learn. I want to be useful. I want Duncan punished. He did this to me. He..."

Trap Jaw struggled for the words, feeling only a flame of emotion within that was more than he had felt since he awoke. Trap Jaw felt a pain within himself and his head ached as he envisioned the man with whom he had worked for the past few years, never advancing.

"We can help you with that," Tri-Klops assured. "Together, we will punish Duncan for what he has done to you. He has no friends here, Trap Jaw."

Despite knowing it was physically impossible, Trap Jaw felt himself smile and it felt good.

The Trial Of Foreknowledge

Chapter Summary

> This is a direct sequel to chapter 3, picking up with Lyn and Teela during the same night in the Sands Of Time.

"Hmm," Teela giggled. Her voice was lower from the fact that she remained mostly unconscious. She mumbled, "You called him Keldor! Silly."

Lyn's eyes remained closed. She had awoken to the sound of Teela's quiet, sleepy laugh. She felt her traveling companion's body warm against her and with her eyes closed, she allowed herself the luxury of simply enjoying Teela's youthful ridiculousness. The young woman had an innocence to her when she was unarmored; asleep, all her defenses were down and Lyn allowed herself the moment to enjoy the instant, recalling how she and Gwen had spent so many nights sharing everything they had learned in a given day. Teela was obviously not Gwen, but she was there and warm and for a few seconds, Teela's presence near her felt good.

Teela pulled Lyn's left arm into her stomach, wiggling slightly to get even closer to Lyn in her sleep. With her right hand, Teela reached back for the cloak that encircled both women, in the process, brushing her fingers against Lyn's thigh. Teela awoke, realizing what she was doing and apologized.

"It's all right," Lyn whispered in her right ear from behind her. Teela thanked her. Lyn noted, "You were asleep."

"I don't feel very rested," Teela complained. Lyn could picture her pout from her tone.

"Another effect of the Sands Of Time," Lyn explained. She sighed, felt Teela tremble before her as her breath tickled the younger

woman's ear, and opened her eyes. "It's still not light out. I have no way of judging how long we have been asleep."

From her own fatigue, Lyn suspected she had been asleep for less than two hours.

"Lyn," Teela began, her tone quieter than normal. Lyn recognized it as fear and she understood that it must be very difficult for the Captain of the Guard to be so vulnerable with her. Lyn resolved to be compassionate with whatever Teela had to say. As it was, the frightened young woman carefully asked, "Will the night here ever end?"

"Yes," Lyn assured. "The Sands Of Time are plagued by temporal anomalies, but they are still part of the larger Eternia. Sunlight masks many of the effects within the desert, but it does cut through. The night will end, young lady."

"Thank you," Teela replied. "Really, thank you. I would never have guessed that you could help me feel safe, but I feel safe right now. Are you sure Kothos actually took your magic?"

"If I had my magic, I would have taken us out of here, Teela."

"Oh, sorry," the young woman said. Lyn was surprised by her reaction.

"You really don't have many friends," Lyn realized. "No one spends much time talking with you, do they?"

"Not so much," Teela admitted. "The joke I made before... I live with the other half of it. Pretty much everyone expects me to pair up with one of the many, many men I'm surrounded by and I don't feel particularly pressured to choose one of them simply because they're always around."

"That's surprisingly wise."

"That might be the nicest thing you've said to me," Teela noted. She squeezed Lyn's hand and burrowed even closer. She admitted,

"M... my dad spent so much time training me and I've worked so hard to train Prince Adam... I haven't really developed much in the way of social skills. My life has been surrounded by conflict. But yes, it has been a long time since anyone told me a story."

"I don't have my magic," Lyn reiterated. "The story... I was just trying to help you fall asleep and telling the story..."

"It made me feel safe to hear your voice," Teela confirmed. "After looking at the sky, your voice... grounded me. Thank you."

"You're welcome," Lyn replied.

They lapsed into silence and Lyn began to doze. Teela was absently stroking her fingers with her left hand, gently, lightly rubbing slow circles from one set of knuckles to another, never moving the palm of her hand. Lyn focused on the soft caresses from Teela, somewhat surprised how her calloused hands did not feel dry or scratchy on the back of the magic-user's hand.

Just as Lyn was on the verge of drifting off fully to sleep, Teela said her name. Lyn sighed, which seemed to inform Teela that she was awake.

"I don't think I'm going to be able to fall back asleep," Teela admitted. "I'm finally warmed up, I feel safe, but I just don't think I can sleep right now."

"What would you like me to do about it?" Lyn asked, not unkindly. She noticed Teela had returned to simply holding her hand. Lyn was very aware that the younger woman was holding onto her as if she was holding on for her life.

"Do you think you could tell me more of your story?" Teela asked. "Hearing your voice helps me feel safe."

"Oh, is that all?" she asked with a wry tone.

"No," Teela admitted. "I was enjoying your story, Lyn. Besides, you just got to Skeletor's arrival."

"Tut you," Lyn chided. She gently nipped at Teela's nearby ear; Teela let out a surprised noise. "You need to listen better!"

"What?!"

"It was Keldor," Lyn corrected. "Has your education truly been so neglected that you have no idea what the difference is? I said 'Keldor' because that is who came through the portal. Skeletor did not exist yet. In some ways, they were two very different people."

"Will you tell me what happened when you and Gwen met... Keldor? Please?"

"All right," Lyn agreed.

I was terrified by Keldor's arrival, but I was more worried about Gwen, who had been knocked unconscious by his entrance into our world. I instantly recognized the muscular man as a Gar; Gars were native to Eternia, but I'm getting ahead of myself. As I mentioned, Gwen and I had discovered the Knowledge Gem on the Lonely Island and I lied about that to Keldor, who had appeared on our world so soon after that disgusting creature who had been killed for his failure to find the Knowledge Gem.

My mind was racing as I looked over the Gar. His eyes narrowed at me while he held Gwen in his left hand with the same amount of apparent effort with which he held the sword in his right. Before he could question me more, I found my voice, just enough to request, "May I have my... friend back?"

I nodded at Gwen in his hand. He looked at me, then at her unconscious form, as if he were just noticing her there for the first time. I took a step toward the much larger, imposing man, and he lowered her so her feet touched the ground. I wrapped my arms around her so she could not fall and he released her to me. I pulled her back with me several steps and the Gar sheathed his massive sword. Given that it was daylight and he had just come through a portal that was crackling with energy, I had not

perceived the sword to be glowing with magic and energy. When he sheathed it, though, somehow I noticed that everything became slightly dimmer around us. I was very aware of the water around my feet and how there were no good places for me to lay Gwen down.

"I need to get her to safety," I insisted. Keldor glanced at me with even more suspicion. I felt myself rolling my eyes as I chanted the simple levitation spell. I wanted to get her back home, but at this point, evading danger seemed to be a moot point, so I just wanted to get us out of the crater. Besides, I was aware-enough even then to know I didn't want to reveal where we lived to this interloper.

I recall feeling a bit gratified as Gwen became lighter in my hands and we rose off the ground, seeing the surprise on Keldor's face. Whatever he had been expecting to find on Eternia, it was clear that our magic was not something he had anticipated encountering so soon. I rose the three of us over the crater lip and gently back down to the other side, to the crystal surfaces of the Lonely Island. As I lay Gwen down on the hard ground, I observed the Gar carefully testing his footing on the solid surface. When he seemed certain he would not slip, he restored his affect of arrogance and power.

I carefully looked Gwen over as I arranged her body. She was unconscious, but alive. Her locator spell had overwhelmed her senses, like if you went from a pitch black room to looking at the noonday sun; the shock just overwhelmed her. She was breathing and I suspected she would be all right; in our practice of magic, we had been known to get knocked about occasionally. While I wrapped her cloak around her, I removed mine and rolled it up and gently placed it under her head. Then I turned my attention to the Gar.

He was looking down on me with a sense of superiority that was almost palpable. Regardless of how much Gwen and I had experienced and been bruised in our magical explorations, I did not like the idea that the one person I cared about in this world

was wounded by my side and the man who knocked her out, albeit unwittingly, stood looking like he owned the world. I wanted to see how fast I could remove that arrogant expression from his face.

"How did you know about the Knowledge Gem?" I asked.

I guessed correctly, the man was shocked that I did not ask anything about him first. Narcissist. In all of his incarnations, Keldor, Skeletor... he has been an egoist. I suspect you will find the easiest way to cut a man to the quick is by simply dismissing them and their presence in favor of anything or anyone else. The Gar was certainly taken aback. Here was this magnificent specimen of Gar masculinity and I was inquiring about a rock.

He frowned.

"Our books record many important artifacts," the Gar revealed. His frown deepened. "At least, they did."

"Past tense," I noted.

"Our library was destroyed," he admitted. "Our books were destroyed. Where are we?"

"We're on an island in the Crystal Sea," I provided. There seemed no harm in telling him this truth. "On Eternia."

"Eternia... good," the Gar mused. "At least those fools got the planet right. Glitix'Glik Tar thought he made it to the right world, but he was an idiot, so we couldn't be sure about even that."

"That would be the corpse we found on the other island," I provided. Maybe if he wanted to focus on the other interloper, he would leave Gwen and I alone.

"We're all corpses," the Gar grumbled. He looked around and found a crystal formation a few steps away upon which he could sit. He ambled over, adjusted the sword at his side, and sat.

"Not yet," I insisted, as he situated himself. "We're not all dead yet."

"A fighting spirit!" he praised. "Admirable. Perhaps pointless, but admirable, especially compared to what is going on out there."

Beneath my fingers, I began to feel Gwen stir. I looked at her and her eyes began to twitch and flutter.

"It's all right," I assured her. "You're safe."

"Where...?"

"We're still in the Crystal Sea." Before she could say anything more, I warned, "We have a visitor."

Gwen opened her eyes the rest of the way. Those beautiful green eyes. I moved her hair away from her eyes, so she could see me. She blinked and came awake. She understood my tone. I understood her look; she wanted to sit up. I helped her into a sitting position. The two of us sat on the ground, me propping Gwen up, facing the gray-eyed Gar, who looked down upon us. He stroked his chin and the jet-black goatee he had. With us so situated, the Gar nodded.

"I am Keldor, the Last of the Gar" he introduced.

I could tell Gwen was frowning by her tone, even as I looked at Keldor, as she noted, "There are Gar here on Eternia."

"Very few," I agreed.

"Really?" Keldor asked. "I thought they were all with us."

"Where?" I asked, trying to make sure that Gwen did not reveal anything more to the interloper.

"Garnia," Keldor replied, as if the answer was obvious. I felt myself frown and Keldor looked momentarily exhausted. He regrouped, "All right. Several thousand years ago, a force was

sweeping through our galaxy. You know what a galaxy is, yes? Good. When they reached Eternia, they were overwhelmed and this planet was the site of a great battle. The Ancients of Eternia and the dragons of Eternia managed to harness the powers this planet possesses and fight off the Horde. Unfortunately, somewhere between their ignorance and their compassion, the Horde fleet that came to Eternia was not destroyed, it was merely teleported to a distant point in the universe many galaxies away.

"In the conflict, the Ancients and the Dragons - it is not clear which - attempted to keep the secrets of Eternia from falling into the hands of the Horde. You've heard of the Horde?"

"Some of the books in the Royal Library mention a war during the time of Hiss," I recalled.

"They describe an off-world invasion," Gwen added. "That's the only record we have of the Horde."

"That would have been an advanced scouting mission," Keldor surmised. "The real invasion must have been lost in your history."

"But it wasn't in yours?" Gwen asked, suspicion evident in her tone.

Whether Keldor felt slighted by her disbelief, he gave no indication. Instead, he continued to explain,"Keeping the secrets of Eternia from falling into Horde possession meant that the knowledge of the most powerful artifacts and locations on Eternia had to be hidden. The single greatest repository of that knowledge was in the Library Of Gar, in our capital city. Whichever force it was that decided to save the knowledge of Eternia's greatest secrets acted... impulsively to save those secrets. They did not seem to care so much for the Gar in the capital as much as the secrets. They teleported the Library, much of the capital city and most of the population of Gar away from Eternia. They magically relocated us on a distant planet for safekeeping.

"My ancestors were convinced that the Ancients had been defeated by the Horde. Their logic was simple; if the threat from the Horde no longer existed, of course whoever had teleported the Gar capital away from Eternia would recover it! Fools! No, their secrets were saved and the battle was won, but the victors forgot about the Gar. We were simply inconvenient people who happened to be near their precious secrets.

"But we survived on that new world. We named it Garnia and we built a magnificent civilization there. It was a magnificent civilization."

His tone of condescension and arrogance gave way to sadness as he repeated, "It was a magnificent civilization."

"What happened?" I asked.

"Five years ago, the Horde arrived at Garnia. They swept in, destroying our cities effortlessly. We were on the brink of utter annihilation when they stopped."

"Why did they stop?" Gwen asked.

Keldor frowned and rubbed his brow. After a moment, he shook his head and looked back at us sitting nearby. He almost looked like he was seeing us for the first time then. He told us, "The Horde captured some of my people. Right before the last of our cities would have been wiped out, members of the Horde actually interacted with some of us. They learned who we were and somehow, they learned of our history. There's a great irony here, as well.

"The Ancients of Eternia sought to keep the secrets this world possessed away from the Horde, recognizing that its goals were complete subjugation or destruction of the universe itself. In defeating the Horde, the Dragons or the Ancients managed to leave the Horde so broken that Eternia became a myth, a fragment of a prehistory in the rise of their glorious empire. If the Ancients had just followed-through...

"The Horde came to my world, which was the repository of Eternia's greatest secrets, and it was there, on Garnia, they relearned of Eternia. They have been searching for nebulous power for eons, traveling the stars and wiping out anything they are unable to control. And on my world, they learned of your world, a place with all of the power needed to make their goals into a reality."

I felt sick to my stomach, I know the color drained from my face because even in the sunlight, my cheeks got cold.

"They're coming here," I realized.

"They are," Keldor confirmed.

"No," Gwen whispered.

"Without a doubt," Keldor insisted. "But we have several advantages."

"What are you talking about?" I asked.

Keldor smiled and his smile was not malicious for a change. Instead, it was confident. He revealed, "We have a head start. You have me. And I am here to stop the Horde and recover Garnia, if any part of it exists when we are done."

"How?" Gwen asked. "If they know about Eternia..."

"They do," Keldor confirmed. "They know its location and they know it is the repository of power they seek. But beyond that, they know very little."

"I don't understand," I admitted. I don't think I was ever as vulnerable with Keldor as I was in that very moment.

"That's all right," Keldor said with more compassion and patience than he would ever display as Skeletor. "That's because I have not finished my story, young lady. The Horde was sweeping over Garnia and I was part of the last resistance. I was a librarian, if

you can believe that, back in that life. I rallied the people on the streets to our defense as our military fell. I was there when the Horde was burning our planet; I was in the capital city. I was there when they stopped firing their weapons.

"It did not take us long to learn what had happened. Early in the invasion, many Gar were captured. Some of the outlying cities fell to grotesque biological weapons that mutated or killed our people. The Horde, we rightly reasoned, had captured and experimented upon our people to sow terror as they attempted to subjugate our world. Failing that, they had begun the bombardment. But the utter destruction of Garnia ceased and we learned why from one of the escapees.

"One of my people, a hero named Kismor, escaped the Horde ship and their horrific experiments. She revealed to us, in the capital, that one of the prisoners had broken under Horde interrogation and begun to speak of the repository of knowledge Garnia protected. Kismor killed that unfortunate prisoner and escaped. And she told those of us in the capital about how the Horde had shown great interest in the secrets of Eternia that were recorded on Garnia. Our politicians debated as the bombings ceased. The streets flooded with Horde Troopers and interlopers. Garnia went from a world on the brink of losing all civilization to being an occupied planet.

"At least the occupation was short," Keldor commiserated. "The Horde's goal was clear and the politicians of Garnia were divided on what to do, so I took action."

He fell silent and shook his head. He looked off into the distance, as if he was just noticing the crystal island he was upon and acknowledging that he was on an alien world.

When it seemed like his intelligent eyes would never stop soaking up and evaluating his surroundings, I prompted, "What did you do?"

"I did what the Ancients had failed to; I made sure the secrets of Eternia could not fall into the hands of the Horde," he revealed with pride. "I destroyed them. I obliterated the library and palace, the two repositories of all of the secrets we were entrusted to protect. They knew about Eternia and its power, but had a vague notion of its location within the galaxy and they lost access to all specific information about this planet. Our advantage now is that they will come, but they will not know what they are looking for."

"But you do," Gwen surmised.

"Some," Keldor admitted. "But not all. I was a librarian, not a library. I did not memorize all of the books, all of the secrets."

"You came here looking for the Knowledge Gem," I noted. "Why?"

"Because it is an artifact the Horde knows about," Keldor stated. "They know of its existence, so it made sense to make that a priority target. But also because if I can find the Knowledge Gem and use it, I should be able to unlock some of the other hidden secrets of Eternia."

"We've been searching for days," Gwen said. "With no luck. We were going to head home."

"You're welcome to continue searching," I added.

Keldor frowned and shook his head. A wind blew through his hair and he inhaled deeply the salty air coming off the Crystal Sea.

"I tell you of an imminent apocalypse and you're just going home?" he asked.

"One dead body is hardly proof," I pointed out.

Keldor sighed. "What about the Goblins? You did hear about the Goblins invading Eternia, did you not?"

"We did," Gwen confirmed.

"Where do you think they came from?" Keldor asked. Before either of us could respond, he pointed out, "They were an advance force from a conquered world. The Horde realized they could save some resources by sending subjugated races in to soften up their enemies. They sent disposable armies out into this galaxy to prepare for the arrival of the main fleet. Their portal technology can only transport so much...

"Your world is a target, but it is also the greatest chance the universe has to stop the Horde," Keldor concluded.

I have always been suspicious of authority, as you may well have guessed. It was a trait Gwen and I shared. She sat up fully and shook her head. I looked at Keldor and shrugged.

"We've encountered any number of fanatics as we've learned to use magic," I noted. "The former queen, Amelia, her followers... they believe Eternia is at the center of the universe. You just sound like a variation on a tired old theme. We might practice the magical arts, but we're not irrational. We'd need something more than just the word of a strange Gar who appeared out of nowhere to convince us that the end is nigh."

"Then you shall have it," Keldor declared. "Your magic... you can create a bubble of air with it?"

"Yes," Gwen insisted. She started to rock forward, so I stepped close and helped her to her feet. We stood together.

"It will have to be sustained for some time," Keldor noted. "You have that level of power?"

I nodded and Keldor rose to his feet.

"Then let's do this," Keldor suggested. He unsheathed his sword and raised it. "You'll want that bubble of air now."

He said a word I could not hear over Gwen mumbling the spell, but the effect of his magic was clear as his sword glowed an unnatural purple color and he swung it through the air. He cut an

arc from above his head down to his feet before him and the sword cut through reality itself, leaving a purple trail through the air and widening into a corridor of distorted light and a deafening roar of vacuum.

I spoke three words to enhance Gwen's spell, then looked at her. Whatever weakness she might have felt following being knocked out shortly before, she showed not even a hint of it now. Keldor motioned toward his portal and Gwen was the first to approach it. By the time I stepped up beside her, the hole in space was wide enough for all three of us to pass through and we did.

I cannot describe to you the feeling of passing through a conduit in space of the magnitude that Keldor had created. When I have my magic back, perhaps I could show you how the typical portal works; how you step in one end and come out the other almost instantaneously. I can take you virtually anywhere on Eternia in an instant, even to one of the moons without you blinking. The moment I knew Keldor was telling the truth came in that corridor between worlds. The duration of our travel was exceptional and I felt every atom of my body being stretched out across the cosmos and snapping back into itself so many times, over and over again, like my body was the shore being lapped at by fierce waves of a storm. I felt like the shore and the waves at once and it was horrible and magnificent and unnatural in a way Eternian magic never felt to me. We felt like we were traveling for hours in a state of limbo, suspended between two places that were an exceptional distance apart without any sense of borders or direction or even form, though our bodies were still visible. I kept focused on Gwen, on her long red hair that took on a surreal glow in the transit between defined places.

And then we were back in reality, but entirely weightless. We found ourselves floating, but not moving in any direction. It was dark, like we were part of the night sky. There was no ground beneath us, but we were not falling and I saw Keldor was looking at Gwen and I and not at our surroundings. It took me a moment for my eyes to fully adjust to the darkness, but they did. The

darkness was not full; distant starlight reached us. Almost as soon as I realized that, Keldor spoke.

"They aren't stars," he corrected my unarticulated thought. "Those are distant galaxies. We could sit and count them if you'd like, but their number is far more finite than the stars in your sky."

"Where are we?" Gwen asked as I contemplated how we could possibly be seeing galaxies as if they were stars.

"There's no name I could give you that would mean anything," Keldor explained. "This place has no name, not any longer. We are in the very center of one of the galaxies the Horde has destroyed. Take a moment and consider that. You see no stars, for there are none left. You feel no gravity because there is nothing left in this husk of a galaxy large enough to generate a gravitational field. This is the nature of Horde destruction.

"It is absolute."

Gwen and I looked around. Distant galaxylight reflected off something nearby, just outside the bubble of air. I realized it was a pebble, sailing through the void that surrounded us.

"How many galaxies has the Horde destroyed?" I asked.

"Three that I know of," Keldor responded. "Four have been entirely absorbed into their body, controlled absolutely. Eternia is in the eighth galaxy they have entered. Perhaps the Ancients of Eternia believed that sending the Horde far-enough away would give them time to evolve and change. They were wrong. They consolidated their mindset and perfected the practice of their ideals. With Garnia subjugated, the Horde is focused on our galaxy, searching for the planet Eternia and its incredible power."

"It's hard to believe," Gwen began. I think of that moment now and I smile because, despite her words, I can honestly say that her voice was the most beautiful thing in the galaxy. It was. She said, "It's hard to believe that the Horde would need anything from Eternia if it can already do this."

Keldor nodded and explained, "It's a matter of time, young lady. It has taken the Horde tens of thousands of years to get through seven galaxies. They are, perhaps, twenty years away from Eternia. With the power Eternia possesses, they would be able to subjugate or destroy the remaining galaxies in our universe in under a hundred years. Consider that learning curve and this place starts to look like the garden spot of a Horde universe."

I felt weak and nauseous, but not at the physics of where we... floated - stood was not the right word. We were suspended in this place outside anywhere we had ever been or conceived and this looked like the lesser of two possible fates for our universe. I was about to suggest Keldor take us to one of the subjugated galaxies, just to prove to myself the veracity of his claims, when there was a flash of light nearby.

A metal object burst, from our perspective, into existence just outside our bubble of oxygen. Keldor would later explain to us the physics of what we saw as a probe moving faster-than-light coming to a standstill near us. I assumed it was similar to the effect of someone exiting a portal, the abrupt way the metal being appeared.

Regardless of how it came to be before us, there it was, visible and sudden. The metal surface of the object was smooth and white with the barest shades of gray to it. It was there in the galaxylight, bright enough to see, looking like an armored man. It had no head, rather a dome that came out of the torso where a head would have been. It had glowing yellow eyes or ocular sensors, the truth is, I wasn't sure what in Subternia the creature was. But it looked like a knight, encased in armor.

On its chest was the same red symbol that had been on the creature we had seen die just the day before on Eternia. That seemed like a lifetime ago in that moment. On this thing's armor, the red winged creature was clear. It was a symbol, bright red against the gray armor, a sharp contrast in the eternal, colorless night beyond our bubble. The symbol was the same as the one we had seen, battered and twisted on the failed footsoldier of the

Horde who had appeared on Eternia. I watched as one wing on the symbol began to glow and I feel somewhat ridiculous in admitting this, but it was not actually glowing, it was light cast from the scepter the soldier held. The armored creature held a staff in one of its hands and it was powering up.

Later, Gwen and I would talk about that moment and I would confess to her that I had been focused on the Horde symbol on the chest of the armored warrior. She would admit to me that she was shocked by the weapon powering up, how the Horde Trooper did not say anything, gave no warning or ultimatum. It arrived, powered up its weapon and prepared to eradicate us. She was shocked by the brutal efficiency that it displayed; that went a long way for her to confirm that Keldor had spoken the truth.

Keldor, of course, was more experienced in such matters. He smirked when the Trooper appeared and muttered, "Right on time."

Before the weapon could discharge, Keldor sliced the thing's hand off with his sword. On the backswing, he said the magic words that made his weapon once again carve a hole in reality and created a portal back to Eternia. Without waiting to see what might happen with the Horde Trooper, Gwen and I leapt with Keldor into the portal.

The experience of returning to Eternia was no less traumatic than the initial journey to that far, ruined galaxy, but it did not seem to take as long, given that I was in shock. I probably would have remained in shock for longer, but when we landed, the gravity tugged at me, knocking me off my feet. My knees hit the crystal ground of the island, hard. Gwen knocked into me as she returned to our reality as well.

I used all my willpower not to cry out in pain as my knees cracked against the ground of the Lonely Island. Even then, I knew better than to show any form of weakness to Keldor. As it was, I winced as we landed, but I did not otherwise express how much it hurt to hit the crystals with my knees.

"What was that thing?" Gwen asked a few minutes later after we had caught our breath.

"A standard Horde Trooper," Keldor explained.

"What was it doing there?" I asked. "If the universe was destroyed..."

"The Horde leaves very little to chance," Keldor revealed. "They have complete control over four galaxies and they left Troopers throughout their destroyed ones. They keep those sentinels active, even in the middle of absolute nowheres so nothing can sneak up on them. The Horde is careful and has the resources to secure their goals. We were there for minutes, at best, before one of their Troopers was there. Right now, a small armada will be redirected to investigate that location."

"Won't that just lead them here faster?" Gwen asked, still rubbing her elbow, though she was back on her feet.

"We might have left some stray oxygen there, but nothing else. The Horde is technologically-advanced, but magically-ignorant. It is what allowed me to survive since the fall of Garnia. They will search the Horde Trooper's memories, but even though it was alerted to our presence and recorded our disappearance, how that was accomplished will elude the Horde hierarchy."

"Can you take us to one of the Horde-occupied worlds?" I asked. Keldor's story was mostly convincing, but one Horde Trooper and a void in space were not quite enough to make me believe absolutely in his words.

"'Can,' yes," he responded. "'Will,' no. I would not take us to a Horde-dominated world or universe. I have learned that their control comes from an absolute hive mind within their subjugated territories. The beings within their territories are merely sensory organs for their minds; neurons in a vast brain. You imagine you could resist, that you would somehow be special, but imagine being a skin cell."

He raised his palm to his face and blew over it with a soft breath. "You would be the cell that did not carry that feeling, that impulse? To be within their space is to become a part of it; there is no bubble, no prophylactic, no opportunity to resist. Within their space, you become a part of the Horde. There is nothing outside it within it.

"We could visit their ships in their armada, but that would be... unpleasant and I doubt our escape would be as clean as from one of the destroyed universes. I certainly would not take us while we are still reeling from that experience."

I was feeling anxious because with all that had happened, in such a short space of time, I had not had the opportunity to talk with Gwen. I remembered from our studies that Gar had exceptional hearing, so I did not want to risk talking with her about anything around Keldor. I had to trust that she recalled the same things I did and also did not fully trust Keldor yet.

It was Gwen who asked, "What would you like to do, then, Keldor? What is your plan?"

"Where are the Elders of Eternia?" he asked in response.

"No one knows," I admitted. It was true. "You claim Eternia possesses great power, unlike anything else in the universe. Certainly, finding the Elders would be the key to tapping into that power. They were the conduit to the power."

"One of the conduits," Keldor corrected. "You humans are so arrogant! You think only of yourselves and your abilities. Eternia has two living conduits to the power it possesses. Where are the dragons?"

Gwen and I looked at one another. I'm sure my expression mirrored hers; she frowned and we both seemed to realize at the same time that withholding that information from Keldor was pointless. The location of the dragons of Eternia was pretty much

common knowledge. Everyone avoided Darksmoke for the same reason.

"Darksmoke," we said in unison. Keldor smiled. I added, "You seek Granamyr."

"You know Granamyr?" Teela asked, coming fully awake.

Lyn nodded, before recalling that Teela could not see her. She answered in the affirmative.

"I only recently met him," Teela admitted. "Skeletor turned my father into a crystal and we needed to seek him out for help."

"I rather liked Duncan as a statue," Lyn joked. Teela gently tapped her left hand, the closest to a reproving slap she could give. The truth was, Duncan was back to his normal self following the incident, so there was ultimately no harm done and Teela was not about to take out any lingering anger against Skeletor on the woman who now held her close. Lyn justified, "You live with a horrid nickname from him for eighteen years and see how charitable you are. Say what you will about us, we don't degenerate into petty name-calling."

"Are you kidding?" Teela asked. "I've heard Skeletor call all of you 'fools!'"

"I suppose," Lyn noted. "But outside that..."

"Outside that..."

"You should get some sleep," Lyn advised.

"When Granamyr just entered the story? I don't think so!"

"What if I told you I was tired?"

"I'd let you sleep," Teela replied. Lyn could hear the young woman pouting and she smiled. She was so close that the act of smiling caused Lyn's lips to brush against Teela's ear. "But if you're just thirsty... if you just need some water..."

"No, I'm fine," Lyn remarked. "This is not a long story, Teela. I will tell you, but then you must try to sleep."

"Okay," Teela promised. "Thank you, Lyn."

The trip to Darksmoke was exactly as perilous as you know, perhaps a little more so given that Randor's roads did not exist and Skeletor had not exerted dominance over most of the Dark Hemisphere. Gwen and I alternated between trying to find opportunities to talk and sharing a quick remark about how we didn't want to leave Keldor alone to his own devices. We seemed to both figure that however things were resolved with the dragons, we would have time to discuss all we had experienced with Keldor after.

Keldor wanted to teleport directly to Darksmoke, but Gwen and I talked him out of that. He seemed impatient, but we explained that Granamyr placed a premium on politeness and if he saw us coming, he could not interpret our actions as at all threatening. He reluctantly agreed and we made the journey to Darksmoke over the course of several days.

We arrived in Darksmoke and Granamyr materialized as Keldor was complaining about how the dragon was not there. The two verbally sparred for a few moments; it really was quite boring.

Gwen, always the best of us, piped up to cut through their quips. She thanked Granamyr for his hospitality and then told him, "We are here because there is a grave threat to Eternia. Keldor comes from a different world, one far away from here. He came with a warning of a threat out amongst the stars."

"We are aware of the Horde fleet," Granamyr said in a dismissive tone. This was our first, real, independent confirmation of any of what Keldor had said. The next came moments later. Granamyr waved his hand and a puff of smoke was created. The smoke reorganized into a frame around a visual anomaly. It was a simple-enough spell, but it was only when Granamyr effortlessly executed the seeing spell that it occurred to myself or Gwen that we had always limited our versions of the spell to terrestrial matters. Of course the spell had enough range to see the Horde fleet; we had just never thought to look there before.

Within the cloud, we saw the Horde fleet, a massive collection of spaceships hovering over an alien planet. The distant world was ablaze beneath the dark ships of the Horde fleet. While Gwen and I watched in horrified fascination, Keldor looked away from the magically-rendered image and took up a stance before the dragon that was a clear challenge.

"You knew about this, but did nothing?!" Keldor shouted.

"You raise your voice to a dragon," Granamyr noted. "How rude. How small you are. What happens beyond Eternia is of no significance to me."

"It should be," Keldor spat out. "If you and the Ancients had properly dealt with the Horde millennia ago, they could not have evolved to menace the universe now. Your failure has led to the genocide of galaxies!"

"It was compassion," Granamyr corrected.

"You spared the lives of thousands to murder and enslave trillions," Keldor accused.

"This is not our doing, nor our problem to solve."

"Join us," Keldor requested, his tone more of a demand. "Help us save the galaxy and liberate the universe from the Horde."

"No," Granamyr answered simply. He made the image of the fleet disappear. "The Horde is not our problem."

"It is," Keldor insisted. "If Eternia falls, the Horde will enslave the rest of the universe."

"We dragons have the ability to leave this universe," Granamyr revealed. "This is not our concern."

"We do not have that luxury," I spoke up. "You dragons might be able to escape the shared fate of the rest of the universe, but you would do so knowing you abandoned the rest of us to enslavement or death."

"And why do you think you would escape the attention of the Horde?" Gwen asked, stepping up beside me as we looked up at the massive, red dragon. "If the Horde has its sights set upon Eternia for the powers it possesses and if it gains those powers, why do you think the Horde would stop at conquering the universe? If you know of a place outside the universe where you and the dragons could flee to, why do you think it would remain safe for you? Why wouldn't the Horde seek to conquer anywhere you went?"

"Perhaps you only see images of this fleet or recall the Horde as it was when it attempted to conquer Eternia millennia ago, but it has refined its methods," Keldor continued. "You are one of the oldest beings on Eternia; the Horde has absorbed all life within four galaxies. Do you truly believe you are more powerful than the knowledge and experience of all life within four galaxies?!"

"We are wise enough to admit our ignorance of that," Granamyr admitted. "We shall have to consider this."

"While you consider it," Keldor pressed, "the Horde fleet moves closer to Eternia. It used to be that the dragons of Eternia would accept a challenge for a favor. I call upon you to honor the old ways! I challenge your champion for the aid of the dragons!"

Granamyr snickered and waved his hand in a dismissive gesture.

"You seek the aid of the dragons?" Granamyr asked. "For what? To gain power?! To liberate your world? Your world is destroyed, Keldor of Garnia. The Horde has left your husk of a planet like a chef discards an eggshell. What would you have us do?"

"You know how to access the powers of this planet," Keldor replied. "You know what the Horde is looking for because you possess the knowledge of this planet's power. Share that knowledge with me and I will protect Eternia and liberate this galaxy and all of the territory the Horde has taken."

"No."

"I challenge your champion!" Keldor yelled, as if that would call other dragons into the debate.

"You would not survive a challenge from our least," Granamyr declared, waving Keldor away.

"Then give me your least!" Keldor demanded. "And when I defeat him, give me your help."

"Fine," Granamyr declared and he waved his hand again.

We were suddenly in a stadium, a massive stadium impossible to be on Eternia. It was in scale with Granamyr and filled with hundreds of dragons, many as large as Granamyr. Gwen and I found ourselves in a box beside Granamyr, looking down upon the main floor of amphitheater. Around us, dragons murmured. On the sandy floor of the amphitheater stood Keldor. He drew his sword while Granamyr apologized to his brethren for rudely interrupting whatever they were doing before. He informed them of the challenge and while his peers laughed, Granamyr materialized the youngest dragon in the center of the amphitheater, before Keldor.

Keldor did not wait. No sooner had the dragon, a blue dragon twice Keldor's size, materialized before him than Keldor thrust his blade deep into the reptile's chest.

The laughter of the dragons ended abruptly and Granamyr ceased his bloviating. The ancient dragon beside us rose up and looked over the railing of the box, aghast. Gwen and I looked at Keldor in horror.

The young dragon, for his part, looked shocked and it reached up toward Granamyr, claws open in a gesture of fear and surprise.

"No!" Granamyr shouted. A tear flew out of his eye, carried forth with the force of his momentum as he stopped against the railing. "Have mercy."

"The Horde will show no mercy," Keldor replied. Gwen told me later that Keldor pulled his sword from the shocked young dragon and beheaded the blue so fast she barely registered it. I didn't see it, though. I watched the tear.

Granamyr's tear sailed through the air toward the dragon who stood against Keldor. I'll never know if it was fate or magic, luck or just perfect mathematical trajectory of force and gravity, but that glob of fluid flew downward in a perfect arc into the outstretched claw of the young dragon. The claws closed around the tear as the dragon died and the tear solidified into a perfect sphere of crystal. Then it was falling to the sandy ground; Keldor finished decapitating the dragon and as he regained his stance, he sliced the dragon's claw off at the wrist. I watched as Keldor reached down and picked up the claw with the crystal ball as the dragons in the arena shouted and threatened and wept. At least Keldor raised that above his head and not the fallen dragon's head.

Gwen and I turned as one toward Granamyr, the same fear on our faces. Later, we would both admit that we were impressed by Keldor's strength and ability, that he had so quickly and efficiently dispatched a dragon. But in that moment, I was terrified that Granamyr might lash out at Gwen in anger.

What met our gaze was the dragon's look of disgust and horror. Granamyr was caught off-guard and it was obvious that it had been a very long time since that had happened.

After a moment, Granamyr called for silence and much to our surprise, the massive stadium fell quiet instantly. Keldor lowered the claw and sheathed his sword, but his posture as he looked up at Granamyr was one of defiance.

"Barbarian," Granamyr spat. "You had a choice and you killed..."

"His life has bought your help," Keldor insisted. "You gave your word. Would you break it before all your kin?"

Granamyr opened his mouth to object, but closed it without speaking his initial thought. All eyes in the arena were upon him.

"I will assist you," Granamyr growled as his brethren looked upon him and he stared at Keldor with menace and loathing in his eyes. "There are many loci of power on Eternia. All have secrets and access to more secrets and power. One locus of power would suit you well, Keldor. It is called Snake Mountain. Through it, you should be able to get all you need."

Granamyr waved his hand as Keldor opened his mouth to speak.

We found ourselves outside, on the outskirts of the Ice Mountains, standing, just the three of us. Keldor closed his mouth.

Granamyr's voice echoed on the wind.

"I have honored my word and mark mine; if you approach Darksmoke ever again, you will not live long enough to make another challenge. Neither you, nor any emissary of yours may approach without meeting a sudden death. Except you, Keldor. Keldor, I promise you; should you ever approach I will make your death painful and it will last eons. I will stretch your death out beyond nature and reason. I always keep my word."

Keldor looked at us and after a moment, he shrugged.

"Which way to Snake Mountain?" he asked.

I shook my head.

"I've never heard of it," Gwen admitted.

"And we've read all of the atlases of Eternia," I added.

Keldor nodded and stepped closer to us, extending the dragon's claw with the crystal orb toward us. He noted, "Perhaps this will help. Dragons and their tears have great power; this can be used to focus other magical energies, I believe. You can fashion it into a staff or wand."

I had heard of the power of dragon's tears and seeing the claw wrapped around the crystal in death seemed to validate the claims. I reached toward the artifact, believing Keldor might be correct.

"That's monstrous," Teela remarked.

Lyn sighed. She felt her body press into Teela's back and heard her own leather armor creak with the movement of her chest.

"There's more than one perspective, Teela," Lyn noted. "Keldor lost his world and he could trace that back, in part, to the dragons. Their mercy or the mercy of the Ancients left his people displaced and in the path of the greatest villains our universe has ever seen. One death seems a small pennance to pay for that.

"And without justifying or excusing or even trying to understand Keldor's actions, what he did was done; there was nothing to gain by not using the dragon's claw or tear. From that moment on, I was convinced, Teela. The dragons know about the threat of the Horde and they have a plan. They have committed not to fight the Horde, choosing instead to abandon us and all of Eternia, indeed all of the universe, to our own fate. When the Horde arrives, if the dragons are discovered, they will simply abandon us to fight the Horde with whatever tools we have at that point. My wand might well be the only positive contribution the dragons of Darksmoke provide in our fight against the Horde."

"Okay," Teela said quietly.

"I'm sorry, Teela," Lyn admitted. "Your people have kept you in ignorance and darkness. But you were born into a life of conflict and trained for a fight that is coming that will see Eternia either victorious or utterly destroyed. I want to protect our world and I will not apologize for using whatever tools are at my disposal to do that."

"I understand," Teela stated. Her tone switched to one of resolve much beyond her years as she declared, "I'll tell you what, Lyn; when we are done with this, when we have thwarted Kothos and I return to Eternos, I will tell everyone at the Royal Palace of the Horde. I will make sure they know that the real threat is coming and it is coming from beyond the stars!"

"Oh child," Lyn said with sadness equal even to Teela's determination, "they already know; they just don't believe or they do not care to stop it."

Infiltration Risk

Chapter Summary

> For the first time, we tell the tale of one of the heroic warriors...

“If we could clear the Court," Randor ordered. "Man-At-Arms, please remain."

While the many occupants of the massive chamber funneled out, murmuring amongst themselves, King Randor remained perched upon his throne, staring intently down upon Duncan. Beside him, Queen Marlena leaned back on her throne. She looked uncomfortable, but her eyes wandered from the dissipating crowd to her husband's back to Duncan's general vicinity. After a minute, the main throne room of the Royal Palace was empty and the guards stood at the open entrances out of earshot, backs to the remaining three occupants.

King Randor waved his friend closer and Duncan approached the thrones. Queen Marlena remained in her more relaxed position.

"My liege," Duncan said with a slight bow. The bow hid the smirk upon his face, but not the amusement in his voice.

King Randor was having none of it that day; his tone was deathly serious as he gravely noted, "Man-At-Arms, we have a situation of some delicacy that needs attending to."

Duncan straightened up; whenever Randor addressed him by his title in private, he knew the matter was one that would not allow him to address the monarch in a casual fashion. A lifelong friendship be damned; there were times when Randor was downright ornery with Duncan, though he had figured out that the tension in their relationship had grown since Marlena had arrived on Eternia and Randor had become a father.

"We have received word that there is a... potential threat growing out on the Plain of Perpetua. Somewhere between the eastern slopes of Zagraz Mountain and the Plain of Perpetua there has been a... mobilization."

"My liege," Man-At-Arms began, seeing the King's discomfort, "whatever it is that is going on, you may speak freely with me. I will do all I can to serve you."

"It's the Queen Mother," Marlena said when King Randor struggled to best phrase what he needed to communicate to his friend. Queen Marlena was not hampered by the conflicting emotions Randor felt and she grumbled, "Her cultists are on the move."

Duncan swallowed heavily. Queen Marlena and Randor's Man-At-Arms were by no means close friends, but both had a solid distrust of magic and a keen respect for science. Randor's reluctance in addressing this issue was, no doubt, in part due to knowing that he was likely to face a united front from the two people he respected most on Eternia. Duncan noticed Randor flinched at Marlena's use of the term "cultists."

"Your mother," Duncan began, trying to adopt a tone of compassion and civility.

"Has gone too far this time," King Randor cut him off. "Her followers have been harmless for years, a nuisance at best..."

"What has she done?" Duncan asked when Randor trailed off.

"We don't know," Randor admitted. He sighed a frustrated sigh and leaned back on his throne.

Marlena leaned forward, lowering her voice, though Man-At-Arms could easily hear her. She revealed, "We have received word from some of the field generals out on the Plain of Perpetua that there have been defections, reports of a few abandoned villages nearby and rumors that Amelia's..."

"The Queen Mother," Randor cut in, his tone far more stern than loud.

Queen Marlena rolled her eyes, but she corrected, "...the Queen Mother's followers have been growing in number."

"They appear to be organizing in a way they have not before and we do not know why," King Randor confessed.

"Are you sure this is Queen Amelia and not Skeletor's doing?" Duncan asked.

Marlena leaned back on her throne and glared at her husband. King Randor rubbed his beard and swallowed heavily.

"As much as I would like it to be Skeletor and his ilk, there is no evidence of that. This does appear to be the Queen Mother and her followers congregating."

"What may I do to help?" Duncan asked, bowing slightly with his head.

"We need more information," Randor admitted.

"But it's not like the Queen Mother's followers are welcoming to outsiders," Marlena added. "Unless this recent uptick in the population of her followers is an indication."

"We are choking on our own ignorance! We need someone on the inside, someone completely loyal to us who can report back as to what is going on within her encampment. There are very few people I trust who cannot be corrupted..."

"I have a fifteen year-old daughter," Man-At-Arms began. Randor raised his hand to silence his friend.

"I am not suggesting you leave Teela," he clarified. "But I need you to choose an operative to act on our behalf and infiltrate the Queen Mother's encampment and report back."

"Of course, your highness. I can do that."

"Time is of the essence," Marlena noted. "We need the operative in place as soon as possible, by the end of the week if that is at all possible."

"I will find you a worthy candidate from the Royal Guard and I will bring them to you."

"No," Randor ordered, with a frown. "Send them out yourself. We are... uncertain how the Queen Mother is gathering her followers, but we suspect her abilities might be far-reaching and she might have agents within the Royal Palace."

"If we were being surveilled..."

"If?" Queen Marlena asked, smirking slightly. "We both know that between Evil-Lyn and that psychopath Tri-Klops, plenty of oracles and spying devices get by you and Orko. Your averages are good, but hardly flawless."

Duncan's cheeks turned red and he was glad his facial hair hid some of his embarrassment. He was loathe to be included in any evaluation with Orko.

"By your leave, your majesties; I will find and dispatch the spy on your behalf."

"Thank you, Man-At-Arms," King Randor dismissed his friend.

Duncan wandered through the locker room, trying to look nonchalant. Projecting a casual affect was difficult for the Man-At-Arms and flew in the face of his carefully-cultivated stern appearance he had developed since being promoted to the post six years prior. The members of the Royal Guard who were changing into or out of armor in the locker room continually glanced at Duncan with unhidden nervousness.

For his part, Duncan glanced at each of the prospective candidates and mentally disqualified them from the task for which he was recruiting. Too loud, too stupid, artificial limb (not a problem within the Royal Guard, but for some reason, Queen Amelia's followers had a tendency to magically-regenerate limbs and whenever that happened, the beneficiary always seemed to join her people), too strong to risk losing to her cult, too drunk...

Then he saw him. Orius sat on a bench, hunched over, slowly binding his shinguards. Duncan had not spent much time with Orius, not since his son went missing, but he had heard the whispers among the royal guards about "the sad sack." Orius was thoroughly loyal to King Randor since he had been given leave to search for his missing son for weeks after - of all things - a wind storm. Duncan could not imagine a wind storm separating him from his daughter and him not continuing the search until her body was found. Yet, Orius had given up searching for Philip after a month and returned to the Royal Palace to pledge undying fealty to King Randor for the boon of allowing him the time to search. Orius was perfect for the mission; he was loyal, programmable and disposable.

Orius was hardly a model of the Royal Guards. While he more than met the height requirement for Randor's palace defense force, he consistently slouched, which made him appear far less imposing than many of his peers. He had some leg definition, but was by no means one of the more muscular guards in the service. Duncan did not know him particularly well, but he knew of him well-enough to know the basic biographical data of the soldier. The only other aspect of the man that stood out was that he was the subject of a betting pool amongst some of the guards; no one had any idea who had ever slept with Orius to eventually give birth to his son, so the theories about who he might have bedded had led to an extensive betting pool that remained up for grabs.

Duncan wandered over to the guardsman as he finished putting on his armor.

"Orius," Duncan said as he reached the point directly behind the young man.

Orius leapt to his feet, his left shinguard falling to the ground - apparently, he had not finished binding his armor. He saluted, spinning to face Duncan. Man-At-Arms sighed.

"Sir!" Orius acknowledged, not looking down at the piece of armor as it clattered to the floor.

"At ease," Man-At-Arms said, saluting back. "Do you have a few minutes to talk?"

"Sir? Yes, sir." He frowned and amended, "I'm just going on duty now."

"Where are you posted today?" Duncan asked. He had not checked the duty roster before entering the locker room.

"East wall, inner," Orius confirmed.

It was a low-priority defensive position. Duncan asserted, "It's fine to be out of position for me. Why don't you come with me to my workshop?"

"Yes, sir," Orius declared. He glanced down at the fallen shinguard and opted not to pick it up as Duncan spun on his heel to leave. The two men trudged in silence toward Duncan's workshop. Man-At-Arms struggled for any possible thing to say to the guardsman who walked with his head down and a perpetual frown upon his face. Duncan felt a sense of relief upon entering his workshop. Finding himself among his tools and gadgets made Man-At-Arms feel at ease and he only realized how upsetting his companion's silence was making him by the contrasting emotion he felt upon entering the room. The doors slid closed behind Orius.

"I was hoping I might be able to ask you a few questions," Man-At-Arms said, getting immediately to the point.

"Of course, sir," Orius replied. He did not quite look Duncan in the eye.

"At ease," Duncan allowed. "How do you feel about magic?"

"Sir?" he asked. Duncan could not think how to make the question more simple for him.

He attempted, "Do you like magic?"

"I don't know that I've ever really encountered magic, sir."

"Okay," Man-At-Arms stalled. He wasn't sure what to do with that answer. He regrouped. "How do you feel about spying?"

"Is there a spy in the Royal Palace?"

"Not that I am aware of," Duncan replied. "Do you think you could be a spy?"

"I'm not a spy, sir," Orius assured. "I am loyal to King Randor!"

"Yes, that's good. But if the king wanted you to spy on his behalf, how would you feel about going on such an assignment?"

"There's someone here the King wants me to spy on?" Orius asked. "Is it Branson? He seems kind of shifty."

"No... it's not Branson. Branson is fine." Duncan took a moment to rub his forehead. Having never gotten to know Orius particularly well, he had not been prepared for how obtuse the guardsman was. Orius was giving Ram Man a run for his money. Duncan decided to give it one more shot. He stated, "King Randor is looking for a loyal soldier who would go to the Plain of Perpetua to infiltrate a community there and report back to me. Your name came up as a candidate and I was wondering if you might be interested in the assignment."

"Yes, sir," Orius replied with the most unconvincing tone possible.

Man-At-Arms waited for a moment. Certainly the man before him would ask what the assignment was... He did not. Duncan sighed and elaborated, "You and I will leave immediately for the Plain Of Perpetua. When we get near there, I will find a location to lie low in and you will go onto the target community. Once you have infiltrated it, you will report back to me on their leader. Will you be okay with that?"

"Sure," Orius confirmed. He then thought better of his answer and delivered a lackluster, "Yes, sir."

"This will give me the chance to test out my new vehicle," Man-At-Arms declared, looking over at the Attak Trak at the other side of his workshop, near the exterior doors. "How soon can you be ready?"

"I'll be ready in half an hour," Orius confirmed.

Even in the Attak Trak - which Duncan was thrilled appeared to be working exactly according to his designs - the trip from the Royal Palace of Eternos to the Plain Of Perpetua took two days. It felt at least three times that long for Duncan; Orius seemed to accept the length of the journey with no complaints, comments, or even interest in the natural wonders the pair passed. While coming so close to Zagras Mountain was usually a thrill for most Eternians, Orius barely glanced once in the massive mountain's direction before turning back to staring at his feet.

So as the pair pulled the Attak Trak up to the village of Grint, the last abandoned position Duncan could confirm on the edge of the Plain of Perpetua, Man-At-Arms was feeling some relief that the journey was coming to an end. He stretched as the pair exited the land vehicle.

"This will be our rendezvous point," Duncan confirmed. "I will be in this area for the next week, studying local phenomena and doing reconnaissance. When you have good information on the

leader of the community over there, sneak back here to report in. We can't risk you being caught with a communicator. Can you repeat back to me your mission, please?"

"I am infiltrating a community, probably people using magic of some sort, about an hour to the east of here," Orius said in a bored tone. "It doesn't matter who I say I am or why I say I am there, as long as I do not tell anyone there that I am working for King Randor and that I am a spy. I need to assess the threat to King Randor and Eternia and bring you back information on the leader of the community. I have one week to get embedded and return here with information."

"Yes," Duncan confirmed. Orius said the words by rote; it was unclear to the Man-At-Arms if he actually understood the words he was repeating back. Having no way to be sure one way or the other, Duncan offered Orius a crisp salute and wished him good luck. Orius returned the salute, turned on his heel and headed off in the direction of Amelia's growing community.

It was an hour before Orius found the target community. He had been wandering in the right direction, but he felt indifferent to his new assignment, much as he had to everything in his life since Philip disappeared. As he passed through the abandoned village of Glort, he saw tents in the distance out on the grassy plains and assumed that it was an encampment of the people he was being sent to spy upon. It took him half an hour to reach the community once he spotted it.

As he neared, Orius could see people moving in and out of the tents in the encampment. They all wore white robes, but beyond that there was nothing that seemed to either set them apart from people Orius knew in Eternos or connect them to one another in this camp. The white-robed individuals appeared to come from all walks of life: women, men, children, black, blue, white, brunettes, blondes, redheads, bald people, piercings, tattoos, clean-shaven, bearded, a woman with a wild mustache, some sort of Aquatican

who seemed to be fine outside the water, an old woman who appeared to be the very archetype of that demographic.

As Orius approached the encampment, he became aware of the sounds coming from it. People in the camp moved vigorously and he could hear the sounds of their robes moving, tent flaps opening and closing, the sound of their sandaled feet occasionally hitting a rock on the ground that had been grassy, but now was well-beaten down by all of the people moving over the small area constantly. Orius heard the sizzle of meat cooking, people in tents making love, and the faint murmur of chanting somewhere up ahead. But for as noisy as the area seemed, it did not take long at all for Orius to realize that he did not hear anyone talking. The people seemed to have no issues with communicating as they took a hunk of meat from someone's cooking meal over a firepit and handed the person sitting beside it a newly-woven satchel or exchanging books as individuals passed one another, but they did so without speaking aloud.

Orius wandered into the encampment, which did not appear to have any guards that he saw or who seemed to notice him. The people in the camp generally seemed content and were focused on their own things.

Somewhat unsure how to actually accomplish his mission of learning about the leader of this group - which he estimated had thousands of people in it as he had already counted fifty tents and he was certain the encampment contained at least four times as many - Orius meandered around several firepits and tents, unimpeded and apparently unnoticed - despite being clad in an entirely different outfit than everyone around him - until he came to a bench in an intersection and decided to sit down upon it. Orius sat upon the bench, watching people pass him by for an hour before he was approached.

The young man, human, Orius guessed about nineteen years old, and a green lizard woman who might have been the same age - the operative had no idea how to tell the age of the lizard people - came up to the bench where Orius was sitting. They stared at

each other for about a minute before the lizard woman asked, "What is your name?"

Orius, realizing he had not thought of an alias, replied, "Orius."

"What do you do?" the lizard woman asked.

"I'm... a farmer," he responded in quite possibly the most obvious lie ever told on Eternia.

The youths did not appear to recognize the statement for what it was. The young man seemed excited by the reply.

"What is it you grow?" he inquired.

"Lots of things," Orius stalled. He suddenly blanked on what crops existed. The community members stared at him and blinked slowly. He guessed, "Corn?" He immediately hoped there was no special way to farm corn and that the young people had no follow-up questions for him. His luck appeared to be with him, as they nodded enthusiastically.

"Would you like a robe?" the lizard woman asked.

"Okay," Orius responded. The young people extended their hands to him. Orius stood up and took the human's hand in his left and the lizard woman's hand in his right and allowed himself to be guided to a tent nearby. Wordlessly, they removed his clothes and boots and provided him with a simple white robe and sandals. As soon as he was clad like everyone around him, the young man and lizard woman disappeared.

In the late afternoon, Orius noticed that the people around him started to move, as one, toward the northern part of the camp. Figuring that something might be going on that he should report back to Man-At-Arms, Orius followed the crowds of white-robed people. The migration ended at the northern border of the encampment. When Orius stood up to his full height, he could see that there were about a thousand individuals in the clear space before him and beyond there appeared to be nothing but the

plains stretching on toward the horizon. As he reached the point where everyone in the community seemed content to stop, Orius realized everyone around him was chanting in unison, but he had no idea what it was they were saying.

The chanting people seemed to all be facing the same direction, so after fifteen minutes of standing on the periphery, Orius reasoned that whatever everyone had assembled for, it was going to happen somewhere in front of him. He began to squeeze through the chanting crowd. No one moved out of his way, but people he bumped or jostled as he passed by did not seem particularly bothered by him either. After fifteen minutes of making his way through the throngs of people, he found himself in the center of the community members and was a little unsettled when everyone suddenly went quiet.

With the chanting done, Orius could hear the thousands of people around him breathing and it was unsettling, though he could not say why.

A moment after the chanting ended and Orius found himself disturbed by the rhythmic breathing of all those around him, bright blue lights began to swirl overhead. They moved rapidly above and around the crowd and while no one else seemed to notice or care about them, Orius looked up at them and was transfixed.

"Magic," he realized and it was only when the word hit his ear that he understood he had said it aloud. He nervously glanced around, but the only one to acknowledge him was the old lady he had seen before. She smirked at him. He looked back at the glowing blue balls that soared above the crowd. The magic orbs did not appear to be moving in any recognizable pattern or as the result of any form of influence from the people below. Orius watched them for several minutes; when he stopped and looked for the old woman again, she was gone from where she had been.

After a time, the glowing magic balls turned from bright blue to pink, then they disappeared altogether.

Once the magic orbs had disappeared, Orius heard singing from near the front of the crowd and the community all seemed to move in that direction. Orius followed along and it only occurred to him once the assemblage stopped that it seemed of interest that there had been room for the crowd to move forward at all. When the crowd stopped, Orius found himself surrounded by singing members of the community. Everyone around him appeared content, if not happy, but Orius felt out of sorts in that everyone around him seemed to know the words and music to the song they sang. He had never heard the song before, so he did not know either the words or the music. Thinking that perhaps they were seeing something up ahead that informed them of the words or music to the song everyone sang, Orius stood up on his toes and looked over the crowd toward the direction everyone seemed to be facing.

"Hey, that's the Queen Mother," Orius realized, seeing a woman out before the crowd in the distance on the flat grasslands at the edge of his sight. Orius heard one of the singers nearby snicker, but when he looked, he could not see who had made the sound. Around him all of the people in white robes continued singing until they reached a crescendo together. After holding one more note, the community stopped together and then immediately began to dissipate. Orius looked around and again stood upon his tip toes, but did not see Queen Amelia again.

Reasoning that the Queen Mother's presence in the community might be what Man-At-Arms would find "noteworthy," Orius dispersed with the crowd and wandered for an hour before he left the encampment. He headed directly back toward Grint, though he stopped in Glort to be sure he was not being followed. He felt no small sense of accomplishment when Man-At-Arms's first questions to him upon walking up to the Attak Trak were, "Were you followed? Are you sure?"

When he confidently replied, "No and yes," Man-At-Arms visibly relaxed.

"What have you learned?" Duncan asked. Orius told him about the Queen Mother apparently leading the community and he was surprised when the King's confidant was not surprised or alarmed by the information.

"Most of the people don't really talk to me," Orius concluded.

"Who has?"

Orius told him about the young people who gave him the robe and sandals. He mentioned the magic glowing balls and the singing.

"What are they doing out there?" Man-At-Arms asked.

"I don't know," Orius admitted. He was tired from being out all day and decided to sleep in the Attak Trak. When he awoke the next day, Man-At-Arms was nowhere to be found, so he headed back to the encampment.

The second day at the Queen Mother's encampment was much the same as Orius's first day there. The members of the community cooked, crafted, and chanted for most of the day, showing no real interest or notice of Orius moving about them. Orius spent the day looking around for where Queen Amelia was in the camp, but was unable to find her. He decided not to ask anyone which tent was hers.

Just as occurred the previous day, in the late afternoon, the chanting turned to singing and the entire community assembled on the northern edge of the encampment. Orius saw the Queen Mother from a distance and after a few minutes of watching the glowing magic orbs circle and listening to the singing, Orius felt someone nudge him. He looked and saw a young woman he had not seen before. She had dark skin that contrasted nicely with the white of her robe and when Orius turned and looked at her, she smiled at him with a calm demeanor and vibrant eyes.

"Would you like to go forth?" she asked, waving toward the front of the crowd.

"No," Orius decided. "I can see everything from here."

The young woman smiled at him and he turned his attention back to the Queen Mother. He could not figure out what she was doing at the edge of the clearing. When it occurred to Orius to ask the young woman, he turned and found that she was gone.

That evening, when the mysterious ceremony ended and the crowd dispersed, Orius advanced to where he had last seen Queen Amelia. Outside the encampment, well away from the tents, on the Plain of Perpetua, Orius found a hole. The hole was just a short distance from where he thought he had last seen Queen Amelia.

The hole was unlike any hole Orius had ever seen before. About two meters in diameter, the hole was a perfect circle. Looking down and into the hole, Orius discovered that it went deeper than he could see; there was no bottom in sight. Moreover, the hole did not seem to narrow and as he knelt down next to the hole, he felt the side of it. It was perfectly smooth. Orius had no standard to compare it to; the hole was unlike any phenomenon he had ever seen. He had no idea how such a hole might be created; its smoothness and diameter implied some form of impossible drill, its depth defied the idea that it had been crafted in any way. Orius could not find any evidence that anyone in the community had even interacted with the hole. There were no structures near or around the hole. Despite that, somehow everyone in the community knew not to fall in the hole and they did not go near it any time but during the afternoon ritual.

Reasoning that the presence of the hole - without actually knowing what its purpose was or anything else about it - was not sufficient to report back to Man-At-Arms, Orius decided to spend the night in the encampment. He was somewhat surprised when he found a small tent near where many of the community

members had lodging completely empty and he hunkered down in it.

Orius awoke the next morning surprised that he had slept so well. He had fallen asleep a little nervous that someone might come to claim the tent he was in, but when that did not happen, apparently he had fallen asleep quite restfully. Orius decided to spend that day investigating the mysterious hole between the encampment and the rest of the Plain of Perpetua. While most of the white-robed people were milling about cooking, chanting or doing whatever occupied their morning, Orius went out to the hole.

In the morning light, the hole was no less mysterious. The sun shone down into the seemingly endless pit and it only reinforced the idea that the hole was smooth and regular all the way down.

But while Orius was investigating the hole, he heard the chanting from the community get closer and he looked up from his investigation to see the people of the tented community congregating nearby. Not wanting to draw suspicion, Orius moved away from the hole and the members of the community obligingly let him into their midst. Right around when he got to the center of the mass of people, Queen Amelia appeared near the hole.

"There is a spy amongst us!" Queen Amelia declared loudly in a voice that commanded instant respect and silenced all of her followers. Hearing the collective gasp go up from all those around him, Orius attempted to mirror the shock he saw on the faces of the community members.

"We must purge the interloper," the Queen Mother insisted. All around him, Orius heard the members of the community murmuring their agreement with their leader. He began to nod his head as well. The crowd began to move and he turned toward the encampment with the white-robed individuals who moved in that direction.

So it was that Orius walked himself up to the very guillotine that had been established in the center of the encampment to rid the community of the spy in their midst. Indeed, only when he found himself carried upon the tide of people around him up the platform where he tripped next to the guillotine did he realize that Queen Amelia knew that he was, in fact, the spy the community sought to dispose of.

But, before he could object, he found his neck being pressed against the wood and as he looked up, he saw the archetypal old woman in the crowd and his eyes were drawn to her hand which glowed a subtle pink and moved in a strange pattern before everything in his vision went dark.

Orius awoke, naked, as his body hit the cold metal surface of the Attak Trak. What was most surprising to the royal guardsman was that his head was nowhere near his body when it landed and that he was aware of that. Orius opened his eyes to find himself staring at Man-At-Arms's midriff and feeling leather on his left ear and warm, smooth flesh on his right ear.

"Evil-Lyn," Duncan growled. "What is the meaning of this?"

Orius opened his mouth to scream and he was surprised when he could. He inhaled and felt his lungs fill with air, but his body was on the ground nearby. Orius even felt his vocal cords vibrating, despite the fact that when he looked down, he could see his own headless neck pressed against the bottom of the console in the vehicle.

"Be silent, you pathetic imbecile," Lyn ordered. Orius obliged. "Really, Duncan? This was the best you could do?!"

"What are you talking about?" Man-At-Arms responded, eyes narrowing at the woman holding the severed head of Orius.

"You sent this fool into Amelia's encampment," Lyn stated. Duncan did not insult her intelligence further by denying her

assertion. "Certainly this could not have been the best you had for the attempt..."

"Hey!" Orius objected.

"He was available," Duncan admitted. "What evil plan are you up to?"

"Here," Lyn said, shoving Orius's head toward Duncan. In shock, the Man-At-Arms reached out and carefully took the head.

"Why...?"

"Just because you sent a pathetic spy into Queen Amelia's cult did not mean he had to die," Lyn explained. "I cast the only spell I knew how to, fast enough to prevent it from drawing attention."

"What did you do?" Duncan asked, looking horrified at the severed head in his hands.

"I saved his life," Lyn insisted.

"How?" Orius croaked out, aware that he was watching his own body inhale to get the air to speak the words from the mouth that was so far from the rest of himself.

"I created a pair of portals, right where your head was severed."

"That's monstrous, Evil-Lyn!"

"I saved his life, Duncan. You'd do well to remember that." The yellow-skinned woman looked at Orius and he looked up at her, feeling nothing but horror. Her tone was strangely reassuring as she noted, "As long as you blink once every twenty-four hours, the portals will be maintained. Each time you blink, the portals renew."

"What is going on out there, Evil-Lyn?" Duncan asked.

"Is that all you care about?" Lyn asked in response. "Amelia was going to kill one of your own and I saved his life..."

"I need to know."

"You don't," Lyn disagreed. "But regardless, it won't matter in another day or two. Return to Eternos, tend to your wounded and the next time you have an opportunity to interfere, consider what I have done here today."

With that, Lyn spun on her heel and before Duncan or Orius could respond, she disappeared in a puff of smoke.

"Umm," Orius began, "what now?"

"I suppose we'll get you back to my lab and see if we can't get you put back together," Duncan decided.

"Do you think you can do more than just that?" Orius asked. "I'd like to be something more than just reassembled."

"Sure," Duncan said in the most noncommittal tone possible.

Two days after they returned, that pathetic, beheaded, terrible spy was remade as Mekaneck.

Tomorrow's Threat

Lyn held Teela close and felt nothing. Physically, she was not numb; she felt the thin fabric of Teela's bodysuit beneath her left hand and the even smoother skin of Teela's thigh beneath the fingers of her right hand. She could smell Teela's hair as the warrior’s head pressed up near her nose. Whatever the young woman used for shampoo had a vaguely raspberry scent that lingered beneath the perspiration that clung to hair. Lyn was somewhat surprised that any hint of raspberries reached her nose after their day in the desert. Lyn felt gratified that Teela had warmed up and as she listened to the younger woman's soft breaths, she found it calmed her.

Beyond the physical, Lyn felt nothing. Talking to Teela about the past had made Lyn miss Gwen, but the pain of her friends' absence had long since been internalized. She missed Gwen, but it did not hurt as much as it once did and as she lay behind the young warrior, she recognized that she simply was reminded of Gwen's absence. Lyn acknowledged that Gwen was gone, but it did not open up all the old wounds, even after spending so much time talking with Teela.

The real disconnect was with the magic. Lyn was acutely aware that Kothos stripping her of her powers meant she could be in proximity to Teela without feeling anything. Teela, after all, clearly had no idea who she truly was; Lyn, however, was fairly certain she knew exactly who Teela was. Lyn, without her magic, was not positive of course, but she did not need to have absolute proof to know that Teela was the lynchpin to so many things on Eternia. If Teela awoke again and asked for more of her story, especially with how Keldor had become Skeletor, Lyn was unsure how she could continue without revealing what Duncan had clearly kept from the young woman. After all, Teela was smart and Lyn was sure that if she were to continue the story aloud, the young woman would put the timeline together properly and start asking the right questions.

Lyn was unsure how things would go when Teela started to learn the full magnitude of her personal history. A lot hinged upon her response. All Lyn knew for certain was that she did not want to be without her powers when Teela began to understand her own.

The day Teela was born changed Eternia forever. Correlation might not necessarily imply causation, but sometimes multiple unrelated events were deeply intertwined and Lyn had long-ago deduced that a powerful magical event had occurred on the day Teela was born. That magical event manifested in numerous ways, most of which involved reality being torn asunder and problematically-restored. Teela, a child orphaned who had no known mother, was born. Out above Eternia, a massive fissure in the space-time continuum opened up and pulled to Eternia a spaceship from a distant world. To her credit, Marlena had made the most of being trapped in an entirely different place in the universe than she knew, but the fissure that had brought her to Eternia had coincided with what Lyn suspected was Teela's time of birth.

Her suspicions that there was a causation to the correlations came because that was the same time that Shadow Weaver had arrived on Eternia.

Gwen's red hair shone in the lights of the small room where Lyn sat as she entered. The pair had long-ago stopped worrying about having lights in the factory on at night; instead, they had created an enchantment that prevented the light from being seen outside. They had also taken over a significant portion of the warehouse and anyone who entered the building's perimeter fell under a simple enchantment to not notice the second floor of the western portion of the building. It was within that section that Gewn, Lyn and now Keldor resided. The early morning light came through a different set of windows, so it was the magical lights that now illuminated Gwen.

Lyn sat behind a pile of books, most of which were very old, though some had only recently come into her possession. Three of the books were open upon the table and Lyn continued to consult various passages between each of the three books.

"Is he still unconscious?" Gwen asked. Her voice was soft and musical and she asked the question without any sense of bias in her tone. Lyn did not look in the direction of the closed door behind her and she was unsurprised when Gwen did not either. Almost a year of magically-stabilizing Keldor had not made either of the young women more comfortable with being in his presence.

"He is," Lyn confirmed. "We should have no problem keeping him asleep for another two to three months. I think I've finally gotten the last of the metal fragments out."

"So we're past the experiments with time reversal?" Gwen asked with a smirk. She lay her hand upon one of the books as she stopped before Lyn's table. Lyn leaned back and looked up at her friend.

"It was worth the attempt," she reiterated. "But yes, I think we are past that. Temporal manipulation was clearly not the key to regenerating the tissue. It certainly isn't bringing back his eyes."

"Keeping him unconscious and stopping further degradation seems to be the right approach then," Gwen agreed. "What are you working on now?"

"Pain management," Lyn revealed, looking up at her friend. "I'd like to find a way to end his pain before the next attempts to reconnect his vocal cords to... whatever in Subternia we're calling his skull now."

"The screams," Gwen recalled. Lyn nodded. "It seems like a very specific problem; is there anything in the books?"

"Not yet," Lyn admitted. "I was going to give it another hour of study; some of these books have translations that appear... biased."

"Would you like help?" Gwen asked, slowly making her way around the table. She wore a long dress with double-slits in the front, so as she moved, her legs peeked out and caught Lyn's eyes. She was wearing red tights beneath and Lyn liked the way the light caught her friend's hair and the tights.

"I'd like some ice cream," Lyn admitted. "Not some magically-created, unmelting, perfectly-flavored ice cream, but some of that strawberry mint stuff we had... where was it we had that?"

"Glort," Gwen replied. "Or Grint? It was somewhere out on the Plain. It was the shepherd whose husband made the sheep's milk ice cream. I knew you liked it more than you let on at the time."

"It seems so long ago..."

"He'll keep," she noted. "Why don't we go out for some? We've got plenty of gold, so between the fun of getting ice cream and upsetting the local economy, it..."

Her proposal was cut off by a thunderclap within the room and the light bulbs shattering from the resulting force. Lyn was knocked back as the table flipped, smashing into her and upending her chair. A bright light filled the room as the artificial magical lights faded, but Lyn was caught off-balance and the cacophony of thunder, splitting wood and falling books left her deafened and disoriented. Whatever the sudden, invasive, light was, it faded almost instantly, as if it had been lightning that somehow followed the thunderclap.

Lyn heard Gwen's voice utter a word of power and magical orbs sprang into existence, lighting the room fully. Lyn felt pain in her left cheek and as she recovered her bearings, she realized there was a massive splinter piercing the skin there. Lyn ignored the pain as she looked in Gwen's direction to see if she was all right. What she saw took her breath away.

Between Lyn and Gwen was a form. "Form" was the most accurate word as it undulated unclearly as an amorphous blob

that seemed at once like smoke, a flicker of light, body parts moving at awkward and obscene angles to one another and a fast-moving object that could not be directly perceived. The form floated, landed, leapt in place, and zipped around at impossible speeds all at once.

Lyn glanced around the form to confirm that Gwen was all right, as she rose to a stand again. The transitional nature of the form between the pair allowed Lyn to confirm quickly that Gwen was alive and still on her feet. She had her wand in one hand, the amulet she wore at her neck glowed. Her eyes met Lyn's and Lyn understood that she felt guilt for casting a protection spell over herself alone. Lyn understood; the placement of the interloper made it difficult to cast a more complicated rendition of the spell.

"What have you done to me?!"

The voice, like the form, was ethereal and contradictory. It was at once loud and near-silent, the words clear and distorted, instantly familiar and so harsh on the ear that they appeared to be from a foreign tongue. The voice was distinctly feminine and a feral roar, a whisper and filled with undeniable gravitas. Lyn was unsure if the voice was surrounding her or coming from within her own head.

Lyn whispered a word of psychic protection and something within the semi-contained maelstrom before her turned in her direction. The voice repeated, but at least this time Lyn was certain there was no telepathic variable to it. She was somewhat disconcerted that the mental shielding did not change anything about the voice.

Lyn's eyes found Gwen. She mouthed a word at Lyn and despite the distortions in space and atmosphere between them, her meaning was clear. Gwen was suggesting, "Portal."

Reasoning quickly that Gwen was theorizing a portal might have brought the abomination before them allowed Lyn to focus. In dealing with Keldor and his brutal wounds - which should have killed him moments after it occurred - Lyn had learned even more

about portals and their effects upon biology. She also had learned a number of spells that involved recombining beings who had been violently altered through the use of portals.

Lyn reached behind herself and pulled her dragonclaw wand out of the magical dimension she stored it in, a dimension that existed just at the fingertips of her left hand and could be penetrated by her will alone. Gripping the hilt of the wand, Lyn aimed the crystal sphere at the anomaly before her and said the words of power that she hoped would properly execute her spell. The magic she had learned in order to study the portals and alternate dimensions had cost the lives of a ridiculous number of rabbits, stray dogs and firespiders. The one thing Lyn had become certain of in her studies was that most entities required something specific to properly interact with the magics she used; a portal that recombined a dog properly from a portal accident might make a rabbit into quantum singularity. Lyn was unsure what the proper form of the entity before her was, so she guessed as best she could that it was something humanoid and hoped the spell might work.

While she cast her spell, and was rewarded by the physical form of the anomaly shrinking some - though it began to shriek, not so much in pain as in surprise and fear -, Gwen conjured a robe. Gwen appeared to be at as much of a loss as Lyn; the sorceress recognized the enchantments she was creating on the conjured garment as a containment spell. As Lyn watched and gently waved her wand, chanting the words to the reconstruction spell, Gwen prepared to throw the Robe Of Containment.

"Now!" Both women were surprised by the voice, its clarity and the intent in its tone. Gwen's shock was not enough to prevent her from moving; she opened the robe and threw it in an arc above the still-shifting form of smoke, body and light that was coalescing before her. Lyn saw two very humanlike arms appear from the cloud to help catch and arrange the cloak as it fell from its arc.

And the room fell quiet.

Lyn had been unconsciously aware of the sound and force of wind surrounding the interloping being, but she immediately registered its absence. Gwen rushed around the robed figure to her friend, a look of concern coming over her face.

"This might hurt," Gwen noted. Before Lyn could say anything, Gwen reached up and pulled the sliver out of her cheek. In the same motion of her hand, she healed the wound and smiled at her friend. She showed her the splinter, which was surprisingly large and unsurprisingly soaked with Lyn's blood. Their eyes made contact and both young women turned as one toward the cloaked form before them, wands raised.

The robed creature floated just slightly off the floor. The robe was bright red and hooded, with a deep hood that hid any hint of the face inside. Instead it revealed only darkness as the robe took the general shape of a woman. From deep within the recesses of the hood, two glowing yellow orbs flashed into existence, nearly blinding the women who stared at the figure. The sleeves puffed out and as Lyn watched, skeletal arms emerged from each armhole, covered barely in a blue-green flesh that reminded Lyn instantly of the skin on drowned sailors in the Crystal Sea in winter. The fingernails on the hands were sharp and it took Lyn a moment to realize the hands had fingers and were not claws.

"Who are you?" Lyn asked, sounding more confident than she felt.

"I do not know," the being admitted.

"What are you?" Gwen demanded. "Your body; it's not clear if you were organic, human, shadow or something else just woven all together."

"Maybe I am," she said. Her voice was coalescing into a dusky, distinctly feminine voice. "Maybe I was, maybe I am none of them. I'm not certain I knew... or that I know. I like that, though... Shadow, woven together of flesh... I am Shadow Weaver."

"What are you?" Lyn inquired again.

The hooded figure shook its head and returned a question of her own.

"Where am I? How did you bring me here? How did you..." she raised her arm to her eyeline "do this to me?"

Lyn and Gwen glanced at each other. Gwen chose honesty and replied, "We did nothing to you. Rather, we did nothing to bring you here or transform you."

"Ah..."

"I tried to restore your form," Lyn admitted.

"After hundreds of years, this is the most... together I have been. My thanks."

"But when you came through the portal," Gwen prompted.

"The most apart I have been in the same amount of time," Shadow Weaver declared. "And that was not a portal, to be sure. Portals are controlled and, in most ways, predictable. That was a rent in the very fabric of reality. What were you ladies doing?"

"Nothing," Lyn admitted, eying Shadow Weaver with suspicion. "If you're more together now than you were before, how could a fissure in space..."

"Magic," Shadow Weaver cut her off. "I was the victim of a magical accident a long time ago and I was nearly destroyed. I have not had this much corporeal form since. Where am I?"

"Where are you from?" Lyn countered. Gwen glanced over at her friend and Lyn shrugged. Shadow Weaver chuckled.

"This isn't a Horde world," Shadow Weaver noted. Gwen flinched; Lyn felt a chill run through her. Her arm felt numb, so she lowered her wand before she inadvertently dropped it. The

glowing orbs within the hood narrowed. Shadow Weaver's voice was mirthless as she continued, "You've heard of the Horde. Interesting… There are so few places in the Universe that know of the Horde, but have not become a part of it. And for a place with such... powerful and potent magic, that is almost unheard of. How could you possibly know of the Horde?"

"We'll ask the questions," Gwen declared, her tone bold.

Shadow Weaver sighed.

"Of course," she said, waving one of her skeletal hands. She glided forward and reached out for Gwen, grabbing her by the neck. Lyn flinched toward them, but Shadow Weaver turned her hooded head and lashed out with her left hand. Though her hand did not connect with Lyn, Lyn flew backwards and even before her back collided with the wall, she felt as if she had been hit harder than she ever had been hit before. Shadow Weaver turned her attention back to Gwen. She did not squeeze the young woman's neck, though her cold hand held her in an iron grip.

"The binding on the Robe Of Containment was clever, child," Shadow Weaver declared. "But elementary to my abilities. Where are we?"

Gwen's eyes widened as Shadow Weaver began to apply pressure. Lyn pushed herself off the floor and tried to get to a standing position. Her legs were weak and she did not yet have her breath back from hitting the wall so hard. Gwen blurred in her vision, though Lyn looked at her friend.

"Eternia," Gwen croaked out.

Shadow Weaver released her hold on Gwen's neck. She admitted, "Never heard of it. And you claim you did not create the time/space disruption that brought me here?"

"We didn't," Lyn heard Gwen confess. Lyn collapsed to her knees; walking and trying to stand up wasn't working. She would rather

deal with a controlled fall than a chaotic collapse in front of the intruder.

"If you didn't, who else could have?" Shadow Weaver looked around. "Perhaps the man in the next room?"

"Most definitely not," Gwen replied. "He's barely alive."

"But I sense magic from him," Shadow Weaver noted.

"The magic is ours," Lyn croaked out. "We've been trying to heal him. It's how we had any ability to put you back together."

"Indeed? Let's see if your friend is doing better than I am."

Shadow Weaver floated toward the door to the room where Keldor lay. Lyn's vision cleared and she managed to get to her feet again.

"Please don't disturb him," Gwen implored. "He's our only hope."

"Is that so?" Shadow Weaver asked, opening the door to Keldor's room. She glided inside and looked over the inert form there. "Oh..."

Gwen reached out to Lyn and Lyn decided they were past the point of pretense with the stranger. She put her arm around her friend and leaned on Gwen heavily. Together they followed Shadow Weaver into the other room.

The Gar lay upon a table, blue skin shimmering as it was surrounded by magical energy and fields. He looked much the way he had when he had come to Eternia; strong, barely dressed, blue. The big difference, of course, was his head. While there was a head in the space where his head belonged, Keldor's head had been reduced to a skull which floated above the table. Shadow Weaver seemed fascinated by that.

Without looking back at the young women, she asked, "He still has a brain in there?"

"Yes," Gwen confirmed. "As near as we can tell, our magical protections prevented it from taking any damage."

"It looks like you did well," Shadow Weaver admitted, tone impressed. She stood back up and turned to face the other two women. "Most everyone assumed Keldor was dead."

"You know him," Lyn pressed.

"More that I know of him," Shadow Weaver corrected. "He was from a pathetic colony world... what was it? Garia?"

"Garnia," Gwen corrected. Lyn winced.

"He claimed the Horde had subjugated or destroyed seven galaxies," Lyn refocused before Shadow Weaver could ask something more.

The ethereal woman shifted her attention to Lyn and when she spoke, Lyn had the impression that if she had a body, she would be smirking.

"Eight now. Garnia, yes. If this is Eternia, then I must return to the Horde to confirm its existence and location."

Gwen raised her wand and uttered a word of power; Shadow Weaver was suddenly ensconced in a column of dull, but noticeable, light.

"The Horde will not destroy Eternia," Gwen insisted.

"It will absorb it or it will destroy it," Shadow Weaver replied. She waved her hand in a casual motion, then took a step out of the containment spell Gwen had made. "The Horde is a force of order and order is inevitable."

Lyn looked at Gwen and she was certain her face mirrored Gwen's alarmed expression. Gwen made powerful containment spells on her own, but together they could strengthen a magical prison for Shadow Weaver. Gwen made a subtle motion of her head,

imperceptible to anyone not as attuned to her as Lyn was. Lyn understood the message instantly: don't try.

"So what Keldor said was true," Lyn regrouped.

Shadow Weaver turned her attention back to the inert man.

"I'm certain it wasn't all true," Shadow Weaver replied. "When the Horde realized the value of Garnia, Keldor destroyed it. Did he tell you that?"

"He told us he destroyed the library," Gwen admitted.

"He did more than that," Shadow Weaver declared. "If this is Keldor, he would be a great prize for me to bring back to the Horde. The leadership of the Horde has no idea how he succeeded in his... sabotage. In eight galaxies of conquest, no one had ever done what he has. He managed to commandeer a Horde ship and its weapons systems to destroy his planet."

Lyn swallowed heavily. She looked at Gwen, who shifted nervously. Keldor's story had not been that specific or as brutal; the Horde had been an unwavering evil and he had protected the knowledge his people kept. Shadow Weaver seemed to be implying something much worse.

"The ship he took over destroyed most of the armada at Garnia and then he just disappeared. No one knew what happened to him. It looks like, perhaps, justice was served upon him. Still, it looks like enough of him remains for the Horde to derive some pleasure from extracting what he knows."

"You have no idea where you are," Gwen realized and articulated.

Lyn smiled, making explicit to her friend the other salient point Shadow Weaver had let slip, "You have no clue how you were brought here; you have no conception of how to return to the Horde fleet."

Shadow Weaver grumbled, but did not contradict either woman.

"Where were you before this?" Gwen asked.

"Etheria," Shadow Weaver declared, as if answering Gwen and Lyn was entirely inconsequential to her. "The Horde fleet had homed in on some powerful magics. Prime thought this might be Eternia; it had shielding that was... problematic."

"How did you find out it wasn't Eternia?" Lyn asked.

"You're not the only one who can open portals," Shadow Weaver declared. "I brought aboard some pathetic creature from the planet and it told us everything. The fleet had just registered the shield when the fissure opened up and I found myself here."

"We should look around," Gwen noted.

"Make sure no one else from the fleet materialized here," Lyn concluded.

"Schzizio lamectus drivinin," Shadow Weaver whispered, her right hand glowing blue. She glanced at her left arm; it glowed green. Her voice hinted at confusion as she admitted, "There is no one else from the Horde on this world."

"We'll check around to be sure," Lyn insisted.

"It is your time to waste," Shadow Weaver noted dismissively. She turned her attention back to the inert Keldor.

Lyn looked to Gwen and wordlessly, the pair left their hidden home in the factory.

"We should assume we're being watched," Gwen said when they got outside. Lyn blinked in the sunlight. She had somehow forgotten it was morning; Shadow Weaver's entrance had both blown out the windows on the second floor of the factory and ensconced the room in a pervading darkness Lyn had not consciously registered. The sunlight felt good on her skin, but Lyn

still felt chilled deeper in her body. She nodded at Gwen and was instantly pleased the two shared a shorthand and a lifelong understanding of one another.

"Always," Lyn replied. "So... Keldor."

"Doesn't change anything," Gwen insisted. "He's still our best hope."

"I agree." Lyn looked around. Outside the shattered glass in the alleyway, there was no evidence of the disturbance on the second floor of the factory. Nearby on adjacent streets, people wandered and talked with one another without any apparent care. There was no evidence of another interloper from beyond the stars in the immediate vicinity.

Gwen cast a locator spell, then shook her head.

"So it's not just her ability to break containment spells," Gwen noted.

"We should keep trying, though."

"She's dangerous."

"Obviously," Lyn agreed. "But if we contain her, we succeed; if we fail, we show her that we're not just going to roll over."

"You think she'll respect us?! I think she'll kill us..."

"No," Lyn disagreed. "She needs us. If she's as powerful as she seems, she'll need us."

"Or the..." Lyn raised her hand to cut her off. Gwen looked at her confused.

"She might not know about them."

"They might be able to..." Gwen cut herself off and nodded. The dragons were their ace in the hole; Lyn and Gwen could not

approach them, but if Shadow Weaver became too much of a problem, perhaps the dragons could solve that problem.

"Can we sit?" Lyn asked. She still felt bruised and a lingering pain from Shadow Weaver throwing her against the wall. It had been some time since Lyn had actually not countered an attack fast enough to prevent getting even inconvenienced, much less hurt.

"Sure," Gwen said, nodding at a nearby bench. The two ambled toward it.

"I just wanted ice cream," Lyn griped.

"We could still go get some," Gwen offered.

"We can't leave Shadow Weaver."

"How about that? How can she be so powerful and not know her name?!"

"Maybe it was part of her strategy," Lyn suggested, sitting down on the bench as they reached it. The cold stone bench felt good on her bruised posterior.

"Like, we help her get her name, that forms a bond between us?" Gwen asked. Lyn nodded. "Seems weak."

"She's a stranger in a strange land. She was vulnerable..."

"That thing strikes me as anything but vulnerable," Gwen asserted.

"But she seems loyal," Lyn realized. "Whatever kept her disembodied or dissociated, the Horde either did it to her or wasn't able to reconstruct her and she remained loyal to the Horde."

"So it seems," Gwen agreed, sitting down beside Lyn. She sat very close, her leg touching Lyn's. She moved her head close to Lyn's

face and lowered her voice. "Keldor didn't say anything about another galaxy even being under attack."

"He might not have known," Lyn replied.

"But two years..."

"That is alarming," Lyn agreed. "If true, it's unsettling."

"The Horde must be getting more efficient at their conquering."

"It's hard not to lose hope in the face of that," Lyn whispered. "But if it's a choice between subjugation or death, I'd rather fight."

"Do you think it's worth approaching Randor?" Gwen asked.

Lyn grumbled. She thought about the question. After a moment's consideration, she responded, "Not yet. It didn't go so hot last time and it hasn't been that long."

"Maybe five minutes with Shadow Weaver would get Randor to take us seriously," Gwen remarked. Lyn smiled softly back at her. Even in the face of hopeless armageddon, her friend was joking.

"We should get her back to the Horde as fast as possible," Lyn realized.

"We have no idea how to."

"True. But the longer she's here, the greater the chance that she figures out where Eternia is relative to the Horde fleet."

"If she figures that out, we can't let her go back," Gwen insisted. "They'd just make a beeline for our world."

"True," Shadow Weaver said, her body materializing before the two seated women. "But you don't really have a way to stop me if I do find a way to leave."

The women flinched at Shadow Weaver's sudden appearance.

"No, we don't," Lyn agreed. She silently resolved to find a way to turn that around. She looked at Gwen and knew she was equally resolved.

"This planet is dripping in magic," Shadow Weaver noted. "It's almost unfathomable that you have not saved Keldor's life already."

"Not everything on Eternia is magical," Gwen observed.

"But it seems the Gar's life depends now upon the part that is," Shadow Weaver declared. "I do not know how long I shall be stranded here, but it seems like the better condition Keldor is in when I return to the Horde, the more pleased Prime might be with me."

"That doesn't track," Lyn said.

"If I were to restore Keldor, Prime would be able to enjoy an eternity of tearing him apart again. That might curry some favor, which I shall undoubtedly need after my absence."

"Why?" Gwen asked. "Is he so controlling...?"

"Don't try to drive a wedge," Shadow Weaver cut her off. "Prime believes in me. Advancement in the Horde often comes at the expense of our superiors, though. As soon as my absence is noted by any of my subordinates, they will begin poisoning my reputation with the Horde leadership and Horde Prime. If I return with a prize, the single act wipes away all of the lies spread in my absence."

"Wouldn't your time be better served by figuring out how you got here and how to get home?" Lyn asked.

"I can multitask," Shadow Weaver insisted. "Tell me, do you have rubies on this planet?"

Lyn and Gwen looked at one another. Gwen made a subtle shrug; she could not see an obvious reason not to answer honestly.

Neither could Lyn.

"Yes," Lyn noted. "The most prevalent source are the volcanic vents in Mount V'ranthrum."

If Shadow Weaver could tell Lyn was lying, she gave no sign - though neither Gwen nor Lyn had any way to perceive that. Lyn was not lying about the presence of rubies in the volcanoes of V'ranthrum, but there were definitely safer locations with more rubies on Eternia. Gwen knew Lyn was stalling; they needed time to figure out what to do with Shadow Weaver and how to accomplish their goals. If Shadow Weaver cared about the tactic, she gave no indication.

"Let us go to Mount V'ranthrum," Shadow Weaver insisted.

“Let me get some supplies," Gwen requested. "Your arrival might have disrupted some of our obscuring spells; we'll need a few minutes to get everything in order to be certain Keldor is not bothered during our time away."

"Whatever," Shadow Weaver grumbled. She cast an invisibility spell and disappeared from sight. Gwen did not need Lyn's magical sensitivity spell to know Shadow Weaver was not truly leaving them alone. She refrained from saying anything risky as they entered the factory and made their way to the second floor.

"Why do you think she needs rubies?" Gwen asked.

Lyn had studied gems in her early studies of magic and as Gwen had learned magic herself, it was one of the few areas where she deferred to Lyn. Rocks, as Gwen frequently joked, bored her.

"There are a number of properties rubies possess that seem to allow them to retain magic better than many other gems or minerals."

"Really?"

"Yeah," Lyn confirmed. "Ancient magical scholars on Eternia found that rubies were more useful in magic than emeralds or topaz, for example."

"That still doesn't tell us what she wants with rubies."

"True," Lyn agreed. She was trying to figure out what specific spells, in relation to Keldor, rubies might have a use. She was failing to come up with anything substantive.

As they reached the door to their magically-obscured domicile, Gwen reached out and touched Lyn's left forearm. Lyn stopped and looked at her friend. The eye contact was all she needed to receive the message Gwen intended: when the opportunity presents itself, act. Lyn nodded subtly and turned to enter their home.

Keldor appeared stable in his magical hybernation. Lyn gently touched the hinge where his jawbone hung on the exposed skull. She wondered if Keldor could feel it when she or Gwen touched his skull. She suspected the answer was "no," but with all of the layers of magic surrounding Keldor's head, brain and the rest of his body, she was not sure.

"We'll be back soon," Lyn whispered, hearing Gwen re-establishing the protection and obscuring spells in the other room. "You should be safe while we are gone."

A few minutes later, Gwen and Lyn ran out of ways to stall and almost immediately, Shadow Weaver materialized in their living quarters. Neither Lyn nor Gwen was particularly surprised when she appeared and without any conversation, Lyn opened a portal to Mount V'ranthrum and the trio stepped through.

Two days in the heat, bright volcanic light and ashy omni-night of the volcanic vents of Mount V'ranthrum yielded no clues as to what Shadow Weaver wanted the rubies for. Lyn had been gratified very early on to discover that her instinct in regard to

Shadow Weaver had been correct; at every opportunity when they left the underground, Lyn watched Shadow Weaver and confirmed the Horde visitor looked to the sky. Lyn had chosen Mount V'ranthrum for exactly that reason. The volcanos might live in a hemisphere of perpetual night, but the sky was obscured by constant ash. So long as they were there, Shadow Weaver would not be able to see the night sky and the stars to get any clues as to where Eternia was in the universe.

Lyn suspected that Gwen was using her magic to keep the search for rubies going longer than necessary. At many junctures in the volcanic vents, the trio would discover sundered rocks and shattered rubies. Shadow Weaver would occasionally pick up a ruby fragment and cast it aside.

Unfortunately for Lyn and Gwen, Shadow Weaver showed no apparent sign of fatigue. The same could not be said for the human sorceresses.

"We are going to need water soon," Gwen noted when they teleported out of the latest set of volcanic vents.

"Go ahead," Shadow Weaver declared. "I can do this without you."

"You don't require food or drink?" Lyn asked. Shadow Weaver had refused any offer of nutrition, even when Gwen or Lyn attempted to be hospitable.

"The magic sustains me," Shadow Weaver insisted.

"Food and drink sustain us," Gwen griped. She looked at Lyn.

"Harmony Sea," Lyn stated, waving her hand and teleporting the trio there before Shadow Weaver could object.

The setting changed from lavafire and the omnipresent glow below to darkness and the sound of ocean waves. Despite the crash of the waves only a few meters away, Lyn could hear

Shadow Weaver grumble. Lyn looked at the interloper. Shadow Weaver's back was arched and the magician looked up at the sky.

"Doesn't the cloudcover ever break on this miserable planet?!" Shadow Weaver griped.

And that inspired Lyn. She saw her moment and had the idea solidified in her mind.

"No," Lyn said, materializing her wand in her hand. While Shadow Weaver turned to her, she used a subtle word of power, which sent a blast of blinding energy from the dragon tear orb directly toward Shadow Weaver. Lyn leapt toward Shadow Weaver, the wand raised to her eye level, discharging as she moved. With her right hand, Lyn made the desperate hex that she hoped might save Eternia.

"What?!" Shadow Weaver exclaimed, clearly caught off-guard. Lyn doubted she would ever have the opportunity to surprise Shadow Weaver again. The sorceress from the Horde recovered quickly and, even blinded, managed to stop Lyn with a fireball. As Lyn fell, she saw Shadow Weaver's cloak glowing.

Lyn woke hours later, her head cradled in Lyn's lap. She awoke with a start, but Gwen gently restrained her. She was surprised to find her mouth was not dry and she correctly concluded that Gwen had been providing her water while she was unconscious.

"Where is Shadow Weaver?" Lyn asked quietly.

"It doesn't matter," Gwen insisted. "We were successful. Don't tell me."

"Okay. But you?"

"I'm fine," Gwen revealed. "Shadow Weaver is angry at me, of course. I told her exactly what I did; I enchanted the Robe Of

Containment so it both cannot be removed without destroying the body inside and it has an anti-levitation curse."

"You grounded her," Lyn realized. "Smart."

"I couldn't have done it without your distraction," Gwen said. She leaned down and kissed Lyn's forehead. Lyn smiled up at her and reached up with her left hand to caress her friend's cheek.

"I'm hungry," Lyn noted.

"Of course," Gwen replied. She helped Lyn into a sitting position, then handed her some fish.

"How long was I out?"

"I'm not sure," Gwen admitted. "I felt safe enough to fall asleep after Shadow Weaver went back to Mount V'ranthrum. Good choice for the sky, bad choice for determining time."

Lyn looked around; it certainly appeared to still be night, but she had been exhausted enough that a whole day could have passed between when Shadow Weaver knocked her out. She did a quick check and was gratified to find her wand was where it was supposed to be in the pocket dimension at her fingertips.

"We should go back there," Lyn suggested.

"We should get ice cream first," Gwen countered.

Lyn snorted; the closest to a laugh she had done since Keldor had been wounded. She said, "I can see the history books now. 'Eternia fell to the Horde while its two most powerful sorceresses took a leisurely dessert far away from the action.' I'd rather not have our footnote be failure due to gluttony."

"Your focus is admirable," Gwen declared. "But at some point, we must have ice cream again."

"Sure," Lyn agreed, getting to her feet. "But not today."

"All right," Gwen consented, taking Lyn's hand when she extended it. Her friend helped her to stand. "But let's make it soon."

Lyn graced her with a faint smile to indicate she would like that, then wordlessly opened a magical portal back to Mount V'ranthrum and the heat and light of the volcanoes there.

Returning to Mount V'ranthrum, Lyn and Gwen were unpleasantly surprised to discover they could find no sign of Shadow Weaver. The magic user could not be detected by either of the women and every anti-invisibility spell they cast revealed nothing. The young women were absolutely convinced that Shadow Weaver was somewhere in or under the volcanic fields, but for all of their power and skill, the Horde sorceress managed to elude them. After a frustrating day of searching for Shadow Weaver, the pair teleported back to their home.

They materialized in the factory to discover it was the middle of the night. After checking on Keldor, they quietly went into their dining area and silently ate the last of the fish Gwen had prepared.

Lyn felt frustrated. All of the years of Gwen returning from school to tell her everything and then for Lyn to share with her all she had learned had culminated in a life where the pair was used to an almost-constant dialogue. Even Keldor's appearance had not fundamentally changed that. Keldor, as he had tried to prepare the pair to save Eternia, had frequent periods where he got tired of talking; he slept and in the years since coming to Eternia, he had taken several pilgrimages to Gar communities and ruins. Early on, Gwen and Lyn had realized they could expose his simplistic invisibility spells and Gwen had enchanted his right toenail so that the pair could always detect it magically. Keldor had no ability to be stealthy around the pair as a result. So their dialogue had continued, despite Keldor's presence and influence.

Shadow Weaver was different, however, and Lyn was disappointed because she could not even discuss with Gwen how powerless they were with Shadow Weaver around. More than anything, Lyn wanted to be able to reassure Gwen that she had solved the night sky problem for them. Lyn could not risk telling Gwen that she had placed a hex on Shadow Weaver's optic nerve. Whatever those glowing eyes beneath the hood were, they were connected - Lyn had confirmed at the moment of casting - to an optic nerve. The nerve now was enchanted to obscure the night sky from Shadow Weaver. Now, no matter when or how Shadow Weaver looked up at the night sky on Eternia, all she would see was cloud cover. The secrets of the stars would remain shrouded from Shadow Weaver so long as she was on Eternia. While Lyn was certain Gwen's enchantments on the robe would hold, her own hex ought to be enough to discourage Shadow Weaver from testing that.

When they finished eating in silence, Lyn looked at Gwen and saw in her eyes the torment that informed her Gwen felt the same way. Wordlessly, they stood and Gwen walked over to Lyn. Gwen grabbed Lyn with such force that some of her long, straight locks fell over Lyn's shoulders. It took Lyn a moment to realize Gwen was hugging her and she eagerly hugged her back.

"We will find a way to get everything back," Gwen whispered in her ear. Lyn could feel a tear from her friend fall on her cheek. After a few moments, Gwen pulled back. Lyn leaned close and kissed below Gwen's left eye, tasting the last of the salty tear. Gwen smiled sweetly, sadly, at her. Hand in hand, they headed for Gwen's bedroom.

No sooner had they curled together under the covers than they heard the snap of a portal popping into existence. They sat up as one, looking toward the closed door of the bedroom. From around the edges, yellow portal light mixed with the familiar oranges and reds of the lava flows of Mount V'ranthrum. Then it was dark.

"Ladies," Shadow Weaver called out. "You might want to join me for this."

Her tone was strangely playful and Lyn's stomach sank. She felt as if she were being toyed with and that annoyed her. Lyn and Gwen slid out of the opposite sides of the bed and walked toward the door. Gwen handed Lyn a robe as they neared the door, cinching up her own robe as she moved. As Gwen opened the door, Lyn activated the magical lights throughout their occupied rooms.

Shadow Weaver stood, floating millimeters above the floor, looking predictably inscrutable with her smoke-filled hood and glowing yellow eyes.

"You're back," Gwen observed.

"Your attempts to find me in Mount V'ranthrum were good," Shadow Weaver acknowledged. "I can see why I was drawn across the universe to the two of you. You have power and ability."

"That almost sounds like a compliment," Lyn noted.

"It almost is," Shadow Weaver responded. "Your ability pales next to mine, but I have been at this for a lot longer than either of you. But you have... potential."

"We know you're just trying to use us to find what brought you here and to get you home," Gwen stated. Her tone did not make it sound like an accusation, merely a statement of fact. Shadow Weaver nodded slightly and did not disagree with the young woman.

"It's amazing," Shadow Weaver redirected, revealing a pair of rubies in her right hand. The gems sparkled in her hand and were virtually identical in shape and size. "After you two gave up and returned home, I started to find more than just slivers of shattered rubies. I found these two and they will serve my purposes nicely."

Without further explanation, Shadow Weaver approached the door to the room where Keldor was kept. Lyn and Gwen followed her.

"It's good you are here for this; I'd hate for my magics to somehow disrupt your own and undo all of your hard work."

Before either woman could ask her what she meant, Shadow Weaver dropped the rubies, one into each eye socket of the skull of the inert Keldor. She waved her fingers over them and the rubies began to glow. The red aura from each eye was strong and dark and after a moment, the edges of the rubies seemed to bleed into darkness so Lyn almost forgot that they were stones illuminated from deep within. Gwen immediately began to cast recognition and protection spells, but they turned out to be unnecessary; Keldor's new eyes appeared stable within the skull and within the magics that held together the broken man.

"Can he see us?" Lyn asked.

Shadow Weaver shrugged.

"I suppose so," she responded. She leaned over Keldor's body and the glowing eyes seemed to brighten in intensity. Lyn felt like Keldor was widening his eyes, so she leaned over the opposite side of his head, pulling Gwen with her. She mouthed the words, "we're here," when the eyes seemed to focus on them and she hoped she connoted an appropriately concerned expression to convey both empathy for Keldor and concern for Shadow Weaver's presence.

"Oh, most definitely," Shadow Weaver confirmed. "There's no way to shut them, of course. But it does seem like he can perceive us."

"So your torment of Keldor has begun," Gwen growled.

"What a poetic way to describe a gift," Shadow Weaver teased.

"And accurate," Lyn noted.

"Yes, well... don't you ladies need to get some sleep?" Shadow Weaver floated to a corner of the room and remained there, apparently disinterested in any further conversation for the night.

The sun was shining into Gwen's room when Lyn and Gwen woke up beside one another the next morning. Lyn opened her eyes and almost as soon as she did, she perceived Shadow Weaver standing in the corner staring in the direction of the two sleeping women.

"We need to start to figure out exactly what it was that brought me here," Shadow Weaver declared.

"We need to eat breakfast," Lyn declared, smacking Gwen's arm gently as she sat up. "Would you get out?"

"Such primitive life forms," Shadow Weaver noted. "So concerned about bodies."

"You seemed pretty concerned about your body when we were putting you back together," Lyn quipped. Shadow Weaver did not respond to the jab, but did turn slowly and float out of the room.

"Would it be fundamentally wrong to use magic to go back in time and get that ice cream a few days ago?" Gwen asked once Shadow Weaver was out of the room.

"Has it only been a few days?"

"It feels like longer, I know. Ever since Keldor arrived, though, time has seemed so... out of order for me," Gwen admitted.

"I know what you mean," Lyn agreed. She rose from the bed and found a pair of loose pants and a loose blouse to wear. Gwen looked better in the earthy colors, but given that Lyn was picking clothes up off her friend's floor to wear, she figured style was not the priority.

"You look like a highwayman," Gwen noted, slipping out of bed and into a pair of leather pants.

"I'd need a belt for that," Lyn insisted. "Besides, this is your everyday wear."

"I can pull it off," she declared, buttoning up a vibrant purple silk blouse that complimented her red hair nicely.

"You sure can," Lyn agreed. Gwen smirked at her and they nodded at one another and headed out into the main room of their living space.

"The universe is a massive place," Shadow Weaver began as they entered the room.

"Look, I don't know how they do it in the Horde," Gwen began, "but here, we start the day with 'good morning' and breakfast. If you want to launch in with apocalypse talk, the least you should do is provide tea or coffee."

Shadow Weaver took a step back. Gwen's tone was, from Lyn's perspective, fun and mocking. Shadow Weaver interpreted it as serious and direct. Shadow Weaver was unsure how best to respond to such demands.

"Which would you prefer?" she asked after a moment, as Lyn approached the cupboards.

"Coffee, please," Gwen requested, interested to see what Shadow Weaver came up with. Lyn opened the cupboard at eye level where the mugs were stored and discovered two mugs filled with steaming, black, coffee. She silently pulled the mugs from the cupboard and handed one to Gwen.

Lyn turned her gaze to Shadow Weaver and noted, "We're different people."

"True," Shadow Weaver responded. "But we both know that you would only state you wanted something different to be deliberately contrarian. You were in the mood for coffee the moment Gwen requested it."

Lyn did not validate Shadow Weaver's statement with words, but did take a sip of the coffee. It was strong and bitter. Lyn tried to recall if they had had any coffee since Shadow Weaver's arrival. She concluded that they had not, which made her wonder how Shadow Weaver knew exactly what the beverage was. Was coffee a universal constant somehow?

"This is good, thank you," Gwen said to Shadow Weaver, after taking a sip of her coffee. "So you want us to figure out how you were brought to Eternia."

"Yes."

"How would you suggest we do that?"

"How did you find Keldor?" Shadow Weaver asked, sidestepping Gwen's question.

"We have spells that detect magic and portals when they open on Eternia from anywhere outside Eternia," Lyn said, figuring that the truth of their first encounter with Keldor was best kept from Shadow Weaver. "When he arrived here, we were able to find him almost immediately."

"Why did you have such spells in place?" Shadow Weaver asked, tone full of suspicion.

"Several years ago, there was an incursion from off-world," Gwen replied quickly. "Goblins, which were not native to Eternia, were unleashed and we recognized them as a threat from somewhere other than Eternia. After that, it occurred to us that we could survive such an invasion better if we knew where and when it was coming from."

"Your rulers didn't employ your services?"

"Our rulers," Lyn scoffed, "do not see eye to eye with us on most things. They did not ask us for anything, much less help, after the Goblin Invasions."

"And these spells remain in effect now?"

"Yes," Gwen responded. After a moment, she amended, "To the best of our knowledge, they are still in place."

"But they did not give you any advanced warning about me," Shadow Weaver asserted. "It seems strange that a non-magical phenomenon would connect two groups of powerful magic users."

"You already said that it was some sort of spatial fissure and not a portal," Lyn reminded her, sipping the coffee.

Shadow Weaver ignored her and looked directly at Gwen as she asked, "Your detection spells are limited to Eternia itself, yes?"

"Yes," Gwen confirmed. "We can easily detect alien artifacts here on Eternia, but it seemed pointless to create a warning system for them; they have to get here somehow. We've been quite effective with our portal detection."

"I'd like to know if I was the only one brought to Eternia when I was pulled here," Shadow Weaver declared.

"We did a cursory search the day you arrived."

"I'd like to search the entire planet," Shadow Weaver insisted. "Is that within your abilities?"

"Abilities, yes," Lyn stated. "Purview..."

Shadow Weaver snorted in response. She observed, "The more I know about the phenomenon that brought me here, the quicker I should be able to figure out a way home."

"I've been thinking, why shouldn't we just kill you?" Lyn asked. Gwen's eyes widened and she looked at her friend. "If you just disappeared from the Horde fleet and no one has any reason to suspect you're still alive, why wouldn't we be better off ending you now?"

"You're welcome to try," Shadow Weaver hissed. "We both know you two lack the power, even together, to make good on that threat."

"Do we?" Gwen asked. She spoke a word and looked directly at Shadow Weaver.

Shadow Weaver laughed.

"Oh child," she chided. "You've played your hand. If I had been there, that would have been quite effective. But now, you shall never again have the opportunity. You were almost clever."

Shadow Weaver faded out of existence before the two women.

"What did you do?" Lyn asked.

"I tried to unravel the Robe Of Containment," Gwen admitted. "It would have worked on the real Shadow Weaver."

"We can try again when we find her again," Lyn insisted.

"No," Gwen noted. "It's a directional command; I have to be looking at the Robe when I issue the command. She wasn't even here this time and I couldn't detect it. She's too smart for that. She won't be where she seems to be ever again, not as long as I'm around."

"We can detect displacement spells," Lyn noted. "We're powerful enough for that."

"Yes," Shadow Weaver declared, popping into existence near the door to Keldor's room. "You know the spells, but even together you wouldn't be able to pull off the magic before I'd detect what you were doing. Go ahead... try."

Gwen inhaled, looking around the room. Before she could say the word of unraveling to Shadow Weaver's Robe, Lyn raised her hand and conjured freezing dust. She opened her palm and began to speak and blow the dust away from her. Before the enchantment

was done, however, the image of Shadow Weaver once again disappeared. Lyn looked around; the spell had worked. Dust remained suspended in the air, the steam above Gwen's coffee hung motionless.

Lyn swore and waved her hand again, ending the enchantment.

"She's gone again," Gwen observed.

"I thought that if I could suspend everything, we'd be able to find her in the room," Lyn said.

"It was a good idea," Gwen noted.

"It was a good idea," Shadow Weaver's voice confirmed. The women looked around, but there was no sign of Shadow Weaver in the room. "But you will never have the opportunity again. Good luck, ladies!"

Gwen and Lyn looked at one another. There was no need for either to articulate the thought that it was reasonable to assume they were not alone. Until Shadow Weaver was definitively dead or gone, they would operate on the assumption that she was nearby, invisible, projecting herself or scrying to see what they were doing, even as she pursued her own goals on Eternia.

"We should work on restoring Keldor," Gwen posited. "We could use another ally."

Lyn shook her head. She sighed, then articulated, "We can't deal with another enemy. If there was more than one fissure and it brought anyone else from the Horde here, Shadow Weaver would have an ally. If we can find any other interlopers first, we have a better chance of stopping them and preventing Shadow Weaver from strengthening her power base here."

"You're right, of course," Gwen said after a moment. "Then it's a race."

"It is," Lyn agreed. She sipped the last of her coffee and frowned, looking at the empty mug.

"It's all right," Gwen declared. "I know where to start."

Gwen's, admittedly brilliant, plan was almost enough to kill both her and Lyn. As soon as they were done eating, Gwen moved close to Lyn and began a spell, nodding at Lyn as she spoke. It was not clear to Lyn what spell Gwen was performing, but her unspoken request was; she wanted Lyn to initiate a teleport spell that was tied to Gwen. So, Lyn did and as Gwen completed her spell, Lyn watched as Gwen's eyes widened. A look of horror crossed her face.

And then they were under water. They were not simply underwater; they were deep under the Dread Sea. Lyn's eyes widened and the saltwater stung her eyes, rushed into her ears and tickled every tiny cut she was previously unaware she had. The water around her and Gwen was, surprisingly, not dark at all and nearby Lyn could see a disturbance in the fluid environment; Shadow Weaver, she presumed. Gwen looked shocked next to her and seeing her friend's fear actually calmed Lyn.

Lyn drew a sigil in the water and bubbles coalesced around her and Gwen creating a close, safe bubble of air.

"A little warning next time," Lyn requested in a wry tone. She glanced to where the visual anomaly in her peripheral vision had been, but saw nothing.

"I had no idea where we were going," Gwen admitted. "I made myself into a divining rod for the largest non-Eternian presence on the planet. It brought us here."

"Where is here?" Lyn asked, finally giving the area a serious look.

As it happened, the pair was in a massive subaquatic city. Massive hardly described it; no matter what direction Lyn or Gwen looked,

there were tall, smooth, gold buildings jutting up from the ocean floor. The pair had materialized on a lane and the wide road had vehicles made of giant shells that carried two to three Aquaticans. The buildings of the city ranged from three to thirty stories tall and the roads wound around the cylindrical oceanscrapers in an organic, fluid, pattern. Kelp lined the streets, swaying softly from the sudden incursion from Lyn and Gwen and the bubble Lyn created to bring them oxygen. The city was lit to a level that had initially made Lyn think they were in daylight, though she quickly realized that all along the avenue and attached to every building were brightly-glowing yellow orbs casting light that the water carried. The light reflected off the smooth gold surfaces and the overall effect was that of being in a glowing city at high noon.

Lyn glanced around and saw that, despite the scale of the city in which she and Gwen found themselves, the undersea city was hardly crowded. The pair had materialized in an intersection and there were dozens of vehicles visible and about one hundred Aquaticans in view. The Aquaticans were in pairs or groups no larger than four and they were spread out enough that it took Lyn a moment to truly conceive how many of them there were. Most of the Aquaticans wore loose garments of kelp; some wore nothing at all.

What surprised Lyn most was the noise. As soon as the bubble was established and Lyn could hear Gwen's rapid intake of breath, Lyn became conscious of the other sounds surrounding her and Gwen. The city was filled with the sound of voices, like bubbles popping constantly and musical tones in the deeper registers. The vehicles nearby hummed with engines that seemed to suck water in from before them, then push it out forcefully from behind. The shell carts Lyn saw seemed to float and connect only to the ground for guidance and stability.

"The Dread Sea," Gwen determined. Lyn looked at her with an expression she knew connoted her curiosity. Gwen elaborated, "The Aquaticans are blue-skinned. Or blue-er-skinned."

Lyn nodded. Though neither had seen the different races or ethnicities of Aquaticans, they had read plenty about them and Gwen's conclusion seemed a reasonable one.

"What is here that's not from Eternia?" Lyn asked. Out of the corner of her eye, she caught movement and she realized that she and Gwen had been noticed by the locals, who were beginning to react.

"I'm not sure," Gwen admitted. "But I feel something from the spell and it is absolutely huge. Maybe there is an object below the city that was transported here when Shadow Weaver arrived?"

The pitch of many of the conversations nearby changed to the higher registers and Lyn scanned outside the bubble and saw many blue-skinned Aquaticans pointing and calling out.

"We need to figure out what it is, fast."

"I'm not sure we have enough time," Gwen said. "If it's something under the city, it might take some work to even find a way to it. I don't think they're going to give us a chance."

"We should try," Lyn decided. She cast a communication spell and was gratified when suddenly the indistinct murmurs around her turned into coherent words she recognized. Unfortunately, most of the words she could pick out from the rapidly-growing cacophony were expressions of fear or anger.

Gwen raised her hands in a placating gesture. Judging from the gasps and at least one scream Lyn heard, the hand and arm motion meant something very different to the Dread Sea Aquaticans.

Undeterred, Gwen called out, "There's no need for alarm. We're here to help."

The Aquaticans closest to the bubble seemed shocked and curious; Lyn assumed it was because her spell worked and the fish people around them could understand Gwen. Lyn watched as

some of the Aquaticans fled, the vehicles steered away and a few of the blue-skinned water-dwellers actually came closer.

"Are you here about the tremors?" one asked. Her voice was decidedly feminine and Lyn realized she had no idea how to tell which sex of Aquaticans was which.

"Tremors?" Lyn asked.

The female Aquatican came closer, her arms at her side, palms facing the human women.

"Days ago, the ground began to quake," the Aquatican said. "Did you cause that?"

"No," Gwen said. "But... pardon me, my people do not know enough about yours; do you have the technology to determine from where the tremors are originating?"

"Of course," the woman said. She seemed prepared to say more, but it was at that moment that the guards arrived.

The Aquaticans who swam over moved with determination and speed. They were focused on the air pocket Lyn had created and they were instantly recognizable as something other than civilians. Whether a police force or military, the moment Gwen noticed them coming, she nodded at Lyn, who looked over her shoulder and saw them. There were a dozen Aquaticans swimming speedily toward the mammals. They wore bone armor that covered their torsos and heads. They carried tridents and some had swords or nets visible, attached to their belts. The moment the civilian woman saw the swimming warriors headed toward the bubble, she fell silent and stepped back away from the humans.

Within seconds, Lyn and Gwen and their bubble was surrounded by Aquatican soldiers, their tridents pointed at the women in a clear indication that they were prepared to defend themselves.

"By the order of King Physhymon, I order you to surrender yourself to Aquatican justice!" the leader of the group, who spoke

with a husky, feminine voice, demanded. "Surrender all weapons and submit to interrogation by the Chief Inspector."

"I'll do no s..." Lyn began.

"We have no weapons," Gwen called out, cutting her off. "We are here to find something that arrived four days ago. We mean you no harm, we have no quarrel with your people."

"The Chief Inspector will determine whether or not you speak the truth," the lead officer stated. "Come with us."

"Okay," Gwen agreed calmly. Lyn felt uneasy. While they were dealing with the Aquaticans, Shadow Weaver was undoubtedly getting a head start at locating whatever it was that had arrived under the sea from off-world.

"We don't have t..." Gwen lay her hand on Lyn's forearm to silence and calm her. Lyn shot her friend a glare that might have stopped anyone else on Eternia, but not Gwen. Gwen shrugged at Lyn and she accepted her friend's direction.

"Make the bubble mobile," Gwen requested. Lyn complied with two words and a wave of her fingers. Gwen turned toward the ranking officer and nodded.

They moved through the city - Gwen and Lyn walking, the Aquaticans swimming, albeit in an upright position like the bipeds they were - in silence. The humans were led toward the tallest building, which Lyn assumed was a palace that also housed the guards. As they went down the avenue, Aquatican civilians cleared the way to let the guards pass, though a crowd was forming beside, in front, behind and - as Lyn noted - above the human visitors as they neared the palace. The Aquaticans who started to congregate seemed much more curious than they were afraid of the visitors.

That tenor changed as they neared the palace and the tremors began. Lyn was not even certain there was a tremor initially; the water around the bubble shook slightly, causing the surface of the

protective bubble to undulate slightly. The ripples were subtle at first, but then Lyn could feel the vibrations through her feet coming up through the ground. She glanced at Gwen, who nodded to confirm that they were both feeling the same thing and that it was real. When the tremors started, the guards surrounding Lyn and Gwen became visibly agitated, casting glances at the humans that were instantly recognizable as accusatory.

By the time the group of guards reached the palace, the civilians around were crying out in fear, insisting that the strangers were to blame and that something must be done. The doors to the palace slid open, apparently automatically, and the Aquatican guards removed their helmets as they led the humans inside. Lyn was immediately caught off-guard by how there was no apparent change in lighting inside compared to outside. Inside the palace was as brightly-lit as the outside; the only noticeable difference between the two environments was the walls.

The guards led the women up a spiral staircase that ascended for several floors; Lyn was not certain how many, as the levels appeared to be staggered along the spiral at irregular intervals. At a floor that seemed no more distinct than the others, the guards waved the women away from the stairs toward a hallway. As Lyn and Gwen allowed themselves to be led where the guards indicated, Lyn realized that the doorways they passed were all open. Outside the initial sliding doors, there were no doors inside the building.

The pair was led to a room that could have been any of the rooms they passed, so generic and indistinct it was in form. The only difference between the small room into which they were led and the others was that the room contained a single occupant, standing facing the doorway, and the guards remained outside the door, tripled up, facing away from the Aquatican inside. The tremors inside the building were less noticeable than outside, though once they came to a stop before the Chief Inspector, Lyn became aware of them again.

"Is this your doing?" the Chief Inspector asked in a tone that was translated through the spell as more of a demand.

"We come seeking the source of your tremors," Gwen provided. "We are not the cause of them."

"Why should we believe you, land-dweller?" the Chief Inspector asked, eyes narrowing.

"We had no idea you were experiencing quakes until we got here," Lyn snarled back. "We are not the cause. We are here to help first by finding out what is causing them."

"Our scientists are studying the phenomenon," the Chief Inspector declared. "We do not need any interference from the denizens of the surface."

"We would like to help," Gwen insisted. The building shook noticeably. A loud crack rang out from somewhere else in the structure.

"Much happens under the sea that land-dwellers never know about," the Chief Inspector replied. "We do not ask for your help then; we do not ask for it now. We are more than able to solve our own problems."

"Don't be a fool," Lyn hissed. "There is more going on than usual here."

"What do you mean?" the Chief Inspector asked. On a level below something shattered and the sound and vibrations of it reached up into the room in which Gwen and Lyn stood.

"Four days ago, something happened," Gwen explained. "We are unsure of the exact nature of the event, but we witnessed an anomaly in space open up and deposit a visitor from outer space onto our world."

"Outer space?" the Chief Inspector said, utter confusion in his tone. He repeated the word, as if trying to get a feel for it in his

mouth; he clearly had no conception of the concept.

"There was a being, a person, who was not from Eternia, our planet, who arrived here," Lyn explained.

"There is not of the sea," the Chief Inspector began.

"Not of the sea, not of the air, not of our land," Lyn elaborated impatiently.

The Chief Inspector shook his head, clearly not grasping the full magnitude of the concept. As he shook his head a thunderous crack rang out from somewhere outside; the sound shook the building noticeably. The floor pushed up against Lyn and Gwen's feet and the humans looked at one another nervously. Gwen recovered first.

"Whatever it was that brought the person we met to Eternia, we think she was not the only thing to arrive on Eternia that day," Gwen said. "We think someone or something big arrived somewhere under your city."

"Impossible," the Chief Inspector insisted.

"No, it's not," Lyn contradicted. The shaking grew and Lyn could see a crack in the gold wall spreading from the floor up toward the ceiling. "We need to get out of here."

"You need to tell us what is going on! What are you doing? What are you doing here?"

"We are here to help," Gwen asserted as the room split in half. There was something instantly disconcerting to Lyn about the way the building was suddenly torn open and she realized fast that it was the fact that nothing was falling. Even as cracks spread over the walls and the floors separated, forming jagged metal tears in the gold, they fractured along fault lines or new seams without breaking more than once. The result was that the effect was that of the building being cut from the bottom up without collapsing further. As the building twisted open from the tremors, the floor

split and Gwen and Lyn found themselves no longer standing on that level. They began to float downward to the ground level. The guards swam down around them and the Chief Inspector swam, continuing to face the women.

By the time the group had reached the ground level, the palace had been fully split asunder and Aquaticans were visible out in the streets fleeing and panicking without any sense of direction or purpose. As they screamed and ran and swam away from the palace, Lyn was able to see more buildings in the distance falling, tearing, twisting, bending at unnatural angles relative to the ground.

It was Gwen who saw it first. As the Chief Inspector began the next question, Gwen's eyes focused on the horizon in the distance far behind him. She grabbed Lyn's arm and Lyn looked in the direction Gwen shoved her, rather than at her friend. Somewhere out where the city ended - or faded from view, it was unclear to the two human visitors - buildings were falling outward, as if reacting to an eruption beneath them. When one of the golden buildings in the distance disappeared altogether, Lyn perceived that the darkness which consumed the building was not a trick of the light, but rather a function of scale. Lyn blinked and looked at the wider view of what was before her and so far away.

The building had not been sucked into darkness; it was being swallowed. Lyn realized that as she perceived massive teeth above and behind the buildings in the distance. Then she saw the shape and recognized it as a head. The snake's head was immense, though she could not be certain of the scale at such a distance. The fact that not one, but two buildings were passing through the maw at the same time filled Lyn with dread. The gargantuan sea snake was moving, still rising out of a fissure somewhere far behind the head that was visible.

The Leviathan was unlike anything Lyn or Gwen had ever studied, so they knew instantly that it was not from Eternia. Their expressions of horror and surprise must have been recognizable for what they were, as the Chief Inspector stopped asking his next

question and looked over his shoulder along the direction the women stared. As he realized what it was he was seeing, the Chief Inspector turned fully to take it in.

"What is that?"

"I don't know," Lyn admitted, moving closer to Gwen. They watched in horror as the thing came infinitesimally closer. The movement of the Leviathan was clearly creating a force at its source; carts, Aquaticans, lights, small buildings were being sucked into the maw. Lyn did a mental calculation based on the size of the carts they had seen upon arriving in the city. She extrapolated outward and surmised that the Leviathan's jaw was at least four hundred meters wide. She thought of what she knew of normal snakes and their maw to length ratio. She whispered Gwen's name.

"It's so big," Gwen mumbled in shock.

It was getting closer, though it still seemed a great distance away. As it approached, details of the Leviathan began to become evident. Its flesh was a dark purple, like an eggplant or a squid's ink. Its eyes were green and flashed into view only as the head swayed subtly from side to side. The head was like that of a snake, with fangs the size of some of the larger buildings, yellowed and sharp looking. The Leviathan did not close its mouth as it moved, so it appeared as it came closer to be an angry vortex extending into darkness behind the lethal-looking teeth.

"Why?" the Chief Inspector asked, turning back toward the two women. "Why are you doing this? What have we ever done to you?!"

"This isn't us," Lyn stated emphatically as the massive creature rushed closer, tearing through the city as it slithered forth.

"Shadow Weaver must have set it loose," Gwen realized.

"It will destroy us," the Chief Inspector declared. Around them, Lyn and Gwen could hear the frantic cries of the soldiers or police

desperately trying to coordinate and respond to the advancing threat.

"We need to get out of here," Lyn insisted. "If we're going to stop it..."

The Chief Inspector's eyes widened. "How?!"

"The first thing would be to get out of its way," Gwen declared. She picked a direction, left out the rent in the building onto a street. Her instinct was good as the street upon which she and Lyn found themselves was perpendicular to the Leviathan's path. If they could move fast-enough, they knew they ought to be able to escape to the side of the beast, as opposed to making a foolish attempt to outrun the advancing creature.

By the time they had run a presumably-safe distance away, the streets were filled with the sound of thunder. The Leviathan's body was smashing the city behind it with its side-to-side movements of its head and body. The buildings being smashed, the vehicles being tossed, the screams of Aquaticans built to a deafening roar. When Gwen stopped running, Lyn almost ran into her. They stood at the end of an avenue before another building, Aquaticans fleeing off to their left in a panicked mass.

Gwen touched Lyn's arm.

"This has to be Shadow Weaver," Gwen's voice rang out inside Lyn's head. They had magically communicated using telepathy very few times before, but Lyn was grateful Gwen started there. Just hearing her voice cut through all of the noise that was flooding through her ears had a calming effect.

"I've got this," Lyn inisted. She turned away from Gwen and retrieved her wand. She looked to her right and over the throngs of Aquaticans fleeing toward her.

The Leviathan was still a ways away, but Lyn could see flashes of it between some of the nearby buildings as it slithered closer. She frowned, but could think of no better way to stop the immense

creature than with lightning. She hoped the Aquaticans would understand. She cast the spell and felt energy being summoned into her body, building, growing and she felt the electric tingle in every one of her bones. For several seconds she was a capacitor, sucking all energy toward her and letting it build within her to a lethal charge. She could smell her hair burning and she saw sparks igniting the hair on her extended arm.

When she could stand the pain and the force within her no longer, she said the final word and the electricity she harnessed flowed through her arm and discharged from her wand in a bolt of ferocious lightning.

The lightning went exactly where the magic guided it, just as it was supposed to. It shot out toward the now closer, deep purple flesh of the Leviathan's face, illuminating it with blue light as it soared toward the beast. Lyn watched as the lightning's energy fractured and split, recombined as it approached and then hit... a magical shield meters away from the beast's skin. The lightning ricocheted harmlessly away from the massive beast, hitting the golden buildings. It bounced back, the lightning chaining between conductive surfaces and flesh, electrocuting those it hit until all energy from the blast was dissipated. Lyn swore.

The head of the beast passed by and Lyn attempted a lightning spell again. Shadow Weaver had been thorough; the beast was entirely protected from all magical attacks that Lyn or Gwen could conjure. Gwen attempted to transmute; not even a single scale on the beast turned to stone. Lyn tried to stop and rewind time; only matter outside Shadow Weaver's magical barrier was affected, which forced Aquaticans who had narrowly escaped the Leviathan back into its path to be crushed or digested as they disappeared into oblivion. The pair had so many attempts to try to stop the Leviathan as it passed; the creature's length was as impressive as Lyn had postulated. Only fear and determination kept them focused on their task, as opposed to succumbing to revulsion and sickness. The Leviathan's body was increasingly covered in the splatter of gore from the unfortunates it had crushed as it slammed through the city.

The magical barrier protected the Leviathan from all magic, but its size protected it from everything else. Lyn watched as an Aquatican guard leapt toward the beast with its full weight and momentum coming down upon its trident. The Aquatican hit the side of the creature and bounced off it like a pebble being dislodged from a tire. The Aquatican's body exploded against the wall of a building, his trident twisted and broken landing between the remnants of the unfortunate guard's ribcage. The Leviathan's flesh was unmarred and unbroken by the attempt to stop it.

As the tip of the tail neared, the roar of the body of the Leviathan moving through the water reached a crescendo. Lyn cast a spell to temporarily deafen herself and Gwen. They looked where the tail had gone, looked up to figure out where the Leviathan was going.

"It's circling the city," Lyn realized.

"We have to stop it," Gwen said, urgently, inside Lyn's mind. Lyn shot her a withering stare that made even the thought of "duh" unnecessary. Gwen continued frantically, "No, I think Shadow Weaver might have figured out a weakness in our magic and is using the Leviathan. How big is that thing?"

"At least sixteen thousand meters long," Lyn shared her calculation. She suspected, given how long it had taken to pass and how tall the body of the beast was as it moved that it might have been even longer.

"Yeah, I think she's going to try to launch it."

"What?!"

"Out of the water," Gwen clarified. "She's got it speeding around; it's building momentum. I think she's going to have it breach."

"And if she does that, you think..."

"She can get above the clouds without leaving the thing, yes," Gwen asserted. "When I cast the spell, I didn't conceive of anything like this."

"We need to stop it now, then," Lyn agreed.

"I don't know how," Gwen admitted. "It's protected from all forms of magic we can conjure."

The Leviathan had, apparently, made it around the entire city; the women no longer needed to look up to see its side as it moved. The buildings of the massive city had been flattened, uprooted, shattered or consumed such that no building standing in the city was as tall as the blood and carnage-covered body that continued to slither around, building up speed.

"It was a pleasure getting to know you," Shadow Weaver's voice rang through Gwen and Lyn's heads. "I'll remember you fondly when your planet is reduced to ash and a single Horde database file."

Something in her gloating tone infuriated Lyn. She "spoke" as if she had already won. Her tone made her victory sound inevitable.

Lyn was not having it. She stood up and split the bubble, so Gwen did not have to remain close to her. In the distance, she saw the Leviathan's head and atop it, she felt for an instant that she saw a flash of red of Shadow Weaver's cloak. Then she saw the back of the creature's jaw and cast one, final, desperate spell.

To her right, a massive chunk of meaty flesh fell out of the sky. Inside her head, Lyn could hear Gwen scream. Lyn cast the spell again and again. Shredded innards and flayed parts fell from - sometimes projected violently out of - the portals Lyn opened. When her sixth attempt to open a portal was blocked by Shadow Weaver, Lyn collapsed to the ground, for the first time realizing that the streets of the city were paved with shell fragments.

But the quakes ended and the ruined city fell silent. Gwen approached her weakened friend, confused. Lyn reached up and touched Gwen's ear, ending the deafness spell.

"How?" she asked.

"I couldn't attack the Leviathan," Lyn revealed. "But I thought that if I could get a portal inside the barrier, near the gills… It still needed to breathe."

"It looks like you did more than that," Gwen suggested, waving toward the disgusting mounds of blood and carnage that littered the avenues and buildings nearby. She laughed nervously.

"It wasn't very precise," Lyn admitted. "But once it worked once, I had to take out the other side and that was... a lot of guesswork."

"Brilliant," Gwen said. "I'd kiss you, but you are covered in the most disgusting..."

"Well done, ladies," Shadow Weaver declared, materializing outside their air bubble. Neither woman bothered to point out that they knew she was not truly there. "I am genuinely impressed."

"That does not matter to me," Lyn stated. "All that mattered was stopping you."

"And you appear to have done that."

"There is nothing else that was brought to Eternia at the same time as you that was that big," Gwen admitted.

"Why would you tell me that?" Shadow Weaver asked.

"Because it doesn't matter now. That thing was the best chance you had to do real damage to Eternia or to discover how it was you got here. Did you even find out how it came to Eternia?"

Shadow Weaver laughed.

"I absorbed the entire contents of its mind before I took control of it. I know all about where it came from, I knew all its strength and power..."

"You have no idea how it got here, though," Lyn realized. "And you still have no clue where 'here' is in relation to your Horde

fleet."

"We won," Gwen stated emphatically.

"Today," Shadow Weaver admitted. "And at what cost?"

Shadow Weaver waved at the destroyed city around them.

"Until we meet again," she concluded before her illusion faded from existence.

Lyn woke from her memory and felt Teela in her arms. She heard the young woman breathing and for a moment, Lyn just listened, taking comfort in the woman's proof of life. Her mind was clouded with the memories of searching the destroyed city, the sights and smells of the dead and the destruction there. She recalled the futile search for survivors. She and Gwen had spent two weeks under the Dread Sea scouring the ruins. They found only three Aquaticans left alive. By the time they left, one of them was dead from their wounds.

Lyn thought of Shadow Weaver and her power and the years that followed and the encounters they had with Shadow Weaver. None were as devastating as the first, though Shadow Weaver had ultimately managed to get the most brutal revenge. Lyn shook that thought from her mind.

She inhaled deeply, the scent of Teela's sweat and raspberry shampoo filling her nostrils, and she calmed herself in that moment, trying simply to be.

The Smell Of Victory

There were remarkably few places in Snake Mountain that everyone who lived or worked in the castle avoided. Enough explosions had come from Tri-Klops's workshop that everyone but Trap Jaw refused to go near it. Enough of the lower henchmen of Skeletor had disappeared or died in shrieking agony after sneaking into Lyn's library that everyone in Snake Mountain gave it a wide berth. The only other place that Skeletor's assorted soldiers, lackeys and henchmen avoided as if it were cursed was Odiphus's den. Even Beast Man refused to retrieve Odiphus when he was needed for a mission. Dealing with Odiphus, Beast Man insisted, was a robot's work.

Odiphus understood the animosity toward him. Shortly after joining Skeletor's warriors, Odiphus had been on a mission and became spooked when he was leapt upon by King Randor's soldiers. Odiphus had been young at the time and unaware of the power of his own glands. Spooked by his assailants, he had shot off a spray of a thick, viscous fluid from his armpits and raised, catlike, ears. The defensive fluid has the desired effect; one human soldier, caught in the main brunt of the cloud of stench, breathed in and died instantly. His companion was not so lucky. The other soldier caught a glancing shot of the spray and his eyes, nose and lungs began to burn. He fell back and reached to relieve his eyes of the burning sensation, momentarily forgetting he held a charge mace in his hand. He struck himself with his own mace and fell unconscious. Odiphus had fled.

Unfortunately for the black-furred biped, returning to Snake Mountain, he was met with glares of revulsion and shouts upon his return. Even soldiers he had trained with, whose lives he had saved, fled in advance of his arrival. Some shouted out for him to leave, others called him names, like "Skunky," "Sklurp," and "Stinkor!" Odiphus, drawn to Skeletor's army by his prophecy of imminent doom to Eternia, remained loyal to the cause. He did, however, relocate to one of Snake Mountain's most distant dungeons, which happened to be an abandoned garbage pit.

Odiphus did not mind the smell; it distracted him from his own scent, which occasionally leaked out of his swollen glands and at least in his isolation, he was not mocked.

Over the years since his body matured enough that his stink glands were active, Odiphus had learned to use them better. He had found himself a useful niche within Skeletor's army. While most of Skeletor's key generals were part of the advanced forces, participating in the primary missions Skeletor led, Odiphus had noticed fairly early on that Skeletor's success rate was incredibly low. So, between not being asked to participate in most of the forward parts of the missions, Odiphus had gotten into the habit of lurking behind, and to the right, of Skeletor's armies. As a result, when one of Skeletor's missions failed and Skeletor and Lyn and the other generals would teleport away, Odiphus would press forward as the footsoldiers fled. More than any other single warrior in Skeletor's army, Odiphus had consistently saved the lives of the soldiers by taking the place of the escaped generals and providing a cover through which even the most heroic of Randor's men was unwilling to pass. Odiphus had come to know his own worth as a result and had stopped relying upon any sense of esteem from anyone else in Skeletor's army.

One night, when Odiphus had awoken to soldiers milling about, he overheard roaming peers complaining about a failed attack on Castle Grayskull and the death of elephants on the cliffside. Odiphus realized with a sense of dismay that he had not even been informed of that mission. He was hungry, but he waited for ten minutes to leave his den before going out into the caverns nearby. It wasn't the other soldiers' fault he had been kept from the mission.

He was only a few steps out of his den when he heard low voices in a nearby cave. Odiphus peered into the darkness of a crack in a cavern near his den. He had never noticed the crack before, but it was wide enough for at least one person to squeeze through. Odiphus reached out with his hand and felt it. It felt smooth.

From somewhere deep within the rocky crevasse, he heard a low, distinct, male voice.

"...inert lava vent that was long forgotten," the voice revealed.

"Duh, what if we're'a found out?" came the distinct voice of the idiot Ram Man who was often seen in Man-At-Arms's company on the battlefield.

"Hmm," Odiphus grunted. It appeared Snake Mountain was being invaded from a new angle. He glanced around. There was no one else around this deep in Snake Mountain. This particular crevasse was several meters and a turn from his own den.

So, Odiphus raised his arm to the darkness and relaxed. He heard the hiss of his glands releasing and he made sure to exhale with the release of his poison cloud. As he stepped away, he heard the voices deep within the lava vent gasp, shout and the retreat order given.

Odiphus wandered back to his den and fell back asleep.

He awoke a short time later to a hissing sound out in the cavern nearby. The air was heavy with the fumes from melting rock. But there was another scent there, too.

Odiphus opened his eye in time to see one of Tri-Klop's droid soldiers lowering a plate to the floor. The plate had the thickest, juiciest, rarest steak Odiphus had ever seen.

Before the steak on the plate was a simple card that read:

O.-

Thank you.

-S.

And it was the best meal Odiphus ever had.

Horror Magic

"Who is Shadow Weaver?" Teela's voice woke Lyn. Teela had shifted at some point in the morning - Lyn was certain it was now very early morning, even without opening her eyes - and was leaning closer to Lyn. Lyn felt her soft hair on her lips and when she swallowed and opened her mouth to lick her lips, she felt Teela's ear.

"Where did you hear that name?" Lyn asked softly, making sure the volume of her words would not cause Teela to flinch. Teela sighed; even with her eyes closed, Lyn rolled her eyes.

"You were sleeping," Teela replied. "You said, 'Shadow Weaver, no!' I assumed that was a person."

"'Person' is a loose description of Shadow Weaver," Lyn quipped, not opening her eyes. "She was... a Horde visitor to Eternia. We... banished her from Eternia eighteen years ago. Shortly after Prince Adam was born."

"That seems like very specific timing," Teela noted. She rubbed Lyn's hand on her stomach with her own hand. Teela's hand was calloused and dry, certainly more from her constant training than from being out in the desert. Despite that, her casual massage relaxed Lyn's tendons. Lyn realized that with her frequent use of her wand, she seldom took the time to actually relax her hands. Teela's rubbing went from gentle enough to be misconstrued as a sleepy motion to her thumb pressing expertly into Lyn's palm to relax her tightened muscles and tendons in her hand.

"Don't go lower," Lyn commanded, though her tone sounded more like a request.

"Okay," Teela agreed. "Why?"

"I don't like my wrists grabbed and..."

"There's a lot of tension in your hand, it will help release..."

"Don't," Lyn reiterated.

"Okay. Will you tell me how you banished Shadow Weaver?" Teela asked. "Maybe tell me who she was and why she needed to be banished?"

"You recently encountered Count Marzo," Lyn noted.

"How did you know about...? Yes," she admitted.

"His sidekick, Chimera," Lyn prompted. "Have you ever heard of the Alazim?"

"No," Teela said after a moment's contemplation.

"Neither had your father," Lyn recalled.

"Have you ever heard of the Alazim?" I asked Duncan. He was in what would one day be his workshop within the Royal Palace. You were actually there, Teela, in the playpen he had set up in the corner. You would have been right around two years old. But Duncan was not yet Man-At-Arms and Orko had not yet arrived on Eternia, so Gwen and I were still easily able to get into the Royal Palace using teleportation spells or portals.

We had not made a habit of breaking into the Royal Palace too often, mostly because there was so little there we could use. The last time we had teleported inside, we had stolen an artifact recovered from a Horde visitor. Our thought had been that we could use the unique metals of the Horde soldier's breastplate to create a destination location to send Shadow Weaver away. The idea was like a magnet for the portal; we would push Shadow Weaver away from Eternia into a location where the alloys like the Horde soldiers used in their armor could be found. We were so developed with our powers that we could now project a person so very far away from Eternia - in the process preventing Shadow Weaver from ever knowing our planet's location. You can imagine our horror when we could not nail down a specific location. The

Horde's presence in our galaxy might be far-enough away to give us a few years before they conquer or destroy us, but there were so many of them that our "reverse magnet" idea wouldn't work because the area to which we wanted to send Shadow Weaver was so massive. While there was appeal to the idea of spreading Shadow Weaver out amongst several solar systems, it seemed unlikely that we could pull that off before she could stop us.

Gwen and I had teleported to the workshop beneath the Royal Palace that day as an act of desperation. I was twenty years old and I had spent years with Gwen working to restore Keldor, without much success, while keeping Shadow Weaver at bay. Gwen and I turned to Duncan because there was, literally, no one else left on Eternia we believed could help us dispatch Shadow Weaver. Magic alone was not saving us. We needed another front upon which to fight Shadow Weaver and Duncan was the smartest person we knew left on Eternia who might have a different angle at which we could attack her.

"No," Duncan said. He eyed me with naked suspicion. He tried not to look at Gwen, which confirmed for me what I had long suspected about his desire for her.

"The Alazim were a race that lived under Zagraz Mountain," Gwen provided. "Or that range of mountains."

"Okay," Duncan replied, clearly processing. "You said 'were;' they are no longer?"

We did not know about the existence of Chimera at that time; we did not know Count Marzo had protected him. I explained, "They are all dead, Duncan. Every single one; an entire race wiped out before you even knew about it."

"Impossible!" Duncan exclaimed.

"It's not," Gwen said quietly. "You know there are many things on Eternia that you have not encountered, as well as things you cannot explain since you started working so intimately with the

King. The Dread Sea Aquaticans... you learned about their existence only after they were extinct. And the bones from the Leviathan that destroyed their city, they contained elements you could not explain."

"You know about the Dread Sea Aquaticans?" Duncan asked. He seemed horrified that we even knew the race had existed.

"We were there when their capital was destroyed," I admitted. "We saw the Leviathan before the sea creatures picked it clean and you found its skeleton. We were there."

"Why should I believe you? You... crazy fanatics!" He wanted not to believe us, but he already seemed to know we were right.

"Because you know the Leviathan was not from Eternia," Gwen began, speaking clearly and emphatically. "You've seen the ruins in the Dread Sea. The Calagor, the Ruipus... you have seen evidence of recent civilizations here on Eternia that have been wiped out entirely. And you have had no explanation for their sudden demise. But we do."

"The Alazim are the latest casualties," I observed. "And now the fate of Eternia hangs in a balance that cannot hold."

Duncan sat down at his workbench, still facing Gwen and I. He no longer looked skeptical. He looked frustrated. Rather than address me, though, he looked at Gwen and asked, "Is it truly that dire?"

"It is," she confirmed.

"Your associate... from a few years ago," Duncan led. "He warned of an invasion. This Leviathan, the Goblin assaults, these creatures and machines with that red bat symbol..."

"The Horde," Gwen provided. "The Goblin legions were sent by the Horde. The probes and soldiers have been randomly sent by the Horde. They are trying to locate Eternia and they are sweeping through our galaxy at an exceptional rate to find our planet."

"Shadow Weaver is one of their most important generals," I asserted. Duncan finally looked at me again. He was scowling. "She has been culling powerful races and entities on Eternia for the past few years. We're all that stands in her way."

"And you're coming to me with this now?" Duncan grunted.

"With her... absorption of the Alazim, we believe Shadow Weaver has all she needs in order to destroy us all," Gwen stated.

I agreed, "We have been working to prevent Shadow Weaver from figuring out her place in the galaxy so she can return to the Horde and tell them exactly where Eternia is. She may no longer need that. The power from the Alazim would allow her to bring Eternia to the Horde."

"What?" Duncan responded in shock. His face was ashen and I suspect if he had not already been seated his legs would have given out from under him.

"The Alazim had a natural ability to teleport anywhere," Gwen revealed. "Shadow Weaver has now absorbed that collective power from the entire race. If she figures out how to control it effectively she can just pull Eternia to the Horde fleet somewhere else in the universe."

"It would kill..."

"Shadow Weaver's conception of magic follows an object-based perspective," I interjected.

I was actually pleased when Duncan processed the information properly. He theorized, "So even on a dead world, she believes the magical elements would be present. The Horde could just sweep over the dead planet and get whatever it needed without any resistance. Why are you here?"

"We have some of the same abilities," Gwen admitted. "We can teleport Shadow Weaver off of Eternia. But unlike Keldor, we do not have the ability to teleport... even outside our galaxy."

"We were hoping you could help us focus," I concluded. "We wanted to teleport Shadow Weaver off Eternia, into the Horde fleet, preferably, a rear position so it takes her longer to get back to the front lines."

"Why not just teleport her into the sun?" Duncan asked.

I felt myself smile as I asked, "Would you actually go for that? I didn't think you had it in you, Duncan!"

Duncan shrugged and frowned.

"Two reasons," Gwen answered in a more serious tone. "We do not know if the Horde is looking for Shadow Weaver, but if they are and we teleport her into the sun, it could act as a beacon, a point for the Horde to home in on and find Eternia. Second, Shadow Weaver has shown a... remarkable resiliency. If she had even a fraction of a second before we successfully teleported her, she could potentially mount a defense."

"To a star?" Duncan asked, incredulous. "Tens of thousands of degrees..."

"It's possible," I confirmed. "Unlikely, but not impossible. And if she survived, she would be beyond the magics we have that are keeping her from figuring out where in the universe Eternia is. I don't care if Shadow Weaver lives or dies, but we believe the best strategy is for her to end up back with the Horde fleet without any connection to Eternia."

"For that, we need you," Gwen finished.

"For focus?" Duncan confirmed. "What are you thinking?"

"We have a general sense of where the Horde fleet might be in our galaxy," Gwen said.

"Oh? How's that?"

"The metals from this," I said, revealing a breastplate from a Horde probe that we had stolen from his workshop some time ago. I handed it to him and I could feel myself smirking. No one frowns quite like Duncan. That man frowned and scowled and if his looks could kill, his eyes would have blown a hole through me.

Duncan set the breastplate on the workbench behind him and glared at me. After a moment, he blinked and asked Gwen, "What do you want me to do?"

"We have a general idea of where the Horde fleet is out in the galaxy," I repeated. "We need a way to change our general field into a pinprick without any way for Shadow Weaver to incapacitate us, escape or discover where Eternia is."

"Does Shadow Weaver respire?" Duncan asked, stroking his mustaches as he began to tackle the problem.

"What?" Gwen seemed caught off-guard.

"Does she breathe?" Duncan rephrased.

"I believe so," I replied.

"But you're not sure..."

"We don't really know what Shadow Weaver is," Gwen admitted. "But we won't have an opportunity to study her. When we leave she'll be able to find us again."

"Why were you asking about her breathing?" I asked.

"If we got a breath sample from her, we would know what she is taking from the air," Duncan explained. "Then I could set those parameters into a probe; we could find both the Horde metal and that atmosphere. If you then cast your magic to the probe, that would give you the exact point-to-point teleport you desire.

"But even that creates a number of problems. We're dealing with an enemy that is very smart."

"How do you know that?" Gwen asked.

"I've studied one of their probes and another Horde robot. I understand their circuitry, the underlying technology, but it took me a while," Duncan admitted. He shifted uncomfortably on his bench. "Ideally, we need to prevent them from doing to us what we're doing to them."

"What do you mean?" I asked.

Duncan frowned and looked at Gwen instead of me. He said, "We'd want the probe to be airtight, so they cannot do an atmospheric analysis on it. We would need to be certain there is not a single component on the probe that has any form of distinctive element that could be traced back to us..."

"We don't have time for this," Gwen contradicted. "The amount of time it might take you to build a probe... there's no way Shadow Weaver does not figure out how to move Eternia before then."

"I don't have time for this," Duncan growled. "I'm supposed to be with Randor while Marlena..."

"We know she's pregnant," I admitted. "Gwen is correct, though; we do not have time for you to build a probe, find Shadow Weaver and run an analysis of her breath and do it all on the fly. We need a better, faster, option."

Duncan nodded, though he continued not to look in my direction. After a moment, he reluctantly said, "The power supply."

"What do you mean?" Gwen asked.

"When we recovered the last Horde probe, I had the opportunity to analyze it. The power supply was unlike anything I have ever seen before. If we could focus on a large-enough concentration of the metals unique to the Horde armor and the substance in the probe battery packs, presumably, we could send Shadow Weaver to a Horde vessel or installation where there is a massive supply of the probes."

"That would work," I noted. "Is there a problem with that plan?"

"No," Duncan said, rising to his feet. "Except that the last remnants of the battery are in the royal vault. I do not have access."

"Certainly Randor could give you access," Gwen noted.

"He could," Duncan confirmed. "But he is a bit tied up right now with attending the birth of his child."

"If Eternia is teleported elsewhere, there won't be a planet for his child to grow up on," I pressed.

"How would your portal work?" Duncan asked. "If I can get the power supply... what is your plan to stop Shadow Weaver?"

"She is hunting for us," Gwen explained. "The incident with the Alazim..."

"I suspect she would like to kill us before she returns to the Horde," I concluded. "So, as soon as you were ready, we would just drop our magical shield and she would likely appear..."

"You want to bring her here?! Absolutely not!"

"Our protection has very limited range," Gwen asserted. "We can't move very far or else she will find us."

"So, perhaps now would be a good time to get the battery," I pressed.

"I don't want to leave you two in my workshop," Duncan admitted.

"I don't believe you have much of a choice," I said. "We won't be going through your things, Duncan."

"We will have just enough time to get the portals prepared. When you get back, we'll narrow it from our seeking spell to the

pinprick," Gwen insisted.

"I'll go get..."

"You're lying," Teela realized, cutting Lyn off. "This is the first time tonight you've lied to me, but you're lying right now."

"I am," Lyn admitted without hesitation. She did not raise her voice in the younger woman's ear and she was surprised that, despite the force of Teela's words, Teela was not raising her voice either. She seemed confused.

"Why?" Teela's one-word question cut through the darkness and all of Lyn's armor.

"Because I don't want to talk about it," Lyn said quietly. "Because it was far more violent and bloody and disgusting than all that. Ask your father; he won't tell you more than I, but..."

"You've told me so much," Teela pressed. "What is it about this story? Why lie at all? What..."

"It's mostly omissions," Lyn asserted. "We did arrive in Duncan's workshop, like I said. But not like I said. Shadow Weaver had just wiped out the Alazim. Gwen and I knew about the Alazim, of course. We had been under the mountains trying to save them. We knew what Shadow Weaver was working toward, the sheer volume of power she was amassing. The Alazim were the final piece of a much larger puzzle in her attempt to flee Eternia.

"When we arrived in Duncan's workshop, we had just failed to save the Alazim. All we had managed to do was siphon some of their lifeforce, their magic energy away from them before Shadow Weaver could absorb their full power. The resulting fight... Gwen had a pretty nasty magic dart stuck in her leg and was losing consciousness... I arrived in Duncan’s workshop with a shattered arm and no wand. We had the power Shadow Weaver needed and a limited ability to stay off her radar while that power remained

viable. We needed Duncan's help to get her off-planet and far-enough away to not be a threat.

"But almost immediately after we materialized, Shadow Weaver did as well and there was a firefight. Shadow Weaver transformed the palace into a nightmarish realm and all that kept Gwen, Duncan and I alive was our use of the Alazim's power to teleport. All that saved Eternia was that we made it to the vault first..."

"Why lie..." Teela began when Lyn trailed off. "Unless... was this when you lost Gwen?"

Lyn considered lying to Teela, but she thought better of it. She shook her head no.

Aloud, Lyn said, "It might as well have been. She didn't last long after we banished Shadow Weaver."

"We don't have to talk about it," Teela resolved. She gently squeezed Lyn's hand and held her arm close to herself.

"Thank you," Lyn said. She felt Teela's hair wet before her closed eyes and realized that she had been crying at some point without being consciously aware of the action. She concluded, "It was horrible."

"We don't have to talk about it," Teela repeated.

"You might not want to talk to Duncan about it; I sincerely doubt he would be even as forthcoming on the incident as I was," Lyn noted. "The experience was not a pleasant one and even now there remain scars from it in the Royal Palace. Rest for a little while longer, Teela; it will be light soon."

Sticky

Long before Skeletor discovered Snake Mountain, Randor - albeit unwittingly - did. A year after Marlena arrived on Eternia, Randor discovered the caves below Snake Mountain. More accurately, Randor and Marlena were the first humans to rediscover the caverns since the reign of Hssss.

At the time, the caverns of Snake Mountain were the homeland of the Stone Spiders. Survivors of Preternia, the Stone Spiders were one of the oldest life forms on Eternia. During the age of dragons, they fled the surface for caves. Named by the Snake Men, the Stone Spiders were both hunters and prey during their dominance. The Snake Men were hunted by the Stone Spiders, whose appendages and hides were strong-enough to resist the bites of the Snake Men. Given the lack of steel in the Snake Men's arsenal, the race of giant spiders was called "Stone Spiders" and the two races frequently consumed one another. The Snake Men ate the eggs from the Stone Spiders and when they were able to fell the giant spiders, the arachnids were one of the few creatures the Snake Men would eat dead. By the end of the reign of Hssss, the Stone Spiders were mostly contained in the larders below Snake Mountain where they were managed as a food source. Since the fall of the Snake Men, the Stone Spiders had enjoyed centuries of growth and dominance beneath Snake Mountain.

It was unclear where Webstor came from, though he had always been in the caverns. Of course, his name among the Stone Spiders was not Webstor - it was unpronounceable by human tongues - but the Arachna was either the last of an ancient race or a mutation among the surviving Stone Spiders. The Stone Spiders were good at a great many things, but keeping track of their history was not one of them. They were a race motivated mostly by a hive mind and instinct, rather than a firm sense of language.

So, it was not until Randor arrived in the caverns that Webstor even truly understood the nature of language. The Stone Spiders

used clicks and hisses and they had clearly-developed thoughts which Webstor could envision in his own head, but they did not have a formal language. Instead, they existed to eat, reproduce and bask in the warmth of the lava tubes while avoiding the bright light of magma that came through the occasional cracks or chasms. The Stone Spiders were content survivors and so, too, was Webstor.

"What do you think is down here?" Randor's voice echoed through the caverns, awakening Webstor and the Stone Spiders near him. Webstor was humanoid and he knew that set him apart from the Stone Spiders. But he had glands that secreted webbing and glowing red eyes, like the gray-skinned Stone Spiders. He was more alike the Stone Spiders than anything else he had seen. Awakening, hearing Randor's voice, Webstor instantly found himself within the human's mind and recognized both language and that this was a creature very different from himself or the Stone Spiders.

Webstor was not a fool. He had, of course, encountered mammals before. Many had wandered or fled into the caverns over the years. About once a year, a bear would attempt to use the caves as its den and the Stone Spiders would feast for weeks upon it. Nothing had ever, within Webstor's lifetime, come into the caves that was like Randor.

Randor's mind was not like that of a bear. When a bear wandered into the caverns, Webstor mostly had a feeling of contentment, the image of a fish or another bear in the bear's mind. Randor's mind was filled with strange, bright, foreign images. People, food, plants, smooth surfaces that Webstor suddenly knew as walls... language. The cave in which Webstor awoke was minimally-lit by the glow of a magma tube a short distance away, occluded by the bodies of a brood of Stone Spiders resting between himself and the light source. Randor's voice had come from a cavern several turns removed, so when Webstor closed his eyes it was from the brightness of the images inside his skull, not the dim light source nearby.

Even with his eyes closed, Webstor saw the bright spaces of the Royal Palace, the sun, moonslights, the smile of the woman... Webstor did not want all of the images in his head. And then they weren't. Just like that, the thought became act and his mind compartmentalized, shutting out his ability to access Randor's thoughts.

Webstor opened his many eyes and they adjusted almost instantly to the dim light. The Stone Spiders around him began to stir. Webstor realized that it was because of the heavy sound of Randor's boots on the rock of the cave floor outside. Randor was not a light-stepper. His footsteps echoed throughout the adjacent chambers and the Stone Spiders felt the vibrations, heard the sounds, and awakened in the chamber's darkness.

There was a second person with Randor, though her steps were lighter. Webstor and the Stone Spiders could feel her moving behind Randor. As one, the Stone Spiders rose and as they surged toward the opening in the cavern toward the adjacent caves through which Randor moved, Webstor felt a flash of fear.

His comrades, his family, did not know what Randor was. They, he knew, had not seen the flashes from Randor's mind. Metal, electricity, magic, they did not understand what Randor represented. They thought only "food" and sought it. Webstor knew that the sounds nearby were something beyond his peers. The eight-legged creatures around him flowed and chattered as they clicked forth on the rocks toward Randor. Randor's voice rang out, closer, and Webstor knew those around him did not recognize his words as anything different than the cry of a bear or the squeak of a mouse. If they did, they would be fleeing, not approaching.

Webstor opened his mouth to say something, anything, to his family to stop them from advancing.

"It really is quite beautiful down here," Randor said. From the sound of his voice, he was now facing away from the Stone Spiders who had left the chamber in which Webstor remained.

Several of the youngest Stone Spiders were still coming from deeper within the chamber and Webstor thought fast and raised his hands. Webbing shot from his glands, covering the chamber doorway. The smaller Stone Spiders encountered the barrier and turned to face Webstor. Their glowing red eyes looked at him with the simple instinctual question of "what?" Already, Webstor's encounter with Randor's mind was having an effect; he recognized that they did not ask "why?"

In the cavern nearby, Marlena's eyes widened. Marlena stood a discrete distance behind Randor, in a decent-sized chamber lit by a deep crevice filled with magma and a lava creek that meandered near the top of the chamber. Randor wore his royal casual clothes; Marlena practical pants, her hair in a tight bun on her head. But while Randor looked at her flirtatiously, Marlena looked ahead to the other side of the chamber.

"We are in danger, your highness," Marlena declared. Her eyes did not deviate from the appearance of the Stone Spiders, massive and numerous, entering the chamber from around a dark corner several meters behind Randor.

Randor turned and instantly saw the movement of the Stone Spiders as they came into the light. He gasped, but drew his sword and took on a protective stance placing himself where he believed he was between Marlena and the Stone Spiders.

Randor, however, was not the brightest ruler to ever grace the throne of Eternia. Randor, muscles bulging in his tight-fitting riding pants, stood staring at the doorway, prepared for any Stone Spiders that charged at him at eye level. Marlena was several steps behind him physically, several ahead of him in the tactical department. She looked up and watched the Stone Spiders grasping their way along the cavern roof.

"Give me your short sword," Marlena demanded.

Two chambers away, Webstor heard Marlena's voice and he understood what her words meant. He knew from his brief

contact with Randor's mind that the short sword was the blade still attached to Randor's waist. In that moment, Webstor fully understood the nature of steel and his heart froze in his chest.

Webstor clicked, desperately communicating to the smaller Stone Spiders he had trapped within the chamber to retreat back into the darkness. He felt their instinct to go into the other chamber and feast upon the two mammals there. Only five Stone Spiders heeded Webstor's quiet demand and returned to the darkness, their red eyes glowing as they left the light. Webstor watched them for only a moment before he turned to watch the dozens of other young Stone Spiders cutting through his webbing in the doorway with their mandibles.

In the instant that the first of the baby Stone Spiders broke through, everything changed under Snake Mountain.

In the next chamber, the flood of Stone Spiders surged and Randor found himself too slow to react to Marlena's call for his back-up weapon. He instinctively swung at the nearest giant Stone Spider, the steel of his blade instantly severing all four legs on the creature's right side. Even as it crashed down to the ground, crushing some of the smaller Stone Spiders skittering by it, Randor caught another Stone Spider in the head on the backswing. His defense was for naught, though. Even as Randor sliced widely and wildly, the multitude of Stone Spiders who had flowed into the chamber on other surfaces shot off their webbing.

Marlena barely had time to inhale before she was pelted at every imaginable angle by webbing. The sticky silk strands coated her with such fierce velocity that she did not even have the opportunity to fall to the cavern floor. Instead, she was cocooned standing erect, Stone Spiders advancing upon her from all angles.

Randor turned to Marlena to gloat about the two Stone Spiders he had dispatched and he saw her stuck and stranded, Stone Spiders descending upon her.

As Randor slashed his sword in her direction, he smacked the communicator Duncan had insisted he take with him on the excursion. The wrist communicator lit up and chirped the second he tapped it.

"Bring fire!" Randor ordered as he hacked through the Stone Spiders before him, feeling the blasts of sticky silk pelting his back as he fought to close the distance between himself and Marlena.

Webstor heard the call and understood what it meant. He reached forward for any of the tiny spiders he could reach, as they squeezed through the holes in his webbing. He was only able to grasp three before he heard the sounds of the heavy boots of the Royal Guards descending in the nearby chamber and the puff of their flamethrowers being ignited.

Webstor grabbed the last two Stone Spiders he could and bolted toward the deeper caverns of Snake Mountain, desperate to escape the screams and pops of his family. When he was as far away as he could conceive - though the shrieks of the Stone Spiders echoed even so deeply in Snake Mountain - Webstor found a crack in the ceiling amid the stalactites, bound himself and the three child spiders he had managed to rescue in a cocoon and leapt up into the crack. He held his remaining brethren and closed his eyes so their glow could not give away their position.

Almost a decade after Randor had committed genocide upon the Stone Spiders, Webstor was visited in the deep caverns of Snake Mountain by Skeletor. The two had interacted several times, but for the most part, Skeletor left Webstor and the few remaining Stone Spiders beneath Snake Mountain alone.

The few times Skeletor had requested Webstor for anything, the ruler of Snake Mountain had summoned him to the throne room.

Webstor, of course, knew Skeletor was coming well before he arrived in the spider chamber. Still, Webstor was intrigued that

Skeletor had come into the depths of Snake Mountain to see him personally. He was even more surprised when Skeletor approached him directly and began to speak.

"Webstor," Skeletor said without preamble, his tone instantly conveying his sense of discomfort. "I need your... I was hoping to get your help on a mission."

The Arachna slid down the webbing he had been lounging upon and skittered over toward Skeletor. Several of his eyes narrowed as he approached Skeletor.

"What is it?" Webstor asked.

"Our spies near Zagraz Mountain have detected an archeological dig of Randor's," Skeletor admitted quietly. "We believe it is imperiled because they have unwittingly discovered the Diamond Ray Of Disappearance."

"What's that?" Webstor asked, coming to a stop before Skeletor.

"It is an artifact," Skeletor declared. "Potentially a defensive weapon to protect Eternia from the Horde. If I can get my hands on it, I believe it would be possible to take Eternia out of the path of the Horde, to a different dimension."

"So why don't you go get it?" Webstor asked, sounding mostly disinterested.

"We have reason to believe that the gem that emits the Diamond Ray Of Disappearance has become exposed. It is not safe for anyone to go near it while it is exposed," Skeletor explained.

"Why don't you send the bots?"

Skeletor sighed. "Tri-Klops cannot be certain that they would not become corrupted if they transported dimensions. Because they cannot be programmed for such fine work, there was some concern that if they were teleported into another dimension, they might evolve into something dangerous to us. It wouldn't do for

us to succeed in saving Eternia only to have us destroyed by robots on the other side. And Tri-Klops does not have time to reprogram the droids before, we believe, Randor's rescue effort will take place."

"Why me?" Webstor asked, suspicion heavy in his voice.

"With your skills, we believe you represent the greatest chance to recover the gem, get it resealed into its container and bring it to us. The risk to you is comparatively low." After a moment of contemplation, Skeletor admitted, "You're the right mix of intelligence, agility and expendability."

"So, you're fairly certain, but can't risk Lyn on the mission," Webstor baited.

"Yes," Skeletor concurred.

"What's in it for me?" Webstor challenged.

"Other than sticking it to Randor?" Skeletor asked. "What would you like?"

"I do like the idea of Randor failing," Webstor noted. "But I want something more."

"What?"

"I want my people back and space for them down here," Webstor declared. "Randor's forces were... efficient. There are only two males left in the Stone Spider population. Randor's people destroyed the population and the egg sacs they found. I would like an egg sac retrieved from the past to revitalize the Stone Spider population here beneath Snake Mountain."

Skeletor sighed. "Manipulating time..."

"I want my people back," Webstor insisted.

"...it's a good way to goad the Horde," Skeletor concluded. "It can be done, Webstor, but it serves no purpose to bring your people back to a world that will then be destroyed."

"I understand," Webstor declared. "But that is my price. If I am successful and then you are successful, Eternia will be safe from the Horde and the Stone Spiders will be able to repopulate these caverns."

"I can find a way," Skeletor decided, reluctantly. "While you are gone, I will explore the means."

"You do not know for sure?" Webstor asked.

"Time travel is a tricky thing. I have avoided the study of it since the fall of Garnia," Skeletor admitted. "In addition to temporal incursions potentially being detected by the Horde, if that... technology or magic came into their possession, it would be disastrous for the universe. Lyn and I can figure it out, though. Will you recover the Diamond Ray Of Disappearance for me?"

"Yes," Webstor agreed.

"The caverns below Zagraz Mountain are where the teams Randor sent have disappeared," Skeletor noted. "That is where I will send you. You will, unfortunately, have to take the long way back."

Revenge Fantasy

Chapter Summary

Tri-Klops has an idea of how to save Eternia from the Horde. He just needs Trap Jaw and Lyn for a risky mission...

"In all the time I knew him, Duncan never mentioned you," Trap Jaw said quietly, twisting the arm attachment into the socket until he heard the satisfying click and the whine as it powered up. The cleanest room in Snake Mountain was Tri-Klop's workroom and the annex in which the two men found themselves mirrored the main workshop. The blast-resistant walls were reinforced, the lighting was bright and the combination of monitoring devices and mirrors allowed Tri-Klops to see the man on the table before him at multiple angles at once. Tri-Klops held a scanner in his hand which gave more precise read-outs than any of the augmented optical scanners his rotating visor provided.

Before him, Trap Jaw lay upon a diagnostic table, his left arm reaching across his broad chest to the mechanical arm on his right side. Trap Jaw continued, "There was once a vague mention of a Tri-Klops, but whoever you were before, he never said anything about you. Not that I remember."

"That's okay," Tri-Klop said with a shrug. His tone was dismissive and his vision flashed to the undulations of Trap Jaw's neck. His apprentice had an elevated pulse that Tri-Klops could easily see.

"I'm sorry."

"Why would you even mention that?" Tri-Klops asked, scanning the arm and its new attachment. Trap Jaw's right arm was functioning optimally. According to the readings, the upgraded collar Tri-Klops had recently installed was able to handle greater bandwidth from the mechanical components, allowing Tri-Klops to better upgrade the attachments he was testing on Trap Jaw. Trap

Jaw had twisted a high-charge pulse cannon to the socket below his right elbow on the third generation mechanical arm Tri-Klops had fashioned.

The inventor's gaze refocused on the monitor on the handheld scanner. Tri-Klops watched the power curve on his scanner and his eye flicked periodically to the stopping fuse to make certain that was holding. An early model of the cannon had a faulty fuse, which led to the cannon firing each time it reached full-charge. Fortunately, Tri-Klops had installed that arm in an armored room of his workshop, resulting in minimal damage, though both he and Tri-Klops had been temporarily deafened for days as a result. For any future tests, Tri-Klops had committed to using the blast-resistant annex he had built. So far, the new annex had not taken a beating and its limits had not yet been tested beyond Tri-Klops's theoretical simulations.

"I don't know," Trap Jaw mumbled. Tri-Klops had been working in such close proximity to Trap Jaw for so long that the whirring of the young man's jaw servos no longer registered in the ears of the man-at-arms. When Trap Jaw mumbled, Tri-Klops could hear him perfectly.

"You do," Tri-Klops disagreed, watching the readout. The charge had leveled and the stopping fuse appeared to be holding. Tri-Klops adjusted the scanner's parameters so he could monitor Trap Jaw's brain functions as he asked, "So why are you trying to hurt me?"

"I wasn't," Trap Jaw contradicted.

"Then why say it?" Tri-Klops pressed. "Think about it."

Trap Jaw's eyes narrowed slightly, the last lingering expressiveness that might have indicated he was frowning or looking contemplative, given that so little of his face remained. The scars around Trap Jaw's cheeks, forehead and neck barely flexed when the apprentice spoke; his eye movements were the most organic way for him to emote, though he seldom did so

actively. Tri-Klops waited patiently while his companion actually thought. He tried to mitigate the young man's feelings of embarrassment by switching his gaze between the young man's eyes and the display on the scanner he held.

"It just popped into my head," Trap Jaw realized. "I remembered it or realized it, but I didn't think I had put it together before."

"Perhaps not consciously," Tri-Klops theorized. He nodded to Trap Jaw to indicate that the other man could move from his lying to a seated position. His nod was also enough to communicate that Tri-Klops would not be aiding Trap Jaw with that movement. Instead, Tri-Klops continued, "It seems like the damage is continuing to repair, though the areas of your brain that regulate impulse control remain..."

"Malfunctioning," Trap Jaw grunted as he twisted his legs down off the table and steadied himself with his functional hand.

"All the more reason to be sure the stopping fuse is consciously connected to your interface," Tri-Klops remarked. The readout on the scanner did not show any new activity within Trap Jaw's brain. Trap Jaw did not seem to even be straining toward any of the damaged memory centers and Tri-Klops did not need to confirm with the scanner that the lower, instinctual, parts of the apprentice's brain were more active.

"You do need to work on that... saying things as they come to mind is a good way to hurt other people, Trap Jaw. It might not, strictly speaking, be your fault, but it will be hard for others who do not know you as well as I do to not take offense."

"Okay," Trap Jaw replied rotely. His tone softened through the vocal modulators as he looked at Tri-Klops. "I'm sorry."

"I know," Tri-Klops responded, his tone somewhat dismissive. Trap Jaw had an almost imperceptible flinch to Tri-Klops's simple words. The young man had been frustrated during many of the

literacy lessons and Tri-Klops was uncertain if the tone or the words set Trap Jaw off more. "I'm not one of the people who does not know you. Let's test out your cannon."

"I was thinking of Duncan and it hurt," Trap Jaw articulated. The confessional tone in Trap Jaw's voice inspired Tri-Klops to look away from the scanner and back at the young man's eyes. Tri-Klops could see sadness and confusion in Trap Jaw's eyes, reflected in the mirrors around the room, perfectly clear to the optical genius. Trap Jaw's voice lowered as he confessed, "I wanted you to hurt, too."

"So, it's not that you remembered anything else from your past?" Tri-Klops confirmed. Trap Jaw shook his head. Tri-Klops frowned, his thin lips barely moving from the expression he held on his face as he refocused on the various readings on the scanner. "You gave me hope for a moment that your memories were returning."

"The man you and Lyn took me to," Trap Jaw prompted. "Was he really my dad?"

"It doesn't matter now. But if you want some revenge on Duncan, go over to the range and take a few minutes to test out that new cannon while I go deal with my issue."

"Where are you going?" Trap Jaw asked. Tri-Klops could hear the fear in his tone.

Tri-Klops checked the scanner once more. Everything appeared to be holding properly. Tri-Klops calculated the probability of this new cannon attachment working as anticipated and found it to be a near statistical certainty. He was not in the mood to watch Trap Jaw test the attachment and felt confident of the device's safety. Besides, the shooting range had mechanical defenses and a security system that would engage if Trap Jaw ran into trouble during the test. Tri-Klops reached out with his left hand and squeezed Trap Jaw's left shoulder.

"I have to go speak with Skeletor," he declared.

The torchlight seemed higher and dimmer than usual, as did the magmalight from below as Tri-Klops entered the cavernous throne room of Snake Mountain. The sound of his boots on the stone floor announced his presence well in advance, but as he approached the darker chamber, Tri-Klops debated switching to his Nightvision. As he pulled back on this Distavision while advancing on the distant throne, Tri-Klops's eyes adjusted to the darkness.

As soon as he was within earshot, Skeletor called to him.

"Are you still going by Tri-Klops?" Skeletor asked. His tone did not imply anything but genuine curiosity, so Tri-Klops shrugged and nodded as he advanced.

"It seems to calm Trap Jaw and it's fine with me," he replied. "I haven't thought differently in the year since..."

"That's fine," Skeletor remarked. "I just haven't known anyone who has changed their name as much as you. It's been a while since you've come up to the throne room unbidden. What is going on?"

Tri-Klops looked at Skeletor as he approached, though he was still several steps away from the throne. Skeletor sat, hunched forward on his throne, a gray cloak covering most of his body, his hood up, his right hand cradling his skull chin. Recessed within the shadows of the hood, Skeletor's gem eyes glowed red. Outside his jaw, Skeletor had not moved at all as Tri-Klops walked toward him. Tri-Klops could not tell if Skeletor was even looking at him.

"What are you doing in here?" Tri-Klops asked, still uncertain if Skeletor's gaze was focused upon him. Somewhere in the chamber bats were flying and even as Tri-Klops approached the raised throne area, his sinuses began to clear. For some reason, it

was more humid in the throne room than usual, though the air did not feel thick on the skin of Tri-Klops's exposed legs, arms or torso.

"Scheming."

Tri-Klops grunted. He asked, "Not even scrying?"

"I use the scrying table when I am making a presentation to all of you," Skeletor replied. "When I want to see something using magic, it appears in my head; I no longer need to see it outside myself to take it in."

"How does that work?" Tri-Klops asked, stopping only three steps away from Skeletor and his throne. He remained uncertain where Skeletor might be looking. "As you might have guessed, I have an interest in the science of optics."

"It's like a cloud parts in my mind and I see it," the skull-headed leader answered. "I focus on what I want to see, then I am able to."

"I'd love to run some objective tests," Tri-Klops remarked. "To compare what you believe you are seeing in your head with the objective truth. I could build some probes..."

"Certainly that is not why you came up here," Skeletor declared. He did not sound impatient, but his tone suddenly made Tri-Klops feel like he was interrupting something with his presence. "Tell me."

With those words, Tri-Klops was suddenly convinced Skeletor was looking directly at him, though he was unsure exactly what might have changed in the other man's gaze or demeanor. Nothing appeared different through his visor, yet Tri-Klops now knew for certain that Skeletor was staring at him.

"Obviously, that's not why I came up here," Tri-Klops agreed, recovering his focus. "I came because I was struck by inspiration

and I needed your authorization to both recruit Lyn and authorize my mission."

"You are always welcome to ask Lyn for anything on your own..."

"It's easier when I approach her with your prior authorization," Tri-Klops cut in. "We're all working to our common goal, but our methods differ dramatically." Somewhere behind him, a trickle of condensation fell from the ceiling and the fluid landed in the magma below, resulting in a surprising burst of steam. Tri-Klops flinched.

Skeletor laughed. His laughter shook his chest and he leaned back on his throne, the hood on his cloak slipping back as he moved so more of his face became visible. Were it possible, Tri-Klops would have believed Skeletor was smiling.

"That is one way of putting it," Skeletor declared, his high-pitched voice sounding lower compared to the cackle that still echoed through the massive chamber, drowning out the echoes of the steam. "What is it that you would like to do?"

"I believe I have figured out a second wave of defense for Eternia and I would like to test it."

"Our plan has been that magic would be our second line of defense against the Horde," Skeletor noted. His tone of voice was the equivalent to his eyes narrowing in suspicion. Tri-Klops smiled faintly.

"We need to be able to survive wave after wave of invasion from the Horde," Tri-Klops reminded. "When I finish the planetary shield, that might be the only thing we need, but it is foolish for us to plan on that. Given what you've told me about their invasion tactics, I have an idea that would neutralize their entire first wave of ground forces, without us having to rely upon magic."

"That would be an impressive victory... if it could be done. How would you accomplish this?"

"I was in my laboratory working on Trap Jaw and I realized that my competition with Duncan led us to two very different approaches to our electronic devices. I realized that almost all of Randor and Duncan's technology is based on shortcuts Duncan took in the development process."

"I don't know what you mean," Skeletor admitted, tone one of growing discomfort.

Tri-Klops nodded in empathy. He said, "Power sources are where Duncan and I started at fundamentally different places. I didn't have much to work with, so I built my own batteries, which I've refined over the years. But all of my devices are based on power sources and scales of my own devising."

"What are Duncan's based upon?" Skeletor asked.

Tri-Klops smiled, recognizing that Skeletor was catching his subtext. He replied, "Horde technology."

"What?!"

"Horde probes form the basis of most of our understanding of electronics and electronic devices," Tri-Klops explained. "Horde probes and robot soldiers recovered during Meero and Randor's reigns underlie all of the technology that Duncan has created because he had access to them and their offshoots growing up. Early on, I had to make things work in the field, so I started making devices that operate on somewhat different principles than Duncan's works..."

"...or the Horde," Skeletor realized. "The history lesson is fascinating, but what does this have to do with defending Eternia against the Horde?"

"I would like to create a weapon that will disable all electronic devices. It's a pulse weapon that I can deploy as a bomb. If it works, we would be able to immobilize all of Randor's forces simultaneously and knock out an entire wave of Horde forces."

"Randor is a fool," Skeletor began, "but I do not see much advantage to this. Temporarily, it might incapacitate those sides..."

"While Randor's skysleds are crashing to Eternia, our forces would remain active," Tri-Klops clarified. "While the Horde is falling to the pulse as well, your armies would be seen as the only protectors with any might to combat the inevitable next wave of soldiers."

"I could lead while Randor is exposed," Skeletor realized. "We wouldn't have to devote more time to trying to figure out how to sway most of Eternia to our side, we would be able to do it in one fell swoop. When did your arsenal come to include psychology?"

"It always has," Tri-Klops asserted. "But in trying to help Trap Jaw deal with his anger, I finally saw one of my blind spots. But I've always been a problem-solver."

"It's an excellent plan," Skeletor agreed. He shifted on his throne and asked, "Why now?"

"Two reasons," Tri-Klops admitted, swallowing louder than he wanted to. "The first is because right now, we're vulnerable to the same type attack. The robot army I've been building, in order to mass-produce it, I actually utilized some of Duncan's power supplies and distribution methods. I have a prototype that is ready to go, of entirely my own design and execution. If it was proven to be immune to the pulse weapon, I would put it into mass production."

"And the second reason," Skeletor prompted when Tri-Klops did not appear eager to continue.

"I would need to test it and the sooner we do that, the better off we are."

"That's not all," Skeletor surmised. "What is it?"

"Between my science and your and Lyn's magic, there is a chasm of information... one of the things our team lacks is a good understanding of medicine," Tri-Klops admitted uncomfortably. Somewhere behind him one of the magma vents began to bubble up. Tri-Klops felt a wave of heat from behind him and Skeletor's skull was suddenly more illuminated by the magmalight.

"And...?"

"And I'm not certain how long Trap Jaw has," Tri-Klops stated. "Obviously, I did what I could, but most of it involved fusing metal to bone and flesh and creating interfaces between biology and technology. It may have been a year, but his body was brutalized, his brain was damaged and the toxins in his blood and tissues are still... I'm not exactly sure how he has lived for this long.

"But if I can run a test on my pulse bomb, Trap Jaw has a chance to get revenge upon Duncan. Then, no matter how much time he has left, he'll have that."

"Your loyalty is commendable," Skeletor acknowledged. His hands grasped the bone arms on the throne as he considered the proposal. "So you want to attack the Royal Palace and set off your pulse bomb to see if it works on Duncan's technology?"

"Exactly. The test would prove that my bomb works and we could rely upon it. It would also prove that Trap Jaw's enhancements and my own are unaffected by it; the prototype as well."

"What do you need Lyn for?" Skeletor asked, suspicion once again creeping into his tone.

"To hide what we're really doing," Tri-Klops explained. "Duncan may have gotten where he is because of privilege, but he is... Duncan is very smart. If I design a weapon that incapacitates his technology and I deploy it and he figures that out, he might find a way to recalibrate his devices. I might not understand it all, but Lyn has an expertise with illusions that almost no one on Eternia

can see through. I need Lyn to accompany me to make it appear that the attack on the palace is a magical one.

"I need Lyn to appear to be leading our forces and to appear to unleash a spell that seems to incapacitate all of the electronic devices in the Royal Palace. If Duncan thinks the attack was magical and he witnesses it incapacitating both sides in the conflict, he's more likely to waste his time trying to find a solution that focuses on magic rather than technology. We'll appear hapless, he'll look in the wrong direction in trying to solve the problem and he will continue to make devices with the same vulnerabilities."

"Lyn ensures that everything appears as if it were a legitimate magic attack that we would never attempt to duplicate instead of the dry run for the technological attack," Skeletor concluded. He raised his right hand to his chin and scraped his nails over the bone there. For a moment, Tri-Klops wondered if Skeletor had any sense of feeling on his face. He had a brain in the skull, but the connection between his central nervous system and the rest of his body was unclear to Tri-Klops. "It's an excellent plan, Tri-Klops. If you can get her to go for it, you have my enthusiastic authorization."

"If?" Tri-Klops prompted.

"It takes a lot to get Lyn to go back to the Royal Palace, especially Duncan's laboratory," Skeletor admitted. "She might kill you even for asking... but if she doesn't and you survive, I'm most interested in how it works out."

Tri-Klops nodded slowly, calculating whether or not it was worth it to ask more of Skeletor. He decided it was not, so he bowed his head, thanked Skeletor and left the throne room.

"What could possibly make you think I would say 'yes' to your request?" Lyn asked, still shaking her head. Tri-Klops had never

been in Lyn's quarters before and he found himself somewhat unsettled seeing her without her cape or her helmet. At least in the heat of her quarters, Tri-Klops felt he understood her choice of minimal armor.

"To be fair, it was only after he endorsed the plan that Skeletor warned me you have an... aversion to going back to the Royal Palace," Tri-Klops admitted. "Given the fact that you have a specific issue with Duncan's workshop, perhaps you and Trap Jaw might both be motivated by revenge against him?"

"Don't try to psychoanalyze me, Tri-Klops," Lyn sneered, turning toward her stovetop and the kettle of water that was beginning to boil atop it. "Care for some tea?"

"Sure," Tri-Klops decided, figuring it might give him time to lay out his plan with Lyn.

"Take a seat," Lyn ordered as she found a clean cup for her guest. Tri-Klops nodded and sat at the small table in the small kitchen. The room was barely large enough for two adults to sit comfortably at the kitchen table near the stove. She waited until the cups were placed on the old wooden table between them and the boiling water was poured into the teapot before she spoke again.

"If Skeletor already authorized your plan, are you just here to sell me on it?" Lyn asked as she sat down opposite Tri-Klops.

"I was hoping you might see the merit in it," he elaborated. "More than anyone else here, you're open to reason. If we want to protect Eternia, the more lines of defense we have, the better. And if we can stick it to Duncan soon on top of defending our planet at some indeterminate point in the future, I thought it might appeal to you. Beyond that, I thought you might enjoy me coming to you from a humble place."

"That part is nice," she conceded.

"I can do my plan without you, but it plays the hand and when the Horde comes, it only buys us defense, not recruitment, if Duncan's equipment survives the pulse."

"I understand the idea and its implications," Lyn said in a dismissive tone. She inhaled the steam from the teapot, which encouraged Tri-Klops to breathe in through his nose. The tea smelled heavy on the cinnamon and cloves. Tri-Klops shifted uncomfortably on the smaller wooden chair upon which he sat; how had Lyn known the type of tea he liked? She noticed his frown and asked, "What?"

"How did you know my tea preference?" he asked.

"What makes you think I didn't just make a tea I like and we happen to have similar tastes?" Lyn replied without answering.

"Did you?"

Lyn shrugged. She said, "It's what was in the pot. Shortly after you arrived, I noticed your station in your workshop. I decided to try one of the teas you brought with you and it turned out I liked it."

"So, it's actually that you like the tea I like?" Tri-Klops asked with a wry tone. Lyn shrugged again. "I don't think of us having much in common."

"Skeletor's lieutenants come to serve, but we're generals," Lyn noted, pouring the hot tea into the cups. "It wouldn't be useful to have two of us with the same specialities, but having similar levels of intellect... I respect you, Tri-Klops."

"So, you'll help me execute my plan?" Tri-Klops asked.

"I didn't say that," Lyn replied. She picked up her teacup and even in the lower light of her quarters, Tri-Klops was taken by the contrast between the white of the porcelain and the jaundiced yellow of her flesh. Lyn's fingers wrapped around the cup and Tri-Klops assumed it was to help keep her fingers warm. He did not

need any scanning devices to know Lynn ran cold. Lyn noticed Tri-Klops staring.

"We do not have the resources to combat the Horde," Tri-Klops redirected, though his gaze remained on Lyn's blue-painted fingernails. "If they have truly destroyed galaxies, their fleet must be of a size and configuration that is truly immense. No single planet can survive them if they focus upon it. Our only advantages might well be that they need people alive to unlock the magical forces Eternia possesses."

"None of this is new information, Tri-Klops," Lyn noted, bringing her cup of tea to just below her nose and inhaling deeply.

"I know, but our chances of survival increase dramatically if we can continually wipe out their robot soldiers and their equipment," Tri-Klops noted. "And the only way for us to reliably do that is to have it in place before the Horde gets here. We can't be developing our defense on the fly."

"I do not disagree with you on that," Lyn said. She took a long, slow sip of her tea. In a much quieter voice, she asked, "Why does it have to be Duncan's workshop?"

"Because I know Duncan's past, but not his present," Tri-Klops admitted, silently impressed by the depth of Lyn's question. "The only way for me to be certain that Duncan has not started branching out on his power supply designs is to set off the pulse weapon somewhere that has both Duncan's established technology and his prototypes.

"Duncan's workshop is the only place that guarantees us access to his full range of creations. If there is anything that remains functional after the weapon is deployed, it's better we know about it now. Duncan is not stupid, but his reaction to Kronis and just the way he treated his prior apprentices... if this weapon works and he still has something he can use to attack us, he will.

"One way or another, we need to know what to expect, so I need to be able to deploy the pulse weapon and make sure it works against everything in his workshop. I gather you have... reservations."

Tri-Klops took a sip of his own tea to create a silent space for Lyn to respond in.

"Not so much to your mission or your plan," Lyn admitted quietly. "But I would rather not go back there. We don't know if we can even teleport directly into the Royal Palace any longer. After we rescued Kronis..."

"There's something more," Tri-Klops prompted.

Lyn nodded. After a moment, she revealed, "When we rescued Kronis, Skeletor and I were working fast and with a very clear purpose. Your plan would require me to... be still within those surroundings."

"The thing that happened to you," Tri-Klops tried to make his tone as delicate and compassionate as possible as he focused his gaze upon Lyn's yellowed fingers, "it happened in Duncan's workshop?"

"Ultimately, yes," Lyn said, without elaborating further. She swallowed, though she had not taken another sip of her tea.

"Is there any chance what... harmed you before would still be there?" Tri-Klops asked.

"No," Lyn admitted. "She's gone, but it would be unpleasant for me to spend much time at all there. And judging by the transmissions Kronis sent when he was Duncan's apprentice, we could not remain undetected in Duncan's laboratory for very long at all."

"We don't need to be undetected; we want an audience."

"What you want is more complicated than a simple illusion because you both want to witness reality around you and have anyone else in the room seeing something completely different. That is no small ask. And because the best illusions require concentration, the setting in this case matters quite a bit."

"I understand," Tri-Klops affirmed. He was pleased that Lyn did not choose to call him on that. He took another sip of the tea. For some reason, it tasted sweeter than it had initially.

"How much time do you need?" Lyn asked.

"I haven't finished the pulse device yet and the prototype power supply for the new model of combat droid needs a few more tweaks. I should be ready to go in three days."

"No," Lyn corrected, smiling behind her teacup. "I meant how much time do you need in Duncan's workshop?"

"That depends," Tri-Klops began. Lyn opened her mouth to ask for specifics, but Tri-Klops was prepared. He continued, "The first variable is the pulse weapon's charge time. If your teleportation spell is not affected by it being primed, we could bring it to full charge and teleport once it was armed."

"I do not see any reason why we could not do that," Lyn confirmed.

"And as long as your magic is unaffected by my pulse weapon, we'd only need to be there long enough for you to make it appear you were casting a spell, then I deploy the weapon and I scan for data after it is unleashed. One minute, then we should be able to teleport out; I'd have all the data I need."

"For that minute, you would need me to create the illusion that you, Trap Jaw and your prototype droid are all malfunctioning, while fending off any attacks from Duncan and any palace guards that respond to the alarms."

"Yes," Tri-Klops confirmed, draining his cup of tea. "And we'd need to be absolutely certain your magic was not affecting any of my readings. The scanners need to work."

"None of this is outside my abilities," Lyn asserted.

"So long as you're able to keep it together there," Tri-Klops reiterated. "The fate of Eternia rests on the effectiveness of this device. My planetary shield is not ready yet and even if you figure out a way to hide Eternia, gravity might still reveal its existence to Horde scanners. Skeletor's inability to provide us with key details makes this our best, most immediate hope. We could be a week away from our first true planetary defense. And all we need to be sure outside my engineering talent is for you to have the fortitude to remain focused in Duncan's workshop."

"When you put it in those terms," Lyn remarked wryly, "how can I refuse?"

Tri-Klops smiled at her and her resolved tone. He did not need to use any of his enhanced visions, however, to notice the flicker of uncertainty and fear flash through her eyes.

Not knowing what he could say or even whether he should acknowledge his observation, Tri-Klops opted to thank Lyn for her hospitality and left to return to his own workshop.

They assembled in the launch bay three days later. Snake Mountain's hangar bay featured a massive blast door that opened out high above the lava fields. Tri-Klops had sealed off the cavern and installed both the blast doors and a level floor as one of his first acts as Skeletor's Man-At-Arms. Since then, he used the bay as a workshop for his vehicular projects. The launch portion of the bay held a squadron of a dozen War-Sleds which Tri-Klops realized he would have to retrofit if this experiment was successful. The War-Sleds caught his eye as he entered the bay

as lightning from outside periodically illuminated the end of the launch bay.

In the hangar portion of the bay, Tri-Klops led his team past the new troop carrier he was working on, tentatively called a roton on his way toward Lyn. Tri-Klops could not recall Lyn ever being present in the hangar bay and he felt a momentary sense of territoriality seeing her at the far end, near the open launch bay doors. As Tri-Klops, Trap Jaw and the two robot soldiers approached the far end of the massive chamber, the scent of sulfur filled Tri-Klops's nostrils. Despite the darkness outside, the air became hotter and drier as Tri-Klops moved through the room.

Lyn wore her usual brown cloak, the same one she had worn when she had approached Tri-Klops years earlier. Her blue cape peeked out the back of the cloak and with the hood down, Tri-Klops could see Lyn's bone-encircled helmet as she faced the black sky beyond Snake Mountain. As they neared, Lyn either heard their footsteps over the thunder and eruptions on the rocky plains beyond or sensed one of the two men approaching. Either way, she turned to look at the men and robots approaching her. Tri-Klops was unsurprised to see she was wearing her usual blue leather armor. He noticed, however, that it seemed cleaner than usual and he wondered for the first time what Lyn wore while cleaning the one outfit she seemed to own.

"If this works," Lyn began as soon as they were in earshot, waving at the empty space around and behind them, "we will need this bay filled."

"When it works," Tri-Klops corrected, tone confident. "Skeletor and I have discussed it. The next challenge is raw materials. We need miners."

"Perhaps we will have to make a treaty with the Widgets," Lyn suggested, her lips turning into a smirk. She looked to Tri-Klops's right and her expression softened. "Hello Trap Jaw."

"Hello, Lyn," he replied. If Lyn found his gruff timbre off-putting, she did not show it, but to Tri-Klops's ear, it sounded like Trap Jaw was grumbling.

"Did you need the blast doors open to facilitate your teleport spell?" Tri-Klops asked, nearing the end of the launch bay.

"No," Lyn said in a quieter voice, turning to look back out at the lava fields and black clouds of soot. "I wanted some fresh air and momentarily forgot... and by that point, the doors were already opening. You really should have an emergency stop for them."

"I'll put that into the next program," Tri-Klops said, stopping next to her on the edge of the launch bay. He detected movement several miles away, across the rocky, fiery plains and effortlessly focused his Distavision. It was a cloud of Lava Bats hunting something from one of the recent plumes of lava from the volcano nearest the colony. While still focused on the bats, he leaned his head toward his shoulder and Lyn and in a quieter voice asked, "Are you ready for this?"

"I am," she asserted. "Five of us?"

"Four for the return trip, assuming this works," Tri-Klops confirmed.

Lyn glanced over her shoulder, past Trap Jaw and saw the two robotic soldiers. She asked, "Which of them is being left behind?"

"The one not holding the device," Tri-Klops noted. "We'll leave it for Duncan to dissect; it will throw him off because the power system is based on the same cells he uses. If you want, there's no reason for anyone to even see our new generation model."

"Let's do this then," Lyn resolved, turning away from the outside and toward the small team. Tri-Klops stepped away from the open door and approached Trap Jaw. The younger man took a step back, in effect allowing all five members of the team to look at one another. Tri-Klops reached out with his right hand and gently squeezed Trap Jaw's left shoulder. Lyn arched an eyebrow,

observing the interaction. The two robot soldiers remained inscrutable.

"Go ahead and charge up your pulse cannon," Tri-Klops ordered Trap Jaw. He reached for the handheld scanner on his belt even as he stepped toward the robot soldier holding the spherical device he had built. While his right hand detached the scanner from his belt, his left touched a control on the pulse weapon. The device hummed to life, though there was no external change save a small light next to the button Tri-Klops had pressed that lit up. He stepped back from the robot as he began to scan Trap Jaw and the device.

"When the blue light activates, the device is armed," Tri-Klops noted.

"Why are you telling me?" Trap Jaw asked.

"In case something goes wrong with the portal," Tri-Klops replied with a faint smile.

"You'll want to press it when I say 'levectus,'" Lyn stated. She frowned even as she raised her wand. "Are your soldiers outfitted with any special optical sensors?"

"The usual," Tri-Klops responded, not entirely focusing on her question. He was watching the power curve on the pulse weapon and the readout on the scanner that was showing a minor fluctuation in the stopping fuse on Trap Jaw's arm cannon. In a somewhat bored tone, he elaborated, "In addition to the full visual spectrum, they have Distavision, Nightvision, infrared, and limited ultraviolet detection. They're robots, so it's less sight than it is analysis, but their programming is solid."

"That's what I'm concerned about," Lyn began with a frown as the idea became concrete in her mind.

Tri-Klops guessed what she was worried about, "They process your illusions as distortions in the visible spectrum. They literally see through them."

"How so?" she asked, lowering her arm. Tri-Klops had a habit of giving her longer explanations and a cramp in her wandbearing arm was not ideal for the coming task.

"When you cast an illusion directly on a person, they are more susceptible to your deceptions," Tri-Klops noted. "If you made Trap Jaw appear to be Duncan, they would see that image superimposed upon him. It would be enough to fool their targeting sensors and they would focus on him as the intended target.

"But for independent illusions, they would register as an anomalous visual distortion lacking in any substance. If you were to create the illusion that you were standing over there, they would see it where you projected it, but without any additional data. The best analogy I have for you is that wherever you cast the image, it would be visible to them like an image projected onto a pane of glass at that location. They would see the image there, but it would register as just an image, and they would still see through or beyond it."

"That might complicate things," Lyn admitted. "My plan had been to conceal your prototypes and create illusory duplicates of you and Trap Jaw. Your first generation soldier cannot interact with the two of you and must interact with the illusory duplicates."

"You're overthinking," Tri-Klops insisted. The readings on Trap Jaw's arm leveled and the charging curve on the pulse device continued along the predicted parameters. "Once the pulse goes off, all of Duncan's monitoring devices will be disabled and so will our friend here. We'll put him at the forefront and have him charge while you do your chanting. That way, even if Duncan ever cracks its programming to view the visual records, it won't reveal any of the visual anomalies from our magical duplicates. Which reminds me..."

Tri-Klops walked to the robot soldier he was planning to sacrifice and plugged a cord from the scanner he held into a port

on the back of the robot's head. The readout on the scanner changed to offer him access to the robot's controls.

"That could work for me," Lyn conceded. "It will only take me about twenty seconds to complete the actual spell once we arrive in the workshop. Probably closer to ten..."

"Then if everyone wants to get into position," Tri-Klops suggested. "Where will you be opening the portal?"

Lyn motioned to her right. Tri-Klops programmed the soldier he was connected to to walk to that spot, then activated a basic attack protocol, before wiping the robot's memory core and data storage. He disconnected the handheld scanner and nodded to his other soldier, which dutifully brought him the pulse weapon. Tri-Klops nodded to Lyn.

"Huh?!" Trap Jaw reacted as the soldier and weapon disappeared. Tri-Klops, of course, could still see it and he confirmed that the illusion Lyn had created was not affecting his scanner's readouts. The weapon was charged and he could see the blue light indicating that fact, even if no one else around him could.

"Let's go," Tri-Klops ordered.

Lyn nodded and waved her wand at a point before herself and the disposable soldier. A distortion formed in front of her, filled with light. She smiled and leapt through with the soldier. Trap Jaw and Tri-Klops followed a moment later, with Skeletor's Man-At-Arms confirming that the final soldier was directly behind him.

Compared to the hangar deck of Snake Mountain, Duncan's workshop was brightly lit and somewhat cool. The first impression Tri-Klops had upon stepping into it was that it was incredibly loud. Unlike the thunder in the distance from the Dark Hemisphere outside Snake Mountain, the alarms going off in Duncan's workshop were shrill and immediate. Lyn's portal had brought the quintet into the center of the workspace, an aisle

between rows of workbenches which became more visible as Tri-Klops's sight adjusted to the room's brightness. Most of the workbenches were covered in clutter; electronic devices in various states of production, weapons with hilts hollowed out and unprepared, mid-modification.

Predictably, the robot soldier before Tri-Klops reacted to the teleportation first. Unhindered by human frailties, it lurched into motion, raising its right arm as it did so. As Tri-Klops heard Lyn's voice beginning her chant, he also heard the whine of the robot soldier's blaster pistol discharge. Tri-Klops looked ahead to where the charged energy would hit and he saw one of Duncan's apprentices at a nearby table. He was in the act of looking up just as the discharge hit him full in the chest, blasting him back, burning through his apron, skin and bones.

In his peripheral vision, Tri-Klops noticed Trap Jaw's left hand spasming open. Tri-Klops had not yet had an opportunity to fully scan the room but Trap Jaw's movement and something in Lyn's tone of voice immediately unsettled the man-at-arms. Lyn's voice sounded confused and unsure in a way Tri-Klops had never heard from her before, but he decided to focus on Trap Jaw. Even as his left hand flapped out from his waist, Trap Jaw began to raise his right arm. Tri-Klops looked at his young friend and gazed before him. He instantly saw what Trap Jaw was focused upon.

At the far end of the room, perhaps only ten meters away, stood Duncan. Duncan was at his primary bench, turning toward the intruders, a look of horror on his face. To the right of Duncan, Tri-Klops could see something floating; in the visual spectrum, it was maroon and comparatively small. It appeared to be a robed creature in a pointed hat, hovering above and to the right of Duncan's primary workbench. Outside the visual spectrum, Tri-Klops saw both a glow and a rapidly shifting field, like atoms exploding forth and a universe collapsing all at once. Tri-Klops blinked and returned his focus to Trap Jaw and Duncan.

Duncan's eyes were coming to the point where he was able to register Trap Jaw as he turned. Some distant corner of Tri-Klops's

mind registered that Duncan's gaze had passed over him, not even registering him as a threat or a person. But as Duncan's eyes fell upon the massive frame of Trap Jaw, his eyes widened. Tri-Klops was uncertain in that moment if Duncan recognized his former apprentice or if he simply saw Trap Jaw's incredibly wide shoulders, bare and muscular. Duncan could certainly see the thick metal plating on Trap Jaw's right side and the arm that was being lifted in his direction. Within milliseconds, Duncan's face was a mask of fear, even as he continued to turn his body and shift his attention. His lips were moving, but Tri-Klops could not hear him over the room's alarms, Lyn's sedate drone, the electric clash as the robot's weapon discharge broke the sound barrier, the crash of the Eternian's body hitting equipment as it flew backward.

Tri-Klops could see that Trap Jaw was focused on Duncan and his arm cannon was almost raised to where it would certainly hit Randor's Man-At-Arms. But Duncan continued to turn and he was raising a hand, empty in the direction of one of the benches before him. Knowing how limited the time was, Tri-Klops stole only the most momentary glance where Duncan was looking. Before him in his eyeline there was a teenage girl sliding underneath one of the workbenches. Her long, chestnut colored hair flowed behind her as she slid, bisecting even as Tri-Klops observed her. Trap Jaw's cannon blast burned through her hair as she slid out of its path on the discharge's way toward Duncan.

Tri-Klops turned to the invisible soldier behind him even as he heard Lyn's voice above the cacophony say, "Levectus." As Tri-Klops stabbed his finger out, he saw the visual distortion near him of Lyn's magical illusion of himself. No one saw Tri-Klops poke at nothing activating the pulse weapon. There was a flash in one of the upper spectrums and the room went dark. Tri-Klops, of course, could still see and he immediately reached for his scanner to get the critical readings.

In the absence of the alarms, Duncan's scream could be heard even before the bolt from Trap Jaw's arm cannon struck him in the chest. Though the overhead lights darkened, the sparks from

the explosion of energy hitting Duncan's chest armor illuminated that portion of the room. A second discharge from the weapon fired from the rapidly-depowering robot soldier was lighting up another spot.

As Tri-Klops began the scans, he heard all Subternia breaking loose behind him and he struggled to focus. He heard the crash of the depowered robot soldier succumbing to inertia and its unpowered shell colliding with a workbench indelicately. Duncan's body smashed against a monitor screen and the capacitors within released an electric discharge somewhere in Tri-Klops's peripheral vision. There were two chiming sounds, accompanied by golden flashes.

Tri-Klops found himself distracted from reading the numbers on the screen by the sound of his own voice coming from behind him, calling Lyn a fool and claiming to be blind. But as he took in the numbers from the screen indicating blast radii and power curves of the hidden devices still active, Tri-Klops heard dueling noises from Trap Jaw and his illusory counterpart. The illusion of Trap Jaw was firing his cannon wildly, the sounds indicating successively less-powerful discharges. As Tri-Klops scanned the robot soldier before him and felt an overt pride at the success of both his power dampening weapon and this robot's resistance to it, he acknowledged a respect for Lyn's thoroughness in creating an illusion so sophisticated.

But as Tri-Klops turned to perform scans on the actual Trap Jaw he felt a flash of concern. While Lyn had smartly made the illusion of Trap Jaw appear powerless - including in the jaw servos, effectively giving his illusion lockjaw and a horrified expression to match the condition - the actual Trap Jaw was charging forward. Tri-Klops could hear the roar in his ears coming from his friend. He looked toward Trap Jaw and saw a distortion around him. Without glancing at his scanner, he looked to Lyn.

Fortunately, Lyn was looking in his direction and she seemed to have the same concern. Tri-Klops shrugged.

"Fool!" Lyn yelled as the quartet materialized in the hangar bay of Snake Mountain. Lyn removed her helmet and let it fall to the floor as she shook her head in frustration.

Trap Jaw fell silent before he stopped moving, though his roar echoed in Tri-Klops's ears.

"No!" Trap Jaw shouted, turning back to the sorceress.

"What in Subternia is wrong with you?!" she demanded in frustration. A blast of hot air blew in from the darkness outside.

"He's not dead yet!" Trap Jaw screamed. "Send me back!"

"That wasn't the mission!" Lyn hissed. "Stand down."

"Both of you, stand down!" Tri-Klops ordered. He frowned as he glanced at the scanner in his hand. He looked from it to Trap Jaw. "Take the soldier back down to the laboratory. Please."

Trap Jaw inhaled deeply over and over, then nodded and left the chamber without another word. He motioned his left hand at the robot soldier, which turned efficiently on its heel and followed the reconstructed man. When they were out of earshot, Tri-Klops turned back to Lyn.

"You did well," he stated. Her eyes flashed anger and he felt secure that she had no cause to be angry with him. "It seemed like you anticipated Trap Jaw's reaction to seeing Duncan again... so what is it?"

"Did you get the scans you needed?" Lyn deflected.

"Lyn, what is going on?"

Lyn shook her head, then turned toward the open space looking out on the magma plains beyond. Tri-Klops walked toward her. Even as she turned away, he could see her expression of fear and concern. He stopped trying to look at her and she visibly relaxed.

"I got all the readings," Tri-Klops redirected. "I didn't have a chance to study them in the field, but I believe I captured all of the essential information. Your reaction had nothing to do with what happened there a decade ago, did it?"

Lyn shook her head, though Tri-Klops could see tears in her eyes.

"Now, not then," Lyn admitted. "I can compartmentalize when I need to."

"Thank you for doing that," Tri-Klops said. He resisted the urge to reach out to Lyn. He had no idea how she might respond to contact like that. He realized in the time he had known her they had never, to the best of his recollection, touched.

"I believed in the importance of your mission," Lyn reiterated, sniffling back a tear and turning away from Tri-Klops. "I am... gratified it was successful."

"So it appears," he declared, looking out into the wilderness. The colony of bats was still hunting. Of course it was; they had not been gone long at all. "I'll finish the shield, pair the emitters with these devices, we'll plant the pulse weapons around Eternia... we'll find a way to win when the Horde gets here.

"But I have to ask you; do you know what that was?"

Lyn flinched.

"What?" she bluffed.

"The thing that teleported the girl away," Tri-Klops prompted.

Lyn turned to face Tri-Klops, looking him square in his eye. Even so, the man-at-arms could see tears on her cheeks.

"What did you see?" she demanded.

Tri-Klops was surprised by the urgency in her tone, but quickly calculated the risks of sharing what little he could. He opened his mouth, then realized he had no idea how to describe what he saw.

"There seemed to be an entity there... small, floating, obscured by its costume," he answered as best he could.

"Seemed?" Lyn prompted.

"What did you see?" Tri-Klops asked.

"I didn't," Lyn admitted. "I noticed the girl first. I... I was unprepared for her being there."

"You know her?"

"Duncan's daughter," Lyn confirmed. She knelt down to retrieve her discarded helmet. Before she picked it up, she used the back of her hand to wipe her tears away. "But I felt the other thing. Whatever it was, it was powerful... on an order to which I cannot speak."

"I don't know what that means," Tri-Klops admitted as Lyn stood back up.

She looked him directly in the eye and her tone was firm.

"I have stood in the presence of a community of dragons and I have gone toe to toe with one of the most powerful magic users the Horde has in its ranks," she declared. "I know you like to quantify things for your... science. If I am ten and Skeletor eleven, before now the most I have sensed was twenty-five, at best. That thing... on the same scale... would be in the thousands."

"You can't be serious," Tri-Klops contradicted, though his voice barely rose above a shocked whisper.

"I am," Lyn said and Tri-Klops believed her completely.

"It was like nothing I have ever seen, though it did appear magical in nature. Outside the visual spectrum, it seemed to defy many describable properties. The best I have is that it seemed like both a wellspring and a sink; a fountain of power and all of it collapsing in on itself at once. Does that make any sense?"

"No," Lyn replied with a faint smile on her lips. "But it reassures me that what I felt in the encounter was real. I will talk to Skeletor about this."

"I have to debrief him on this mission," Tri-Klops stated. "Did you want to come?"

"I'll discuss it with him later," Lyn decided. "I should get back..."

"I understand," Tri-Klops said. "Sorry about Trap Jaw..."

Lyn shrugged. She noted, "As you said, I anticipated some of his response. The illusion of his cannon going off... I figured that would cover us in a worst-case scenario. I planned for that."

"But the other thing," Tri-Klops led as he touched the control to close the blast doors.

Lyn swallowed heavily.

"Nothing could have prepared us for that. Whatever that was, it represents a level of power none of us have ever known. That makes it either an incredible tool for our salvation or the greatest potential for our destruction."

"It would require further study," Tri-Klops concluded as the blast doors sealed shut like a massive, tuneless gong. "I suspect if it turns out to be either, you and I will be working closely again in the future."

Lyn snorted as she began walking toward the hangar portion of the bay and the rest of Snake Mountain beyond.

"That was always going to be the case," she remarked.

"I suppose it was," Tri-Klops agreed as he followed at his own pace.

The Loneliest Child On Eternia

Lyn's teleportation spell brought her to the closed door to her quarters. Of course she could have focused the spell to bring her all the way back inside her home, but she did not want to surprise the other occupant. She had gotten into the habit of arriving outside the house as a way to show respect to the young man within.

Since the return of her abilities, Lyn had been doing every mundane task utilizing her magic; Kothos be damned! Damn him for robbing her of her magical powers, even temporarily. She had made sure Kothos got what was coming to him, though.

And now, Lyn felt some fatigue, which she recognized by the resistance from the door as she opened it.

He was sitting at their table, eating cereal. Lyn had no idea what time of day it was or if he had been on his own mission while she had been gone for the days and nights prior. It was not uncommon, she knew, for him to simply eat cereal when she was not around. She felt a strange amount of relief seeing him with the bowl; she was not in the mood to cook, nor in the mood to try to encourage him to cook for her. Their eyes met as Lyn removed her helmet.

"Skeletor is looking for you," he said.

"I'm sure he was," Lyn noted archly. "I found him. He was suitably displeased with me."

Lyn stepped fully into their main room, which served as both kitchen and dining room. There were two other doors out of this particular chamber of Snake Mountain, one to each of their respective quarters. As Lyn set her helmet on the dining room table, her charge noticed the helmet and her hand. His eyes widened.

"What happened to you?" he asked, not even attempting to hide the surprise in his tone.

"Skeletor sent me to recover the Fountain Of Life," Lyn noted. "I was unsuccessful, but I managed to get a canteen of water from the Fountain. It has... rejuvenated me."

"I didn't know that was possible," he remarked, taking a slow bite of cereal. "This might take some getting used to."

"I've been jaundiced for so long, I had no idea the effect would be so complete... or so quick. Regardless, I had no idea it was possible to restore myself either. Ironically, I only took a small sip because my throat was so parched. I'd been out in the desert with Teela and the night on the Sands Of Time went on for a long, long time. My throat hurt from telling her stories."

Lyn reached out and gently stroked down the length of the young man's nose from between his eyes to the tip. He smiled slightly. Lyn walked around the small table and sat down behind where she had set her helmet.

"I'm finally ready to tell you the story," Lyn said quietly.

"Are you?" he asked.

"Telling Teela all about my early escapades and meeting the man who became Skeletor, talking to her about my best friend, Gwen... I feel it's selfish to not give you the one answer you've wanted most. I can't spend a time-distorted night telling my adversary my life story without telling the only person alive whom I love the story they most want to hear."

"Now?" he asked.

"If you're up for it, sure," Lyn decided.

He picked up his bowl with his right hand and drained its contents into his mouth. As he set it back onto the table, a little less

carefully than he might have intended - a sign to Lyn that he was enthusiastic - he smiled at Lyn.

"I sure am!"

"Then make yourself comfortable, because this is the most important story I could tell..."

The Alazim had just been wiped out and Gwen, Count Treeno, and I were desperate and broken. I've never mentioned Treeno to you because he was with Gwen and I for such a short time. Count Treeno had encountered Shadow Weaver, a powerful Horde sorceress who had been trapped on Eternia by Gwen and I years prior, only days before we met him. It was Count Treeno who had revealed to Shadow Weaver the existence of the Alazim and he had accompanied Gwen and I to stop Shadow Weaver from using the power of the Alazim to her benefit. We were, alas, too late.

Count Treeno was a buffoon, but he was an expert on the Alazim, a race of Eternians with the ability to teleport anywhere. Treeno understood their culture and their biology, as well as their magic. He had been duped by Shadow Weaver and when Gewn and I found him, he transformed Gwen and I into giants before he had a heart attack and died. I know, that seems like a ridiculous storytelling conceit, but to understand the story that follows, you have to begin with the idea that Gwen and I had been fighting a losing war against a single, powerful, invader for over two years at this point and we were six meters tall. Treeno had informed us that the only thing the Alazim respected more than raw magical power was physical imposition without threat. The Alazim, apparently, had once been dominated by a tall race of crystalline entities, which left them with a cultural bias. We needed every advantage to negotiate with the Alazim, so Gwen and I allowed Treeno to cast a very specific growth spell upon us which made us - and the clothes and objects on our persons at the time - to transform proportionate to our body. Treeno, however, suffered a massive heart attack shortly after beginning the spell and by the

time Gwen and I were six meters tall - enough to make the Alazim look up to us - he was dead.

It didn't even occur to me to go back for Treeno's body until much, much later; that's how insignificant he was in our attempt to stop Shadow Weaver. But what is important here is that Gwen and I were six meters tall and not used to our bodies. The attempts to save Treeno when he fell... made the problems his body was experiencing worse. Much worse.

With Treeno dead, Gwen and I teleported ourselves under Zagraz Mountain to make an attempt to negotiate with the Alazim and stop Shadow Weaver from exploiting them or their power. The Alazim were masters of teleportation, which came to them as easily as blinking comes to us. Their home under Zagraz Mountain was a massive open chamber under the mountain, like a domed amphitheater, where the citizens could look down into the central stage. Instead of seats surrounding the chamber, there were ledges, each of which led into the private quarters of each Alazim. Almost every Alazim I had ever known of spent more time on their personal ledge, rather than in their quarters. The Alazim were an exceptionally social race.

Gwen and I teleported into the center of the community, where all of the Alazim would be able to see us and our imposing height would not cause us harm. After all, it wouldn't do for us to appear under Zagraz Mountain only to impale ourselves on stalactites - which were still a hundred meters above us - or into one of the ledges on the outskirts of the arena, which was a much more realistic concern.

We were there for the end of the Alazim. When we arrived, the chamber was surprisingly bright, filled with a purple pink glow from all around. Gwen and I turned around, looking at the outer rings of ledges to see where so much light was coming from. It was the passages from each ledge to its accompanying personal quarters; the giant chamber that housed the Alazim civilization had been sealed off by a glowing purple-pink crystal that was very obviously magic in nature. The Alazim's teleportation was only

inhibited by the Alazim being trapped in a crystal container and Shadow Weaver had essentially made their entire community under Zagraz Mountain into a single containment vessel for their people.

I sometimes imagine the horror of the Alazim people; I only know of a single one who survived and only recently learned of the existence of Chimera as a vassal for Count Marzo. But at that moment, as my eyes and Gwen's adjusted to the setting in which we found ourselves, we witnessed what we believed to be the end of the Alazim civilization.

Shadow Weaver looked deceptively small to us, standing or hovering just off the ground near where we arrived. Gwen and I looked down upon her; she was essentially a bright red rippling cloak that was wreathed in a light blue ethereal mist that swirled independent of her and the fluttering of her robes. Her hand was a sickly blue-green flesh that looked like something rotted and drowned. Shadow Weaver's hand ended in sharp nails that were sinking into the throat of the last of the Alazim. Even as Gwen and I perceived the last of the ancient magical teleporters, we would see the arcs of magical energy transforming and transferring the Alazim's power and ability between the entities. The Alazim were a tall, muscular race, but Shadow Weaver's power vampirism was fast and brutal and somehow this barely material creature from beyond the stars was holding up the last Alazim by its neck.

The last of the Alazim was a desiccated husk within seconds, the last gurgling cry that came from its mouth only registering in our ears as it ended. Shadow Weaver dropped the husk to the rock floor of the community of the Alazim and it was only then that I recognized that the dust that coated the rocky ground was undoubtedly the remainder of the Alazim. To my horror, I realized that the vast majority of the dust was still in the act of falling to the ground. Shadow Weaver was moving with exceptional speed and her ability to entrap and wipe out the entire Alazim race had occurred within minutes. If Gwen and I had just been a few minutes faster...

Shadow Weaver cackled, perceiving us for the first time since our entrance. As her laughter died and her speech began, she began to slow, an effect made more obvious by her finger and hand movements as she returned her arm to well within the confines of her layers of flowing robes.

"Well, if it isn't my two favorite Eternians," Shadow Weaver taunted. "And you've done something lovely with your bodies... whatever for? Oh... you were here to negotiate with these creatures, weren't you? You came to prevent them from giving me their powers or helping me in any way. Foolish girls, you're just that far behind. I am so close now to being able to rejoin the Horde!"

This seems like a good time for me to tell you about Gwen. I've mentioned her before, I know. But I've never told you just how important she was to me and how significant our relationship was. The truth is, I don't know how much she knew about how much I loved her, but telling Teela about her last night, I figured you deserved to know that truth so much more. I owe it to you to tell you about this amazing woman.

Gwen was the smartest, funniest, most clever person I ever met. She and I met when we were both six years old and she was living with her mother in the Royal Library Of Eternos. We grew up together and if I hadn't had a head start on her with magical training, she would easily have eclipsed me with her abilities. Gwen was intelligent and articulate and curious about the world around her.

And she liked me. I had never met anyone who seemed to care about me or was interested in what was going on with my life, but even as a little girl in the library, Gwen cared about me. Gwen asked about me and my life and my interests and we shared everything.

We grew from little girls into women. Gwen transformed over the years from a cute little know-it-all with book learning to this redheaded knockout who was just absolutely brilliant and

sophisticated. If she had not chosen to live with me on the fringe of Eternia, scouring ruins and libraries for obscure magical texts, she could have fit in with the aristocracy of Eternos with her intelligence and beauty. But she chose magic and she chose me. So, every day after she was done with school - for as long as she went to school - I was graced with her presence, her mind, and her stunning form.

Gwen is only going to feature prominently in the history books of Eternia if I am successful, if Skeletor succeeds in saving this world. Skeletor owes his life to Gwen, as do I many times over, and Eternia is here today because of Gwen. But outside Duncan and I, Gwen might only be recalled as some young beauty that once turned the head of men and women who saw her back in the day. Like me, she was a recluse, so most people only saw her as a fleeting glimpse of pale skin broken by freckles and long, red hair that shone in any lighting. The truth, however, is that Gwen was an incredible woman who I think about every day.

So, in that moment, when Gwen looked at me and I looked at her, it is important to know that the years of proximity, of intimacy, allowed us to communicate without words.

"We need to get help," Gwen's eyes screamed at me.

I was feeling much more impulsive, though. I could not see a better opportunity than right then because I knew whenever I experienced a magical growth, there were usually moments that it took for me to fully understand and acclimate to them. So I know my look was saying, "Strike now," and Gwen understood that.

I leapt forward toward Shadow Weaver, swinging my wand like a mace as I moved. I was speaking the words to a containment spell without even thinking about it. In my peripheral vision, Gwen moved with her staff, the crystal atop it glowing green. She was performing a transmutation spell.

Neither of our magics worked, however, as we collided with an impenetrable sphere of power surrounding Shadow Weaver. The

exact nature of her protection spell stopped our forward momentum, but was not enough to push us back. My wand hit the barrier and it became visible. A green fog of Gwen's transmutation spell surrounded the shielded Shadow Weaver, but it did not penetrate.

Gwen looked at me in horror. I know my expression was one of fear and remorse. Those seconds lost would come back and bite us in the ass, but I did not know that then. My mind raced to reconcile the abilities Shadow Weaver possessed now with everything else I knew.

Shadow Weaver, however, was in the mood to taunt us. She noted, "So close, children. Your spirit almost makes me wish the universe could reflect such delicious chaos."

"It can," Gwen growled as she stepped back and hunched down slightly. "The universe is free without the Horde. It can be like this, it can be like us."

"My poor naive girl," Shadow Weaver cooed as the fog around her shield began to dissipate. "Everything in this universe seeks to order the inherent powers that exist in nature. Your magic, the Horde's weaponry and mind, it is all entropy moving toward order and stability. Do you not understand the size of a galaxy, my pets?!

"The Horde has brought order to entire galaxies. That amount of power is a momentum you can never catch up to. Join us instead of continuing this futile fight. You can help me and the Horde finish our work in this universe if you simply join us."

"No," I said. I was looking at Shadow Weaver and her rippling robes, but I am certain I heard Gwen mirror my sentiment at the exact same time and with the same force.

"Then stay on this wretched planet until I bring the full might of the Horde to bear upon it," Shadow Weaver threatened.

It was Gwen, even before Shadow Weaver, who seemed to sense it first. As I opened my mouth to speak, Gwen flicked a magical speck of dust at me to get my attention.

"We will..." I felt what Gwen had done and looked in her direction, cutting myself off.

Gwen gave me a significant look. I know how stupid that sounds, but when you've grown up with someone and know them so intimately, you can look at them and all they have to do to communicate with you is tilt their head slightly and widen their eyes and it is enough. It is significant.

Gwen's look was telling me, "Stop" and "feel that?" I reluctantly complied. My mind was racing for any possible way to stop Shadow Weaver. With the power of the Alazim, she could easily teleport herself off Eternia now. It seemed possible that she could even teleport the Eternian fleet to our planet, so the idea that she had to be stopped consumed me. But there was Gwen telling me without words that there was something else going on. So I stopped.

And I felt it.

Something powerful, far outside Zagraz Mountain, had suddenly manifested. I could feel a magical energy coalescing somewhere far away, but with such distinct power that I could sense it even there. Being magically-attuned, there was an electricity at the back of my head that sensed these things when they were so impressive. It took me a moment to even feel it because Shadow Weaver's presence was such an overwhelming and impressive magical force.

But there it was and we could feel it. I nodded to Gwen even as I cast a disorientation spell in Shadow Weaver's direction. I did not have much hope that it would land, but it was all I had that I could think of to do as Gwen opened a portal for us. I stepped through Gwen's portal uncertain where we would land or how fast Shadow Weaver might follow.

I immediately felt pain in my head and disorientation. The portal had brought us somewhere with lower ceilings - for we were suddenly indoors - and my forehead hit a chandelier even as my torso ran into Gwen before me. My eyes adjusted to the lighting and the surroundings were immediately familiar from the pink walls; we were in the Royal Palace in Eternos.

"What?!" Duncan's voice came from my left as my senses clarified.

Gwen had opened a portal into the Royal Palace, though our exact location within the palace was unclear to me. The portal she had manifested had clearly conformed to the size of our bodies. I rubbed my head with my left hand, after remembering to slide the handle of my wand into the loop on my belt, while my right reached up to stop the chandelier from striking my forehead again. I stepped slightly to the left of the hanging light to get my bearings.

Duncan cowered below me, even as he reached for the mace on his own belt. We were in a hallway in the Royal Palace, one of the ones with an arched ceiling. We had entered the hallway only meters from a closed door. Duncan had clearly not expected anyone in the hallway, much less so close to that door. He was wearing the armor of the royal guards, though he was not outfitted with a helmet. His bare face - he did not have the mustaches at that time - was frozen in an expression the embodiment of shock and horror. His eyes blinked from me to Gwen. He whispered her name.

"Duncan," Gwen acknowledged. Her voice seemed loud in the confines of the hallway.

"What in Subternia is going on?!" Duncan demanded. I could hear the energy function of his mace powering up as he activated the weapon's enhancements and took a defensive stance.

I released the chandelier as I moved around it. My tone was, admittedly, antagonistic given that we were hoping desperately for Duncan's aid. I growled, "Have you ever heard of the Alazim?"

"No," Duncan spat the word out as if angry at his own ignorance. He was probably reacting to my frustrated and combative tone.

"You won't now," I noted.

“This isn't productive," Gwen snapped. She focused on Duncan. "We are moments ahead of a horror you do not understand. We, all of Eternia, need your help. We are, all of us, in great danger, Duncan."

"We can't be here right now," Duncan insisted, not lowering his mace or changing his stance. He shook his head, as if to refocus, and asked, "Can you make yourself normal size?"

"It's not our spell," Gwen admitted. "We don't have the time to focus on that and figure out what is going on here."

Duncan frowned. "It'll be tight then," he declared. He touched a control on his wrist, activating a communication device. "Relief rotation to position A-3, immediately."

As soon as he severed the connection, he returned his mace to his belt - without powering it down, I noticed - and turned to the wall behind him. Attached to the wall was what appeared to be a standard lighting unit - one of the artificial torches that had replaced the classic lighting I had grown up seeing around the Royal Palace following Queen Marlena's arrival. Duncan reached up and pressed the decorative screw that fastened the unit to the wall. On this particular torch, that fastener was actually a button and it activated a concealed door on the wall behind Duncan. Duncan nodded in the direction of the secret passageway he had exposed. It was dark and looked very small.

"Duncan..." Gwen began.

"You'll fit," Duncan postulated, still eying me with suspicion. "It'll be tight, but this is the most direct route to my workshop. Go feet-first and slide; don't try to walk down the stairs."

We could hear the footfalls of the relief guards rushing toward the hallway. Gwen took the leap and whatever we might have hoped for in terms of keeping our presence in the Royal Palace clandestine was lost by the sound of her staff and every solid enhancement to her armor and cloak scraping the stone walls of the secret passage. I winced at the sound, twisted my fingers to utilize a quick silencing spell which eliminated the ambient noises of Gwen's abrupt descent and would prevent mine as well, then passed by Duncan.

"If this is a trick, you evil witch..."

"Charming as always," I quipped before leaping into the darkness. Duncan frowned, but followed immediately, sealing the passage as he passed into it. Unlike Gwen and I, Duncan took the stairs as they were intended. I squeezed down the spiral staircase on my side, keeping myself from getting caught on steps, the walls and fixtures while letting gravity pull me down. Duncan remained close above me almost the entire time.

Gwen, whose plummet was much less controlled than my own, had kicked out the wall - or hidden door - at the bottom of the staircase when she abruptly collided with it. So, I unceremoniously slid out of the secret stairway and into Duncan's laboratory. While the high ceilings there would easily accommodate our giant forms, I made no effort to stand up. A quick glance at Gwen confirmed she was no worse for wear. She had rolled between two work tables and was remaining on all fours. Our eyes met and I could tell that she had nothing worse than a few scrapes and bruises and she wanted to focus on the problem at hand.

I propped myself up on my elbows as Duncan entered the workshop and glanced at the hole he had anticipated sealing shut with some hidden button. He frowned at the twisted out wall that was no longer a concealed passageway and frowned. He turned his attention toward Gwen.

"What, exactly, is going on here?" Gwen and Duncan asked each other in unison. I felt a quick flash of jealousy; it was so rare that

I was reminded that Gwen and Duncan grew up together and had some formative experiences Gwen and I did not share. Hearing their identical cadence and tone and timing was unsettling to me.

"What do you mean?" Duncan demanded after a moment.

"We just witnessed what could have been the final victory of our enemy, but we all felt something that drew us here," I explained. "Some new power appeared on Eternia just a few moments ago."

"Hmmm," Duncan grumbled. He walked away from the hole in the wall toward one of the work benches. "You don't say. How do you know?"

I sighed. He was stalling and we didn't have time. I noted, "You know that our bodies respond to lightning and electricity. You wouldn't doubt a blind, deaf woman's knowledge that there was lightning around her because she could feel the energy of it. A significant-enough magical presence cannot easily be obscured from those of us so attuned to it. Gwen, me, some of the remaining Counts... Shadow Weaver, we can sense the big things. There's one here."

Duncan reached his bench and for the first time I noticed we were not alone. Next to his bench was a playpen, a cube two meters on each side. At the top was a glowing pink field. Inside was a girl, perhaps two years old. Duncan touched a control on the playpen and the pink lights near the top turned off.

"Are you using a force field to keep a child inside a tank?!" Gwen asked, tone incredulous.

Duncan sighed as he removed the small girl and held her close. He glared at Gwen and noted, "It's a playpen, not a tank. And she was asleep before I left her only a few minutes ago. So, you only just now sensed something powerful and magical here in the Royal Palace...?"

"Yes," Gwen admitted.

Duncan's mouth was hidden from me as he kissed the toddler's forehead. I was impatient at the time and did not realize his expression was one of relief. He held the girl, clearly his daughter, close as he demanded again to know what was going on.

"The Alazim have been wiped out by our enemy, an enemy of all Eternia," I noted.

"The Alazim were a race that lived under Zagraz Mountain," Gwen added. "Or that range of mountains."

"Okay," Duncan replied, sitting down on a stool at his workbench, still holding his daughter close. "Why should I accept your premise that your enemy is my enemy? You have appeared, like this, at the most sensitive time imaginable to try to spin a yarn..."

"They are all dead, Duncan. Every single one; an entire race wiped out before you even knew about it," I cut him off. His arrogance was grating. "She's not committing genocide to help Eternia, she's amassing power leeched from her victims."

"That's impossible!" Duncan exclaimed. "We've been surveying Eternia and we know so much more than we ever did before."

"It's not," Gwen said quietly. "You know there are many things on Eternia that you have not encountered, things you cannot explain since you started working so intimately with the King. The Dread Sea Aquaticans... you learned about their existence only after they were extinct. And the bones from the Leviathan that destroyed their city, they contained elements you could not explain."

"How do you know about the Dread Sea Aquaticans? That information has been kept so compartmentalized... unless you have spies in the Royal Palace," Duncan accused. On his shoulder his daughter squirmed.

I rolled my eyes at the banality of his suggestion. I noted, "The political machinations of the Royal Palace are so far below our purview as to be insignificant. We know about the Dread Sea Aquaticans because we were there when their capital was

destroyed. While you and Randor have been primping and preening and witlessly acquiring wealth and power from the citizens of Eternia, we have been fighting for the planet's very survival. You found a skeleton and a dead city; we fought the Leviathan and actually tried to save the citizens of that kingdom. We were there!"

"You're fanatics!" Duncan insisted, as if attempting to convince himself. "You're crazy. Anarchists! Why would I believe the words of...?"

"Because you know the Leviathan was not from Eternia," Gwen stated, speaking clearly and emphatically. "You've seen the ruins in the Dread Sea. The Calagor, the Ruipus... you have seen evidence of recent civilizations here on Eternia that have been wiped out entirely. And you have had no explanation for their sudden demise. But we do."

"Even if I could confirm the existence of any other races on Eternia, what is so pressing now?"

"Think of it as a puzzle," I suggested. "Eternia's disparate races seem to possess remarkable biological traits or trained skills, but none hold enough of the power to truly utilize them all or evolve. Our enemy is a magical collector, for your purposes, and the Alazim are the latest casualties in her attempt to put together the image she has for what the puzzle displays. And now the fate of Eternia hangs in a balance that cannot hold."

Duncan patted his daughter's back and she began to quietly coo. The young father turned his gaze to Gwen and I could see even in her current state he was still enraptured by her. He asked, "Does your evil twin speak the truth? Are things honestly that bad?"

"It is," she confirmed.

"A few years ago, you were in the company of a being who made similar claims. Much like you today, he burst into the Royal Palace

with a story that could not be easily proven," Duncan began. "You picked strange people to hop into bed with."

"It wasn't like that," I growled. "And if you had listened to us, we would be that much closer to solving the problem."

Duncan ignored my snide tone and focused on Gwen. He observed, "Your friend warned of an invasion. He claimed it would be massive and unstoppable. But the Leviathan apparently fell to one of the weakest armies on the planet, the Goblin assaults have been manageable and infrequent... the only evidence of some massive invasion are occasional random creatures and machines with that red bat symbol that seem equally inconsequential."

"The Horde," Gwen stated. "The Goblin legions were sent by the Horde. The probes and soldiers have been randomly sent by the Horde. They are trying to locate Eternia and they are sweeping through our galaxy at an exceptional speed to find our planet."

Duncan shrugged. He carefully rose and set his daughter back into the playpen, amid a veritable nest of blankets that supported her small body. She looked fragile in the device as Duncan reactivated the force field.

"You have a family now," I noted. "You have a vested interest in this planet not falling victim to the Horde in a way you never did before. We're here because we actually need your help to stop Shadow Weaver. Shadow Weaver is one of the Horde's most important generals and now she is probably one of the most powerful sorceresses in the universe." Duncan flinched, though he tried to maintain an indifferent facade. I decided to make it as clear as I could to him.

"Shadow Weaver has been culling powerful races and entities on Eternia for the past few years, absorbing their abilities in a way that allows her to use their power even after they are destroyed. Her sole purpose is to escape Eternia and tell the Horde fleet the location of Eternia so they can come here en masse to conquer the entire planet and its powers.

"Right now, this moment, she has virtually everything she needs in order to do that. We are all that stands in her way."

"And yet you are here instead of wherever she is," Duncan noted.

"Because we need your help," Gwen admitted. "This problem..."

Before Gwen could even complete her sentence, the problem manifested. There was an explosion of pink light and a popping sound as Shadow Weaver teleported into existence. She was facing me as she materialized and her glowing yellow eyes seemed strangely feral to me, though I could not say how. Her eyes, after all, have always only been glowing lights in a field of black mist; how they emote in ways I could recognize, I do not truly understand. But in that moment, from my lower vantage on my back, she looked pissed and I knew I was in danger.

"Always a step behind," Shadow Weaver noted as she raised her desiccated green hand in my direction. I rolled immediately to my right, colliding with a workbench and sending its contents scattering. The clumsy defensive move was enough, however, for me to avoid the lightning bolt Shadow Weaver cast from her hand in my direction. The thunder followed almost instantly as the lightning bolt electrocuted various metal devices as they fell onto the floor.

In one of his most impressive moves I've ever witnessed, Duncan removed his mace from his belt and launched it at Shadow Weaver. His aim was true and the electrified mace sped toward Shadow Weaver's head with insane speed and force. In fact, it happened so quickly that I did not actually see Shadow Weaver's right hand rise. In a portion of a blink of an eye, Shadow Weaver's hand was raised and the mace was stopped, suspended in midair. Shadow Weaver must have acted entirely instinctively because the force of stopping the mace pushed her back on the polished floor. Still, she did not fall, though she turned her entire attention on Duncan.

"What have we here?" Shadow Weaver taunted. With a twist of her fingers, she rotated the mace and wordlessly sent it back on the trajectory from which it came. Duncan perceived the weapon with enough time to crouch defensively, but not too much more. As a result, the mace struck Duncan's left shoulder, shattering the protective armor there. The sound of bone snapping and the flesh of his shoulder both cooking from the electricity of the mace and being smashed into a pulp from the metal's force carried to where I was gaining my footing. To his credit, Duncan did not cry out.

"Such feeble creatures," Shadow Weaver declared.

Duncan stared at her as he pulled the mace from his ruined shoulder with his dominant hand. I could hear him click off the mace so its electrification was no longer active. I watched as he slid his mace into his belt loop. Shadow Weaver laughed at him.

"Giving up so easily?" she asked.

"What makes you think that?" Duncan asked. As he spoke, he used his right arm to loosen his belt enough to stuff his ruined left arm into the space he made. As soon as his left forearm was within his belt, he tightened the belt, barely wincing as he did so. He slowly removed his mace with his remaining hand, staring at Shadow Weaver the entire time. I was silently impressed that he showed almost no emotion as he arranged his shattered arm.

"It's so rare that the bug volunteers to have its limbs plucked off," Shadow Weaver's tone oscillated between manacing and perversely joyful.

"Think again," Duncan said and he stomped his right foot on the polished floor. A disc only three centimeters in diameter launched out of the front of his boot and slid across the floor in Shadow Weaver's direction.

"Really?!" Shadow Weaver laughed. I felt myself wince as the disc neared Shadow Weaver. It did seem like a pretty feeble attempt on Duncan's part. Shadow Weaver lifted a finger and the disc

stopped its approach. But as soon as it stopped, a vent opened on the top of the disc and a spray launched from the disc directly at Shadow Weaver's hooded head. Whatever it was the disc launched, by the time it was near Shadow Weaver's face, it was a thick black and gray smoke.

Shadow Weaver coughed from behind the smoke and I used the opportunity to peek in Gwen's direction. She was shifting back to her legs, while remaining down. She lifted her staff and stood just enough to smack it upon the ceiling. A web of lightning spread out along the ceiling before descending upon Shadow Weaver. Incapacitated as she had been by the smoke, the lightning managed to connect, knocking her back. I opened a portal behind her and as she fell through, I closed it.

"Where did you send her?" Gwen asked.

"Somewhere icy," I admitted. "I didn't think it through; I just did it."

"How much time do we have?" Duncan asked.

"Not enough," Gwen postulated.

"Why did you have to do this today?!" Duncan said, turning toward the playpen. His daughter had remained asleep inside it and he pressed a button to make the sides of the cube opaque.

"With her... absorption of the Alazim, we believe Shadow Weaver has all she needs in order to destroy us all," Gwen stated.

I agreed, "We have been working to prevent Shadow Weaver from figuring out her place in the galaxy so she can return to the Horde and tell them exactly where Eternia is. She may no longer need that. The power from the Alazim would allow her to bring Eternia to the Horde. What she just did is a fraction of her power now; she might well have the ability to teleport the entire planet."

"What a fascinating idea," Shadow Weaver said, materializing behind Duncan. She manifested an ice blade with her right hand,

but it shattered on the back of Duncan's armor. She reached out with her left hand and waved it, flinging the Royal Guard across the room. Duncan grunted as his momentum was stopped by his left side smashing into one of the work tables.

"You must have thought of that," I spat at Shadow Weaver.

"Of course I have. I'm just surprised you thought of it. For my adversaries on this planet, you haven't truly proven yourself to be very creative."

"Really?" I challenged. I waved my wand at the floor below her, hoping Gwen would know that I was changing the state of matter of the floor beneath Shadow Weaver. The enemy sorceress began to scoff, but Gwen correctly anticipated my action and she waved her staff in a downward motion, creating a spell that acted like a giant invisible hand, pushing Shadow Weaver down into the floor. The action took just long enough for me to complete my motion and wave my wand back the other way.

"Parlor tricks," Duncan grunted, not realizing that we had sealed Shadow Weaver into the floor, not merely made some illusion. I hoped Gwen would not explain to Duncan that Shadow Weaver's cloak kept her contained and alive, a hope paired with the desperate wish that Shadow Weaver would become so angry she would forget it.

"So desperate to win my approval," Shadow Weaver noted. "I suppose I should have anticipated some creativity after you dispatched the Leviathan."

"What?" Duncan responded in shock. "Why are you doing this, you foul witch?!"

"Such brazen name-calling from the vermin," Shadow Weaver purred. Her shoulders flexed; she was already figuring out how to free herself from being melded to the floor without breaking the integrity of the robe of containment. "Eternia has something I

need in order to help the Horde complete their task of bringing order to this universe."

"You would kill to do that?" Duncan asked in horror, stepping closer to the entrapped Shadow Weaver.

"I have many times and I will again."

And she blinked out of existence and to Duncan's right, coming between the man and the opaque playpen. She was fully intact and stood over the cube, even as she raised her right arm to once again magically shove Duncan away.

"Perhaps this is what I am looking for," Shadow Weaver realized. Duncan managed to stop his momentum before slamming into another wall or table. He pivoted toward Shadow Weaver.

"Stay away from her!" he demanded. He made a futile effort to raise his mace and charge the sorceress.

But I was more focused on Shadow Weaver, as was Gwen. We both witnessed Shadow Weaver reaching down toward the top of the playpen and her hands connecting with the energy field of the force field Duncan used to contain his daughter. As Duncan swung his mace at Shadow Weaver, the Horde sorceress shrugged her shoulders in confusion at the force field.

Shadow Weaver recovered herself the instant before the mace would have connected, freezing time and space to contain Duncan. She slowly turned and even though I could not see her face from the angle at which I stood, I could tell she was menacing Duncan. He was trapped, completely.

But it was curiosity that dominated Shadow Weaver's tone as she apparently truly inspected the mace Duncan wielded for the first time since she arrived. She noted, "This weapon is both crude and cruel... Is it your own design?"

Duncan, held as he was, could not even blink to respond.

Shadow Weaver continued without his reply. She said, "The pieces of this, oh my! You were the one who melted poor Keldor's face, aren't you?! This was the type of weapon used to scar that fool, wasn't it? The Horde is in your debt, Duncan; he was such a thorn in our side and had real potential to unwind our plans.

"But perhaps you can serve the Horde again," she postulated, turning away from the timestopped Duncan and the mace only centimeters from her hooded head. She looked down at the playpen again and reached for it. Again she was thwarted by the force field.

Gwen blinked us together: the playpen, Duncan, herself and me, just close enough and across the room from Shadow Weaver. As with so many of our improvisations, I understood the one-two nature of her action. My responsibility was to open a portal to get us out of there and I did, keeping my eyes upon Shadow Weaver's back as I opened a portal below our feet and we fell through it.

Duncan recovered his ability to move as we landed in the cave, instinctively reaching out for the playpen with his right hand. A spurt of blood from his ruined left shoulder informed me that even as Duncan fell, he tried to use his destroyed, restrained arm to protect his child. Gwen snapped her fingers to make a featherfall spell in time to cushion the playpen. It landed without incident.

"Where are we?" Duncan asked. He looked around the chamber of the Alazim. The purple pink glow of Shadow Weaver's crystal containment spell lit the cavernous chamber still. The girl's playpen landed on the papery husk of one of the Alazim, crushing its remaining matter into a small cloud of dust.

"Under Zagraz Mountain," I confirmed. "It seemed like the last place Shadow Weaver might look for us. We don't have much time."

"I need better information than what you've given me," Duncan demanded as he checked on the playpen with his daughter.

"The Alazim had a natural ability to teleport anywhere," Gwen explained to Duncan.

"This is where they had been," I interjected. "This is where she wiped them all out."

"Shadow Weaver has now absorbed that collective power from the entire race. If she figures out how to control it effectively she can just pull Eternia to the Horde fleet somewhere else in the universe."

Duncan confirmed his daughter was both present in the playpen and still asleep before turning back to us. He noted, "If she took Eternia somewhere else, that would kill everyone on the planet."

"Shadow Weaver's conception of magic follows an object-based perspective," I explained.

Duncan did not seem to need that explained. He sounded disgusted as he postulated, "Even on a dead world, she believes the magical elements would be present. The Horde could just sweep over the dead planet and get whatever it needed without any resistance. Why didn't you come to me with this sooner?"

"It's not like we were allies," I noted. "Look how much it has taken to get you to believe even this much."

"Now is not the time for acrimony," Gwen, ever the pragmatist, attempted to defuse the situation. Still, I was gratified that she did not abandon me entirely. "You and Randor have not reacted positively to being told you were wrong in the past. We sought you out today because we are out of options and we are out of time. Will you help us?"

"I would, if I had any idea what we could do to stop this menace you brought to me," Duncan sneered.

"Certainly, you must have ideas," I challenged.

Duncan winced. Even in his severely wounded state, he seemed to be working to put together the pieces he had been exposed to.

"Ideas aren't the problem," Duncan declared. "Time is."

"We came to you because..." I began to bluff.

Duncan raised his good arm, waving away the rest of my sentence. He noted, "You had no idea where you were going when you teleported into the Royal Palace. You were following something magical. But I think you're realizing now that she has you outclassed on magic. You need a different front to fight her on.

"I get that, but the difference between my science and your magic is time. We don't have time for me to create and build inventions based on what little I have learned about Shadow Weaver."

"Magic doesn't just happen," I noted defensively. "We studied for years..."

"Whatever," Duncan dismissed, dropping his right hand to his side.

"What is going on in the Royal Palace today?" Gwen pressed, without moving closer to Duncan. "We were drawn there, so please, tell us what is happening so we can understand what Shadow Weaver might find."

Duncan glanced at the playpen and frowned. He seemed reluctant to respond.

"That big, huh?" I noted when he tightened his jaw muscles. "Fine. What have you observed about Shadow Weaver that we might not already know?"

Duncan shrugged. After a moment, he admitted, "Despite being magically-powerful, she still responds to the laws of the physical universe, like gravity. She appears to be a living being, so she respires. She seems as dependent upon her senses as we do."

"How does any of that help us?" I asked. Admittedly, even I could tell my tone was snide in how I asked the question.

"You want her off Eternia?" Duncan asked.

"We do," Gwen agreed. "But we want her away from the planet without any ties to Eternia. If there were a way to teleport her to the farthest Horde outpost in the Universe, that would be preferable. But we do not have the magical ability or technical knowledge for that."

"You pretty well killed the one person who did," I remarked.

"For that, you'd want something like a magnet," Duncan replied, ignoring my jab. "You'd want something that would push her as far away from what makes us distinct as possible. But the criteria..."

With that, Duncan's legs collapsed under him. He sank down, barely arranging himself in time so his back was against the playpen. Duncan looked pale in the purple light of Shadow Weaver's containment spell. I realized that his shoulder must be bleeding pretty bad beneath the crushed armor. I waved my arm to stop time around him.

I looked at Gwen and found she was already looking at me.

"We need to find out what is happening at the Royal Palace today," she insisted. "And we need to know if he has anything, anything at all, that might allow us to stop Shadow Weaver. We don't have any other options, Lyn."

I nodded and looked at Duncan. I blinked to break my spell.

"Duncan," I said firmly. "I'm going to freeze you again to stop your bleeding and when this is all over, we'll come back for you and your daughter. We can save your life."

"We need to stop Shadow Weaver," Gwen insisted. "It seemed important to you that she still conforms to the laws of the physical

world. How does that help us?"

Duncan coughed and blood splattered from his mouth onto his good arm. He looked down at his right forearm and apparently realized how dire his situation was.

"In my workshop, I have a device. It's a prototype that uses light like a weapon."

"Light?" I asked, my tone disbelieving any of this could be of use.

"With my device, you could slice her in half. I nearly cut the parapet off the Royal Palace when I brought it to full power." Duncan's voice was taking on a dreamy, delusional quality. I glanced at Gwen, my expression clearly telling her we did not have long. She gave me a nod so subtle I doubt anyone else would have observed it.

"Where in your workshop is it?"

"Bottom right drawer at my bench, the one Teela's pen wa..."

"Duncan, focus!" Gwen demanded. She reached toward him, but saw the difference in size between her hand and his head, noticed his flinch at her movement, before she stopped herself. "What was going on at the Royal Palace today?"

"The Queen," Duncan said, his eyes starting to roll back in his head. "Marlena just gave birth."

I waved my hand, freezing time around Duncan and his daughter. I rolled to a sitting position before Gwen.

"I don't see how that helps us," Gwen lamented, shaking her head. "So what?! She gives birth..."

"The 'how' or 'why' doesn't matter now; we all felt raw power coming from the Royal Palace. If it has something to do with the child Marlena just gave birth to, Shadow Weaver is likely to try to absorb that power, too.

"We've run out of time," I said. "Against all odds, it seems like Duncan might have something that would allow us to stop Shadow Weaver. If we can kill her..."

"If there's any other way..." Gwen said, a tormented expression taking root on her face. Even as she spoke, she rose to her feet, preparing to open a portal back to the Royal Palace.

"We've killed to save Eternia; the Leviathan was certainly alive... Shadow Weaver has made her goal known; the Horde wants to wipe out life and freedom in this entire universe. We might not have another chance to stop her from helping them.

"Besides," I growled, looking down at the timefrozen Duncan, "when Shadow Weaver is gone, we'll come back and save his life. Balance in the universe."

Gwen laughed and shook her head. She could not help but smile and I wish I would have known then that that would be the last truly happy moment of her life so I could treasure it. There aren't many regrets I have in this life, but not remaining in that instant a little longer is one of mine.

Wordlessly, we opened a portal to Duncan's laboratory and stepped through.

Shadow Weaver was nowhere to be seen as we entered the laboratory, but it was hard to even say that as Duncan's workshop was not at all as we had left it. Instead of the simple room lined with workbenches covered in partially-completed devices, we found ourselves in a field, the air around us shimmering with what the inexperienced might perceive as heat, but we knew was magic. Even as I looked to Gwen to confirm we had arrived at the correct place, a hedge bloomed into existence and a massive tree burst out of the ground a few meters away and promptly died.

Gwen and I looked around. The transformations around us were not merely illusions; the physical laws of reality within the Royal

Palace were being transmogrified instant by instant by two opposing magical forces.

"This won't do," Gwen noted as a wall of vines materialized, transformed into stone and then was launched off into the horizon away from us.

I reached out with my mind, with my magic. I could feel a few familiar footprints as I stretched; magic users we had encountered in our travels: Cayleen, Count Marzo, The Duke Of The Desert, many others. I recognized what they were doing; they were simply creating a conduit for the magic powers of another, though I did not know who. As one of the off-site sorcerers was snuffed out, the floor of Duncan's workshop replaced the grass Gwen and I had found ourselves standing upon.

"Shadow Weaver is here, but also picking them off," I realized. A geyser of blood erupted nearby.

"They're trying to keep her from getting to the Queen," Gwen confirmed. The sky above us turned into a solid sheet of ice that then was thrown with impossible force down toward us. I instinctively used a protection spell, shattering a hole in the block before it crushed us.

"Shadow Weaver will kill them all," I said. I spoke aloud hoping that the defenders of the Royal Palace, whomever they were, would hear and adapt their strategy. "We need the workshop back."

The ice around us melted into water and a pink wall of Duncan's workshop appeared a meter to our right. As soon as it did, though, spikes - regular and sharp - sprouted from the wall. I grabbed Gwen as best I could as the water smashed into us and my back was lacerated by the spikes. The water was draining somewhere, fast, and even as I fell to the floor protecting Gwen from the spikes, I recognized the water’s movement as incongruent with the physical space we were occupying.

The spikes became flowers, which engulfed the ceiling, giving Gwen and I some perception of the physical dimensions of the room. Almost as soon as we could perceive the ceiling above us, the flowers transformed into slugs and rained down upon us.

"We need thirty seconds," Gwen pled, hoping the magic users who were fighting Shadow Weaver would hear her.

But it was Shadow Weaver's ethereal voice that responded.

"Then you will never have it!" Her voice was a roar, exploding from within our heads and rending our ears at the same time. A massive green and blue desiccated hand swung toward us. Gwen raised her staff defensively, but even the approach of the phantom limb came with enough force to push us back. It did not connect, though a wall of steam swept over us.

"You will only have seconds," the voice that rang in my head was calm and self-assured, confident with only the barest hint of strain in the last instant of telepathic contact. Without turning my head, my eyes connected with Gwen's; she heard it, too.

"There you are!" Shadow Weaver's voice roared from all around us as the surreal landscape snapped back into the sharp parameters of Duncan's workshop. Gwen doubled over in pain as a workbench materialized in her shin.

I blinked and figured out exactly where in the room I was; Duncan's workbench was three rows of tables ahead of me and to my left. I pushed off the floor, forgetting for an instant that I was still six meters tall. My body launched forward with speed that seemed amplified and I barely managed to catch the corner of the workbench. I could hear Gwen rising behind me as I grasped the handle on the drawer. The Royal Palace was shaking; perhaps all of Eternia was shaking, I had no way to know.

As I pulled open the drawer Duncan had directed us to, I doubled over in pain, as if the biggest metal fist ever constructed had

punched me in the stomach with the force that would split a mountain. My vision went white with pain.

You see, magic, as a concept is, tough to describe and sometimes descriptions of it are contradictory, I'm afraid. One way to understand magic would be to think of a container, like a water silo. Imagine that magical power is the water in the silo. Sorceresses, sorcerers, wizards, all magic users on Eternia tap into the silo with their abilities, which range from straws to pipes of larger diameters. At that moment on Eternia, so many powerful magic users were pulling from the silo, so there was almost no water in it. But then, somewhere - many, many places around Eternia, I suspect - Shadow Weaver slaughtered... so many of the defenders of Eternia who were using magic. When they died, the way they died, the magic they had been siphoning out flooded back into the silo with such force that Gwen and I, tapped into the same silo, felt it.

Shadow Weaver had left the palace and, in the blink of an eye, teleported to multiple locations on Eternia, killing the magic users who were funneling the power that was keeping Shadow Weaver at bay in the Royal Palace.

I could not even see the device as I wrapped my large fingers around it. It was cold and metal and not at all heavy as I lifted it. My vision cleared and I could see what, exactly, it was I had picked up.

The weapon was bulky, as if it had been intended to be mounted to a tabletop. The cannon was rectangular at the base, making it easy to grip from the bottom, but rose into a conglomeration of cylinders, curved tubes, open paneling and buttons. The intention was clear, though, as at the elongated end of the topmost cylinder was a single crystal that ended the cannon like a demented, stunted spear. To his credit, Duncan had clearly labeled the buttons on the device: Off, Charge, Fire.

Almost as soon as I had retrieved the weapon, I turned to look at Gwen. She was already turning toward the wall we had smashed

through when Duncan brought us to his workshop. The passage, which could no longer be called a secret passage, was exposed to us and Gwen had wisely begun moving toward it.

Shadow Weaver's assault on the magic users of Eternia had been successful, so fast, and she redirected to her original purpose, which was getting to the door at the end of the hallway high above, where all three of us sensed a new power on Eternia. Whatever that voice had been in my head seconds prior, I had no connection to it now. I suspected even then that whatever that voice was, it belonged to a magic user whose power was at least equal to that of Shadow Weaver, but who had been carefully kept safe by the sorcerers who Shadow Weaver had just slaughtered.

It seemed, in that moment, it was all up to us to stop Shadow Weaver. Looking ahead of Gwen as she moved toward the opening and the stairs beyond, I saw the air start to shimmer. Hoping she would deal with countering Shadow Weaver's spells, I prioritized a spell which tethered me to Gwen. For the time it would take for me to catch up with her, all of the distortions to reality would be unable to separate us. The staircase became vines, which hardened into wood before Gwen. Shadow Weaver was doing what she could to prevent our ascent.

I caught up to Gwen, who glared at the smooth-bark wood before us and waved her staff. I envisioned the hallway to the door in my mind and cast a spell transforming the building into the bowels of the Leviathan. As Shadow Weaver returned to her last known location, she would find herself disoriented in the dark organic mass I conjured. Gwen restored the staircase, connecting the stonework to the disgusting mess I had created several floors above. We entered the tight confines of the spiral staircase.

Almost as soon as I crossed the threshold into the darkness, Shadow Weaver decided turnabout was fair play. The stairs bent upward at an even steeper angle and the stone unfurled into veins and arteries; the wall to my right became a sheet of fat and the air became thick with humidity. We were in the circulatory

system of some massive beast and I was shoved from behind by the undulation of some unseen organ.

"This is disgusting," Gwen noted as she attempted to transform the environment again.

Recognizing Shadow Weaver's response as a delay tactic, I created a portal loop in the hallway above us. From the doorway of the passage we were in to the closed doorway to the royal bedchamber, the occupants of the hallway found themselves in a recurring loop of the Ocean Of Gnarl. I combined it with a teleport spell; any attempt Shadow Weaver used to move herself away from the transformed location would bring her to the rest of the Ocean Of Gnarl.

"I can't do it," I noted.

Gwen looked down upon me, arms flexing as she had begun to pull herself up on cords of pulsating blood vessels. I raised the device in my hands and she immediately understood I was not in any way giving up. Gwen nodded and kicked her foot into an unseen wall beyond the visible veins upon which she hung. There was a wet noise as her foot implanted into some form of tissue, which she tested. As soon as she was certain it would hold her weight, she gripped the organic tendrils tighter in her left hand and freed her right. She waved her fingers of her right hand in my direction.

Immediately, I felt my feet leave the floor. In my peripheral vision, I saw massive spider legs carefully attaching to the wall and pulling. Gwen had manifested an arachnid - or just its legs - on my back to raise me up the transformed stairway.

Shadow Weaver must have been able to scrye our position as I was not lifted very far by my unseen arachnid before the walls suddenly became sheets of ice. I began to fall.

Gwen, however, must have realized she had reached the top of the stairwell and in a desperate attempt to keep from falling, she

leapt up as our environment changed again. Her free hand caught the lip of the doorway, which she manifested with her touch. As I fell, I cast a spell to create a rope and launched it upward. It wrapped around her waist and I created a personal shield, jettisoning the weight of her conjured spider legs so as not to hurt her as much when the line went taut. Still, I heard her pained grunt from below her even as the air was knocked out of me by hitting the wall of ice.

As soon as my voice returned, I cast the coil spell, letting the rope pull me up to Gwen.

The most dangerous moment was upon us; as we prepared to pull ourselves up and through the doorframe into the hallway, we would have to magically restore the reality of the Royal Palace. Undoing all of the magics that had held Shadow Weaver at bay would allow us to see the doorway we sought and traverse the distance to it. It would also allow Shadow Weaver to do the same and our best hope was reaching the door and the royal bedchamber before Shadow Weaver. We needed to be between Shadow Weaver and whatever Marlena had given birth to in that room.

Gwen nodded solemnly and pulled herself - and by extension, me - up, aided by a simple lightening spell. I waited until the last possible moment to cast the incantation that undid all of the other magics in the area. It was at that moment, as all reality was restored to clean lines and familiar colors that my thumb hit the button on Duncan's weapon, activating it. I could hear a whine as it began to power up.

The pink walls of the Royal Palace hallway seemed instantly familiar and strangely comforting and Gwen and I turned to our left toward the closed door to the royal chamber only a few meters away. The palace guards were on the floor - dead or unconscious - behind us with only one ahead. I did not consciously register at the time that the one before us was face-down, the rug discolored from water. In altering reality to confound Shadow Weaver, he had likely been drowned. We leaped

into motion as fast as we could and given our enhanced size, we truly were moving fast.

But our good luck wore out three steps from the closed door. Shadow Weaver materialized before us and, in the same motion as appearing, blasted the door to the royal bedchamber open. She did not even look back at us as she advanced.

We charged in behind her.

The royal bedchamber was naturally lit by the sunlight coming in through the high skylights at the vaulted ceiling. I had forgotten that it was daytime still with all of the distortions to reality. The sunlight reaffirmed the time for me and it lit Marlena on her bed.

Despite the ornate doors Shadow Weaver had destroyed, the room was surprisingly simple. Apparently, Marlena had not redecorated and Randor did not care about such things in those days. The room contained only a massive bed with a gold framed headboard and a cradle. Marlena sat up in the bed, covered in heavy dark blue velvet blankets. The cradle next to the bed was larger than I expected, even with my perspective of being larger than normal. My eyes barely registered Marlena as I was fixated on Shadow Weaver who was floating menacingly just steps ahead in the large bedchamber.

I heard a click from the direction of my hands. I did not think.

I do not recall if it was Gwen or I who called Shadow Weaver's name, but as we did, my thumb activated the device in my hand and Shadow Weaver spun to face us. There was light below me, which was not uncommon; many spells I cast shot beams of light from my hands. The light this time was from the crystal, what Duncan would later describe to me as a firing diode, at the end of the cannon. My initial sense of surprise came from the speed with which Duncan's device worked. There was no kick to it firing, it was suddenly on and the light below my eyeline extended in an invisible beam through the air to the still-spinning Shadow Weaver.

It's impossible for me to describe the speed with which this happened and how I felt a distinctly different sense of surprise at seeing the robe of containment I had bound Shadow Weaver in sliced open. You might think going from shock to shock would become indistinguishable, but even at the time, I was able to acknowledge that it was weird that Duncan's device did not produce any force. Then, within a blink, I saw a burn cutting through the cloak with a tiny red dot.

Shadow Weaver's experience must have given her some idea of what it was I held as she manifested knives and launched them at me. Her speed was exceptional and I did not even realize she had produced the weapons, flung them at me and that they had hit. Instead, I was transfixed by the iridescent red dot on Shadow Weaver's bright red robe traveling left and upward. My eyes met Shadow Weaver's widening eyes. What had been a pinprick in her robe had become a gash and Shadow Weaver had not been prepared for what that would mean.

Gwen, as it turned out, was working at incredible speeds at containment. I was not even aware of the explosions until a moment later, after Gwen had already reacted to them.

The first explosion came from Shadow Weaver herself. The threads of the robes she wore sliced, the contained power and entity within began to burst forth, first as golden light, then dark smoke, then a green gas and a fluid that might have been blood or pus. As Shadow Weaver's hands desperately clawed at the robes and all that she was began to burst out of them, Gwen erected a magical cylinder to minimize the splatter and force.

The second explosion came from Shadow Weaver's lungs, a scream that deafened in pain, surprise and wonder. I do not think Shadow Weaver even knew she could be so hurt at that point.

The final explosion came from far above us. Shadow Weaver's magical weapons, the sound of them skittering across the floor somewhere far behind me going unheard amid all of the noises in the bedchamber, had knocked my arms so the light cannon was

now pointed at the glass ceiling. The skylights were shattering and the glass was raining down upon us. Only Gwen's awareness of the situation prevented the Queen, myself, her and the babies from being showered in glass. Gwen created a protective bubble instants before the glass would have cut us and I blinked as the falling glass was pulverized into dust just above our heads. It slid off the invisible barrier as I looked down at the device in my hand.

I clicked the weapon off.

Shadow Weaver was still screaming and from the cradle, a baby began to cry. Marlena, nearby, seemed frozen in terror, unmoving with the blanket pulled up to her shoulders. Shadow Weaver doubled over as more of herself and magical energies burst forth from her sliced cloak.

"Stop," she begged. She fell to her knees and her right hand desperately flailed against her innards and the forces of magic blasting out of the cut robes. She raised her left hand toward us, not in an attempt to perform any type of magic, but in an expression of helpless desperation. "Please."

My eyes naturally gravitated toward Gwen. The echoes of Shadow Weaver's scream, the shattering glass, the crying of the baby from the cradle all fell silent in my ears as I made eye contact with Gwen. Her green eyes shone in the daylight and they were beautiful.

Gwen said with her eyes what her voice could not articulate in that instant.

Mercy.

I loved her so much, I knew her so well... our enemy was defeated and she could not stand to let that wretched beast die. She said with her eyes that she would grant Shadow Weaver mercy and I was paralyzed in place for a millisecond as Gwen began to raise her arms.

"No," I heard my own voice demand, even as Gwen acted. "Not unconditionally."

Gwen froze in place and Shadow Weaver dropped her extended arm to use it instead to try to hold her split robes closed. The light inside was fading; the fluids and organs within were no longer being projected out, but still they pushed at the cut cloth. Shadow Weaver's desperate eyes flashed something else; respect.

"My life for his," Shadow Weaver growled. "I will give you what you need to heal Keldor."

"No catch," I insisted, stepping closer to Shadow Weaver. Even as I moved, I felt my perspective shifting. I was getting smaller, reverting to my normal size. I glanced at Gwen who frowned at me. She seemed hurt by my placing a demand on her mercy; she was not changing in size.

"I will give you everything you need to bring him out of his coma," Shadow Weaver spat out. "You will have him back; I have a way." She grimaced and something within her popped and splattered out between her fingers. "But you'll have to act fast or else we'll both die..."

I don't think Gwen even waited for me to nod; she created a magical needle which soared toward Shadow Weaver. At speeds faster than we could register, the needle spun through the fabric of Shadow Weaver's robe and physically reconnected what I had cut.

Shadow Weaver inhaled, a sick, wet sound that was belabored. Her sickly green hands, covered in her own internal fluids, fell to the floor and landed in a puddle of her own tissues and entrails. She managed to bear her own weight and not fall forward, but it was clear to all of us Gwen had simply stopped the flood from within the robes, not restored the sorceress. She inhaled again, then coughed.

"Now," I demanded.

"Of course," Shadow Weaver agreed, her voice tired and defeated. "Help me to my feet."

"Don't," Marlena insisted over the cries of the baby in the cradle next to her. She eyed Shadow Weaver with suspicion from her vantage point on the bed. "Don't touch her."

Shadow Weaver hissed and pushed herself to her feet. Gwen raised her hand and her staff in a defensive move. I suddenly felt the weight of the cannon in my hands, so much heavier now. I knelt down and set the device on the floor, then pulled my wand out and aimed it at Shadow Weaver.

"I will keep my word," Shadow Weaver insisted, coughing again. She brought her hand to her mouth as she coughed and we could see blood splattering onto the back of her hand. With her other hand, she began to twist and wiggle her fingers. "You will have the cure I promised."

I watched as smoke coalesced above Shadow Weaver's fingers. It happened fast; the smoke appeared, condensed into a sphere ten centimeters in diameter, then became larger as spikes extended out from it. It looked like a burr to me and I was so focused on it, I did not see Shadow Weaver's expression.

I heard her voice, though, as she finished her thought, "Though I doubt you will figure out how to use it in time."

And the burr began to sail through the air toward me. I stood in shock as it left her hand and moved in my direction. Gwen was not so limited. She leapt in front of me. I saw Shadow Weaver's eyes as the burr connected with Gwen's abdomen; her expression transformed from defiance to disgust. Whatever it was, Shadow Weaver had intended it for me. Gwen's willingness to sacrifice herself was unfathomable to our adversary, but Gwen made the leap.

The baby's scream from the cradle was drown out by Gwen's pained cry. I looked at her as her body rolled in midair, still giant.

The burr connected to Gwen's armor, then passed through. As I watched, her torso extended, distended as the burr disappeared within her. Gwen dropped her staff as she soared through the air, her arms moving to clutch her newly distorted stomach.

She landed hard on the floor of the bedchamber and I rushed to her side. Shadow Weaver approached. Her right leg appeared lame as she hovered toward Gwen and I; her right foot dragged at an awkward angle against the floor as she moved.

I rolled Gwen onto her back, placing her head in my lap. Shadow Weaver looked down upon us.

Her voice embodied a smile as she gloated, "It is done. We shall see if you are clever enough to save yourselves."

"You'll pay for this," I growled back. Gwen's eyes rolled back in their sockets; she was in pain and struggling to maintain any sense of consciousness.

"I doubt it," Shadow Weaver declared. She began to float back, away from me. Her voice must have gotten louder as she moved because I did not consciously register how far back she was moving. "Eternia actually had a chance with the three of you. But there won't be three any longer. You'll be lucky if there's even one."

"No!" Marlena screamed.

I looked away from Gwen. Marlena had not moved from her position on the bed, but her left hand was extended in the direction of the cradle. My eyes followed where she was desperately reaching.

Shadow Weaver had reached the cradle and plunged both her hands into it. She withdrew her hands as I watched, holding a baby in her arms. Shadow Weaver coughed, though the baby fell silent, and pulled the newborn close to her chest. Cradled in her left arm, Shadow Weaver lifted her right hand.

"Be seeing you," she hissed. As her hand fell, a portal opened and she flinched from the pain of the magnitude of it. She and the baby blinked out of existence and the portal collapsed.

I blinked as my ears were assaulted once again by screams. Marlena was screaming in the direction of the vanished Shadow Weaver and her child. The force of Shadow Weaver's portal closing sent a blast of air through the room, like a wind that lifted most everything. As I watched, the gust passed over Marlena and flipped the heavy blanket off her. With her left arm extended, her right came into view. Beneath the blanket she had been cradling another newborn to her breast the entire time. The baby was now exposed, but did not respond to his shrieking mother.

Gwen rocked up on my lap, her body twisting and shrinking to its normal size. Her voice joined Marlena's chorus of pain. The cause of her scream was obvious; even as she shrank back to her usual size, the lump in her abdomen remained the same size. Gwen's body contracted around the burr, which perforated her uterus.

Marlena stopped screaming first. As she did, she reached to arrange the fallen blanket below her nursing newborn. She looked from him with concern and love to us, anger and hatred in her eyes.

I only had an hour, though I did not know that then. It was horrible and I both can never forget it and I do not want to spend the time describing it.

Shadow Weaver had left us a riddle. She had promised to save Keldor, but taunted us that we wouldn't be able to figure it out. We wouldn't have; it was Marlena that did. I recognized that Shadow Weaver had magically created a life form and impregnated Gwen with it. I could not fathom how that could save Keldor and I desperately tried to list off what was unique about it as I cast spell after spell to divine what was inside of Gwen.

Gwen went in and out of consciousness, the seed within her growing exceptionally fast. As it grew, the embryo pushed into her

uterus and it was horrible. Marlena demanded a guard get a scanner and the royal physician. They arrived just in time to perform a single scan.

I could not figure out what could be of use from this, why Shadow Weaver would use this way to try to save Keldor. When the scan was performed, Marlena saw it instantly; the embryo was mammalian. Gwen and the embryo had connected with an umbilical cord. She was magical, the burr was magical, but they had connected so fast with something primal and biological, unique to that connection. Marlena theorized that the umbilical blood might have properties that could heal.

And I snapped because Gwen was bleeding and Shadow Weaver was gone and the stupid royal physician had a resigned expression on his face and turned off his devices. So I pushed him away and opened a portal home and I lifted Gwen up and carried her through.

Roughly fifty-five minutes after Shadow Weaver had impregnated Gwen, she was pregnant to term and her body was pushing the baby out. She was conscious once more as she began to deliver.

She looked at me, her eyes wide. Her hand grabbed my forearm as I looked up at her face from below her.

"Don't let it be for nothing," she demanded and she pushed as best she could.

The baby was not facing... it didn't matter. The poor baby's arm came first... His left hand reached out, just as she bore down. She didn't scream or whimper, but the hand and wrist I could see emerging were enough to inform me of all that was going wrong. The baby, like the burr, was covered in spikes, bony protrusions that were solid and erect and very much not designed for a human birth canal.

Gwen's last words rang in my ears, all of the fights with Shadow Weaver flooded my mind, and everything became clear as I

thought of Keldor and the silence of being in a galaxy the Horde had destroyed. If Gwen was giving her life for me, for Keldor, for Eternia, I had to make it worth it.

Her last attempt to push forth her baby made an audible crack as her cervical muscles crushed the poor baby's arm. I realized that there was nothing I could do to save her; there was so much blood.

I will be honest; I do not remember the exact sequence of events that followed. I know I did what I had to. I wiped away my tears and I cast a spell that opened my best friend in the world, my sister, my love. I freed her baby and somehow I cut the umbilical cord and brought it to the next room where Keldor still lay encased in his magic protections. I know I touched one of the baby’s spines, but I don’t recall the pain, only my focus of purpose. I have a vague recollection of dripping the umbilical blood into Keldor's neck, magically bypassing the connections between skin and skull. I recall doubling over in pain as a drop, a single drop, of blood touched my skin.

I lost consciousness.

I awoke to Skeletor's red glowing eyes looking down upon me. He was Skeletor now, though he had not chosen that name yet. He was watching me as I slept and he seemed to know as soon as I was awake.

"You've been through it," he noted. His voice was raspy and high; I doubt he had gotten used to speaking again.

He reached out to me and the first sight I had of my jaundiced skin was my yellowed hand grasping his cold blue one.

"What? How long?" I managed to get out. My throat was parched. As he pulled me into a sitting position, I felt the first wave of pain from my abdomen. It felt like every heartbeat was giving blunt force trauma to my liver.

"I was going to ask you the same thing," the reanimated Keldor said. "I've been conscious for two days now; you've been out of it since I awoke. It took me a little time to reason out what was going on in your body. The liver is a regenerative organ, but I'm not sure how yours will work with the magic I had to use to stop..."

I raised the fingers on my hand and he fell silent. He adjusted some pillows behind me and carefully leaned me back into them. When he was certain I was not going to fall over, he left the room and returned a moment later with a glass of water. He sat down beside me on the bed and I didn't think it was intrusive or presumptuous at the time. We sat in silence while I drank it, his gem eyes staring at me the whole time.

I swallowed the last of the water. My hand was weak enough that it was shaking just holding the empty glass. Skeletor gently took it from my hand; I am sure I looked distressed seeing the tremor in my hand.

"While you were incapacitated," I began. My voice caught in my throat. "We... we encountered someone you might know: Shadow Weaver."

Skeletor flinched and he reached out to me. Before he touched me, though, he seemed to think better of it and he let his hand fall to the bed. It landed next to my covered leg and neither of us really noticed it.

"It's amazing Eternia is still here," Skeletor said. He actually sounded impressed. "It's incredible you are still alive."

"Gwen..."

"I'm sorry," he said. His voice conveyed the truth of his words; he was genuinely filled with remorse. "I had no idea how long you would be unconscious..." I blinked and he elaborated, "She was... beyond any help. I needed to take care of the body. I'm sorry if you didn't have a chance to say good-bye properly."

"Is the child...?"

"It's alive," Skeletor assured. "It's sleeping in the kitchen."

"He," I corrected.

Skeletor nodded. "Yes, he."

"Have you been feeding him?" I asked.

"I didn't know what you wanted done with i... him, so yes. So far, it seems he likes pheasant. I've been... testing out my body and in discovering how it works, I had food leftover. I might not need to eat any longer, but the child likes pheasant. Would you like me to bring him to you?"

"Is it safe?" I asked. I did not know if it was poison from his spine or the placental blood which had damaged my liver. Skeletor had no way of knowing, I suppose, what my specific concern was, but given that the child I had seen in my friend was like the burr… he figured out I was concerned.

"I found a way," he assured. I nodded.

And he brought me you, wrapped up in so many blankets that every spine was covered. Only your face peeked out of the pretty impressive wrap Skeletor had created. You looked like a giant marshmallow.

As he set you in my arms, Keldor said, "I don't know what to do about his hand; it's pretty well crushed. It looked like every bone in it..."

"We'll figure something out," I said as I looked into your eyes.

"He doesn't cry or anything," Skeletor noted.

"I wouldn't expect him to," I said. I glanced at Skeletor and somehow I felt the question he had. I answered it without him having to ask. "He's Gwen's. Shadow Weaver said that the three

of us might be able to stop her and the Horde, so she made sure there weren't three of us. Gwen sacrificed… I mean to keep him. I'll raise him, so part of Gwen lives on in this world."

Skeletor looked down and away. It wasn't possible for him to frown, of course, but his tone sounded like he was.

He asked, "Will I be losing you, then, too?"

"No," I assured, looking down at your face. "I might not be saving the world for Gwen and I to live in, but I'll save it so he has a life unlike ours and a world that is better than what we grew up in."

And looking down at your face, I noticed that spot, right there, between your nose and forehead. I reached out and caressed it and you gurgled with joy. I might not be able to ever hold you or comfort you any other way, but that spot... allowed me to touch you safely and make sure we had a connection. Not a day since has gone by that I haven't...

We sat like that for some time and I held you and told Skeletor the story of the years he had been incapacitated and the fights Gwen and I had with Shadow Weaver. When I was done, I asked him to help me out of bed and he did.

"Will you watch him for me?" I asked Skeletor. "There is something I have to go do."

He nodded. I think he assumed I wanted to go grieve Gwen. Of course I did, but as I handed your swaddled form off to Skeletor, I recalled that I had a promise to keep. I found my cloak and put it on. Standing up straight hurt, but I managed to stand without leaning on Gwen's staff too much. I decided to take that with me for physical support, even though I had my wand with me as well.

I opened a portal and stepped through.

The cavern below Zaygraz Mountain was darker, Shadow Weaver's containment spell having worn off, of course. With a single word, I illuminated the crystal atop Gwen's staff and lit the former home

of the Alazim. It was easy to find Duncan and his daughter; they were exactly where I had left them, still in stasis.

I released the spell on Duncan's head; the rest of his wounded body remained frozen, but his head became animated.

"What are you doing, you witch?!" he demanded.

"I'm about to bring you two back to the Royal Palace," I said. "I thought we could take a moment first. You've seen a fraction of what is coming. Shadow Weaver escaped; she abducted the Queen's daughter. I have no doubt Shadow Weaver survived and when she figures out where Eternia is, she will bring the Horde here.

"You have a daughter," I noted, nodding at the playpen nearby. This was, of course, long before we had found Tri-Klops, so I offered, "Join us, Duncan. Let's save Eternia together. We could use someone like you on our side. And your daughter... your daughter deserves to grow up in a world that can be saved."

"My daughter will be saved because we will stop the evildoers like that... Shadow Weaver! We don't need your help."

I sighed and rolled my eyes. After a moment, I unfroze time around the playpen and the rest of Duncan and opened a portal to the Royal Palace's medical complex.

I stayed in the dark cavern alone for a little while after. I wandered, slowly acclimating to the pain in my gut. I don't know what I was looking for as I looked around the homes of the Alazim, but I missed Gwen and I didn't want to go immediately back home.

But then I did. Skeletor was there, feeding you strips of pheasant. I watched as he almost touched your nose, but then looked at his own fingernail and realized that might not be the best idea.

I announced myself and he looked up. You gurgled hearing my voice and my heart skipped a beat in my chest. Skeletor handed

you to me and I rubbed the bridge of your nose.

"It's up to us," I told Skeletor. "We're going to need a base of operations."

"Okay, Lyn," he said. "Let's save your world. Let's save what remains of the universe."

"I'm sure you recall much of what came after. We moved here, I taught you and would disappear occasionally to recruit. Tri-Klops fashioned your cuff and hand when your growth spurts finished..."

"I said before that 'Gwen was an incredible woman who I think about every day,' Spikor. I didn't say I miss her every day and that was deliberate. I do not miss her every day because I have you, my unexpected child. You are the legacy of my best friend and the living embodiment of her sacrifice. You're also your own young man, coming into your own, and I am proud to be your guardian. I might not be your mother, but I love you as if you were my son because as Gwen's child, she sacrificed everything for us all, not the least of which, for your life."

"Thanks, Lyn," Spikor said. His eyes were overflowing with tears, so Lyn produced a soft cloth and carefully dabbed around his eyes and cheeks. He swallowed as she did. When she sat back, he concluded, "Thank you for telling me that. I love you."

Lyn smiled, looking into Spikor's eyes. His eyes were yellow and reptilian, so unlike Gwen's soft green, undeniably human, eyes. And yet, something in the young man's eyes instinctually reminded her of Gwen in an undefinable and primal way, like they contained the last connection she could imagine to her long-dead friend.

She concluded, "I love you."

Epilogue - After Their First Encounter With...

"Well..." Skeletor began as he entered the hangar bay.

He stopped. None of Tri-Klops's robot soldiers were present.

Lyn stood next to the wall. Her right shoulder was badly bruised and as Skeletor entered the room, he watched her lean into a support to reset her obviously dislocated shoulder. She grunted, but did not fall. Skeletor's gaze fell over the others in the room.

Tri-Klops was holding his visor together, the disc atop his head clearly fractured. He was being held up by Trap Jaw, whose arm cannon was pinched in the middle and twisted back in a nauseating angle. Odiphus was nowhere to be seen, but his smell lingered; it seemed to be stuck especially to Webstor's webbing, which Clawful and Whiplash were working on disentangling themselves from. Beastman was clutching his left eye, a gash above which was bleeding down his face and into the fur on his chest. Mer-Man leaned on his trident nearby, his left leg dangling and useless. He struggled to rub his forehead with his other hand without falling over. Jitsu was nowhere to be seen.

It had been planned as a simple invasion of the Royal Palace. Skeletor and his lieutenants had gone over the plan so many times. The plan had been simple; destroy the barracks of the palace guards and steal the crown. It had been planned to highlight the vulnerability of Randor's court and win a symbolic victory. Most of his associates did not even look up as Skeletor entered and stopped abruptly. They all turned, several glaring as best they could, at the sound of shock in his voice.

"What in Subternia happened to you?!"

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